

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 01

Morning for Diablo started quite early.

Let’s rephrase that.

As Diablo doesn’t require sleep, he gets work done during the night. In order to work together with his respected master Rimuru in the morning, he finishes up all his miscellaneous work when he is free.

When he visited Rimuru’s room in the morning, like always, the everyday event of Shuna and Shion fighting over who gets to wake up Rimuru was taking place.

“Excuse me Shion, but you woke him up yesterday, didn’t you? It’s my turn today, no?”

“Forgive me for saying this, Shuna-sama. This isn’t something to be done in turns, but my duty as his secretary. Such a thing, even if it’s Shuna-sama saying so, I cannot abide by it!”

Splendidly ignoring all of this, Diablo entered the room.

(Oh dear. It's admiring how they can keep this up without getting tired every single morning. With such noise, there's no way that Rimuru-sama hasn't noticed yet.....)

He once tried to advise the girls to be careful but,

“Forget it. That's basically walking naked into a minefield, you know? For the irresolute, it's better to just ‘let the sleeping dogs lie’.”

Thus, since Rimuru himself had instructed so, Diablo decided to let the girls be.

That is, without a doubt, the correct choice.

That is because it was like a daily morning custom and even Milim or Ramiris participated from time to time.

Or rather, there were also cases where Milim or Ramiris even slipped into his futon.

The girls' commotion further increased when they witnessed such scenarios and when on top of that, should Milim also join in on the commotion, there's no space for Diablo.

(Kufufufufu. As expected of Rimuru-sama, you have read this far ahead, haven't you?)

While admiring Rimuru's accuracy of predicting what's forthcoming, he was adhering to the saying of 'letting sleeping dogs lie'.

If he lets every single thing bother him he will only get tired, so it is best to not care, is what Diablo understood.

However, this was something possible of only Diablo.

For example, if it was Benimaru, the girls would demand him to be the judge.

“Onii-sama, please tell Shion off!”

“Eh, no wait..... It doesn’t really matter who does that.....”

“Benimaru-sama. This is a definitely a secretary’s duty. One’s job is important to them—even Benimaru-sama is willing to understand that, right?”

“Ah, that, you know, one’s job is important but——”

“Onii-sama!?”

“Benimaru-sama!!”

Thus, in that way, being blamed by those two, there would also be times when he was the one being treated like the bad guy.

It’s exactly because Diablo always has this aura of rejecting

and overwhelming others that the girls have a hard time talking to him.

Therefore, everyday, Diablo polished his ability to ignore others and was able to freely exhibit it.

“Rimuru-sama, it is Diablo. Morning preparations have been completed, so I’ve come to call for your presence.”

Calling out to him like that, Diablo would enter Rimuru’s room.

However, the situation was different from normal this time.



After bowing, Diablo raised his head.

Diablo shifted his gaze atop the bed, where he saw a single

slime wobbling and quivering.

“Oh? Rimuru-sama, is something the matter?”

“Purupuru. I am the slime Rimuru-n. I am not a bad slime, you know!”

“Has something upse——”

“Oh my——!! What’s happened, Rimuru-sama!?”

“Excuse me, Shion! Please let me embrace him as well!!”

Diablo was just about to ask if Rimuru was not feeling well after noticing his unusual behaviour, when suddenly Shion came thrusting in out of the blue from the side.

She embraced the quivering slime above the bed, and began to delightfully rub her cheeks on it.

While looking at that enviously, Shuna put her hands forward to snatch away the slime from Shion.

It seems like to the two of them, Rimuru's unusual behaviour wasn't a big problem.

(Even so, Shion..... To have thrust me aside so easily. If it's in terms of strength she might exceed me..... Nevertheless, what exactly has happened to Rimuru-sama——)

Looking at the two of them embracing and caressing the slime in turns with sidelong glances, Diablo tried to sort out the situation.

There was no mistaking that the slime before him was Rimuru.

But, from that very person's mouth the name Rimuru-n came out.

Even if someone could deceive Shion, there's no imposter out

there who could fool Shuna's 'Unique Skill Analyst: Appraisal' so there's no doubt that that's the actual person.

(Even with my senses, I am able feel endlessly large amounts of magicules. Which means that, that slime is undoubtedly Rimuru-sama himself? No, but still——)*

That slime just let the two do as they pleased, looking embarrassed.

He looked innocent no matter how one looked at him and didn't feel like the usual, brazen Rimuru.

However, one still can't overturn the conclusion that this is the actual person.....

Shuna and Shion delightfully started to look after the slime——Rimuru-n.

(Perhaps, this is one of Rimuru-sama's evil schemes. Well then, what will he do this time?)

Diablo reached such a conclusion.

He probably left his real body behind and transferred his consciousness to a clone to take action somewhere.

Because if 'Multiple Parallel Existence' is used, it's possible to immediately determine the position of his 'Body Double'.

Diablo recalled that due to the cost of becoming such a vast existence, Rimuru was complaining about having difficulty executing covert actions.

(Oh dear. Is it because an explanation would be troublesome after leaving behind his consciousness? Or is it that, he left a message about going out for the time being..... In either case, it boils down to me searching for Rimuru-sama, doesn't it? Kufufufufu.)

Leaving behind Shuna and Shion caring for Rimuru-n on the bed, Diablo followed his instincts and promptly started the search for Rimuru.



The escape was successful.

Well, it's only natural.

After all, I had prepared the clone body which doesn't have a single bit of magic in it after carefully repeating the experiment over and over.

This body has the same level of performance as humans.

There's surely no one out there who can realize I am the demon lord in this form.

I was feeling good that the plan was progressing smoothly.

The objective this time was to participate in the 8th Development Forum of Magic and Science—which was being

held in Ingracia College Town.

I wasn't going to be the one hosting it, rather I was planning on attending the event as a general participant.

Although the forum is held every year, there was a reason behind him participating this time. One of the presenters this year was an acquaintance.

That presenter was Mai Furuki.

She is the person from whom I completed the full version of 'Teleportation'.

Currently, there are three places which have institutions called academies.

One is the academy called Tempest Institute of Human Resource Development, located in Tempest, where I reside.

This academy was expanded to the former Ingracia Kingdom, now Ingracia College Town, and was called Ingracia Institute of Synthesis.

And then lastly, in the Sovereign Alliance of the Nasca Namrium Ulmeria Empire was NNU Institute of Magic and Science Investigation.

The academies have different characteristics, but don't quite necessarily excel at anything in particular.

As for the annually held forum, the town where it's held is changed every year. This time it just happened to be held in Ingracia College Town.

Even the presenter for this event, Mai, was not researching in the Ingracia Institute, but was a member of the NNU Institution of Magic and Science Investigation. She got into NNU since it seemed the most advanced publicly but..... due to Mai being easily able to move about using 'Teleportation', she wasn't really tied to being a member of any particular school.

This time, finally, Mai had succeeded in developing the navigation method for travelling through dimensions.

And since she was announcing the theory, it's impossible for me to not want to participate in such a thing.

As for why I had to participate stealthily, there was also a reason behind this.

Since I have become famous as the Great Demon Lord who saved the world, if I declare that I will attend an event in public, the venue will be filled with havoc with arrangements and preparations for security.

I fear there are the fools who target me to gain fame but, even if that happens there's no need for someone to accompany me. Just that it would be terrible if the possibility that the presenters or audience getting involved comes true.

Particularly the presenters, since the most intelligent people from every nation are making a name for themselves—the loss faced in such case would be immeasurable.

Although I could just rewind time and undo it if such a thing occurred, it's better to just be careful from the start so that I don't need to go through such troubles.

Or rather, I just wanted to take a walk alone to relax too.

My home country, Tempest, has now grown into a metropolis and no matter where you are in the country, there's always someone watching.

Although I generally live as I please, it's only natural for me to want to enjoy some free activity.

I am moving confidentially with the plan this time.

I even stayed quiet about it to Diablo but, knowing him, when he sees the body I left behind–Rimurun, he will probably realize my intention.

All it comes down to is a game against time but can he really find me at my current state, when I am no different from a

human?

That's also one thing I am looking forward to.

And so, like this, I sneaked out of Tempest and went to the airport.

I won't use 'Instant Teleportation' here. The reason behind that is that they can guess where I am headed from the distortion in space and I don't want that.

If it were my real body, I could teleport without leaving any traces behind but that body in itself would be easier to locate.

And if I were to casually take actions like that, there's the fear of being found out by Shuna as her Unique Skill Analyst: Appraisal's accuracy is only next to Milim's or mine.

Well, that's why I prepared Rimurun, though.

Because I left that behind, I can deceive Shuna or Shion's eyes.

And there's only one reason behind coming to the airport.

To get aboard an airplane.

Generally, it is always better to escape on foot rather than using any public facilities as that way it's easier to escape surveillance.

However, the surveillance in this world is done by magic so it isn't something to be that worried about. Rather, going by myself would be easier to detect as the traces of the abilities I used can be detected.

With great trouble, I have finally gotten a human's body. I can use my abilities without any problems but I judged that it would be safer to seal it just to be sure.

Steadily saving up my little allowance, I have managed to secure quite a lot of coins.

To be honest, I can get whatever I want directly so I don't really need money. As such, the money I had on me hadn't increased much from the early days.

And so, the money I slowly raised by clinging on to Myourmiles in tears or threatening him was about 200 gold coins.

That's a huge sum of money in Japanese yen—about 20 million yen but is it really a lot for a Great Demon Lord? I had my doubts about it but as I still left the job of paying my subordinates to Myourmiles, I decided it would be better if I didn't complain and stayed quiet.

At the airport, I bought a ticket to go to Ingracia Kingdom.

It cost me 10 gold coins—1 million yen.

However, it's still not time to panic. It looks costly at first but it is actually pretty reasonable.

I could have travelled spending less than a tenth of this amount if I took the train. However, even with the fastest train, it would take at least 3 days to reach Ingracia Kingdom from Tempest. And when you take stopping at every city along the way into account, it would take more than 10 days.

And when you also include the cost for food and inns, using an airplane is very economical. After all, with a plane, you can reach Ingracia Kingdom within half a day.

When comparing time and money, it's the modern person's nature to prioritize time.

It's weird how that stays with me even though I have an infinite lifespan.

<<Tempest Airline–The operating company of the airplane–master's company, isn't it? Even if you spend extravagantly here, it will come around to your own pocket so there's no need to sweat over the small details.>>

It's the end if you go and say that. That would make my

timidness very noticable, wouldn't it?

As always, Ciel-san's retorts are unsparing.



And so, after this and that, I bought a ticket and got on board the airplane.

The interior was luxurious, which is how it should be since it costs 10 gold coins. It's only natural. This is something even I dealt with as well, after all.

Now then, on I go to the luxurious guest cabin–

“Ah, you. You're entering the academy this time, right? Then come this way.”

When I was heading towards the first class section, I was

stopped by a conductor.

He probably misunderstood me as a Ingracia academy's student from my appearance.

At the moment, my hair color is black and I am also wearing glasses and a mask. Thanks to that, I wasn't standing out that much.

I had set my appearance up as a 15 year old so I guess being misunderstood as a student can't be helped.

I wanted to take Minami Satoru's appearance but that was impossible.

I did bring the gene data when I came back so it's not that I can't do it but.....

<<Answer. There's no reason to change your sex.>>

Like that, Ciel-san rejected me coldly with a tone she used to use before.

It's not like I can't do it. It's that Ciel-san wouldn't permit it.

She rejected saying that things would get troublesome if I were to develop a sex.

—I will definitely not allow other women to enjoy!
Outrageous!!—

Uh, I just felt a chill run down my back.

Looks like it will be better to not think too deeply about this.*

Either way, I need to deal with this conductor first.

In the upper class section, there are individual rooms.

There are only a number of these luxurious rooms at the upper section of the airplane.

Compared to that, the normal tickets were like the ones of the previous world's airplanes—a lot of seats lined up in a space.

The cost of that ticket is only 1 gold coin and so is loved by the general public.

This time, I chose the luxurious room to avoid others' eyes but...

Now that I think about it, if I were to get into a luxurious room looking like this, that would stand out more.

Changing the ticket would be easy so I guess I will let the conductor's misunderstanding stay.

The seats on the plane are rarely full so there might also not be a need to tell him anything...

“Ah, yes. Sorry, I am not used to this so I made a mistake.”

“Ah, we get a lot of kids like you. The ticket price is high so your parents are also probably worried because they couldn’t come with you. But rest assured. The crew in this plane will take responsibility and make sure you reach Ingracia Kingdom safely.

The conductor said with a refreshing, handsome smile. If I am not wrong, only people over B rank with more skills than the general knight can become a conductor. This conductor does not only look good but is also skilled.

He should be equipped with a special defensive suit made with magical fibre and an engraved magic which lets them transform their aura into a blade.

The conductors are of a much higher rank than the low ranked nobles—they are elites.

It’s the employment rule I decided on so there’s no mistake.

And such an elite is courteously behaving with one student candidate.

I also felt satisfied seeing that Tempest Airline's education has been thorough.

I thanked and followed the conductor into the general section.

"Well then, good luck."

He said that with a refreshing smile and left.

"Ah, thank you."

My reply ended up being very blunt but I can't afford to stand out so please forgive me.

I sat on an empty seat.

I should reach Ingracia Kingdom within 10 hours or so.

If they are searching for traces of my magic, they will never find me. It would be a different matter if they knew of the searching methods used in my previous world but here, I can rest easy and flee.

I let out a sigh of relief and was in a good mood as I lied down on the good seat.



Diablo, who had started searching for Rimuru, pondered.

(Now then, if I were to guess what Rimuru-sama thought...)

Diablo pondered, and soon came to a single conclusion.

That if Rimuru as he is now were to seriously flee, it would be

an extremely hard job to trace him.

When he called his subordinate Moss and learnt that Rimuru wasn't spotted in their whole surveillance network, he immediately understood that Rimuru's fleeing plan this time was very elaborate.

If so, what will he do?

He tried to think about it from Rimuru's perspective.

There's a risk of being located immediately if he used flight or teleportation. If so, then he's probably travelling by foot.

But to track him like that, one would need to know his destination...

And at that moment, he suddenly remembered of a person who might know more about Rimuru's actions and his destination.

That is a being who is like a secretary to Rimuru–

Of course, it is not Shion.

After all, when compared to Shion, even Diablo was doing more secretary work.

He recalled the scenario he saw before exiting Rimuru's room.

Diablo had thought of asking Shuna to predict Rimuru's destination but he gave up even before talking to her.

That was because in front of Diablo's sight, Shuna and Shion were undergoing a fierce fight.

“I will take care of Rimuru-sama. It will be difficult for someone crude like you, right?”

“What are you saying, Shuna-sama? Even though I am like

this, kids love me! You should just leave it to me.

They were playing a tug of war with what could be called Rimuru's empty real body.

(Ku-kufufu..... She is matching that Shion's strength?! When did Shuna-dono acquire such strength... No, that has no involvement in this matter. If they are distracted, it would be best to not ask them anything.)

Diablo nodded by himself and left the room without the other two noticing.

“You two, don't go too far–”

Saying that with a low voice to not get noticed by those two, Diablo left the place behind.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 02

Now that I could relax a bit, I decided to observe my surroundings.

Just like the conductor had said, there are many students on board.

As there are a lot of exchange students all year round, about 20% of the Tempest Airline’s customers were students.

The system of getting exchange students started after the thought of reviving the three academies by taking in each other’s good parts.

After all, education policy in each of the academies differ from each other, so I decided it would be best to have this exchange in order to broaden one’s outlook.

At the Tempest Human Resource Development Academy, we have the curriculum of training one’s mental and physical

condition, on top of education, to make them into an immediate asset.

It seems that in the Ingracia Synthesis Academy they are teaching the culture, social etiquettes of nobles and economics on top of the general education programs this world had before.

At NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy, they are mainly focusing on research and investigating fusing other worlds' science with magic to create new techniques everyday. It is a famous but strict academy which requires a high level of talent from the students and evicts anyone who is deemed talentless.

The reason Mai is affiliated with this academy is because it develops the most cutting edge tech officially. But in reality, the actual cutting edge tech is being developed deep within the labyrinth but only an extremely small number of people know of it.

Now then, these are the three academies at this point but what most of them generally do is learn the basics from Ingracia kingdom and then transfer to any of the other academies which suit them.

If you want to train yourself and be of use to the world, you go to Tempest.

If you want to deepen your knowledge about a particular field, you go to NNU.

If you want to use human resources and bear the responsibility of making living harmonious for the people, you stay in Ingracia.

To be honest, there is no age limit when it comes to getting admitted to NNU or Tempest but only the talented people can get in. The reason for this was simple—if they don't have the required talent, they simply can't follow the lectures.

This is why I came up with the exchange student system.

With this, you can experience each of the academies before deciding about your future.

The other reason behind the exchange student system is to

readmit the students who can't keep up with the lectures of Tempest or NNU back to Ingracia Academy.

It is all up to the students, whether they want to get better or stay down.

If they work hard and actually do get better, they can get admitted to Tempest once again.

But if they were to stay down, that is as far they go.

There's the repeating a grade system in Ingracia's academy but only up to two times.

It is because the country bears all the education cost, students who don't have any will to study are expelled.

Although there were no superiority between the academies once a student graduates, it is generally acknowledged that the Tempest graduates are well-built in physique and the NNU were the brains.

And based on that, it was generally accepted by the public that graduating from Ingracia's academy was easier.

And because of these reasons, the planes are used pretty much every month by students to move between Ingracia and Tempest.

Although the conductor thought I am one of those students, it is actually convenient for me that way for the time being.

And so, I feigned ignorance and continued my observation.

“Like I said, why do I have to use the same seats as these poor people?”

“You are absolutely correct, Julius-sama. However, it is decided by the academy so please overlook it this time—”

“Hmm, I understand. But, still. Couldn't the academy prepare a better ship than this?”

“That’s right, Julius-sama. This is also proof that the academy is taking us, the nobles, lightly. I must ask my father and restrain the academy!”

“That’s exactly right! At that time, please let me help, as well!”

While I was gazing from the rear seat, a noisy bunch came in crowding into the general seats section.

They were wearing classy clothes so they probably came from Ingracia’s academy.

Although the Ingracia kingdom changed its name to Ingracia College Town, it seems like the previous nobles can’t shake off their noble feeling.

It is a problem seeing how there are people who still look down on Tempest as a city of demi-humans or monsters and scorn NNU, saying the Empire is uncivilized and what not...

The tall, smug-looking guy seems to be called Julius. Judging from the fact that he is still a student, he has probably not inherited his family's leadership yet.

And the person trying to butter up to him was a well-dressed guard knight. Although uncouth, he seemed like a sincere guy. The guard was probably the noble kid's aide who is now acting alongside him as the noble kid is now a student.

As he isn't carrying any weapons because it would stand out here, I am guessing he is a knight from his demeanor. There's a rule to keep all weapons of the customers in custody.

Well, there are many loopholes but I can't be bothered to think about it all. The conductor will handle things if something were to happen but generally, one needs to take care of themselves, after all.

If one doesn't bother other passengers, those things are overlooked to a certain extent.

Other than the noble guy, there were two noble girls and a

butler for each.

The girls were wearing the girls' student uniform. However, the butlers were wearing custom made-to-order battle uniforms.

Although they looked like normal butler uniform, they were made from special fabric for fighting, just like the conductor's. They are probably ordered to protect their masters, the noble girls. They were more or less strong—about 'C+' in rank, I would say.

These kids seem like quite the elite.

But, what's with students having butlers?

It feels a bit too overprotective considering that they set out to learn to be independent. Well, this world can be quite dangerous so I guess the parents would be worried.

There were mixed reviews about this but the academy decided

to tolerate it.

Well, leaving that aside.

These students... did they just say 'couldn't prepare a better ship than this'?!

And to also insult the academy--these kids are very cocky.

That's not something you should be saying considering that Tempest is assisting the three academies from its taxes.

I got a bit irritated and shifted my gaze towards them.

As I did that, I noticed that the other students were also not taking it well.

I mean, of course they would not.

It's the worst pattern—to be complaining even though you're studying for free.

Even if these kids were nobles, inside the academy, there is an ironclad rule saying that they were all equal. Although we are tolerating them bringing along guards and butlers, we are definitely not going to allow partiality towards them...

It looks like their sense of being the chosen people isn't fading...

“Oi, you guys, that's enough! ‘Being poor or rich is completely dependent on the family and it does not affect the student's skill’—that's the common ideal between all the academies, you know?!”

A red-haired youngster couldn't tolerate it anymore and raised his voice. In response to that, the young man called Julius made a scorning expression and said over his shoulder,

“Hah, to think the likes of you stinking beasts would come directly talking to me. What blasphemy.”

“Oi?!”

Reacting to Julius, a few other students stood up.

They seem to be students of Tempest as they had prominent characteristics like monsters or demi-humans.

It is only natural for them to be angry but... hmm, what should I do?

It's sad seeing people like these exist even 8 years after completing the academies. These things are not reported to me but it seems like there's a need to conduct an internal audit.

“You guys, what are you doing?! Just sit down already!”

Just when I started pondering on what to do about the situation, a bald man came in and shouted.

He seems like one of the teachers and couldn't overlook this commotion.

I thought the teacher at least wouldn't discriminate but...

“Julius-sama, I will punish these students so please spare them. And also, I negotiated with the crew to move you to the high class section as there's a space empty because someone cancelled. Please move there.”

And like that, he started being toady to Julius.

And the moment that teacher came in, the Tempest students looked down as if they had given up.

Seems like they gave up early thinking that they can't win against a teacher.

“What is with that guy...”

I ended up muttering out.

“Oho, that’s thoughtful of you. However, I can’t really expect much if someone cancelled on it.”

“That is true but it will surely be better than here.”

“Hahahaha. I guess I will have to show face if Mr. Jujilas says so much. Well then, guys, let’s go.”

Saying that, the Julius party left.

That cancelled room is probably the one I was going to use.

I guess they are treating it as cancelled since I didn’t show up on time...

At situations like these, it is completely the passenger’s responsibility and so they won’t return my 10 gold coins.

‘Should I go and drive them out?’–I even ended up thinking something like that.

But, if I were to do that, things would get troublesome and there’s a chance of my identity getting revealed so I won’t, though.

But, what did he call that guy again? Jujilas? That guy is getting fired.

The management of the Ingracia Synthesis Academy is not under my jurisdiction but Tempest is supporting them with huge sums of money. With my authority, firing such a teacher will be a piece of cake.

“You, is this seat empty?”

Someone came asking me, while I was enraged at that teacher.

“Eh? Ahh, it is.”

Saying that, I shifted towards the side.

And so he happily sat beside me.

“Hey there. You ended up having to see that, didn’t you? I haven’t seen you before so you are entering the academy first time this year, right? The whole academy isn’t like that—just that there’s an old-fashioned fraction like that still remaining. We are also bothered by them. But, people like those are very few so I am sure a lotta fun things are waiting for you! So I want you to not have a weird preconception about it.”

Just as he sat, he started talking to me.

This guy is wearing an NNU uniform so he’s probably from a different academy than Julius before. But it seems like he knows him.

He also probably heard me there and this might be his way of following up.

“Is that so? Well, are you having fun?”

I thought about introducing myself but giving my real name would be bad.

So for now, I plan on leaving things as they are if he doesn't introduce himself.

Thinking that, I asked the question.

I wanted to know his true opinion for research as it might be helpful later.

After all, it would be easy to have him talk since we are both students.

But it seems like he didn't expect such a question since he looked surprised.

“Aha, ahahaha! You’re interesting. My name is Magnus. I might not look like it but I am a fourth year student of NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy.”

I don’t know what he found so interesting but he burst out in laughter.

Since he introduced himself, it would look weird if I did not.

“Ah, my name is Satoru. I am heading to Ingracia to take care of something.”

“Hmm, Satoru-kun, eh? Or is it Satoru-chan?”

“Well, I would prefer -kun.”

“Got~it! So, you are also in the academy–”

The student who introduced himself as Magnus came talking

to me over-familiarly.

He seems refreshing but it is kinda concerning how overly friendly he is being.

It is also a bit unpleasant how he casually comes invading my personal space. I don't need to worry about being directly touched as I have a 'multidimensional barrier' up unconsciously but...

How should I explain this... like, he has this self-important attitude?

He probably doesn't have experience of getting rejected as he's talented.

“Hey you, you're acting too friendly with Magnus-sama!”

I had been feeling it too but it seems that that is how it looked to others, as well.

But, it is upsetting how she says it, making it sound like I am the one being too friendly.

“Now, now, Rozari. This is Satoru-chan. He’s a new student enrolling this year. I was just about to ask him where he plans to get in to.”

Don’t joke around with me, I told you to use -kun, didn’t I?

Looks like he is quite the confident type who doesn’t really listen to others.

“But this kid... despite being less than a student who hasn’t even enrolled yet, isn’t he being too cheeky to a senpai?”

The female student called Rozari came butting into our conversation, judging me as cheeky.

Well, that’s fine and all but I don’t see any reason for them to be so self-important by being senpai when I haven’t even enrolled yet.

“Cheeky... now listen here...”

“Hmm. The only people allowed to talk to me are fourth year students. Either that, or people who are within rank 100 based on results. I am not someone people like you can speak to. If you understand then give up your seat already!”

Looks like she doesn't plan on listening to me at all and acted like she was driving out a dog.

She probably wants the seat next to Magnus.

She probably likes him or something and I am in the way.

This is extremely bothersome.

“Even if you were to talk about being a senpai and what not, it doesn't matter to me as I am not even a student yet. Besides, I couldn't care less if you are a fourth year student or whatever. I don't plan on giving up this seat so you better get lost.”

To my reply, Rozari began shaking in anger.

And then left, saying ‘you will regret this’ and giving me a scornful glance.

The general age at which students get enrolled to the academies is around 15, when the body is complete. It is normal to increase one’s fundamental academic skills at a near educational institute until then.

There’s an admission exam, so if one can pass that, they can enter the academy.

The highest grade is the 6th year grade so one would have quite the merit if they are in the fourth year.

And so it’s not like I don’t understand why she was being so pompous but I can’t accept the attitude of looking down on others.

“Oho, you can sure talk!”

“That noble, and now that woman and her meaningless pompousness, is the academy really okay?”

“Ahahaha. Well, it does hurt when you say it like that. I mean, you are considered an elite if you graduate from the academy, right? And so the people who rank high in results tend to be very arrogant. She isn’t a bad kid.”

“Hmm, I guess that needs to be fixed as well.”

“-Eh?”

“Nothing.”

I aborted the conversation to dodge the topic.

These kids are like problem children themselves.

Who knows what kind of problems my Tempest Development

of Human Resources Academy is facing.

It's a relief that that red-haired student had his ideals right but it is also a concern because he is being too docile. However, since there are some discriminating even among the teachers, this is a huge problem.

If there are students and teachers like these all over the academy, I can't help but think there's someone intently wanting me to know about this so that I can eliminate the corruption...

Right, for example–

<<I would like it if you stop doubting me. It's upsetting how you are always pondering about what I am scheming.
fuming>>

Eh, *fuming*.....?

It is true that I doubted this might be one of Ciel's scheme but

she went and dodged the question before I even asked.

But, I too am learning. Judging from how she said that, she isn't denying it.

'I didn't do it'—she isn't declaring that. That was the moment I started doubting Ciel-san even more.

<<Negative. I exercise my right to remain silent.>>

Eh?! You had a right to remain silent? That's the first I am hearing of it...

Well, that's fine.

I do feel like that itself is like an answer.

Besides, this isn't something I can neglect.

<<Well, then?>>

Yeah, it seems like I might need to take some drastic measures.

<<The forum is scheduled 10 days from now. There is enough time- >>

Then, is there an unpopulated island on this flight route? With a lower level of danger, if possible.

<<I have finished searching. It seems like there is an island called the Maldolando island. There are a few monsters over rank A living there and it also looks like there is a lower class demon lord seed living there. It's an uncivilized island so I think it suits the conditions.>>

Lower class demon lord seed?!

That's danger level low?—or so I thought but it seems like Ciel-san is also annoyed by the students' attitude.

I guess it's fine. It's a bother, so that island will do.

I thought of a plan to give the pep talk.

Arrogant people who can't rid their noble-like feeling.

Overconfident youngsters.

Even with a sense of justice, too docile youngsters.

There's a problem with every one of them.

The teacher is out of the question as his disposal is confirmed
but I would like to believe that the students can be rectified.

And for that...

I guess I will ask for cooperation from the person who

probably knows my situation at the moment. And while I am at it, might as drag in the idle ones.

<<Understood. Then, I will immediately contact—>>

And like that, I got to know of the inside situation of the academy and decided on going forward with a plan to improve it.

10 days until the forum.

The question is, whether I will be able to rectify these guys without letting them find out who I am.

Looks like first time in a while, it's time for the teacher part of me to take the stage.

While thinking of a plan to reform these distorted students, I was feeling excited.

And then, I contacted the only person who knew about my movement.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 03

After pondering for a while, Diablo set out without hesitation.

He hurried towards someone who certainly knew about Rimuru’s whereabouts.

And the place Diablo arrived at was the Information Control Room—in other words, Souei’s room.

As Diablo knocked, Souka answered the door and asked what business he had.

“Kufufufu. I have something to request of Souei-dono. I want you to convey the message.”

“Souei-sama is currently busy. Please come again later.”

Souka went and rejected his request straight out.

However, Diablo wouldn't give up just like that.

“Now, now, don't say that. Or what is it, you plan on getting rid of me by force?”

Diablo radiated overwhelming intimidation while still having a smile on his face.

Souka tried to endure it even while biting into her lips and making a grim face but–

“Stop it, Diablo. If you want to come in, just come in.”

As a voice came from inside, the tense air was also lifted.

“Yes, then I shall intrude.”

And like that, as if that was the natural procedure of things, Diablo casually went in and sat down on a sofa with an air of

composure.

As Diablo relaxed, a demon chevalier appeared out of nowhere and began serving tea on the table.

Seeing all these with a side glance, Souei coldly asked,

“What do you want?”

Diablo did not answer immediately—he first took a sip of the black tea the demon chevalier prepared.

And then, he surveyed the room.

(Hmm. Now then, judging from his subordinate’s (Souka’s) actions, it seemed like he was having some sort of a conversation with Rimuru-sama just now but—)

Souei is tight-lipped.

There was no way Diablo would get an answer if he asked normally. However, he could try going straight ahead this time on purpose.

Diablo decided on that after thinking a bit.

“Kufufufu. It’s simple. Where is Rimuru-sama at the moment?”

“What are you talking about? Shuna and Shion are with him.”

“Surely you jest. If it’s you—you probably know where the real Rimuru-sama is, don’t you?”

As Diablo went silent after saying that, Souei also looked at Diablo in silence.

And at that moment, both of their calculations intersected.

As for Diablo, he planned on following around Souei wherever he went.

As long as Souei doesn't confess, he just had to follow Souei around.

And Souei had accurately read Diablo's thoughts and instantly came to the conclusion that that would prove to be an obstacle to what he was going to do now. However, it would be difficult to say the least words to get rid of Diablo and he isn't someone Souei can deceive easily either.

"I don't think I need to say this out loud, but you do understand that I won't leave you until you answer me, right?"

"Thought so. You won't believe me if I said I didn't know, would you?"

"Of course I wouldn't. There's no way you, who is connected to Rimuru-sama physically to always be able to have contact, doesn't know of his location, right?"

Diablo answered with a smile.

And in fact, Souei indeed was the only one who had a physical connection to Rimuru among other connection methods so that he can make contact if by chance things were to go wrong.

And that physical connection method was a connection formed with 'Sticky Steel String' and 'Shadow Space'.

It is an application of the string telephone method but with this, it is possible to convey thoughts even faster than normal conversation with the help of complicated encrypted transmission.

As there are some beings who can trace communication between the subordinates who use 'Thought Transmission', they came up with this analog method.

It is something Rimuru came up with in case of the worst case scenario but Souei was supposed to be the only one who knew about it...

“How do you know of it?”

Souei was menacing.

In response to that, Diablo was still composed but, unusually enough, he laid bare his emotions. And in his beautiful face, he deepened the devil-like smile.

“Kufufufu. So it really exists? I had thought Rimuru-sama would come up with something like that. I didn’t feel the need for it till now so I didn’t bother but the situation calls for it now so I had to confirm it.”

‘He got me’—was what Souei thought.

To fall for a leading question—an unlikely miss for Souei.

However, it wasn’t just a miss on Souei’s part, it was also the result of Diablo’s skillful ‘Thought Guidance’.

Souei wouldn't have fallen for it under normal circumstances but the situation was different this time.

Souei was in no situation to have a prolonged conversation with Diablo—he needed to act immediately.

As such, he fell for it due to a slight impatience.

Souei clicked his tongue and sunk in his chair.

“You will have to cooperate as well then, is that fine?”

“Yes, of course.”

Souei asked Diablo with a sour expression, to which Diablo replied with a satisfied nod.

And like this, Diablo and Souei began to cooperate and move accordingly.



Giving up on trying to evade Diablo, Souei decided to insert him into the plan.

“Come in.”

As soon as Diablo accepted, Souei called out to the next room as they didn’t have much time.

“Hahhahha, Souei-han still has ways to go, huh? Being completely trapped by Diablo-han like that.”

“Don’t go provoking him like that, alright? I would even probably throw up if Diablo-sama were to intimidate me.”

Being called in, two beings walked in.

A man, having a laugh at Souei’s mistake, and a young lady,

deeming it inevitable.

It was Laplace and Tia.

“Shut up. Diablo joining was also part of the plan. We don’t have time. Let’s get this program together.”

Souei casually made it so that it looks like he didn’t make a mistake and Diablo joining in was part of the plan from the start.

“Wha?! Souei-han, glossing over your mistake lik–”

“Souei-sama said ‘shut up’, didn’t you hear?”

Souka said, holding a kunai to Laplace’s neck.

Laplace, now having cold sweat, laughed and closed his mouth.

Completely ignoring all that, Souei began explaining.

“It is true, as you have predicted, I have received a secret mission from Rimuru-sama. And that mission is–”

Souei told Diablo everything about the mission he received from Rimuru without hiding anything.

He was thinking that he would need reliable pawns either way.

The most important part of the mission was to not let Shion, Shuna, and even Milim know of his whereabouts or his movements.

Although Shion and Shuna were already distracted by the body he left behind, Milim might come down from the sky to play like she does sometimes.

Souei explained that Rimuru was worrying that if Milim was to find out about this when she comes, she might spoil

everything.

“Well, if it’s that Milim-sama..... If she were to know that we are hiding something...”

“Hmm. That is certainly true. So that’s why he went so far to not leave any traces.”

Diablo and Laplace understood.

With that as the base, the group began discussing on how to progress with the mission.

The mission objectives were the following:

First, kidnapping only the students riding on the plane as Rimuru and take them to the Maldolando island.

There, they would release all of them and reform them

thoroughly with actual battles.

Second, investigation on each academy's corruption.

The main point of this part was to confirm if there was anything wrong with the academies which might be the source of the students' corruption. And upon confirming that, he also said to inform Ingracia that the students will be a week late.

There was a need to proceed with these two simultaneously.

And the problem was that the plane Rimuru was on had already taken flight.

It was a battle against time—to not only catch up to this plane, but to also bring along a plane which could take in all the students.

“Laplace, do you understand why I called you now?”

“Wha?! Don’t tell me you plan on using my air pirate ship–?!”

“What else is there? You were bragging about it happily before, weren’t you? Use it now.”

Laplace became pale.

It seems this air pirate ship was quite important to Laplace.

“By the way, what is this air pirate ship?”

Diablo asked Laplace as he was curious.

And immediately, as if he had regained his spirit, Laplace began explaining happily.

“Are you intrigued? Actually, I made it with the parts Rimuru-sama created, with my refined knowledge! I also had a battle with Benimaru-han’s ship the other day and it ended in my

overwhelming victory, ya know? Rimuru-sama had said that it would increase the speed by three times if I dye it red so I did that half in doubt but doing that was the correct move! Moreover, I also used the chip from Rimuru-sama which I received as reward for the underworld job and got a high speed autocannon! And its majesty, man! It is definitely what you would call an air pirate ship. I am planning on installing electromagnetic weapons next but this needs optics weapons which can produce high output heat–”

“Wait a minute.”

Laplace was bragging on about his ship but Diablo stopped him.

There were many points to be concerned about but there was no time to be spent on Laplace at the moment.

“I feel like there are quite a few things I should be concerned about right now but did you just say that Rimuru-sama was also involved in this air pirate ship thing you made?”

“Oi, now’s not the time for that, is it?”

“No, it’s important, Souei. This chip point you used—you can get stuff like that from it? And Benimaru-dono is also in this?”

“Yes? There’s also Gabil-han and Gerudo-han. If nobody wants the object within a certain amount of time, the one who goes to ask for it the quickest wins. And if more than one person wants it, then they have to bid on it. It’s the most popular hobby these days! Gerudo-han is starting by polishing his keel—that man is an expert. And—”

Ignoring Laplace as he happily kept going on, Diablo turned around to face Souei.

“Did you know of this, Souei?”

“I did know that they were doing something but..... to think it had spread that much.....”

Even Souei was not amused.

“You and I, the people who are supposed to be most knowledgeable about Rimuru-sama—but it seems like we still have ways to go. Well, that’s fine. Let’s leave that aside for now and move on with the mission.”

“Right. I shall investigate this properly once we are done with this.”

“At that time, I would like an explanation as well.”

Diablo and Souei nodded and moved forward with the plan.

They made Laplace shut up and gave him the job of kidnapping the students with the air pirate ship.

“As I thought, you’re planning on using my ship—”

“This is a message from Rimuru-sama but... he said if you’re able to complete the mission, he would even prepare a letter of marque—”

“I will do it! Please leave it to me!”

Laplace’s whole face was lit up with a smile and he took Tia and happily rushed out.

It would be better to limit the use of Spatial travel so that Milim doesn’t notice. Souei had already decided that this mission would best fitted for Laplace when Souei received the mission from Rimuru at first.

However, it was their blunder that they didn’t know there was such a rage among airships currently.

Diablo and Souei reflected on that.

And after that, the two of them began discussing about the second objective.



It had been a while after the ship had taken off.

Although the duration of flight is affected by the weather, the plane would arrive at Ingracia Academy City within 10 hours.

However, this time, a certain event will soon commence.

And exactly when I was thinking of that, Laplace came.

The announcer had announced that the plane was now entering a state of emergency.

Magnus kept on talking to me frequently so Laplace really saved me.

Why do I need to tell this guy about my favourite food or hobby and stuff?

He isn't trying to hit on me, is he?

I don't think so 'cause I look very plain now as I was wearing round spectacles, a mask and also had black hair.

Well, I guess it doesn't really matter since Laplace is here.

After all, starting now, he won't have the leeway to be hitting on people.

“Hyaaahhaaaa!! This ship is now under the rule of the air pirates–Greed Circus!! Cry, scream and despair as you please!”

A cheerful voice echoed inside the ship.

Laplace, that bastard, looks like he's enjoying this to the fullest.

He wanted a letter of marque because he wanted to do this, eh?

Well, it doesn't really matter as it won't really affect me.

He won't dare attack any of the Tempest Airline's ships and it isn't really fun seeing the ships the other countries develop emerge into the sky.

For what it matters, I have already confiscated all the techniques related to airships from the Empire.

It was among one of the conditions to acknowledge the Empire as independent. After all, I would like the monopoly of the sky to remain under Tempest.

Although I don't think it will ever happen but, to prevent the usage of airships in wars between countries, this matter was one of the highest importance.

After all, if you were to get rid of the skies among sky, land, and the sea—there's only limited area where you can fight.

Although I don't think there are any idiots out there who

would come picking a fight with us, it would be difficult to stop other countries from fighting amongst each other. We can be the mediators but intruding in their problems even before a war breaks out would only buy their animosity.

And when I thought about it considering all that, to have those wars not affect any civilians, removing flying forces would be the most effective.

Airships are inventions which completely change the concept of wars. And because of this, there was a need for us to keep it to ourselves.

As such, there was also a need to crush the airship-related inventions made by other countries. And so I was thinking of coming up with something to stop that. So if I were to just leave it to Laplace, he would happily do these tasks.

All that's left is to make sure they don't find out I am the one behind this. I should be careful to not leave any evidence behind.

While thinking of such things, I was observing the course of events.

“You can rest easy. I will protect you!”

This Magnus dude took my hand and said so without even feeling the least bit embarrassed.

What’s this, what’s this?!–I felt like shouting that out loud.

What ‘you can rest easy, I will protect you’, huh?

Don’t shit around with me, you idiot. In the first place, I told you I’m a guy.

My heart is undoubtedly that of a guy. This Magnus dude really doesn’t listen to other people.

I ended up grumbling about him. I guess I will let it rest since I

didn't say it out loud.

Putting Magnus aside, I should go and do my job.

A jolt raced through the ship, signifying that Laplace's ship had connected.

The cockpit is probably in a state of panic right about now.

First, let's rest at ease.

I predicted such situations to occur and installed emergency transmission devices in every ship.

I brought out a 'sticky steel string' from my fingertip and promptly connected to one of those devices.

With this, I can produce letters on the monitor using transmission codes.

It would have been easy if I used 'Thought Transmission' but.....

I decided to not use skills which leave traces behind as much as possible but this is turning out to be quite difficult.

Or so I am complaining but actually, I installed these devices 'cause I wanted to enjoy moments like these.

I am glad they are coming in handy. I will keep it a secret that I am having fun feeling like a spy.

My message was shown on the cockpit's monitor.

It seems like the aviation transmission decoder is reporting that to the captain with a pale face. I can perfectly grasp the situation with my Spatial Grasp.

I also let them know that I am aware of the cockpit's situation.

As expected of the aviation warrior elites.

They moved exactly as I had predicted. A smile appeared on their faces—as if to show that they were excited because this boring flight turned into something fun.

More than anything, using my name was important.

It was an order from the top of the top of their companies.

Of course they would be in high spirits.



After that, things progressed smoothly.

“Hyaaahhaaaa! You see, I am in need of some strong subordinates. You people, you young and talented people! If you become my subordinate, I will spare your liiiiiveeess!!”

I understand you're completely on board with this but can't you do something about how you talk?

If he keeps on doing this every time and if by chance someone were to know that he is my underling.....

No, let's not think of something so far ahead.

More importantly, I should enjoy this moment.

"Y-you bastard! To do this to an honourable teacher of Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy—Guhaa?!"

A brave teacher challenged Laplace as he was getting too excited.

But, needless to say, he was beaten up.

The teachers are more or less brilliant but even the head of the year is about A rank at most.

Normal teachers like these are of about B or A rank so there's no way they could win against Laplace.

That teacher has good prospects. It would be troublesome if he were to quit so I guess I will go visit him later with some gifts.

“Fuffuuuunn~ I am the strongest! Did you think you could win against me with just that? Naive~ Naive, naive, naiveee!”

Laplace got passionate with his acting.

He was glancing towards me, as if he wanted compliments or something.

I hurriedly averted my gaze.

That idiot, what does he plan on doing if they know we are allies? On top of that, the sign he slightly made with his hand was saying that he wanted more chips as reward. It is true that his acting is quite good but what a cheeky little brat.

And well, I was exasperated by Laplace but the same couldn't be said of the other passengers.

They were just about to panic.

However—

“Alriiightt, stopp! I just checked up right now but it looks like there are quite a few students aboard, huh? Captain, how about we kidnap these kids this time? Even if we kidnap that old man over there..... doesn't feel like he will be of any use even if we train him from now.”

Tia, eh?

It seems like she came over to this side after the linking with

the ship was done.

In the end, no more fights broke out on the ship.

Because Tia came in with two passed out ride conductors.

They were actually acting passed out.

As even B rank experts were no match for them, even the academy's teacher group gave up.

After all, there's a fear of the ship itself getting destroyed if a serious fight broke out.

They probably made their decision considering that.

And like that, they obeyed Laplace and the students got on Laplace's ship.

“Listen here now, don’t you kids go around and be riotous on the ship, alright? If you do, I will be supeer angry, you know!”

That’s probably him being serious.

This ship is extremely precious to Laplace. He probably would rampage immaturely if even the insides of the ship got damaged.

Or rather, I am impressed he even agreed to using this ship. It seems like there are more reasons behind it other than the letter of marque I suggested... ah, he was probably intimidated by Diablo.

Laplace was aware that he had a hard time dealing with Diablo so he probably went for the letter of marque rather than trying to defy him.

If so, then I should think that this situation is completely within Diablo’s prediction.

As expected of Diablo—seems like he read my movement quite accurately.

After this and that, the students all got on board Laplace's ship.

Even the ones from the luxurious rooms. It looks like Tia went ahead and made them shut up beforehand.

And like this, just as I had expected, we succeeded in getting everyone related to the academies on Laplace's ship and headed towards Maldorando island.

By the way, this is what happened on the ship after we had left.

“—We are extremely sorry for the commotion. The air pirates just now were just a side show our leader, Rimuru Tempest had thought up of. It was planned to have the passengers enjoy this entertainment on this boring flight. Moreover, we haven't let the people related to the academies know of this to have them learn how to deal with emergencies. We are extremely sorry for

the troubles—”

Such a broadcast was circulated.

With this, the passengers’ anxiety and fear was rubbed off and a sense of relief brought on a feeling of excitement for them.

There was no complaints as my name was said.

Well, there was no damage or problems either so...

It can’t be helped if people associate this incident with the rioting Laplace later on.

If that time comes, I swore to myself to declare that they are copycat criminals.

—Besides, them associating this relation is also within calculations. After all, it would turn out to be an implicit threat

that Rimuru-sama won't permit anyone else to fly these skies—

I felt like someone chuckled a bit but I guess it's just me imagining things.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 04

Maldoland island.

My magic perception sensed a few semi-demon lord seed unique specimens, just as Ciel had said.

One at each of the four corners of the island.

Seems like they each have their own territory.

And in the middle, I could sense a demon lord seed. What’s interesting about this is that even though these monsters are fighting with each other, they haven’t seriously tried killing each other and are maintaining the equilibrium of the island.

There are probably still many monsters whose strength equals that of demon lord level sleeping in different regions of the world just because they still do not have intelligence.

This time, we just coincidentally found one of those monsters.

Now then, what does Laplace plan on doing now?

While feeling excited inside, I looked towards Laplace.

“Well then, I will have you lot become my underling but.....”

“Don’t make fun of us! Even we can fight seriously here. There’s no one who would become you—Guuahh!!”

As we descended from the ship, Laplace began his speech.

Students of different academies were lined up accordingly, with their instructor in front.

Including the instructors and guards, there were more than 100 people there.

Seems like there were about 30 people from each academy on board the plane.

It was wise of them to obediently get down from the ship.

After all, if by chance the ship got scratched or something, Laplace would surely go crazy.

Well, they are probably thinking of using the ship after beating Laplace here so both parties are likely thinking of fighting away from the ship.

And so, just as Laplace started his speech, one of the instructors interfered. As a result, he was silenced by a punch from Tia.

Unfortunately, there's quite a big gap in fighting skills among them and since it has already been 10 years since the big war, the instructors also got lax and so are no match for Laplace's team.

“Mm—Fuffuffufu. If you want to oppose me, you are more than welcome, you know? I will clearly show you the difference in our strength right here and now, how about it?”

Laplace provoked them, spreading both his arms.

“You piece of shit!”

“Don’t make light of us. We will show you our strength!”

“We will protect you guys. Rest easy!”

And so they went on.

While saying that, they took a stance facing Laplace.

As they had handed over all their weapons, they were bare-handed.

“Come forth, sky blade! Manifest! Origin magic: Create Weapon!!”

One of the instructors splendidly created weapons and passed them on to all the other instructors.

Although the weapons have a time limit on them, they were quite strong since they reflected the strength of the user.

Considering that instructor’s skill, those are probably unique weapons with a 10 minute time limit on them.

4 other instructors were battle types.

And as soon as they all got a weapon, the fight had started.

.....

.....

.....

I don't even need to say out the result.

The instructors did try hard. Really hard.

But, reality is just too harsh.

These people who didn't even cross A rank were no match for even Tia alone.

“S-sensei!”

“I-it can't be..... Even Brown sensei.....”

Such gloomy cries of the students could be heard from here and there.

It pains me to do this but I can't cut corners since this is all to correct the abnormality going on in the academies.

I gave Laplace a small nod.

“Fufu. As expected of me, super stroong~! Well, well? Are there any idiots left who still feel like disobeying me~?”

With pompous behaviour, he looked past the students and lightly ‘overpowered’ them.

His appearance was now giving off a feeling of madness, fitting right into the scene.

“Well, well, now then, since we have all come to an understanding, I will have ya all wear this~!”

Laplace gathered everyone's attention by snapping his fingers and brought out a bracelet.

It's a magic item called the parasite bracelet.

It's an assisting tool made by the research team to help with conquering labyrinths and it displays the information of the person wearing it in numbers.

It also quantifies the strength of the monster you defeat and was a trial product to make it easier to see one's score.

It was made to record and quantify the monsters one defeated or the traps they undid.

If the challengers have this on when they are trying to beat the labyrinth, when they die or return, they can easily see their total points.

And we prepare freebies depending on that number.

I remember such a project being brought up in the previous meeting.

Laplace probably brought that item.

That's perfect then. We can also have the bracelets' performance test.

Also, Laplace's objective is also probably–

“Numbers are displayed on this bracelet. I can understand how you guys did in this island with just a glance. I think you people probably understood how it works from just that but as I am really kind, I will properly explain! The first test you have to pass in order to become my subordinate is to survive one week in this island. But just surviving seems boring so I will also be cutting those off who have the lowest scores! Now, isn't it more interesting now? You do understand what I mean by cutting off, right? Well then, well then, this is the start of a fun, enjoyable survival gaameeee~!”

His speech seems a bit off but I guess it's fine.

But it does seem like he completely fits into the role, as he explained jestingly.

As I thought, he probably plans on motivating the students using this bracelets numbers.

And before I knew it, Tia had gone around equipping the bracelet on each of their hand.

“Please wait! What do you mean if the number is low? At the very least, can’t you tell us the minimum number we need to not get cut off?!”

Oho? To ask a question in this situation–this student has guts.

When I looked closely, I realized it was the red haired demi-human who flared up at the noble.

Really, it seems like his half-assed sense of justice and responsibility is strong.

“Hmm, hmm, you would want to know, wouldn’t you? Actually, I haven’t got around to thinking about it.”

While still using his weird expression, Laplace glanced at me for help.

You idiot! You didn't think about it?!

Or rather, it's troublesome if you come asking me for help in this situation... I guess I have no choice.

If I use too much of my abilities, they will find out. And stopping the time is out of the question as Laplace can't move in the suspended world.

However, at this distance, it is possible to use 'thought transmission' for ultra-fast thought conversation.

If the processing speed is accelerated by 10,000 times, 1 second would be equal to 166 minutes.

While thinking of it as a bother, I used 'thought acceleration' on Laplace and his crew.



The moment I used the skill.

“Good day, Rimuru-sama! How did you like my acting?”

“It has been a while, Rimuru-sama! Is it okay to leave the rest of this to us as well?”

They greeted me, as if they were waiting for it.

It’s also fine to leave it to them but I do have the time so I decided to listen to their plan.

“Oi, Laplace. You didn’t think any further than this, have you?”

“No, no, I did think a bit, for what it matters, you know? But it’s just that I haven’t thought of what punishment to give if

they score below a certain point or even what point that would be since I don't know the students. To think that red-hair would come specifically asking for the minimum number..."

It seems like Laplace was planning to act after seeing the results.

It is true that he can't carelessly give them a number since he doesn't know how much the students might be able score but.....

"At times like that, it's fine if you just go 'that~is~a~s~e~c~r~e~t~!', you idiot!"

"Ahh! There was that move."*

With an 'oops' expression on his face, Laplace scratched his head.

He looks like he's really aware and shrewd and what not, but there are times like these where he's just stupid.

“Well, there’s no point in saying that this late so let’s decide on the number.”

I brought back the topic from derailment.

To review, let’s first confirm how this bracelet’s scoring method works.

Alert movement: 1-10 points

Negotiation actions: 1-10 points

Monster subjugation: Below E – 1 point

D – 2 to 5 points

C – 6 to 30 points

B – 31 to 100 points

A – 500 points

Above A – 10,000 points~

Rescue movement: 1-30 points

Obstruction movement: -1 to -100 points *Does not go below 0

Dangerous action: Points reset

Murder: Points fixed to zero

I think that's about how it was set up more or less.

The 'actions' and 'movement' are areas where the individual is awarded points but in 'subjugation', the whole party shares

the points.

However, I will make it so that they all have at least 1 point

It's a safety measure 'cause otherwise it would be too severe.

Of course, I wouldn't be giving them a point even if they form a party and defeat a monster below E rank.

It goes without saying but if one subjugates a monster by themselves, they will get all the points.

However, there's danger in going down that road.

For example, although there are monsters above A rank here, it would be impossible for them to hunt those down.

Against one A rank monster, there needs to be 5 B+ ranked adventurers for it to be equal.

This is the current lowest rank of a floor boss in the labyrinth but even top parties with 6 adventurers have a hard time dealing with it.

To defeat these monsters safely, at least double the amount of members is needed.

It would be great if the students who aren't even B rank yet can hunt a C rank monster in a group.

If I were to be realistic, it would be hard for these students to even get a 100 points in a week.....

“I see, so they would only go upto a 100 points even if they try really hard.”

Laplace said with a thoughtful expression after listening to my explanation.

For the students, even if they hunted a D rank goblin, they would only get 1 point each. They won't reach a 100 points even

if they beat 14 goblins a day.

To begin with, this isn't a monster land or anything so monsters won't be coming out one after another like in the labyrinth.

With the Calamity type monster on the top, a pyramid shape was taking form.

We have already confirmed one 'hazard monster' in each 4 sides of the island.

Only these 5 are over rank A.

Besides that, it seems like there are a few other unique monsters of A rank.

With these monsters in the lead, they were increasing their numbers and races.

But even then, there are like a few dozen B rank monsters and a few hundred C rank monsters.

And there are barely a few thousand D rank monsters.

If 100 students were to hunt 100 D rank monsters each, they would need 10,000 D rank monsters.

But such numbers of monsters do not exist in this island and so they have no choice but to go for dangerous C rank monsters.

Or rather, if they went to do that seriously then it would disrupt the ecosystem of the island and I doubt the king of this island would permit it.

So logically, that's a no-go.

The fact that the number of monsters is less means that the danger is also less.

And that is why we chose this island—because we can confirm their safety. It would not be dangerous unless they challenged the semi-demon-lord by themselves.

As for me, I want them to learn how to cooperate with others here.

The ones who are arrogant, the ones who are insensitive and even the ones who don't believe in themselves.

By working hard here, they will learn about their powerlessness, about how important it is to work together with others and about how they can prove to be useful.

It is my aim to make them find something that they are lacking.

There's no need to go out of their way to challenge the king of the island or do something risky.

And so I explained to Laplace.

Laplace and Tia listened closely.

Seems like they agreed.

“Then, let’s make the passing score to be 30. But what about the punishment?”

“Just do whatever you like.”

“Ha? In what sense are you implying..... don’t tell me?!”

“Yep. Don’t you think such an idiot being in the academy itself is unforgivable?”

“I do think that, yes! I very much think that!!”

Laplace looked extremely happy.

It seems like Tia didn't quite understand but she understood after my next line.

“One year. I will leave them to you for a year, Laplace-chan.”

“Thank you very much! I feel pumped up already. Also, about the letter of marque, is it really...”

“I don't mind not giving it to you if you doubt it, you know?”

“I am extremely sorry! I believe Rimuru-sama from the bottom of my heart!”

Laplace looked so happy that it felt like he would go jumping saying ‘yahoo!’ any moment now.

It seems Tia also caught up as she gave a complacent smile.

I guess that is how it is for them, huh...?

After all, I just officially admitted that they can take low level students as their subordinate.

These two are special agents under Souei's control so they generally don't really get along well with others.

And that's exactly why, even if it's only one year, they are so happy to get allies.

There's also the letter of marque on top of that.

If some country tries to experiment aviation, he plans to instantly go and crush it.

If he has subordinates when doing that, that would be the best stage for Laplace.

Even for Tia, a subordinate worth grueling training would be a good toy to her and that also reflected on her smile.

“However, if a youngster with a future was to get involved in an illegal act–”

“Stupid! I’m the one giving you permission, so it’s legal, alright?! Listen closely, I am the Great Demon Lord. Although I acknowledge the countries ruling their territories in the land, I do not permit it in the sky. As such, it is only natural for the person who announces his right of exclusive possession first becomes the owner, right? Well, I did need Milim’s consent as well but..... look at this!” *

Saying that, I brought out a high class paper with ‘intracerebral imagination’.

The paper has been hardened through magic and it does not degrade. It’s the best paper out there which doesn’t have creases, even after being folded.

However, what’s important isn’t the paper but what’s written on it.

There, under Milim and my joint signature, freedom related

to specific objectives in the vast sky were written in clauses.

Maybe Laplace had thought that it was only a license to freely use the air above the Juura's great forest, which is under my rule.

However, the paper I prepared is more of a right to rule the sky permit rather than just a letter of marque.

“Wh-what in the world?! What... what kinda thing have you prepared.....”

He was surprised. Or perhaps exasperated.

Laplace couldn't even speak.

“That means, that means? We will really be, able to freely.....?”

“Hmm. That’s right, Tia-kun!”

She screamed ‘kyaah!’ and clinged onto Laplace.

And so, as I also showed them the proof, Laplace and Tia also believed me.

“That means, in other words.....”

“Hmm. Even if a student were to become your subordinate and work under you, that won’t be a crime. After all, any ship flying through the skies without asking my permission is basically illegal trespassing. Besides, it would be the students who would be troubled if they talk about it after a year when they are released..... Moreover, won’t they be able to use that experience they gained over the year and make it their own?”

“Please leave it to me! I will properly educate them!”

“Me too! So much that every day will be paradise!”

It seems Tia and Laplace both were passionately thinking about their future plan.

“Now then, since you two properly understand now, let’s get back to the topic at hand.”

Saying that, I switched gears.

And like that, in the period of not even a second, we discussed many different things.



And we came to a conclusion.

As soon as the ‘thought transmission’ was released, this time, Laplace didn’t hesitate and started to explain again.

And then—

“Well, everyone, do you understand? It’s 30 points~! Incompetent fools who can’t even cross 30 points are not needed in my team~! But, but, I need to use my resources effectively so I will have you work on a secret base over here. You’re free to choose~. And so, please do your best and not die!”

“Alright, attention! This is important so listen closely! We don’t need garbage who pull back others! Our leader is kind so I think he will take really, really good care of his subordinates. But, you know, selfish people won’t be able to become his subordinate. If you want to stay and live here, I won’t stop you but during this one week, don’t you dare betray your allies, alright~!? Keep in mind that all your moves are being seen through that parasite bracelet so act such that you can be proud! Well then, have a fun week~!!”

And like that, the two brought it to a finish.

And just like that, they left the disordered students in the island.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 05

The students left behind had various reactions.

Majority of the students broke down in despair.

I guess it isn’t that weird that they fell into a state of panic and disorder since the people they had been relying on, the instructors, didn’t stand a chance.

However, a portion of the students took the initiative and started gathering to confirm what kind of items they had at hand.

Moreover, it seems the non-combat instructors also hadn’t forgotten about their professional duty.

“The instructors’ conditions have stabilized. We couldn’t confirm any after-effects of the fight nor any curse type spell traces. They will probably wake up after a day’s worth of rest.”

The doctor was a silver-haired pretty woman.

She was very calm and acted without forgetting about her job.

She laid down the 4 instructors defeated by Laplace and brought out her emergency aid kit.

She also brought out a blanket from her 'Space Storage' and was also careful about hygiene.

As expected of a Tempest Development of Human Resources (Tempest DHR from now on) instructor.

By the way, although the passengers' belongings are checked when they are getting on the plane, these 'space storages' are not subject to it.

And as a matter of fact, checking it would be a hassle.

Or rather, the current state was such that the guards would stay silent unless someone is carrying a weapon clearly.

The reason behind this is simple—a person who is actually strong, will be strong bare handed as well. I decided that it wasn't worth fussing over a weapon that much.

The belonging inspection is just for face, what's actually important is spreading the information that using skills or magic inside the plane is forbidden.

And for that, I made the system which monitors the usage of magic or skills inside the place perfect.

The magic canceller which was being researched in the Empire has been downsized and installed in all parts of the plane. With this, no one can use magic inside the plane.

Although, it is also true that for people like me, who can use magic freely without intonation, it doesn't seem to work.

However, the downsized magic jammer is proving to be a very useful monitoring device. It can detect a distortion in space due to mana tremors.

Not only can it detect normal magic use, it can also detect when one uses 'Space Storage' or 'Spatial Travel' and it has more uses other than its original purpose.

Thanks to that, it is possible arrest someone who performs a forbidden act inside the plane instantly.

Ah, I got off tracked there.

And because of these reasons, the beautiful silver haired doctor could carry her work-related tools with 'Space Storage'.

It seems she also had a simple tent with her which she promptly started setting up.

A few students helped and a quite big sized tent was made within a very short amount of time.

One could say that a field hospital has been set-up here.

And if I were to also add, by this moment, the doctor's score had crossed 20.

It was clear that assisting actions were much more effective in scoring points than fighting against monsters. That in itself goes to show that how important helping each other is here rather than acting by oneself but who knows how many of them have realized.

As far as I could tell, only the students who helped looked like they had realized that.

Although the survival had just started, I was extremely interested in how the students would act depending on the situation during this one week.

The doctor wasn't the only one who took quick action.

Even the research instructor who is a member of the research

laboratory was loyal to his duty.

This one seems to be affiliated to the NNU Magic Science Investigation Academy (NNU MSIA from now on).

“It seems we can’t contact the outside world. There is probably a high density magic storm covering the whole island. If the storm were to be blown away with a strong magic from an edge of the island, we might be able to make contact temporarily.....”

He too was calm and simply explained the grave situation.

I could already spot a few students break down in tears as they were hoping to make contact with the outside world now that Laplace was gone.

Although I do feel pity for them, this is also a test. I need them to try their best.

Putting that aside, this instructor...

Was he planning on making the students realize the situation by going out of his way to state the graveness of it?

Can one actually inversely become calm being in a close to panicky situation knowing that it is unlikely for help to come?

While I am not certain if he aimed for it or not, although there are students who looked to be saddened, there weren't any students acting rashly.

Besides, there's a way.

It seems the portion of the students who were skilled thought up of a plan after listening to that instructor's explanation.

"In other words, we just have to find the point where the magic storm is the weakest at the edge of the island. On top of that, everyone other than the communication team will keep trying to make it possible to make contact, is that correct?"

NNU's student-Rosalie, asked the instructor a question as the

representative of the rest.

Without answering, the instructor contemplated.

“Hmmm..... Whether that’s possible or not, I can’t say for sure. Just that that is one of the options we have on the table. If we are to wait in this situation where our connection with the outside world has been cut off, we only have two choices—either to abide by this Greed Circus’ saying or go against it. Just think of it like this—another option has been added to that, which is asking for help within the week. Either way, you will have to believe in your judgement.”

He finished saying, sounding indifferent.

Rather than telling them the answer, he probably wants to entrust this to the students’ free will.

Quite the guts this instructor has, to be able to do that under these circumstances.

Amongst all that, an Ingracia Synthesis Academy instructor spoke up.

“I have just finished analyzing the performance of this bracelet. It seems to be an item made by high-level magic techniques. It also has features enabling us to communicate among ourselves and view our stats. It’s structure resembles that of parasitic monsters so it will be difficult to remove.”

He started announcing the result of the parasite bracelet analysis.

He seems to be quite the skilled instructor, as he also noticed the hidden function.

This communication function in the bracelet makes it possible to communicate between 6 people in total and he’s pretty good if he was able to find that out.

Well, they would know immediately once they actually use it, though.

“What do you mean by difficult?”

One of the students asked.

Since this instructor is skilled enough to notice the hidden function, it isn't that unusual that he noticed this as well.

He looks like a small plump old man but I must not look down on him.

It is true that looks can be deceiving.

“That's a good question. Once worn, this bracelet acts as a parasite to the host. In this case, we are the hosts and what's surprising is that the 'bracelet' part of this bracelet is only a small portion. Its real body seems to be over our whole bodies, like a net of nerves. It would be difficult to rip this off even with the academy's latest healing devices. After all, even if you were to cut off your arm, it would probably regenerate from its roots around the body!”

He explained happily, for some reason.

Well, he is right.

You need to enter a specific release key to take it off.

“And its effects on the body.....?”

“None. This is, in a sense, like a magical living thing. As it’s taking mana from the surroundings, it does not affect the host. To the point that it also has a built in function to inform other registered members if one of the member is in danger. As I have mentioned before, about the communication function, you can only use it among the registered people and their conditions will be completely visible to one another! Red would mean critical condition, yellow would be danger and blue would be under normal circumstances. It’s original purpose was probably to communicate between allies. The pirate before didn’t explain anything other than the number before so maybe he didn’t know about its original purpose..... or, maybe—”

The plump old man got excited as he kept explaining.

It seems like he deciphered it to a dangerous level. However, the students didn't seem to care much about that.

What's important is that if it's within 5 allies, they can communicate with each other through 'thought transmission'.

That information slowly soaked in with the students and the place fell silent once again.

By the way, I was also made to wear one.

It would be weird if I were the only one not wearing it. Besides, it feels like it would be convenient having it on. It would be easy for me to remove it but I will let it be for now.



Now then, they all know what's up now.

Thanks to the unexpected skillfulness of the instructors, the students regained their composure to think of a plan about what to do from now on.

About an hour had passed since Laplace left.

To regain their calm in this short period of time—these students are quite brilliant themselves.

The instructors exchanged looks and an elderly came forward.

“—Now then, everyone. I am Ingracia Synthesis Academy’s William Roaz. I wish to overcome this grave situation with you all.”

With that as the introduction, he calmly started talking to the students.

It was just before noon. Around time when one would get hungry.

Nothing would happen if they were to lament here all day so there was a need to do something.

Having foreseen that, the eldest one here, who is also a former noble and a magic instructor of the Ingracia Synthesis Academy, started simply explaining the situation to everyone.

“You have probably understood with this explanation but in short, we have 3 choices. First, we can stay right here and wait for help. Everyone knows that the Tempest Airlines is the Great Demon Lord Rimuru-sama’s company. There’s no way a person like him will forgive someone who raises a hand on it. I think it is very plausible that he will be able to find this place before that Greed Circus group comes back.

Second, we can head for the edge of the island and request help by ourselves. This much is obvious but this is a risky option. It’s much more risky compared to the first option and we can’t even tell how likely the magic communication is to succeed unless we reach there. Even then... it’s worth trying for the proud students of the academies.

About the third, I can’t really recommend this one. And this is because it involves listening to the Greed Circus and becoming

their subordinate. In other words, going out of this mana storm with their ship and requesting help when they are not paying attention. There is a need to make them believe you quite a lot for this, not to mention you would need to prove your strength as well.

Well, and so, after discussing with the other instructors, we have concluded that these 3 have a high chance of working. And so I would like to hear your opinion on it—”

Hmm, hmm.

Just as I had wanted it to turn out.

To be honest, there isn't anything more sad than not participating in the game even after I went through the trouble of setting up the numbers. There was a concern of what will happen if the students are apathetic and just wait for help.

In that case, I was also seriously considering having them forcibly work here for a whole year.

Of course, they would not be making a base.

It's an unexplored island so I was thinking of making some health resorts and amusement facilities and make it into one large leisure island.

Well, it might be 'leisure' to us but it will probably be horror for the general public...

I was thinking of getting a new training institution as I was getting kinda bored of investing my wealth and time in the labyrinth.

Although there might be a need to get the semi-demon lord seeds and the lesser demon lord seed's agreement for that.

Hedro Griffin living in the decaying swamp in the East side.

Sand Scorpion living in the hot desert in the West side.

Poison Tiger living in the poison jungle in the South side.

Ice Naga living in the glacier bay in the North side.

And Rock Elephant, reigning in the middle.

I have left the negotiations to Laplace such that he shows no disrespect to the absolute rulers of the island. Although I am concerned, there's no worry in terms of strength.

Although the lesser demon lord seed is as strong as the former demon lords, it is just living by instinct. It doesn't have the intelligence to command its subordinates.

And exactly because of that, if someone even stronger than it went for the negotiation, there will be no war.

It would be good if we could make this a lasting relationship...

Well, if they were absolutely against it then there's no choice and we would have had to search for another island.

I got off point there.

The students gathered in groups consisting of the ones who know each other and started discussing.

They were thinking of what they should do, what has the highest chance of working.

Amongst all that–

“Hmm, ludicrous. Sage William has also grown senile, hasn't he? To expect for the Great Demon Lord to help..... Such an embarrassing act would be too disrespectful towards the brave hero Masayuki-sama who saved my brother Elric! In addition to that, it is also an insult to us, the royal family. It isn't something I can overlook as the rightful successor of the Ingracia kingdom. As the 2nd prince, I will take a different path than you rest!”

That arrogant noble kid Julius said with an anger filled face.

Eh... ah... hmm.

Now that I think about it, Ingracia kingdom fell into a national crisis, didn't it?

Amidst the Great War, the people from the royal family and a part of the knights had rampaged.

Although they were people who hated me, they were own family to Julius. I guess it can't be helped if he doesn't see me in a good light.

At that time, while solving the problem, Masayuki saved the prince Elric from getting executed so it seems his position in Ingracia has been fixed.

Although I do think it was quite firm to begin with, he is probably treated as a God there now.....

I remember him crying and accusing me of leading all this when he came last time.

I just ignored it, thinking ‘say your complaints to Ciel-san’.

Oh, it seems like Julius’ group had started moving while I was remembering Masayuki.

“I will welcome those who want to move forward under me! I swear by my name, Julius, that I will guarantee your safety!”

A cool phrase from a pretty face.

And with just that, a few of the female students started to get up and follow him.

What’s surprising is that there were also some instructors who were going to follow him.

That Yujilas lord or something instructor of course followed him but there was also another instructor from the Ingracia Synthesis Academy who followed him.

From the looks, this guy seems to be a battle type but he didn't challenge Laplace before. It seems he is one of the rotten instructors like Yujilas. Or he might have a very cautious personality.....

“Wait! Don't do something selfish even in this situation! We need to cooperate with each other and leave the island, right?!”

The red demi-human is like a mass of sense of justice.

I also think he is right. Rather, I am wondering why that William instructor brought up 3 options in this situation.

It is true that he probably wanted the students to think for themselves but it will just aimlessly make them panic in this situation... Even though the normal practice here would be for the instructors to come up with a plan and make the students form a group to act.

Although I did predict the third option, I still can't make sense why an instructor would suggest it.

This William instructor looks to be strict and wise so he might have something planned but.....

The worst case scenario would be this--the students fall into panic and start acting separately.

If this were to happen, I would have no choice but to suspend the test. That is because I need to ensure the students' safety.

On top of that, I planned on revealing my identity to discipline them forcibly.

In that scenario, as they will know that I am here, the escape play will also come to an end. I had to lead the situation properly so that it doesn't come down to that.

Laplace, Tia and me.

While protecting the students from the shadows, we will continue the survival.

As such, it was barely within our permissible range for them to move in three groups.

It goes without saying that it would be ideal for them to move in unison.

But that is from the management perspective. For the students in an extreme situation, the most important thing is to stay alive.

When I consider that point as well, I can't arbitrarily decide that Julius' action is wrong.

After all, fastest way to form a group in this extreme situation for them is in a sense having the students under them.

It is certain that by abiding by the rules Julius decides, the order and chain of command will be upheld.

“Hmm, what a dumb dog. I am not just Julius in this situation. I am the second prince of the Ingracia kingdom, in a position to lead others. Isn’t it obvious that there’s a need for a leader so that the students don’t just follow your stupid suggestions?”

Hmm, it seems he did have some resolution when making that statement earlier.

In other words, he isn’t just a simple arrogant noble–royalty, eh.

“However, if we were to decide on a leader, we should have respect everyone’s opinion–”

“Now, now, wait, Karma. There is a point to what Julius is saying. This isn’t the time to be leisurely hearing everyone’s opinion.”

The one who stopped the red hair–Karma, was Magnus, who was flirting with me.

“Magnus, eh? However, we can’t just accept his judgement...”

“Like I said, just wait a bit. We haven’t even had food yet, you know? We have to prepare food and water by ourselves for a whole week. Although the people who can use ‘space storage’ can secretly have their preserved food. Everyone isn’t that thoroughly prepared, right? We were going to a presentation and didn’t prepare anything for extracurricular activities.”

“That is–”

“First, let’s see how he manages everyone before deciding, alright? It is true that we need a leader after all.”

“–That is, right. I understand.”

Surprisingly, Magnus was able to splendidly persuade Karma.

It seems he isn’t just flirty, his head works too.

Besides, I didn't fail to hear Magnus muttering 'for now, at least' like everyone else.

He looks like someone who is kind to everyone at first but he might have a different face inside.

I braced myself, thinking it would be better to not let my guard down.

As Karma and Magnus persuaded others, the other students didn't complain either.

Despite what they might be thinking inside, they had agreed to this setting for now.

It was fortunate that there weren't any idiots here who would do as they please even in this situation.

As all the skilled people of each academy agreed to this, all the students were under Julius for now.

And like this, communal living for a group with Julius as its leader had begun.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 06

Julius’ coming forward as the leader, whether it was good or bad...

Either way, a roll-call was done and they passed food to everyone.

“Getting dragged in even though you’re not even a student yet... tough luck.”

One of the instructors passed me the food saying that but... the food was so simple that it even made me long for CalorieMate. *

This food was in a pack for carrying, made mainly for when conquering the Labyrinth.

It’s commonly referred to as ‘ration’(battle food).

The instructor was called Irina and she was a researcher in NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy.

The battle type instructors and students were careful and had at least a day's worth of energy food with them but the research students weren't that prepared.

And so, amongst all that, this Irina brought out these 'rations' from her 'Space Storage'.

It seems she was researching the passing of time inside the 'storage space' and had a lot of food in it.

But unfortunately, the time in 'storage space' is the same as normal if it's created with magic or skill.

However, if one were to put food in a sterilized storage space without any germ in it, there's no chance of it getting spoiled.

Even then, the ultimate conclusion reached was that complete preservation was impossible due to insufficient processing and

various other reasons.

Actually, my 'imaginary space' can preserve things in it perfectly as it is not ruled by time but we're not talking about that right now.

Not only the rations, all the food everyone had on them was collected and was managed by Julius' group.

And with that, 3 days worth of food supply was gathered, considering 2 meals a day for everyone.

It seems that the food supply the battle type people were carrying came in handy and provided some leeway.

Apart from the taste, it had proper nutrition.

Something can be done about water by magic, so for now nobody will be dying of starvation during this one week.

As I was having my somewhat sweet but not delicious food, a good smell came drifting my way.

It was from Julius' group.

Those guys, despite this situation, they had prepared a table and chairs and were having an elegant lunch.

That too was cooked in a simple cooking set and served like in a top restaurant.

“Julius-sama, the quality of the food will be subpar due to the circumstances. Please, forgive me.”

“Hm, it can't be helped. Although I am reluctant, I do understand that I have to be the model for the people.”

“Thank you very much for your kind words.”

While sucking on the ration, I stared at them, exasperated.

The butler apologizing to Julius was the student Maria's escort, if I am not wrong. Yep, that's probably it considering that they're sitting on the same table.

Other than them, there's also a boy and another girl sitting there, with both of their butlers serving as well.

As if they were in a different world.

I had a boat load of things I wanted to say to him like where they got those food or that this is the time to be working together or if they actually knew what they're talking about, but for now, there's one thing I understood well and it's that this guy really can't read the atmosphere.

Karma looked annoyed and Magnus just gave a bitter smile while looking towards Julius.

Normally they would probably flare up at him but the

situation was so bad that they didn't even have the willpower to complain.

“Looks so good. This much isn't really enough for me.....”

Beside me, a fat student let out a sad sigh.

Judging from his fat, that amount of food is certainly quite sad.

“Don't complain! This has been optimised to have the perfect nutrition balance and makes you feel full, you know?”

A girl beside him scolded him for whining.

That's exactly right. Although the taste isn't very good, this ration is a top quality product.

“Hmm. But, you know, I am a battle type too so... That kind of

deception doesn't work for me.....”

The boy repeatedly sighed.

It seems he was trained against illusions and neurotoxins so the effect which had some merit for him was ineffective now.

It might be that he's just being gluttonous but it sure is pretty rough when there's a limit to how much you can eat.

“It's half-eaten but do you want some of mine?”

And so I offered him mine but...

“Eh, is it okay? Then, uwah–”

“Ah! Mondo-kun, you okay? I will have a look at you so come here.”

A branch suddenly came falling directly onto this Mondo kid's head.

Mondo was now being held up by instructor Pyuri, who had pretty, silver hair.

“Oi, is he alright?”

“Ah, ehh, you are?”

“Ah, I am Satoru. I am just a normal person who got caught up—”

“Eh, umm. Satoru-kun, eh? He is fine so you don't need to worry, okay? Ah, right, in situations like this, I think it's not good to give your food to others, you know?”

She said, after hesitating for a moment there.

Is she thinking of me as impertinuous or is she really worried as an instructor?

<<No matter how you look at it, it seems like she was trying to stop master from handing over the food.>>

Right.

In other words, this means that she found out who I am, right?

And the fact that the branch which came falling was cleanly cut was proof of that.

<<It wouldn't be weird for an instructor to know Rimuru-sama's face. It's kind of unreasonable to try and deceive people just by changing your hair and eye color. She will probably come making contact soon.>>

And when I heard that, I could also see why the instructors gave those 3 options.

In short, they probably wanted to find out what I was thinking about the situation and what was the correct option.

If so, then I guess I will reveal that tonight—I thought, while looking at Mondo-kun being carried away.



After having lunch, it was time to announce policy decision.

Without consulting with everyone, we will be going forward with what Julius and his group decided.

Julius had completely become everyone's leader, having the most authority.

“Well, what plan will we go with?”

To Magnus' question, Julius just sneered and answered,

“That’s obvious. We will head for the island’s edge with just the battle elites. It’s fine if we can call for help there. And even if we can’t we will be able to collect points.”

He declared, as if it was obvious from the start.

Julius’ reasoning went like this:

There are some students who can also use ‘space storage’ so they will be setting up a base here.

The research, economics and politics students will engage in constructing a place to sleep. Food supply is also not stable so they will be gathering as much food as they can.

While doing that, they will take actions such that they gain the most points possible.

The fact that some students got points just for helping set up the tent was made public and so they wanted to find out if there were any other ways to get points, as well.

“The people staying behind, you guys also need to act such that you get as much point as possible. It won’t be a problem if we can blow away the mana storm but if we were to fail, we won’t have any other choice than to listen to those pirates. Being isolated to this island for labor work—we mustn’t accept that at any cost. The most important thing is to earn points and at least make it out of the island!”

Julius’ confidant gave a speech.

If I remember right, he is Julius’ escort knight and his name is Clad.

It seems like Clad has been entrusted with leading the students.

It also looks like making certain of battle types is also Clad’s job.

As soon as he was done with his speech, he looked at the students and started selecting the ones who seemed to be dependable in fights. And then, he made groups of 5.

“That plan is better than I expected. I was worried he would work us really hard...”

“Despite everything you say, you really do your job properly after all, Karma. While Julius does treat you like an idiot and what not, I am sure he can’t ignore your skills.”

On the side, I could hear Karma and Magnus having a conversation.

Maybe because of the mingling in the academy, they seemed to be closer than just normal acquaintances.

Although, it also doesn’t seem like both of them trust each other from the bottom of their hearts.

I secretly listened to their conversation.

“Well, I will cooperate. What’s important is everyone being saved and if he does it properly then I am willing.”

“I see, then I shall also see how it turns out.”

Putting the serious Karma aside, even Magnus didn't seem like he would oppose Julius.

Well, it is true that having a dispute at this point wouldn't be a wise thing to do but...

But it looks like Karma was even more surprised by Magnus' words than me.

“That's rare. For you to listen to Julius.”

“Not really. It is true that what he said makes sense. If we just earn the points, we won't be left in this island. If we do that, we could look for opportunities to call for help while pretending to do as the kidnappers say.”

“I see. Then I guess we will be having a joint struggle for a while, huh?”

“Yea, I will be counting on you, Karma.”

“Same here, Magnus.”

While Karma was surprised, Magnus just replied shrugging his shoulders.

It seems even Karma was convinced by his logic.

Ultimately, it seems both of them aren't actually content with Julius taking the lead but they have come to the conclusion that they will see how it goes for a while.

They are much more rational and it isn't like they completely lack the spirit of cooperativeness like I had thought earlier.

My opinion of them has improved but still, we have a while to go.

There's no need to hurry so I shall be watching closely.

Now then, it would be great if they go at it with this level of cooperativeness—while thinking that, I restrained from making an evaluation before the results.

The grouping had ended.

5 teams were made and 5 members were in each group.

As you can only register 5 people in the bracelet, the group members were now registered to each other.

And the members of Julius' group were registering all of the 5 members of the other groups.

If they do this, they can be aware of each group's location even when they are away so that's quite a good plan.

Although that way Julius' group can't register each other but since his escort is never leaving his side, I guess it will be fine.

And Julius himself had registered the instructors so that he can communicate with the base.

This way, the ones remaining in the base will know about the exploring group's whereabouts and can rest easy.

This Julius kid—although his aristocratic attitude can get very annoying, he is quite smart.

He has all the good points down and is making exactly the right decisions.

There might be a 'brain' in his group but he still deserves praise for implementing it.

These 3 might not just be your regular problem children.

I guess I will have to see it to the end.



A total of 25 battle type students departed in high spirits.

The ones remaining split into two groups to prepare dinner and secure a place to sleep.

The place we are currently at is an open grassland between hilly areas and is spacious enough for the ship to land.

Although the surrounding is covered with hills, on the other side of it are mountains and deserts.

If you head for the center, then you will be faced with mountains and if you head for the edge then you will find deserts.

And there, each of the rulers should be present. Or rather, because of them and their leaking aura, the terrain transformed into this abnormal environment.

On the other hand, there is a forest but as there's also a ruler living there, it was connected to a jungle.

To be honest, as there are rulers on all four sides, it will be difficult for the search team.

There's no doubt that it will be easier for the people staying back.

And as such, I am in the staying behind group.

Tear is supposed to be protecting the search groups from the shadows so I don't have a role to play there. *

Or rather, now that I am at human level, I would have trouble even with unique monsters, semi demon lord seed level is way out of the question.

To be more precise, if I get even a bit serious, my identity will be revealed and it would be game over.

And so, I will be among the non-combatants.

I want it to be clear that it's definitely not like I want to relax.

Now then, about the work for the ones staying behind–

The job that looks most easy is setting up the tent for the equipments.

A very thoroughly prepared instructor had outdoor training camp equipments in his 'space storage'.

It might just be that he thought it would be more troublesome to put them in storage but some things are better left unsaid.

After all, he's all happy and what not from all the respect he's

getting from the students so I will just leave it as him having a careful personality.

Besides, the tent even has an insect repelling effect due to a simple magic circle. With space magic, the insides are also a bit more spacious so it's perfect for situations like this.

There were 30 tents of which each can fit about 10 people and so we have more than enough space even if we make the tents gender-segregated.

The way to set it up is rather simple—you just need to break the magic seal on a flat surface and spread the tent. After that, you just need to put up all the sides.

However, I am not a student of any academy so I am not supposed to know about breaking the magic seal.

It's actually quite simple but if I were to do it, I would completely be labelled out as a suspicious person.

And like this, I was inevitably put into the food supply group.

Looking at the other students put up the tents with a backward glance, we headed into the forest.

Beside me was Mondo-kun—the fat student from before.

Although two instructors were leading about 30 students, that alone wouldn't be very secure so a battle type student was included in each group.

We were also working with 5 members in a group, like Julius and the others.

The relief squad was in the middle with the four collecting squads protecting them from all four sides.

The relief squad also had registered each member of all groups so this arrangement was appropriate.

Instructors are not included in the groups so we had a total of 27 people.

Mondo-kun was also a battle type if it matters so he was chosen as one of the escorts for people heading into the forest.

I don't know all the students so I will just have to trust the instructors' judgement on the personnel selection.

Well, Ciel-sensei isn't saying anything either so it's probably fine but...

"Ahh~ahh, this is the worst~ To be protected by Mondo, out of all."

The one who was whining beside was a girl named Marsha.

She was the same girl who was with him a while ago and it seems they are childhood friends.

Although she is complaining, she seems like she is having fun.

However, the same couldn't be said about her friend.

“Oi, oi, I am here so you can rest easy. Well, sure, my results aren't as good enough for the search group but I am still quite good in actual battles, you know?”

“Right~ Compared to Mondo, I guess George is better.”

“Oi, what do you mean better?! Sure, I am in middle in the ranks but it hurts when you compare me with this low rank.”

The George kid said.

And a red-haired girl nodded to that.

Apparently her name is Aina. She has freckles but is a cute girl.

George, Aina, Mondo and Marsha were my group mates.

I was observing to get a grasp of the collecting group's personalities but it seems like Mondo-kun isn't really valued highly.

Excluding me, it seems he has the lowest grades among the 4.

However, it didn't seem like he was hated or anything. Rather, he felt like the mood maker of the group.

It might be because of Mondo-kun that this group doesn't seem anxious.

Although Mondo-kun might not be willing to be made fun of, it definitely is making the rest feel less stressed.

"E-even though you say that, I have things I am good at too, alright? I might be lacking stamina but my explosive power is above average, you know?"

“Stuupid. Being able to continue fights for a long ime is the most important—even the instructor was saying that, remember?”

George sneered at Mondo-kun’s excuse.

Certainly, if he gets hungry and laments easily, you can’t really expect him to hold his fights for long. But still, like he says, he might shine in power.

At the very least, it is a big plus point that his resistance is high.

It seems like his body can resist neurotoxins so if he trains that part, he might have an interesting growth.

“Well, what are we going to do?”

A while after going into the forest, George gathered the group mates and asked.

George was this group's leader.

“Shall we search for a water place first?”

“Right~ the instructors were saying that too. Securing water is of utmost importance. I can see water coming into the forest from the mountains so let's head there~”

Marsha answered and Aina agreed.

And so, we started walking towards the water place—in other words, the river.



“Hyaahha~! Fishing here is the best~!”

The one who raised that excited voice was, me.

I was having a really good time fishing.

About how it got like this–

We secured water and used magic to see if it was drinkable.

It had slight toxins and parasitic magical insects but was perfectly dealt with boiling magic.

George and the other 3 are from NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy and so they are a bit weak at battle magic. But on the other hand, it seems they were doing research to improve lifestyle magic and so surprisingly enough, we were able to procure water quite efficiently.

We could make water with magic too but it's always better to have another supply.

We were lucky to secure water.

Moreover,

“Alright, perfect!”

Marsha grinned.

Who would have thought, this Marsha girl is a user of <Space Expansion> while still being a 4th year.

This is the lesser version of <Space Storage> and can only increase the capacity. However, space-type magic are extremely difficult so being able to use even this is praiseworthy.

When compared to <Transition Magic> which is already developed as techniques, this <Space Expansion> is much harder as it's still being researched.

Even just this proves that this Marsha girl has potential.

George and Mondo frantically scooped up the water and Aina purified it with magic.

And Marsha kept on putting purified water into the ordinary survival flasks.

That had good coordination considering how much they were complaining.

And, as for me–

“Ah, you can’t use magic, right, Satoru-kun? You don’t seem like you have much stamina either so could you search this area for any edible food?”

George told me.

By this area, he meant as far as their eyes could see.

I am not a kid so I don't plan on going away alone anyway but...

It seems like from their eyes, I am still quite young.

What is this treatment? I am pretty sure I have set my appearance as a 15 year old.

But either way, it's no use complaining so I decided to do what I could.

—As such, I attached a string to a tree branch and made a simple fishing tackle.

At times like this, clothes with threads come in handy. I am producing the strings by my own but this way I can easily deceive them.

As for the bait, I used the insects under the waterside rocks.

Insects which come up in your house are enemies, a target for annihilation, a subject for hatred but—it's weird how I can go around searching for insects myself in places like these.

I even disassembled the trap which the instructors gave us in case a harmful monster came up. And then I used it as a net to put the fish I catch in.

My preparations are perfect.

And like this, I prepared the tools and bait and started fishing.

“What are you doing?”

Marsha asked.

It seems like their job of collecting water is done.

When I looked at the other 3, I found them lying down,

exhausted.

Their stamina and mana probably ran out.

“Fishing. I was wondering if I could catch a few fishes and have them for dinner.”

I had already caught about 30.

Seems like this fishing place is really good as no one else has fished here before.

It’s my own personal record—catching 20 fishes in an hour.

“Fishing? Sounds interesting! Can I do it too?”

She asked with glittering eyes so I handed over the tools and showed her the basics.

It seems Marsha had never gone fishing before and was very interested.

After teaching her for a while, I told her to try it herself and she had immediately gotten enthusiastic about it.

She's quite something considering that the other 3 are exhausted and she is fine despite the fact that she used the most mana.

While giving her advice, I started making a second fishing rod—

Or I wanted to but...

By the time I was finished, Aina came by and by the time I had finished the 3rd one, George came and participated too.

At the end, even Mondo wanted to fish so the total amount of fish I caught that day was stopped at 33.

But still, not only did we secure water, the total amount of fish we caught was 104.

One could say this is more than enough.

But while returning, Marsha used <space compression> on the whole net and Aina used weight limit magic on it. Then George and Mondo did the physical labor of carrying it. I have decided to not think about how all the fish we caught would have gone to waste if they hadn't done all that.

All's well that ends well.

And like this, the first day of harvesting in the forest had come to an end.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 07

On our way back, Marsha suddenly let out a yell.

“Hey! I was just checking the bracelet just now and something crazy is going on with my points! For some reason my points have risen to 44?!”

Their attention drawn by her statement, everyone else checked their bracelets, as well.

“Uwo! I am only 19 points, eh?”

“I am 26.”

“I only have 15 points?”

George and the others informed each other of their points.

Following Marsha, Mondo had the highest points.

Hmm? Even if we did get points from our activities today, I thought it would have only been a few points....

When I hurriedly checked my points as well, surprisingly enough, it was at 41.

And when I checked how I got those points—it was listed that I got about 33 points from monster subjugation and 8 from support actions.

Oi, oi, fish also count as monsters?!

And what's this 8 points for support actions? Because I made a fishing rod for each of them?

Like 2 points for each? It's more of a shock that I only got 2 points for such painstaking work.

But still, this is too unfair, this way of earning points... even I am astounded.

“If support actions gave 2 points then—we get one point for each fish we catch?!”

“I see! I also caught about 24, if I remember correct, so there’s no mistaking it.”

“Don’t put on airs just ‘cause you won in fishing, Mondo. However, that settles it. I also remember catching 17 so each fish gives 1 point.”

I heard George and Mondo conversing.

Oh, shoot.

With this, scoring points becomes super easy.

I started panicking inside.

“Hahaha, this is stupid. Earning points so easily, the person who set it up must be an idiot. Those Greed Circus guys are quite the foolish bunch, huh?!”

“Right? I also think so. I was thinking it would be quite hard~ But this makes it a piece of cake, right~?”

George said with a laugh and Aina also followed up with a nod.

Their words hurt my ears.

Why? ‘Cause I was the one who set it up.

It’s just a bit, no, actually, quite a bit embarrassing.

I had set the 30 points to be the passing limit so Marsha has

already passed.

Mondo only needs 4 more points and even Aina who has the least points among them has earned about half the points needed.

<<Fufufu, exactly as calculated, huh, Rimuru-sama?>>

Ciel spoke to me happily while I was sulking.

What are you talking about?—when I asked her that, she replied with an atmosphere of ‘I know what you are planning’.

<<After today’s activities, Mondo, who is a dropout, will be viewed in a better light. And also Marsha, who has a talent for magic will be given a different role, right?>>

Wh-what?!

In other words, this grouping wasn't appropriate, as I thought. It seems they just grouped the problematic ones.

Well, that is fine now but the problem is what Ciel just said.

—A different role for Marsha... you say?

<<You will feign ignorance, I see. What exactly are you planning, keeping it a secret from me, as well?>>

Ciel answered, sounding like she was really enjoying herself.

Hahaha, it seems she has misunderstood, thinking that this was something I schemed.

Needless to say, I neither calculated for this to happen nor am I scheming anything.

All of this is just Ciel's misunderstanding but... I guess I will

use that for now.

—Fufu, as expected of Ciel. I can't hide things from you, can I? Mondo seemed like he lacked confidence so I just helped a bit, you see.

<<As I thought. However, that was too lenient of you. To use your valuable trick which you were saving for something like this- >>

Ah, hmm.

This isn't a valuable trick I reserved or anything, you see.

It's something even I didn't notice, you see.

I mean, who would think that an E rank monster giving 1 point would apply to fish as well, right?

There are no fish inside the labyrinth, after all.

And even if there were, they would be man-eating fish or demon fish living in the wetlands.

Well, even I kept small insects like mosquito or fleas to be not applicable.

Although the ones living in Apito's territory are different....

It was a complete mistake on my part but as Ciel-san saw it as one of my strategies, my dignity has been upheld for now.

I did think of changing the bracelet's settings by using the master command but I stopped.

If I did that, the points we got just now would look weird.

Besides—even regarding the fish strategy, since we caught this

much today, surely the catch will be less tomorrow.

It's something like a one-time bonus stage.

Just like Ciel said, a trick of a sort.

Even if the other students were to try and imitate, it wouldn't go as easily.

In the first place, it's difficult making the fishing rod.

That's probably not something they are taught in school and definitely not so simple that they can make it after seeing it once.

There's surely no one who thought—'oh, something like this might happen so let me bring my fishing rod along'.

And, above all, the only reason we were able to have such a big

catch was because I, being a gentleman as I am who likes fishing, went to all the trouble of making the fishing rod using Ciel-sensei's calculation abilities.

It will probably be fine to not worry about that.

And like that, with a total catch of 123 fish, we had made a triumphal return.

The scenario waiting for us at the rendezvous point was one of the exhausted students.

It seems even the fruits which looked good at first turned out to be poisonous after an appraisal using magic.

And even when they tried to hunt wild animals, it was another hardship as they had no access to any good equipment.

It seems one of the groups had created a pitfall and kept waiting for their pray to fall in but ultimately ended the day without a single hit.

Another group had used appraisal magic on all the plants and were about to completely run out of mana but still managed to gather only a small amount of food.

Another group seemed to have encountered a low level monster and gathering food had been the least of their worries as they desperately fought them off.

All the groups' achievements were poor and they had only earned a few points, making them feel even more depressed.

And without a doubt, our group had produced the best results.

“What is this?! How is Mondo being so useful?!”

“Shut up, Billy! I was there as the group leader so it's only natural!”

One of the exhausted students was jealous of Mondo's results and was trying to flare up at him but was put down by George.

Even after that, everyone was surprised by our group's high points and kept asking questions on what kind of activities we did.

The other groups had no other choice but to remain silent in front of my 41 points.

Although the highest points was earned by Marsha.

It seems Marsha's magic helped her earn some points—ultimately giving her 39 points for the fish and 5 for her magic.

I don't really care about losing in points but I can't accept losing to a beginner who started fishing just today.

I mean, sure, I was making fishing rods for the most part later on but... even still, it seems like there is a need to show her the awesomeness of an expert next time.

Well, leaving that aside.

George, Mondo, Aina and Marsha explained in detail about our activities today.

And after this and that, when we had reached the base, there were 15 tents completed.

It seems they were simple tents and building them was simpler than I had thought.

All of them only earned about 1-3 points so you can tell how much they really worked from that.

“Make sure to store stuff which should not get wet, inside the tent!”

I heard an instructor say.

They are probably going to use a big tent for a shared storage space.

There was also a tent for meetings and a particularly extravagant one for the nobles.

‘Are you kidding me? That’s unfair!’ — it was luxurious enough to make me want to say that out loud.

Well, I guess it’s fine. I don’t really want to sleep outdoors either so it was fortunate that someone had tents.

The thought of blowing it away by a sudden gust did cross my mind but that would lead to my points being decreased.

I should think of something to make my tent’s interior better.

While I was looking at the complete tents, the students started preparing for dinner after taking a small break.

Our group also started working, so I decided to help out.

“Is our group preparing the exploration group’s portion as well?”

When I asked, Marsha replied,

“Right... I do want to but I am not really good at cooking...”

“Eh, not really good? You’re nowhere near—”

“Do you have something you would like to say, Mondo-kun?”

Mondo tried to say something there but stopped after being overwhelmed by Marsha.

Even George was pretending as if he didn’t hear anything and was preparing the stones for the stove. It seems it would be wise for me to pretend I didn’t hear anything either.

“Aina—”

“What is it~ Satoru-kun~?”

This is bad.

I feel like I might step on a landmine.

I could spot George on the other side shaking his head so I understood that these two are out of the equation.

“No, just that I would like to ask you and Marsha to gather some branches to burn for the fire, is that okay?”

“That’s completely alright!”

“That would be easy~if we combine our magic, huh?”

George told them to be careful and not get out of sight.

This place is surrounded by hills but the entrance to the forest can be seen clearly.

The other groups also seemed like they were going to gather some branches so these two girls should be fine.

Normally, our roles would be opposite but since we have magic here, we do not decide on anything with just physical abilities.

As such, we didn't pursue the topic any further and started our work.

After driving away the two girls, I started dealing with the fish.

As there was no kitchen knife, I prepared it with the small survival knife.

I could tell that there were no parasite or poison in the fish with my Appraisal but I feigned ignorance and asked them to

check it again.

“Yep, it’s fine! There doesn’t seem to be any problem!”

Mondo told me with a lively voice.

He is probably excited about being able to eat something other than the rations. I have been hearing his stomach roaring for a while now so I could tell how much he was looking forward to it.

“Alright, then all that’s left is to grill it.”

When I raised my face, I saw that the students from other groups coming to watch.

The students studying at the academies probably have experienced camping but they don’t have survival training. As such, even if you hand them fish or grass, they won’t know how to cook it.

I guess I have no choice.

“I will do it once more so you guys can prepare your food yourselves.”

As I said that, the students watching me looked relieved and hurriedly started to imitate what I did.

When I had finished preparing the portion for the exploration group, a major problem came to light.

We don't have any seasoning.

Are you serious?! This instructor, he has survival kit but not this?!

It's only natural to prepare the stuff you can't get naturally before camping.

“I am sorry! My Space Storage was full with the tents...”

Instructor A came earnestly apologizing to me, someone who isn't even a student.

I don't know his name so A is good enough.

He had bandages wrapped around his arms and his head so he's probably one of the instructors who fought against Laplace. It appears that Laplace also held back enough, since these guys are already healed enough to move.

It seems he was the only one carrying tents but to me, seasoning is much more important than tents.

“Seasoning is more important than tents!”

“I-I am sorry! I thought we would be enduring with the rations when camping so...”

“So you don’t have anything?”

“Umm... I have a bit of salt...”

“You have salt? Then it’s fine.”

Ah, I am relieved. I am really relieved.

Salt is all-purpose so we were able to avoid the worst case scenario.

He also had some citrus fruit so the salt and dripping some fruit juice on the fish should be enough.

Instructor A handed over the salt to me, feeling ashamed.

I took the salt with a smile.

He probably thought my anger had dissolved seeing my smile and shamelessly mixed with the other students and started imitating me.

I shall overlook this considering he provided the salt.

The students also looked relieved after hearing our conversation.

“This kid is scary~”

“He was really overwhelming, huh? Peter-sensei looked quite scared, didn’t he?”

“T-there’s no way. No way the sensei would be scared of an ordinary person, like a kid!”

I could hear such conversations but since I was in a good mood, I decided not to bother.

The problem is the salt.

It seems he wasn't joking when he said he only had a bit of it.
It looks like we will run out of salt soon.

Maybe even tomorrow.

While thinking to myself that I have to do something for tomorrow, I continued the work.

Dinner was in barbecue style.

In this situation, when we don't even have cooking equipment, the methods in which we can cook are limited.

The exploration group brought back edible monsters so I processed those too.

They could do that themselves since it is taught in their

lessons.

It seems they also knew how to find out if it could be eaten or not so there doesn't seem to be a problem.

However, just in case, I used my Appraisal carefully on it and found out that not only was the processing not done properly, the monster's meat was crushed with a sword and so the quality was very low.

But we can't really be asking for much.

I also prepared it with chopped up herbs.

As if he was in our group to begin with, Magnus came mixing in.

He looked around and was searching for me.

He's very annoying but once you get used to him, he seems more like a dog.

“Yo, Satoru-chan. You also prepared our portion!”

Too over-familiar.

And the looks from the surrounding is annoying too.

“Not for your sake, though.”

“Now, now. Are you tsundere?”

Oh just shut up.

I think there might be a need to call him out to the back and deal with him.

While thinking that, I decided to first grill the fish properly.

It gave off a savory scent, stimulating everyone's appetite.

In addition to the best spice of them all—an empty stomach, these are also the fish I caught so I grilled them good.

I mean, of course, if one were to judge it normally, it wouldn't be as good as Shuna's cooking. However, from the fact that I caught and cooked these by myself in this natural environment, this rivals the best cooking out there.

“Delicious! What is this? It's super delicious!”

Magnus, who was annoying me, took a bite and shouted.

“You're exaggerating, idiot.”

Saying that, I also took a bite.

Delicious!

Are you serious?!

I only grilled some fish. It must have been of high quality.

And such voices could be heard from here and there, proving that we weren't the only ones finding it delicious.

Mondo was eating with his whole heart and soul. Tears were flowing out of his eyes, crying at the bliss of a full stomach.

And looking at us with annoyed expressions were the great nobles from their own table, lined up with high class cooking.

I don't know how many days worth of food they have. It seems they have a whole separate menu for themselves as well.

Well, that's fine for now.

The monster meat wasn't that good but it was edible.

We don't even have seasoning so this is how it's supposed to be. It was enough to fill the belly.

And like this, we were enjoying a much more balanced meal than I thought we would.

After dinner.

"Well, how did the exploration go?"

I was full now so I asked casually.

"Yeah. It is going smoother than I thought. That Julius, pompous guy but he's surprisingly good. He's noble —royalty at that too, and so is quite good at using others. Thanks to that, we were able to cover plenty of distance without having a single drop-out. We should be able to see the coastline within 3 more days."

It seems Julius looked capable even from Magnus' point of view.

He might actually be good if he got rid of that elitism.

It looks like he also looks up to Masayuki so telling him to lecture Julius might do the trick.

“Hmm. is that so? Strong monsters will probably come out so be sure to be on guard.”

Since they had no problems today, I just gave a simple advice.

I don't think there will be any but I would like to avoid any casualties caused from a lack of awareness.

“Haha, you are worrying for us, aren't you?”

“There's no need for your worry! There's no way Magnus-

sama will be taken off by lowly monsters!”

The girl who is always beside Magnus raged.

“Yes, yes. Well, either way, don’t let your guard down.”

I stood up as I said that.

“Yea, I know. Rosary, calm down.”

“I am calm!”

With that behind me, I left to tidy up.

That night.

Feeling the presence of a sleeping magic activate, I opened my eyes.

As this body is really close to a human's body, it is possible for me to imitate sleeping by thinning out my consciousness but since I have no need for sleep, sleeping magic doesn't work on me.

However, the target for the magic wasn't me—it was the other female students sleeping in my tent.

Marsha, Aina and two others.

I was put in their tent. I told them I was fine with the boys' tent but was rejected by everyone.

“But, I am a guy—”

“Even if you're a guy.”

They told me they were worried more about me than themselves.

As I was also being persuaded by George and Mondo who didn't believe me at all, I decided to bend since it was getting bothersome.

Or rather, since I am used to being cared by Shuna or Shion, this much doesn't really disturb me.

And as such, I was in the same tent as the girls but–

This doesn't seem to be a sneak visit.

“Satoru-dono, are you there?”

I could hear a small voice calling for me.

I was thinking of going to them myself but it seems they came contacting me first.

“Yeah, let's go.”

“Haha!”

I answered to the call and quietly exited the tent.

The one who greeted me by kneeling as if it was only normal was William Loaz, the elder magic instructor of Ingracia Synthesis Academy.

“You noticed?”

“Of course. I realized with one glance. However, Souei-sama said to keep it a secret in his message so...”

From what he explained while we were changing locations, it seems this elder William is one of Souei’s spies.

Even though I say spy, he is actually a subordinate of a subordinate of Souka.

It seems all of the spies lurking in each of the countries started moving as I gave the order to Souei to investigate the academies.

Even though I say that, these spies normally look for the country's movements and so small stuff like investigating the academies aren't included in their job.

They are people who deal with things on a much greater scale.

They normally gather circumstantial evidence of interior corruption or expose injustice. And it seems there were also people who were in the academies to investigate.

William was also one of them.

"I thought my heart would stop when I received the direct Thought Transmission from Souei-sama."

He said, probably remembering of that time, as he trembled a bit.

That is true.

I understand his feeling—being directly contacted by someone who is like above the clouds.

It even seems he is more afraid of Souei than me.

No, that's probably it.

Souei is—no, Souei and everyone in the information department are quite strict on their subordinates...

It seems they don't have the expression 'in the worst case scenario' in their dictionary.

Failure=death — they are even feared by other sections.

I was lead to the tent made for the instructors.

As I entered, the instructors knelt down.

Brown, the guy who lost to Laplace at first, Pury, the doctor and Blum, the plump, old man.

There was also this other guy, called Heinrich, who seemed like an intelligent researcher. He is the guy who identified the mana storm covering the island.

And—

Shaking in his boots was the instructor who gave me salt before, Instructor A—or as I came to know later, Peter-sensei.

“Oh? If it isn’t Peter-sensei.”

“Gyaaahh—! P-please forgive me!”

What a wonderful dogeza.

He went from kneeling to a jumping dogeza.

Really, this is my first seeing it... a jumping dogeza.

“I won’t do anything.”

“R-really?! Then, you will forgive me?”

I wondered what was there to forgive? —but his reactions are too suspicious.

“Before I decide on that, tell me what you did.”

I can’t think that he would be this scared just from treating me like that.

That’s what I thought when asking him but...

One after another came out, his evidence of neglect.

It seems even for the tents, it was just him choosing to not be bothered to tidying it up.

I was exasperated, listening to his trivial sins confessions.

“Got it. 3 months of salary cut.”

“Ha, eh? Hahaa!!”

“However, don’t slack off from now on, alright?”

“O-of course!”

“Then it’s fine.”

This is too stupid so I let Peter off the hook with a salary cut.

And then.

They introduced themselves formally once again.

All the instructors here are all under the supervision of the information department.

In other words, they are enthusiastic fellows who haven't been corrupted.

All the three Tempest's instructors in the island were here.

Actually, Peter here is also a battle type instructor from Tempest.

I am glad that there were no corrupted instructors in my home, Tempest.

Although I don't know what is happening at the actual

academy, since Souei should be entering there now. Either way, there doesn't seem to be any here so that's good.

And from the Ingracia Synthesis Academy were William and Blum.

Heinrich was the only one from NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy.

These people were the collaborators.

Either way, I can trust these 6.

I decided to drag these 6 in this and started a discussion on what to do next.

Side Story – Rimuru's Elegant Escape Plan – 08

The next morning, I was suffering due to the pain all over my body.

The first thing I felt was that something was wrong with my back and legs.

Was it just me? I wondered, but then the piercing pain started to rush through me.

In the blink of an eye, it spread through my entire body, and not being able to bear it any longer, I woke up.

—Hey, Ciel! My body whole body hurts for some reason!?

<<There is no problem. It is only sore muscles.>>

Ciel said with a lack of concern.

What? Sore muscles...!?

For a second, I didn't even understand what it was that she said.

This was because I never got sore muscle ever since I was reincarnated into a slime.

Not only that, I had 'Pain Nullification,' so I wasn't supposed to feel any pain...

<<I was obeying your order of not wanting to be suspected and made you close to a human. Should I turn the pain off?>>

Ciel said, and I finally understood.

I see. Yes, having sore muscles would not be strange if I were human. Actually, it would be the most natural thing.

I was moving nonstop yesterday, and my feet were tired. And sleeping in a tent without a real bed meant that my body would not be recovering all that much.

It wasn't only me, but Marsha and Aina also looked like they had not slept well.

If I cut the pain off now, it would draw attention as being very strange. After all, I was a terrible actor.

And so I gave up on being relieved of the pain and decided that I would just have to bear it for a while.

The others awoke, and the second day of our survival began.

Breakfast was just rations, and we used the containers to hold water to replace water bottles.

It was good that the water that had taken so much effort to get yesterday was useful now.

The exploration group was cheerful today as well.

I didn't see anyone who was still affected by the fatigue of yesterday.

They were trained differently to me.

Actually, I now had a body that had no training at all, so that only made matters even worse...

In any case, the exploration group did their roll-call in full gear in front of the magic circle, and then set out after the physical boost magic had spread to all of them.

After watching them leave, the rest of us that remained started to act.

I wanted to do something about salt today.

And I had also planned to gather any kind of seeds that could be used as a replacement for pepper.

You only needed a little salt and pepper to enhance the flavor of meat.

To be honest, while I could bear the pain of my sore muscles, I could not bear having to eat bad food.

I felt like I was whipping my sore body as I walked over to the others in the group.

“You look like you’re in pain. Are you alright?”

Mondo said with some concern.

To be blunt, this pain which I had not felt in over a decade, was quite severe.

However, my pride did not allow me to be the only person to give up.

“Of course, I’m alright. More importantly, where are we going today?”

“Huh? Aren’t we going fishing today as well?”

I said while pushing back the pain. George looked at me with surprise.

“I thought that it was fishing today again.”

“Me too.”

Marsha and Aina also thought we were going fishing.

Mondo was nodding, so he must have been thinking the same thing.

“Considering what happened yesterday, we probably won’t catch much. I don’t think we should go fishing today. Besides, we ran out of salt yesterday. Unless we find something to replace it, we won’t be able to eat our catch in a way that tastes good, you know?”

I explained, and everyone agreed.

“It seems like everyone else is going towards the watering hole anyway. And I want to explore in a different direction from yesterday...”

That way, it would be only us who would be acting separately from the gathering group. There weren’t enough instructors to escort us, and it was a little risky from a safety perspective, making it the most realistic for the others to investigate near the watering hole.

“Alright. Let’s gather all kinds of plants and seeds today!”

George declared excitedly, and we nodded in agreement.

The students that had been out gathering yesterday were only looking for fruits that were edible.

However, today I intended to search for herbs or seeds that could be used as condiments. They could probably be used as a preservatives for the meat from the hunted monsters as well. So acquiring plants with those properties would be important.

Well, perhaps it wasn't all that important, given that this was only one week.

That being said, it wasn't a waste, since this was primarily aimed at educating the students.

And like that, our day of gathering had begun.



It was a block in the city which was surrounded by a gigantic wall.

Diablo moved boldly through the streets, not caring about the eyes around him.

Not only did he rarely leave the central office building in Tempest, but he was able to freely travel anywhere through 'Spatial Travel,' so the act of walking the streets was very refreshing to Diablo.

It was Souei who walked next to him.

He wasn't wearing his usual attire, but wore the same kind of casual clothing that the city residents wore.

Diablo did the same in a black shirt and pants.

However.

Despite the common design of Souei and Diablo's clothes, the material was high-quality material that had magic threads made in Tempest, woven into the fabric. They were so expensive, that most onlookers would go pale just imagining how much they

would cost.

On top of that, they also wore accessories that were imbued with ultra-advanced magic, and it was hard to imagine a more extravagant way to dress while walking outside.

However, it wasn't the clothes they wore that was drawing attention.

The main reason was clear, once it was noted that the ratio of men and women staring at them favored women quite heavily.

To put it plainly, they were two very handsome men that were walking.

“They are looking at us. They are so rude.”

Normally there was not a single person with a death wish in the central office who would dare look straight at Diablo.

Be they civil officer or even military officer, all would kneel and look down when passing him in the hallway.

Indeed, there were only a handful of individuals aside from the ones higher up who could take a casual attitude around Diablo.

“Don’t let it bother you. It’s just that your clothes stick out too much.”

“What are you saying. I am all in black and look very plain...”

Souei ignored Diablo’s grumbling, but Diablo was not satisfied.

He had prepared his most plain clothing because they would be going out into the city in secret. And so it was only normal for him to be annoyed at the suggestion that he was drawing too much attention.

(There will be a punishment when we return.)

He decided, even though he couldn't even remember the face of the person in charge of his clothes. Still, this was not enough to calm his annoyance.

"I know! What if we recognize the action of staring at us as aggression, and have them all killed..."

"Don't do that. This is why I didn't want to come here with you."

Diablo had made this suggestion very happily, but Souei callously rejected it.

And so they continued to be stared at by residents until they reached their destination.

Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy–

It was Tempest's central education facility that was built under Rimuru's sponsorship.

And this place was one of the best educational facilities available and was one of the three great schools of the world.

Rimuru had ordered that Souei investigate it, and Diablo had come along as well.

They were in front of the gate now, and Souei was talking with someone.

Diablo began to look around aimlessly, and then he spotted a strange group of people.

They wore matching white robes and had hoods that covered their faces.

They seemed to have a detection blocking effect as well, and he could not tell what their races or abilities were.

Demon Lord Milim's 'Dragon Eye' would have been able to see through it without a problem, but Diablo's 'Demon Eye' did not allow him to pry deeper.

(Hmph, how boring.)

Diablo said with annoyance.

Diablo was hardly a perfectionist, and he had his subordinate, Moss to gather information for him. But still, having people who he could not detect standing right in front of him was a problem that he could not ignore.

As Rimuru had released information, the magic in this country had advanced greatly.

Because of this, anti-devil weaponry had also been improved, and now the demons could no longer feel completely safe, even though they were the strongest race.

These days, if you just had the money, it was possible to acquire weapons that were the equivalent of Legend grade.

Even this was still inconsequential to Diablo. But the fact that there was now concealment magic that exceeded his detection

on the market, was something he couldn't just leave.

That being said, Diablo was currently pretending to be human and only using one-hundredth of his magic. His abilities had dropped accordingly, and his power now was a far cry from what it usually was...

Diablo's 'Demon Eye' was also affected by his magic, so comparing it to Rimuru or Milim, whose powers did not depend on it, was not exactly fair.

But that wasn't an excuse for Diablo. He did not like this at all.

(The wearers are estimated to be at holy knight level. But they've acquired Legend grade weapons and gained power. Something like that...)

They were not strong enough for him to be cautious.

Even now, if Diablo took them head-on, he could kill all of them in less than a minute.

But still, something about this irritated him. It had to do with the atmosphere that oozed out from the group.

Diablo was about to take a step forward, but someone grabbed his shoulder with a ‘Don’t.’

“You try to cause trouble the moment that I take my eyes off of you.”

Souei said with exasperation.

“Hehehe. No, that’s just not true. Those people were unsettling, so I thought I might talk to them...”

“That is what I mean by ‘causing problems.’”

Souei said and shook his head.

However, he knew that this would happen the moment that

Diablo had started to talk about coming with him, and so while he was exasperated, he did not complain.

Souei glanced at the group that Diablo had indicated but continued to talk calmly without the faintest change in expression.

“We got a message from Moss. He arrived safely and contacted a magic teacher from the Ingracia Academy called William Roaz, who was cooperating as a spy.”

“Oh, that is convoluted.”

Diablo nodded at Souei’s words.

He had already lost all interest in the group with the white robes.

To Diablo, the only thing that was important was the movements of Rimuru, his master.

It was because Souei understood this, that he brought it up.

After Laplace had left, Diablo had called for Moss.

And then he ordered for the smallest 'Clone' that was made from Moss to be relocated close to Rimuru without anyone noticing.

This mission was put into effect by Moss's 'Clone' using 'Shadow Movement' through the 'Sticky Steel String' that connected Souei and Rimuru.

'Spatial Travel' allowed you to arrive immediately, but they could not do anything like that since it would draw attention.

And just now, after flying through the shadow space at super high speed, Moss contacted him to announce that he had succeeded in landing on Maldoland island.

It would be best if Rimuru did not notice, but it didn't really matter either way.

Just like Diablo, Rimuru's power had also been weakened.

Actually, he had dropped it to be level with humans, so it had dropped at a much more severe rate compared to Diablo.

So perhaps he would not find out, but Diablo would not get his hopes up regarding this.

(Normally, it would be ideal to protect him from the shadows...but it's not possible to hide things from Lord Rimuru.)

That's what Diablo thought.

Moss had landed on the island and made contact with this William.

He gave the new 'Sticky Steel Ring' that Souei had entrusted to him to William, and they had communicated through 'Thought Transmission.'

He had likely used this direct method of contact to avoid the possibility of it being intercepted.

In this aspect, Souei was very cautious. Diablo was so impressed that he left a lot of matters to him.

“So, what did Moss say?”

“Don’t get so excited. According to the collaborator–William, Laplace is doing well. The combat instructors were better than expected and were trying to resist.”

“Well, that’s obvious. The academy is sponsored by Lord Rimuru. They have no need for useless people there.”

“However...”

“However?”

Souei ignored Diablo's words and talked about the report from William.

And he knew full well that Diablo would be furious upon hearing it.

"It seems that there were teachers who didn't try to protect the students."

Diablo became enraged in an instant.

"Kill them all. That's what we should tell Moss."

Diablo said with a smile.

There was no need to differentiate there. He wanted everyone other than Rimuru and the students massacred.

Souei sighed deeply and then continued without changing his

expression.

“I told you not to get too excited. Lord Rimuru has gone through the trouble of going out there for the very purpose of exposing those wretches. Lord Rimuru is not one to throw away the entire box because of one rotten fruit.”

Behind those words lay a certain sentiment: Lord Rimuru would never allow such a thing, you idiot!

Diablo realized this and retaliated to Souei.

“...That may be. But Lord Rimuru shouldn't have to be bothered by such a small thing...”

“Indeed, I agree with that. And that is why we will deal with whoever mixed the rotten fruits in the box. It will have to be severe, so they will never think of something so foolish ever again.”

“Oh? So, there is a possibility that someone is deliberately

meddling with the academy. Is that what you are saying?”

“Exactly. However, it is still under investigation whether it is coming from within the academy or from the outside.”

After hearing these words, Diablo’s eye narrowed and he smiled.

It might have seemed like a gentle expression, but it was actually an incredibly cold one.

So much so, that some of the women who saw him as they walked passed them on the streets ended up losing consciousness.

This both satisfied and calmed Diablo to a certain degree, and so he asked Souei to continue.

He had decided to hold back on his wrath until the time came to differentiate and judge those who were to be dealt with.

Souei had been right all along.

Once Diablo had become calm, he could immediately realize that there was no way that Rimuru would allow them to waste the personnel that he had spent so much effort in raising.

It was only normal for him to work to remove the root of the problem instead.

Souei saw that Diablo was satisfied with this, and continued his explanation.

Currently, the only people who know of Rimuru's identity were the teachers who William, the collaborator, had seen as trustworthy.

Souei had also agreed to this and had seen it as a convenient thing for Rimuru in the reeducation of the students.

“Hmm. However, what if this William doesn't have the best judgment?”

“If that happens, then we’ll have to kill them all, including William.”

Souei said bluntly.

Souei himself felt that it was his error that he had not realized the current situation at the academy until Rimuru had pointed it out. And while he would make distinctions unlike Diablo, he meant to still put a purge into effect.

Diablo liked his answer and readily agreed.

It would not be good to bother Rimuru while he enjoyed the island. Both of them agreed on that point and also on the point that they should avoid any meddling past a certain point.

Because of this, they should also respect the decisions of the teachers there and leave the rest to Rimuru.

They would carry out the orders that they had been given.

That was the answer that they settled on.

Diablo and Souei looked at each other and nodded before walking through the gates of the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 09

Diablo and Souei were led to the president’s office.

Diablo was deep in thought and did not even glance at the person who had guided them and bowed politely before leaving.

He understood Souei’s argument. And he knew that it was right.

What Souei thought, was that if the academy was decaying, the reason must be that someone was doing it deliberately.

If that was the case, he was right to stop Diablo who was just going to purge it.

Unlike his master who wanted to save everyone, Diablo felt that it was his role to convict people. However, if there was a possibility of self-correction still left in the academy, then it was his job to watch over it.

Politics and finances, research and culture, and military defense.

They needed to nurture personnel who could be active in these fields.

And in an ideal environment where people helped each other and did not allow corruption and in-fighting.

That was the ideal the Rimuru had established.

As for the realization of this ideal society, Rimuru himself had said that it was impossible. But he had also said that the process of pursuing this ideal, and the effort put into eradicating the foundations for corruption, was his true aim.

Veldanava tried to lead people through having a Demon Lord become the enemy of humankind.

Emperor Rudra tried to make humankind unite and stop fighting by having the angels strictly monitor civilization.

As for the great Demon Lord Rimuru, who Diablo loved and respected, he wanted to decrease the corruption itself through changing the very nature of humans and increasing their ability to self-correct.

And so attempting to corrupt the academy was to go against Rimuru's aim completely. It was the actions of an enemy.

It was a challenge against Diablo.

(Hmm. I thought that it was just that the self-correction wasn't working, but there's a possibility that that isn't the case. Indeed, if that's the case, I was imprudent to try and deal with it so simply. Still, it's hard to think that there is anyone so foolish to try and sabotage Lord Rimuru's plans...)

Diablo switched his way of thinking.

He had intended to deal with the incompetent people in Rimuru's place, but that was a mistake.

If there were people who were so foolish as to try and upset Rimuru's policy for the academy, and they were successful, then it was him who was the incompetent one.

–He would crush these enemies.

With a clear will, Diablo listened to what the president had to say.

As Diablo and Souei sat on a sofa in front of him, the president began to explain the situation.

This president was one of the early goblin members who had evolved after being named by Rimuru, so there was never any fear of betrayal. However, he was aware that he was being tested as well, and so he dripped sweat as he desperately spoke.

He seemed to be acquainted with Souei, but the fact that both Diablo and Souei had visited him, seemed to suggest to him that he had failed in some aspect, which made him very uneasy.

There was a report from the collaborator that Souei had prepared.

According to it, there was no chaos that could be observed from any awareness of rank or prejudice with the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy.

Souei checked all of these and had them confirmed.

Diablo observed these details and determined whether or not there were lies mixed in with the president's words.

Souei's questions continued without trouble.

However...

"Now, the last question. It seems that some of the teachers have taken an arrogant attitude towards the students. Why is this?"

Upon hearing this, the president's face looked severely bewildered.

Diablo continued to smile as he observed his face carefully.

It seemed that Souei had used his own routes to gain various information.

(He's a very reliable man at these times. It's no wonder that Lord Rimuru assigned 'secrecy' to him.)

Diablo was impressed as he watched the scene unfold.

"Yes, this problem has been bothering me..."

The president said while looking very troubled.

He was apparently going to lay everything out honestly, instead of doubting Souei's words.

Diablo and Souei listened to him.

This was his explanation.

There was a system in place for exchanging students between schools, and the same system also exchanged teachers.

However, there were times when the teachers of nobility from the Ingracia Academy would take an oppressive attitude towards the students.

And it was these noble teachers who brought these men in white robes with them as guards.

“Preposterous. The three schools are all equal. I cannot understand why these teachers would treat the students in this way.”

Said Souei.

And this was the president's answer,

“About that, they insist that they are teaching the students about how to behave towards nobles before going out into the world... Additionally, it seems that the NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy is receiving financial aid, and so they have sided with their stance. And because all three schools are supposed to be equal, their case has gone through...”

Not only didn't they have a clear reason for objecting, but the other schools were in agreement. And so he had no choice but to allow them to continue, explained the president.

And while he said 'noble,' all of the teachers who worked at the Ingracia Academy would have to add 'former' before it. But there were still kingdoms who kept the noble class, so they were not entirely wrong, either.

It was not a bad thing to learn how to deal with people in a polite way.

And while it was practically bribery to change one sides

opinion with monetary aid, there was no clear proof of it.

It was a difficult thing for the president, but as it had not caused any serious trouble yet, he had remained silent. That was the situation.

Diablo thought.

Until a moment ago, he would have decided that they should all be killed. But not now.

If there was an enemy, he should find out what they were thinking so he could rout them out completely.

He would not just pull out the stem and leaves and allow the roots to remain.

“Also...they, in fact, have tremendous abilities as well. The men in white robes are significantly stronger than our school’s combat teachers. Perhaps it will be a good stimulant for the students...”

The president finally added.

Hmm. Diablo continued to think.

After hearing this explanation, he was sure of the enemies existence.

The group of people in white robes that he had passed by must be the men that the president was talking about. They did seem quite capable, and he would not be surprised if they were stronger than the instructors of the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy.

Diablo was now happy that he hadn't carelessly approached them.

He was thankful to Souei for stopping him. He was letting his guard down recently, since things were so peaceful these days.

They must be the enemy.

But what was their aim?

By making this clear, he would be able to understand the scale of their operations and plan accordingly.

Was it to make the students feel inferior?

Or perhaps it was to corrupt the students themselves?

And if that was the case, what would they gain in return?

Diablo's thoughts moved rapidly.

He made predictions, checked the results and gains from it, and began to select plans that seemed to add up...

There were a few possibilities that he came upon.

These led him to one final possibility.

“Hehehehe. President. I have one question, if I may?”

“Uh, yes, of course. What is it?”

Diablo had suddenly addressed him, and while he seemed very surprised, the president turned to him.

He did not expect Diablo to ask him a question in such a polite manner.

“Oh, you don’t need to act so seriously. What I wanted to ask is this; among the teachers who were sent from the Ingracia Academy, did any of them make any requests regarding the dispatching of personnel?”

Upon hearing this question, the president became silent for a while and thought.

But then he looked up and straight into Diablo's eyes and said, 'I do not remember ever receiving such a request.'

But his words didn't end there.

"Indeed, I have never heard of such a request from the teachers that are former nobles. They only introduced us to those men in white robes, the Glory Knights. However, I heard that a number of these Glory Knights were sent to NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy, so there is a possibility that some kind of request has been made there."

"Hehehehe. Good. That will be most helpful."

Diablo thanked him with a gentle smile.

This fit with what he had been considering, and he felt that the possibility he had arrived at was practically confirmed.

"Diablo, did you realize something?"

“I did. Well, the enemies purpose, anyway. However, I don’t even know the size of their forces or who is behind it all.”

“...Hmph. That should be enough. Let’s go.”

The two of them whispered so that the president could not hear, and then they quickly got up from their seats.

“Well then, we will be leaving now.”

“Please keep this visit a secret between us.”

Diablo and Souei said. Then they left the room behind them.

The president who was left in the room had a vague idea that something was about to happen. But the only thing that he could do was keep silent, just as they had told him.

–He was the only one here who was confused, and the rest of

the academy went about their day as usual.



Diablo left the academy and headed to the airport.

Souei followed him without saying anything.

But then he finally opened his mouth just as the airport came into view.

“Are you going to tell me, Diablo?”

Hehehehe. Diablo smiled and then nodded.

“Of course, Souei. But first, we must buy our tickets.”

“Are we going to the empire?”

“...No. We’re going to Ingracia.”

“Oh?”

He kept quiet after that, and the two of them bought their tickets for the airship.

And then they used their spare time until departure to visit the luxury restaurant on the highest floor of the airport.

They entered a secluded room that was completely soundproof.

Even here, the two of them tended to draw attention, but they no longer cared about that.

“Now, let’s hear it.”

Souei began.

Diablo wet his tongue on the expensive fire wine he had ordered, then he opened his red lips.

“Hehehe. But first, let me ask you. Why did you stop me earlier?”

“It’s simple. Lord Rimuru has strictly forbidden any acts of violence against persons who have not taken clearly aggressive actions towards us.”

Setting aside the killing of traitors and punishing those who cause harm, that was the general rule of Tempest. And he had to follow it, even if he was of the elite.

This was the same for Souei as well. He did not intend on purging without Rimuru’s permission. And so Souei found it necessary to gather evidence first.

“And you were right, I’m sure. However, I don’t want to bother Lord Rimuru over such small matters. Surely you can understand my stance as well?”

Diablo looked at Souei with narrowed eyes and used ‘Demon Lord’s Haki.’

But Souei replied with a cool expression.

“Are you still going on about that? That is blasphemy, and unforgivable.”

Diablo listened and then nodded happily.

Yes, as if it were the answer that he had wanted to hear.

And then he continued as if erasing all of the pressure he had been exuding a second ago.

“Very good, Souei. Even when I was pressuring you, you stopped me without flinching. I was actually trying to threaten you rather seriously just now.”

“Whether you are serious or just lying, my actions will remain the same. If one of my comrades make a mistake, it is for me to stop them.”

“...That’s what I wanted to hear. That kind of self-correction among comrades is important. I think that is what Lord Rimuru believes. And when one of us goes astray, it is necessary to draw a clear line. That is what I think.”

And so Diablo explained his idea to Souei.

The reason that the president of the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy could not act this time was that there was no concrete evidence.

Even if the other schools were acting suspiciously, it was up to the views of people to determine whether it was right or wrong.

That meant that you could not judge what someone was doing as being evil just by your own intuition.

This was why there was a system of deciding by a majority, and you could not go against it.

So of course, it did not make sense to just blame the president.

The real problem was the lack of a surveillance system.

Monetary aid and bribery. They had different names but the result was the same. In that case, it was necessary to find proof of these actions.

What was needed was the establishment of a system that you could report to when you thought that something suspicious was happening.

“Regarding that, that was my mistake. I had my spy search the place, but no detailed reports had come up.”

“I too have become lax due to the peace. Though, your spy may need to be punished...”

“That’s my concern. Now, you were talking about drawing a line. What do you mean?”

Souei’s eyes were telling him to get to the main subject.

Diablo continued to smile as he did just that.

“In other words, they attacked that line.”

“What...?”

“Let me ask you a question. Do you think that people from other countries can meddle in the politics of our country?”

To Diablo’s question, Souei replied with, ‘Impossible.’

It was true.

Tempest's political structure was separated into an Upper House and Lower House, and bills that were passed by the Lower House would still be discarded if the Upper House rejected it.

The Upper House was made up of the elite, and only those that Rimuru chose were allowed to join it.

The administration itself had Rigurdo at the top, and the members of the Lower House were elected by citizens. But in matters of legislation, the Upper House held much more power.

And during times of war, all of the institutions would serve under the Upper House.

As long as this system was in place, even if a foreigner gained citizenship, it would be difficult for them to meddle in the country's politics.

Even if they managed to join the Lower House, they could not gain the highest level of power in decision making.

“Exactly. But what about in matters of business? Or in important institutions such as research?”

Souei’s answer was exactly the same.

His answer was that it was ‘impossible.’

Rimuru was surprisingly stingy when it came to money, and he had acquired all the vested interests in advance.

There was no chance of getting in afterward.

As for the research institutions, heavyweights of the country such as Ramiris and Veldora were involved there, and of course, they left no room for people of other countries to enter.

“Yes! In other words, if those of other countries wanted to enter these important institutions, they will have to wait for the next generation. If they tried then...”

“I see. That’s the connection to the academy...”

Yes. Diablo nodded.

It meant that the enemy was at least smart enough to know that it was a waste of effort to try and force people in now.

So they would likely plan in the long term instead of just thinking in the short term.

You could say that these were formidable opponents.

–Corrupt the students and create discrepancies in their abilities.

If that happened, brilliant people will naturally flow into Tempest.

The students of Tempest would faithfully follow Rimuru’s

words, and would not act with hostility towards any humans. That's why they were probably holding their heads down now.

And like this, the enemy forces would start to control them and gain new authority.

This was a long term plan that took this all into account...

However, because Rimuru had a distrust of the students at the academy, they had succeeded in catching the enemy's plan by the tail.

"That is Lord Rimuru. He must have seen through everything."

Diablo said in an emotional voice.

Really? Souei seemed to doubt it, but he knew that voicing it would just make Diablo angry, so he kept quiet. He did feel like there was not any contradiction in Diablo's theory, and he couldn't think of any other purpose.

And so he brushed it aside and asked Diablo a different question.

“So, why Ingracia? Can’t we just go to the empire and find proof of the bribery?”

Diablo kept smiling as he answered.

“Indeed, I thought of that too. However, I had one doubt when it came to that.”

“Doubt?”

“Yes. A simple thing, really. These people are no longer nobles, so where did these funds come from?”

“...I see. There is a need to investigate that.”

“Yes. Even if we found proof of this bribery, what if it’s not

real...you cannot bribe someone without money, after all. The Ingracia Kingdom was one of the kingdoms that were left alone because of Lord Rimuru's kindness. I don't think the money came from the western countries, but it will be necessary to find out clearly where the money came from."

"I understand. You are probably correct to think in this way."

Souei said and closed his mouth.

The only thing left was to find out who was behind it all...

Diablo's idea was simple.

They were not sure of the size of the enemy forces and the leader. That was all true, but it was clear that it was someone involved with the academy.

They should remain calm and slowly apply pressure to this enemy.

If they did that, the enemy would reveal itself without a doubt.

Diablo came to this conclusion. And now, they would just wait quietly for their departure time.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 10

The second day was horrible.

Moving as a group was just not ideal. It was a day of realizing this.

As predicted, the people who went out fishing came back with miserable results.

And of course, we too were unable to accomplish much.

As we weren’t allowed to stray too far from the eyes of the instructors, the area we could go to look for herbs and seeds was very limited.

And these were areas that the other students had already searched on the first day, so it was no surprise that nothing good had come up.

If we were allowed to, I would have wanted to go to the west.

It was a desert area, so the variety of plants over there would have also been quite different.

That made me think that there would be plants suited for cooking spices...

In any case, what we were able to get was a little collection of seeds, edible grass and a clump of rock salt.

Had we gone near the shore, we might have been able to get some water to make sea salt, but of course, we could not do that. I would have been able to manage it alone, but the exploration team had only advanced one-quarter of the way through the island in a day. And so getting salt from the sea was not a very realistic idea.

Had I not realized that the rock was crystallized salt, then we would have had to eat our food without any salt at all...

...No, that is a lie.

The rock salt alone was something that I had secretly prepared.

I didn't think you could make anything without salt, and so it was necessary for me to prepare this thing at least.

In fact, there was a salt lake to the west, but as we had gone to the same place as yesterday, I could not go over there.

And so with no other choice, I had crystallized the salt in the ground when no one was looking. And then I stuck it onto the rocks so no one would think it was strange.

And then I pretended to be ignorant of it so that Mondo could discover it.

“Thi-this! It is a clump of salt!!”

Mondo was overjoyed when he told me. His happiness was incomparable to my own terrible acting skills, and he was overflowing with happiness at this discovery.

It didn't result in any points, but no one became suspicious about it.

They were all unsurprised, thinking that picking up some rock salt was hardly enough to get you some points.

And so that was how I was able to prepare some salt.

I returned to the base and started making dinner.

Lunch was either rations or whatever you could find in your environment. And so we had searched for seeds and wild berries...but, it was not enough.

For George and Mondo, it was about the amount, but for me, it was more about quality. It was dry and not sweet. To be honest, they were just bad.

And so I had had higher hopes for dinner, but we had not been successful.

Sadly, I licked the salt and sipped the disgusting grass soup.

It seemed like Magnus and a few other students were sticking to their rations.

I understood why.

Overall, it was such a tragic dinner that I wanted to cry.

At the same time, the smell of the fancy dinner that Julius and the others were eating wafted in the air. And it lit a fire of rage within me.

To be frank, this was a challenge.

I don't remember ever being this pissed off in the past few

years.

This delicious smell was making us feel even more miserable.

“We will have to try harder to prepare a good meal tomorrow.”

“Yeah. I’m too hungry now. I’ll do better tomorrow!”

“Ye-yes. Me too.”

Perhaps there was something intimidating about the way I had said it because George seemed a little taken aback as he nodded.

Mondo was so hungry that he just nodded without really thinking.

The two girls were also in agreement, and with that resolve,

we split up for the night.



And then it was the 3rd day.

I had good luck from the morning of that day.

The pit that I had made on the first day had trapped a pig-like monster.

...No, that's a lie.

I had worked secretly during the night to find it through 'Magic Perception,' and then catch it with 'Sticky Steel String,' and then I led it towards the trap.

Today we would eat some good food! It was this hope that forced me to loosen the magic restraints I had put on myself.

Caution? What is that? Does it taste good?

They say that there are many city people who long to live in the countryside or live off of their own produce in the forest. However, most of them soon realize how inconvenient it is once they try it.

I was much the same.

My body is hurting because of my muscles and I'm forced to eat horrible food. Not only is there no entertainment, but there isn't even a place to take a bath... It had only been two days, but I was already feeling my limits.

And on this third day, I had decided that I would no longer try to bear any of it.

"I'm going to stay here today and prepare this guy to be butchered."

I declared to my teammates. There was a 200 kg boar-like

monster in front of me.

Thankfully, I already had 30 points, so there was no need to worry about getting more.

“You don’t need us to help you?”

George asked. I answered,

“Leave the cooking to me. But it would help if you could gather some logs for firewood.”

Upon hearing this, George readily agreed.

He decided to gather wood during the morning and then go out gathering in the afternoon in order to rack up some points.

He had likely sensed that I was serious, and thought it better to not get in my way.

Now it was just me and one other person left.

It was Marsha.

She already had enough points, and so I had asked for her help.

“I...as you know, am not very good at cooking...”

She seemed worried, but it was no problem.

What I was going to ask Marsha was not cooking, but a new type of magic experiment.

I thought that her talent for magic was genuine, and so I wanted to use this opportunity to perform an experiment that I had thought of.

Besides, if I needed any help, there was also an instructor who

was healing from an injury that I could ask.

“Alright, I’ll be back once at midday.”

“Leave the firewood to me!”

“See you later!”

So saying, the three of them set out.

Now, it was time to start preparing the food.

As I had caught the monster alive, the meat would be very fresh.

I asked the combat supervisor, who had recovered from an injury, to remove the blood and process the meat.

There was something awe-inspiring about watching it happen.

If I wanted to—well, I could perform it in auto-mode with Ciel's help, but I didn't want to draw any attention.

I just want to make it very clear, it had nothing to do with my sore muscle.

You could say that the instructor's efforts were a huge help.

On the first day, we had done a fish barbecue, but today we would have meat skewers.

I added some wild vegetables that looked highly nutritious along with the meat as I skewered them.

Then I sprinkled some of the prepared salt over them and finished it off with some ground up grass on top.

Now I just had to cook them.

To be honest, it looked quite delicious already.

After all, I had used ‘Appraisal’ to find out the right amount of salt and adjust the flavor with the herbs.

This meant that under the circumstances, it was in the best possible state.

However, I was not finished yet.

The main dish would be the soup I was making now, through boiling the bones.

“How is it?”

I asked Marsha.

And then–

“I can’t believe it... How...there is no magic depletion, so how is it possible to control magic with such accuracy for a long period of time!?”

She replied with much excitement.

It seems to have worked. I gloated inwardly.

I actually wanted to test it myself, but that was just not possible. My identity needed to stay hidden, and it wouldn’t make sense for me to teach new types of magic when I wasn’t even a student.

And so.

I had Old William become my assistant.

Well, I asked him to be sort of an instructor.

Last night, I had secretly talk with William, saying that I would have Marsha stay as a helper. That was when William would naturally start to talk to her and eventually instruct her. That was the plan.

And it was going well.

As for the rest...



After I finished preparing the bones to be boiled in the large pot, I started talking to Marsha.

That was the signal to start.

“Marsha, I’m sorry. But could you adjust the flames with

magic?”

I asked her in the most natural way.

And since Marsha accepted it as planned, the adjusting of the flames while the bones were boiling became her job.

But it wasn't the easiest job.

While Marsha had a lot of magical power and was good at controlling mana, you needed to be able to concentrate well in order to do it.

As I watched from the side, William saw his opportunity and approached her.

He called to Marsha, who was having trouble, and gave her some advice while also trying to change the subject.

“Ah, that reminds me, Marsha. I have this magic item passed on to me by a friend...perhaps you will be able to use it. Do you want to give it a try?”

While helping her, he casually referred to this thing as if just remembering it. Then he pulled out what appeared to be seven playing cards from his pocket.

The material that they were made of was pure ‘Demon Steel.’

“Master, what is this...”

“This is...”

William explained it to her just as I had explained it to him last night.

He glanced at me several times to make sure he was getting it right, but it seemed like Marsha didn’t notice it.

He was mostly right anyway, and so I gave him the okay signal.

With renewed confidence, William returned to his explanation.

What I had given him last night was a new type of magical device that I had devised.

There were eight media cards that formed the basis.

These represented the eight great attributes of the power of spirits that made this world.

Light and shadow, time, and earth, water, fire, wind, and sky.

What Marsha had received, was seven of those eight.

Time alone could not be used by people, and so I had excluded

it.

The light could purify, nurture and regenerate.

The shadow could conceal, was psychological, and could destroy.

The earth had the power to pull, break and condense.

The water could solidify, stop and be released.

The fire burned, accelerated and exploded.

The wind was in waves, had an impact and vibrated.

The sky was space, existence, and information.

Like that, the media cards had primitive words that

represented the different natures carved into them.

And so all you needed to do was allow magic to flow into the card and will it, and it would be possible to create that effect.

As the media card itself controlled the magic, the effect would not be interrupted even if the person using them became distracted.

What was important was your imagination when activating the magic.

You did not even need to chant.

Nothing would happen if you will a shadow effect while using the light card. And while you did need to make the right choices and follow the procedures, that was just a matter of becoming familiar.

I decided to call this new form of magic–Anagram Magic.

Currently, it only had the most basic letters carved in, but I intended to eventually make it more complex and layered.

For instance, I could combine earth-type(condense) and fire-type(explosion) and create 'Gravity Collapse.'

Though, there were still some problems left, like the learning curve, the concentration that is necessary to set parameters and the fact that the required energy was enormous.

Of course, this was an extreme scenario.

However, it was easier and more efficient than element magic, and it was easy to understand that it was a form of magic that allowed anyone to control the rules of the world.

I'm sure that it is obvious, but I had no intention of allowing it to circulate outside.

This was merely an experiment to see how much use a normal student without a lot of knowledge could get out of it.

Basically, I wanted to test the ease of use.

<<As I thought, that was your intent all along.>>

For some reason, Ciel sounded a little smug.

By the way, there should be no doubt that it was me who thought of this Anagram Magic.

However—It was, of course, Ciel, who developed it.

And so she had predicted that I would try and test it somewhere, and she had predicted from the first day that I would ask Marsha.

Of course, I know! She seemed to want to say.

However, it was only by chance that I thought to conduct this experiment.

It was necessary to adjust the fire while cooking. And when I was wondering how I could do this, I thought of Marsha.

Usually, I could have easily controlled it with magic, but I couldn't do it since I was supposed to be an average person. And so I could not adjust the fire myself.

Still, there was no way that I was going to give up on a delicious meal... And then I thought of it. Marsha's talent.

In other words, I passed on this magic to Marsha in order for her to cook the food.

I thought that it would be bad to ask an instructor to do such a menial task. That was all it was.

–Yes, it was all for a delicious dinner!

Why do I care so much about food?

Well, think about it for a moment.

Among the three things that are considered to be the great needs of humans, sleep, carnal desire, and appetite for food, the only one that I have left is food.

Is it any wonder that I am so desperate?

I didn't acquire "Beelzebuth" for nothing.



–Well, in any case, the experiment was a success.

Marsha used the fire and water cards to control the heat perfectly, just like I had requested.

“Master William. These magic cards are amazing!”

“Hmm...indeed they are...”

Marsha said with excitement, but old William did not seem to share her enthusiasm.

He had been exposed to a form of magic that surpassed his understanding, and he was having too much trouble breathing to show excitement.

I felt a little sorry for him.

He was looking to me for help, and so I thought I might go and help him.

However, the food was more important now.

I pushed thoughts of William aside and started to do the finishing touches.

I removed the bones, boiled the meat and vegetables, and added the seasoning.

This was also accomplished under the perfect management of Appraisal, and so it was adjusted to be the most delicious it could possibly be under the circumstances.

I traded places with Marsha and got to work.

During this time, Marsha joined the teachers as they skewered the meat and lined them up.

The firewood that George and the others had gathered in the morning were placed in the portable stove, and a grill was placed on top...preparations were going smoothly.

As for me.

The boiled meat was soft and the mysterious wild vegetables had a smell that usually would not have been possible.

And so this stew, which to be honest, was an original that completely ignored the recipe, was complete.

I cautiously tasted it.

It was excellent, and would not be inferior to any dish made by Shuna.

“It’s perfect.”

I said with overwhelming emotion.

I felt as if I had not eaten for an unfathomably long time, but it had only been three days.

However, it had been very painful for me.

I never would have expected my identity to be in danger of being exposed over not being able to eat, but thankfully, things

turned out fine.

I would not make the same mistake the next time.

In any case, I just wanted to bask in the perfection that was this stew.

Marsha looked like she wanted to taste it too, and so I gave her a spoonful.

“It’s delicious!! This is much better than the stew at school and at home!!”

It was a good thing to be able to share your joy with others.

Marsha and I were able to forget time itself as we rejoiced in what we had accomplished.

At the same time, it seemed like the other teachers who had

helped also wanted to taste it. But that meant nothing to us, as we had lost ourselves in the moment.

And so we did not notice them and were ultimately the only two who got to taste it.

Eventually, it was evening.

George and the rest of the gathering team had returned, and we had more than enough firewood.

And once preparations were complete, a magic circle flashed, and the exploration team also returned.

And then, at last, it was the beginning of the long awaited dinner.

A loud cheer rang around us.

Some were even crying loudly with emotion.

Several students walked up to me and offered words of gratitude.

I think there might have been a few teachers as well, but I didn't think about it.

Magnus even said, 'Hey Satoru, come and be my wife!' while getting up, and so I said, 'I'll punch you' and took away his stew.

It was a waste to allow such idiots to eat it.

After that, I heard words of apology in a pained voice, but I ignored them.

The stew that had been confiscated from Magnus was gladly eaten by Mondo.

Also–

“...This is good.”

Even Julius had come to eat the stew as well.

“Hmph, you should be thankful.”

I said pompously.

Yet in spite of my attitude, Julius just left silently and did not complain.

I thought that it was an even scarier reaction.

And so, the night of the third day ended in a very satisfactory manner.

-However, the incident happened right after that.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 11

The night of the third day.

I had just enjoyed a long overdue and most satisfying meal, and was now soaking in a luxurious bath.

Marsha has used the magic cards I had given her and combined them to create a simple bathtub. She had also prepared the water and adjusted the heat.

“This really is so useful. The right combination and your imagination are all you need to perform complicated magic.”

“Heeey, where did you get those magic caaards?”

Aina asked as Marsha sighed in awe.

It wasn’t surprising that she would wonder about this.

It was such a convenient magical tool and you would not be able to find them anywhere, no matter how hard you looked. It had the kind of overpowered features that didn't even exist in ancient Artifacts.

“About that. It was something that Master William received from an old friend. He let me use it as an experiment to test its abilities. He said it would be perfect for helping Satoru.”

“Hmm. I seeee... But, you learned to use them in just one day. Are they reeeeeeally so easy to use in spite of being so highly effective?”

“Exactly! There is no way that such complicated magic could be controlled by such cards! If I had to guess, there must be a degree of the procedure built-in already, and the Anagram works to activate the magic? But then again, that would be complicated as well...”

Not only Aina, but the other students were also very interested now.

And as was expected for elite students, they had a vague idea of how the cards worked.

It was both correct and yet, incorrect.

The part of achieving different effects through the rearranging of meaning was correct, but merely having the procedure built-in was not enough to be able to activate magic.

Instead of doing that, the words, which were the power itself, were integrated, ensuring that the procedures would not interfere with each other.

To put it simply, the words would rearrange themselves according to the user's imagination, automatically creating the magic.

That was why it was necessary to select the card with the right meaning.

To be blunt, it was not possible with the current magic

technology.

From my perspective, Marsha was a complete amateur, and so seeing how much use she could get out of it helped me understand the level within my troops that I could place it in.

Of course, it was all a state secret.

Well, I was keeping it hidden from everyone, so it was just my secret.

If word of this item got out, people would say, 'We want it for our army!' I could see it coming from a mile away.

I didn't want people to have such high hopes when it wasn't even finished. Besides, it would be troublesome if my carelessness allowed it to be discovered.

Also, if the decision was all left to me, then it would look like I am favoring some, so I would need a good reason for it.

I thought that I would just randomly pass it on to someone to experiment, but Marsha was not my subordinate and was the perfect specimen.

And in regards to keeping information secret, this island was the optimal test site.

The only thing left was to prevent the students from talking, but I could think of that later.

I wasn't that serious about hiding it, and at worst, I would just need to hurry up and finish it. Then there would be no need to keep it a secret.

Currently, it was a magic item with no plans to be revealed to the world. But it was interesting seeing the reactions of the students.

Perhaps I should just distribute them around the academy and have it established as a new form of magic.

If I did that, the statuses of magic users would skyrocket, and so it will be necessary to have certain restrictions.

I thought of all of this as I soaked in the bath and listened to them talk.

“Buuuut, did you really receive it today and also understand how it woorks?”

Marsha chuckled at Aina’s question.

And said,

“To be honest, there was a memo inside of the instruction manual. There were some examples for adjusting heat of hardening earth and gathering water. They were very detailed explanations.”

Marsha said as she scratched her cheek.

“I was quite surprised because it was the magic we needed in our situation.”

She said and then laughed.

“Whaat! So then Master William just told you about it quietly then!”

“That’s true. It would probably take days of research to discover the combinations!”

“Still, to think that he was helping you from the shadows like that. Master William is quite dashing, isn’t he?”

“Huh? But he’s so old...”

The students said.

I felt like their conversation was going a little off course.

And surely William wasn't that old?

It was me who had prepared the memo. Of course, I had William write it, so it would like it was he who had secretly helped the students.

And of course, I was glad that they took the bait just as I had planned, but I wished that they were a little more grateful to William.

As for the memo, it goes without saying that I had it written because I wanted to take a bath.

It seemed unnatural for such instructions to be in the manual, so I had to think a little.

It all had to be natural. And so the memo was a good way of allowing Marsha to use the magic with ease.

And my efforts were well worth it, because I was able to take a bath after three days.

I did not want to bathe with the girls originally, but regardless of who I bathed with, I could not have my body seen, and so being able to cover myself with a towel was at least an advantage here.

“Still, if we had magic like this from the beginning, it makes our desperate attempt to get water on the first day look rather stupid.”

Marsha said with a laugh.

Whether it was making it rain and gathering it or creating ice and then melting it, preparing water with magic alone was quite difficult.

Of course, it was an inconvenience that nobles, who had magic tools for that very purpose, were unaware of.

Well, we were now able to collect water without such troubles. And so we were able to bathe like this.

As this was training, there were some girls who had brought soap for everyday use.

I borrowed some to wash my hair and felt very refreshed.

That was really a matter of feeling.

My body was now made like any other human, which meant sweat. Of course, if I could no longer stand it, I could just turn those features off.

But right now, I wanted to enjoy this life, and so I left them all on.

And because of it, I felt very good now.

Living like this once in a while was not bad at all.

And so, with Marsha and the others' voices in the

background, I continued to enjoy this long-overdue bath.



I was able to get out of the bathtub without my identity being exposed.

But then again, I had declared to all that I was male, but it seemed like no one believed me.

People were never cautious of me and just entered my tent like it was nothing.

Was that alright? I wondered. But it was a little late for that.

There was a line of girls outside of the tent who had apparently heard rumors.

The tent was quite large, but could only house about ten

people at once.

We had borrowed one of the large tents just for this.

And because of this, it looked like it would be a long time until all of the girls were finished.

And one other thing.

Being able to see the frustrated expression of Julius and the others was a very pleasant surprise.

This bath was made by Marsha, so no one could try and cut the line.

I would not allow such a thing.

It was prepared because I wanted to take a bath, so why should I allow anyone to go first?

That's ridiculous! I am sure of it.

But this was a good day.

A dinner that was much more delicious than what those damned, snooty children of nobility were eating. And also the best possible bath under these circumstances.

I was able to fulfill these two strong desires of mine.

I was so full of satisfaction as I headed back to my tent.

Just then, my 'Magic Detection' felt a strong wave of magic.

It was detecting the presence of a monster that was coming towards this base, while brimming with tense emotion.

Was this emotion–appetite!?

<<I expected that this would happen. As you noticed yourself, the herbs that were mixed in Julius and the others' food had something in it that stimulates the appetites of monsters. The effect of it is now starting to lure surrounding monsters here. >>

I hadn't noticed it actually. And so what?

No, I see... I remember feeling strangely irritated yesterday over being hungry. It must have been because of those herbs.

It had nothing to do with my own lack of patience.

That must be it.

There was no way that an adult like me could be so impatient. Yes, I thought it was very strange.

Wait, there are more pressing matters right now.

-Have the instructors noticed it?

<<It seems like a few of them have. They were specially selected, after all.>>

Hmm, then that's fine.

I was relieved to see that they weren't the useless types who would fail to be cautious.

Now then, if Julius and the other were mixing monster-luring herbs into the food...

What was their aim?

If anything, they were eating it, which meant they would be in the biggest danger...

-Could it be that Julius is being tricked into doing it?

<<I think that is highly likely. Julius has more wounds than on the first day. But I believe that this development was also unexpected for the culprit. It is the Poison Tiger, one of the strongest creatures on this island, that leads the pack of monsters. They probably wanted to be rid of Julius and that group in a natural-looking way. But they will only attract attention like this. No, not only that—it may even be hard to survive this if they hide the power that they must have. We may be able to find the culprit by watching this fight.>>

The Poison Tiger which prowled the southern poison jungle was great indeed.

It was not something that could be reasoned with, so you had no choice but to kill it.

But still, getting rid of Julius, huh?

While I wasn't sure if the intention was to kill, I did not like the method at all.

Considering that it was mixed into the food, there must be a

traitor.

This was clearly planned out, likely even before my own survival plan. In other words, I had been used.

That was terribly, unamusing to me.

Ciel already had her eye on a suspect, and she was probably 99% certain of it.

But could these culprits kill the Poison Tiger? It might be best to prepare just in case.

According to my own plans, none of the students were to be exposed to danger.

I would not allow this interference to cause any deaths.

–Do you think that all of the students will make it out safely?

<<It will be difficult if things continue like this.>>

I thought as much.

Well then, I must give them a little helping hand.

I walked away from my tent while drying my hair.

And like that, I pretended like was I taking a walk in order to cool off, and headed for a secluded spot.

Once I was sure that there were no students around me, I activated 'Detection Block' magic.

All sound was erased, and I was surrounded in silence.

“You’re here, aren’t you, Moss?”

I said into the darkness.

“Here, my Lord.”

As if in answer to my call, a figure appeared and bowed reverently towards me.

Moss was a Great Demon.

A Grand Duke of the demon world who stood above all of the Demon Lords.

And-while he was the lieutenant of Devil Lord Testarossa, at some point he had become Diablo's errand runner.

Are you sure about this, Great Demon? I did wonder sometimes, but he had very useful abilities.

It was Testarossa's fault, anyway.

She allowed Diablo to use her subordinates as he pleased.

But then again, I was also using Moss when it was convenient for me, so I couldn't say too much...

Even now, he had immediately appeared after I called him, and paid homage to me.

But really, this guy was useful.

He was stronger than even the former Demon King, so even if he was a 'clone,' he was still stronger than the monsters on this island.

"I have a task for you."

"That brings me the utmost pleasure."

Whenever I ask him to do something, he always accepted it

very happily.

Maybe I should buy him dinner sometime.

I think a barbecue would be good. No, I'll think about that later.

“Hmm. Then let me ask you this, can you protect everyone from the monster that is coming towards us?”

“That will be the easiest thing. My Lord.”

“Good. Then do it. It would be best if there are no deaths. However, I would like for you to hide your presence as much as possible.”

“Haha, I understand. I shall protect them from the shadows then.”

Moss bowed once again and then vanished from my sight.

Now I could relax a little.

I returned to the others as if nothing had happened.

Oh, I forgot to invite him for a meal to show my gratitude.

I could ask Diablo to send him a message, but that seemed like too much trouble, so I should just tell him the next time we meet.

You should always thank people in person. And so I decided to show Moss my appreciation for this occasion.

Now, how will this play out?

I was sure that the worst possible scenario had now been avoided, so I might as well just lay back and watch.

Who was the culprit that had tricked Julius? And what was their aim?

And how capable were the instructors going to be in dealing with this danger? How strong were the students that Julius was leading?

Within this dangerous situation, everything would be revealed.

I would use it all to my advantage. That's what I thought, as I smiled.

And then—

The first thing that echoed was the ferocious roar of the monster.

It was the signal of the very long night ahead of us.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 12

Three days after Rimuru’s escape.

Diablo and Souei were still residing in the Ingracia Kingdom.

They had concentrated on gathering information in the relevant locations on the second day, and they now had a good grasp on what was happening.

In just one day, they had talked to the prominent leaders of nearly every country. It was incredibly fast and would have been unthinkable under normal circumstances.

Much of it was due to Souei’s spying efforts, but Diablo’s unrelenting energy meant that they were able to avoid a lot of the trivial processes.

The truth was that there was no one who would reject meeting with them once the name of the ‘Demon Lord’ who worked under Great Demon Lord Rimuru, was brought up.

No matter how much pressure the guards and gatekeepers tried to exude when attempting to send them away, Diablo's smile was enough to make them freeze and eventually give in.

Of course, giving in was the right answer for them.

Continuing to resist here would have absolutely no benefits for their wellbeing.

And so things went very smoothly and without interruption. And they had just now finished checking that they had all the information that they needed.

And so today–

Diablo and Souei were attempting their biggest challenge yet in the Ingracia Kingdom, to be granted a visit to Elrick, the former prince.

This Kingdom of Ingracia was in chaos due to the previous great war, and while it was called a kingdom, it was no longer

ruled by a king.

The royal family had temporarily lost their position, and all of the power and authority had been taken by the Freedom Arbitration Committee.

Even after the great war, a noble assembly was established under the supervision of the Committee's directors, and the royal family had no involvement in running the kingdom.

If anything, they were not permitted to be involved in the government at all.

And it was not only the royal family. Powerful nobles were used as model cases for democracy and the abolition of the class system. And this was gaining attention all of over the kingdom.

Of course, without the interference of the Committee, the kingdom would have likely perished during the chaos of the great war.

The previous king had been killed by Elrick, the prince, and Reiner, leader of the Grand Knight Order. And they had attempted to usurp the throne.

The Hero Masayuki had quieted the chaos, and the anger and chaos of the people had begun to heal.

Thanks to this, the ire of the public did not move towards the royal family and other nobles.

But ultimately, Prince Elrick was disinherited and he lost his right of ascension before being confined.

The nobles who had aided Prince Elrick were also dealt with, which meant a vast purging of many powerful nobles.

Because of all of this, the Kingdom of Ingracia had no choice but to continue and accept the intervention of the Freedom Arbitration Committee.

As 10 years had passed, there were even some among the

nobles who accepted the current situation.

However, this reality where they could not make decisions without depending on a foreign country, was not something that the public could accept.

Therefore, it soon became an earnest wish by many, that the royal family be restored, and independence regained for the Kingdom of Ingracia.

Elrick could be seen as the culprit who had created this situation, and so it was not easy for even someone like Diablo to be able to meet him.

Normally, it would have been difficult to even find out where he was being held, nevermind actually meeting him.

And yet in just 1 day—and through official means and without relying on violence, Diablo had been granted a meeting.

This was an impressive feat in negotiating that astonished

even Souei.

“A pleasure to meet you. I am Elrick.”

“Hello, Elrick. I am called Diablo.”

“–I am Souei. It’s nice to meet you.”

There was a simple greeting.

It was only these three in the room.

The room was perfectly protected from eavesdropping, on top of Diablo’s own ‘Magic Barrier.’ And so the space they were in was so isolated that it might as well have been in a different dimension.

It was only after this high level of secrecy was secured that Diablo spoke of the main subject.

“Now. The reason I came to meet you today, is because I wanted to ask you about your younger brother.”

This straightforward question seemed to have made Elrick relax.

It was much better to have their purpose known clearly, than to talk endlessly in a roundabout way and slowly chip away at his sanity.

They had been able to predict that being locked up for 10 years had dulled his ability to understand what the other person wanted.

Furthermore, it had probably been a long while since he had a conversation with a stranger.

It seemed that Elrick believed that Masayuki had saved him, and ever since then, he had lived without holding on to any strange ambitions.

And while he was not able to walk freely outside, he was allowed to go as far as the gardens in this mansion owned by his family, as long as he was accompanied by a guard.

This lifestyle seemed to have caused a dislike for high-class manners and intricate negotiation rituals.

From all of this, it was clear that Elrick had lived the past 10 years without much interaction with others.

“Julius is brilliant. He accepts the hopes and expectations of the other nobles and is trying his best to meet them. As his older brother, I believe that he will make a fine king.”

Elrick said without hesitation.

Hmph. Diablo clicked his tongue.

He looked at Elrick carefully and decided that there was no lie in his words.

And he was right. Diablo's ability to observe never failed him.

After that, Diablo asked a few questions with a light-hearted air, as if he were asking about something mundane.

“What happened to the royal family's fortune?”

“They have been frozen. There is also a royal inheritance that has been passed down for generations, but that is being managed by the Committee, and I do not have free access to it. Besides, that money cannot be used...”

“Why?”

“The best thing about the Kingdom of Ingracia was that it was safe. But that is a thing of the past. If we wish for future developments, we must invest in personnel training. Yes, just like a certain person once said.”

“Oh? What person?”

“The Great Demon Lord, Rimuru.”

“I see.”

“...Hmm. Indeed. Lord Rimuru did come to see the Kingdom of Ingracia once.”

“Yes. There was such a time when I had so much work to do.”

Diablo usually stuck very close to Rimuru, but when the great war was over, all of the leaders had flocked to him.

The anger towards Rimuru for his deceit had been directed towards Diablo and not Rimuru.

Even Diablo could not go against the many complaints of the leaders, and so he had no choice but to run about and deal with the aftermath.

“Yes. It was during that time. I was being held responsible for what happened, but the Hero Masayuki came out with me, and I was saved. It was then that I was so lucky to have met him. Once I saw him with my own eyes...”

He chuckled as if the memory was amusing to him.

“I would never again think of going against him.” He said while looking Diablo straight in the eyes.

After that, Elrick related what their conversation had been about.

What Elrick said was this–

The Kingdom of Ingracia had been built in the plains where there were fewer monsters, as it was far away from the Great Jura Forest. These favorable conditions allowed it to become a center for politics and culture, where the leaders of all the other countries came to meet.

However.

Now that Great Demon Lord Rimuru had unveiled a plan of coexistence and mutual prosperity, the level of danger in the Great Jura Forest had dropped dramatically.

Not only that, the country of Tempest now had improved means of transportation through a network of railways, and had developed to a point where it could be considered the current center of the world.

In fact, the main headquarters of the Freedom Arbitration Committee was in Tempest.

A country could no longer stand out by being safe alone, and the center of politics, culture, and finance had all moved away from the Kingdom of Ingracia.

And so it was necessary for this country to have something to call it's own.

“It was something I heard 10 years ago, and years later, it became reality. Those who were able to revolutionize their way of thinking have managed to deal with it, but there are still people who believe that they are the center of the world. It is a force that is splitting the former nobles.”

Those who had once sat in the center of so much splendor

would find it difficult to relinquish their seats. He suggested that civil war might have erupted if the Committee was not monitoring them.

“Julius is like a shrine for the conservative noble forces. He accepts their grievances and uses them to his own gain. Furthermore, he contains the revolutionaries who attempt to use force to bring about democracy. He adjusts things so that change comes slowly. Even as his older brother, I am nothing but amazed at his handiwork. Even his arrogant behavior is probably calculated. A king is not permitted to ever bow his own head. Those who want to restore the royal family would never allow it.”

Erick said, bringing his story to an end.

Diablo nodded and pondered on this.

This meant that this Julius Prince was acting like a noble while understanding everything.

That was why he was unable to be stopped, even if was a

student now.

“Well then, would the money from the royal family that he is allowed to freely use really be enough to maintain that lifestyle? Are you sure he is not receiving monetary support from somewhere?”

Diablo asked.

“No. He is very proud, so I doubt he would accept such a thing.”

Elrick said flatly.

Diablo nodded with satisfaction upon hearing this.

“That’s useful to know. I am thankful for all the information you provided.”

“Well, then. We should be leaving...”

Diablo and Souei offered words of gratitude and got up from their seats.

“–Um... Did my brother... Did my brother do something?”

Elrick asked in a voice that seemed somewhat distressed.

Diablo smiled and answered as if to put his worries to rest.

“No, not at all. There is no need for you to worry. Besides—and this is just an example, if a student really did do something, then it would be the parents, teachers and the state who should be responsible. That is what Lord Rimuru would say.”

“But...”

“Classes such as nobles and commoners have no meaning

there. No, they are not allowed to have meaning. What your younger brother is doing is wrong, but it is the teachers who are allowing it, and it is the establishment that is the school that should take the blame. And as long as the school is under Lord Rimuru's sponsorship, then we must think of all the students as being under his protection. The actions of your younger brother require punishment, but the student Julius will not be convicted of any crimes. I can assure you of that."

"I see...that is good. Unlike me, he does not think of Lord Rimuru in a kind way... He idolizes the Hero Masayuki..."

And so Elrick explained that he was worried that his brother would do something rude towards Lord Rimuru, who he owed a great debt to. After that, he saw Diablo and Souei leave. Bowing his head for one final time, he said, 'please help my brother.'



After leaving the mansion where Elrick was being held, Diablo and Souei headed for the airport.

This meeting was the last part of their information gathering, and so they had no intention of staying any longer.

And since they did not want to draw attention, they decide to travel by sky instead of a magic circle

As said before, Space Transfer was out of the question.

The two wasted no time on the way to the airport, as they traded their opinions on what they had heard.

“As I thought, someone has definitely made contact with him. However, it is most likely that Julius is not their coconspirator.”

“That seems to be the case. Julius is seen as a shrine of sorts to the nobles. He must be avoiding any monetary aid so he does not appear weak.”

“He must have a stronger spine than I thought. Interesting. Very interesting.”

“-Yes.”

Souei agreed with the conclusion that Diablo had come to.

In fact, the previous day's investigation had allowed him to understand the situation regarding the fortune of all of the nobles.

This included money that was not written in the books, and he would know if there was some abnormal circulation of money happening.

It was clear that Elrick was speaking the truth.

There was no one in the world who could help Julius with money while keeping all traces of it out of their eyes.

Then there was only one answer left.

Julius was fighting alone, without help from anyone.

And like Elrick had said... No, Julius was even cleverer than what he had suggested.

He had started up an enterprise aside from his studies without any of the nobles surrounding him realizing it.

It hired people from other worlds at a high rate. And it was conducting all kinds of research in order to become a body that would give birth to new cultural activities.

It was nothing short of a gamble, but it appeared that Julius had won. Not only had he increased his hidden fortune, but he had also made enough money to go against the enemy forces that tried to surround him and the other nobles.

Though, this was partly due to the cooperation of the members of the Hero, Masayuki's party, who would sometimes visit.

After all, the people from other worlds that were hired were people that Masayuki had brought.

It was after doing much research on all of these facts, that Diablo and Souei had visited Elrick.

Through hearing about what Julius was like as a person, they became sure that there was a discrepancy in what he showed to those around him, and what he was really thinking.

They were also sure that with Julius' personality, even if he did become the shrine to bring the Ingracia Kingdom together, he was not so foolish as to become a puppet king.

They understood that he was harsh on others, but even harsher on himself.

“It seems that Julius is a serious and capable person. I am sure that many people will find it uncomfortable, the day he becomes king.”

“Do you mean the people of the Council? I doubt they can do anything about it yet...”

As he was under the supervision of the Committee now, there was nothing that the Council, which was made of members of various nationalities, could do.

Besides, the last great purge had taken out everyone who would have been good at such maneuvering.

“I do wonder... But perhaps there is someone like that outside of the Council?”

“Hmm. I won’t deny the possibility.”

“Of course.”

Souei said grimly.

In other words, it would be best to consider that this Kingdom of Ingracia was being targeted by someone.

(I see. I see. This must be in the vein of the economic war that Rimuru had predicted...)

They could not fight back in a war of military power.

However, in terms of economic exchange, there was a possibility of standing on top of some others.

Those who thought this way may have instigated such an economic war. If that were the case, the various developments now would connect into a single line.

After all, this had been predicted as a path that could not be avoided while negotiating for coexistence and mutual prosperity.

However, such methods would not work against Tempest...

If you wanted to advocate for democracy, then numbers trumped all.

It would be one thing if it was only within the country, but when something like the

multi-cultural Council makes decisions–It is not about a proportion of the total population or power of the country, even if things were decided by a majority in the name of such flowery words such as equality...

The decision of the three schools was a good example.

A vote by the majority is in no way a system of equality.

A country should not be swayed by the opinions of other countries.

This was why Tempest had opted for the bicameral system. It took on its own system of government that could be called a democracy under an imperial government.

There was no way to take advantage of it.

Then what could you do?

If you wanted to target something, it would be, economic activity.

The only means left is to force them to accept your terms, while using your economic ties as a shield.

It would take a terribly long time for this plan to work.

And the enemy had a surprising amount of patience.

And they had seen traces of those hands reaching out not to just Tempest, but deep into other countries as well.

This was an opponent that should not be underestimated.

(It's been a while since I had this much fun...)

Diablo had no understanding of the economy, and he didn't care to.

He was not interested.

As someone who believed that you should just take what you wanted, he had no interest in money.

Gold, silver, jewels. Diablo thought of such things as bait to manipulate the greed of humans.

What Diablo desired in the truest sense, was not something that an object could replace.

In negotiating, several conditions were laid out on a table, and both parties would discuss possible compromises. But Diablo felt that this was all pointless.

If the person was strong enough to just flip the table over, you would need to have an equal amount of strength, or there was no way to negotiate.

Diablo could not understand why some people put so much faith in the goodness or wisdom of others.

Though Diablo did believe that promises had to be kept, he would never make a promise with someone who was not his equal.

It was because of all of this, that Diablo could only see this economic war that humanity was waging against the Great Demon Lord Rimuru as futile.

(–How foolish. Even ignoring Lord Rimuru, to try and control the world through the economy... I would never allow such a thing.)

Diablo felt that anyone who could not understand this must be very foolish.

“Hey. You aren’t thinking about killing everyone who is behind it now, are you?”

“How dare you... I may have been on edge after being separated from Lord Rimuru, but I am quite calm now. There is no way that I would think of such a thing.”

Souei had made the jab with the perfect timing. Almost as if he could read his mind.

Diablo was surprised, but lightly denied it.

“That’s good then. Lord Rimuru has forbidden the subjugating of others through violence.”

Just like Souei said, Diablo’s beloved master, Rimuru, cared deeply for humans.

And while he did not entirely avoid using his power, he tried not to use it more than was necessary against other countries.

As Diablo was always close by, he could hardly be ignorant of this, and he, of course, understood it.

Because of this, Diablo decided on a whim that he too would use his brain, rather than his strength, to deal with this opponent.

While this may be a war to the humans, it was all a game to Diablo.

Humans—weak, foolish, greedy, and yet, there were some with strong and noble souls and some who were more intelligent than demons.

He was not interested in the economy, but he was interested in humans.

Hehehehehe. Diablo sneered.

He had a feeling that this game—this entertaining money game, was about to begin.

And like that, the third day came to an end.

And in turn—the tumultuous fourth day began.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 13

The morning of the fourth day.

The light of the sun was blinding yet warm, which made it hard to believe that there had been such a fight last night.

The intense battle with the poison tiger had gone on all through the night.

They had somehow been able to drive it away, and now everyone was sleeping deeply as if they were dead.

No one had died in the fight, but many were heavily wounded.

The casualties had stopped there because Moss had been ordered to protect everyone, but it would not have been strange if the outcome was one of a majority death, had I not intervened.

It wasn't so much that Julius was a bad commander, but that the enemy was too strong.

It was like asking an elementary school student to defeat a soldier. There was too much of a gap in basic combat abilities.

In fact, it was one of the strongest on the island.

Semi-Demon Lord rank power was nothing to scoff at.

But nevermind that. A much more important incident has occurred...

So let us go back for a moment, and I will explain what it was that had happened.



The combat teachers stood in the forefront and faced the

poison tiger.

Unlike the time with Laplace, they were fully prepared.

Physical boosts through magic and skills, physical boosts through items. And completely equipped with unique equipment.

Their power was equal to an A-rank... However, an A-rank could be quite diverse.

A-rank. It was proof that you were at the strongest level in this world.

There was an enormous barrier to being admitted as an A-rank, and you had to be strong enough to set yourself apart from everything that is beneath it. It was the seat of the strongest.

However, that was before—before the great war.

Now that the Tempest unique rank equipment was circulating, it had become quite easy to achieve an A-rank.

People who have conquered different layers inside of the labyrinth often sold their acquired items on the black market, which meant that people were able to buy them with money.

Of course, acquiring unique equipment through such means would not allow you to use the equipment to its fullest potential.

If your base level had not reached a certain point yet, then you, of course, would not be able to break through the A-rank barrier.

Because of all of this, each school had a number of A-rank teachers employed there.

And yet...

With the threat of the monsters in front of us, it did not seem

excessive.

Hazard rank, Calamity rank, and the old Demon Lord level, which was Disaster rank.

In the end, there was even the Catastrophe rank, which no one would touch.

As we were the only Catastrophe ranks, it wasn't really something we had to consider, but the Hazard rank monsters ruled their territories in many lands. And so allowing a degree of the unique rank equipment to circulate was partially in order to increase the number of people who could fight them.

Because of this, damages from monsters all of over the world had decreased dramatically.

As for comparing the teachers and monsters in terms of power, we were at a great disadvantage, just as I had predicted.

I had already felt that Hazard rank monsters were too much

for them, but this poison tiger was Calamity rank, so there was no comparison.

Just as I had said, there was a huge difference.

There was always a bigger fish.

Still, the teachers had relied on their numbers and surrounded the poison tiger, trying desperately to hold it.

And the result was this. The poison tiger's powerful poison had injured them all to the point where they were on the brink of death. It was a terrible sight.

But they had done well.

They had used all of their power.

After all, I had witnessed it myself. They had felt that they

could not fight ungracefully in front of me, and they had fought desperately against an opponent that they had no hope of winning against.

I felt like praising them without reserve.

At the same time, Julius and the others were also impressive.

With the pack of monsters coming towards them, Julius has stood in the front, fighting to his best ability while encouraging the others.

“We will surely win! Don’t give up!!”

He shouted. The students had been in danger of losing themselves in fear, but the voice gave them courage.

He had more backbone than I had thought.

And his skill with the sword was not bad. And he was even using magic.

He must have spent a lot on his equipment, as it was of the finest quality, and seemed like it was a lot more advanced than the weapons and armor of the teachers.

And while he was a student, he was almost as strong as an A-rank person.

Handsome+Prince+Capable!

I hated it.

The conditions were so great for him that all the males around him would feel miserable.

However, none of this had anything to do with the monsters. The monsters did not discriminate and did not spare Julius because of those qualities. He was only food to them.

And so they attacked, one after another.

Julius fought desperately.

Julius' followers were also fighting hard.

The argumentive Maria Rogwall and the quiet girl, Carole Primrose as well.

And the butlers.

Even the students who had seemed to have lost heart had regained their will and were cooperating with a fervor again.

Those who could fight went out in the front, while those who could not, acted as rescuers.

They were very efficient too.

The tents were lined up here, and the terrain made it easy to see everything.

As there was no place to hide, those who could fight moved out and created a circular protective wall around the center.

There were some students who screamed and cried, but as they would get in the way, they were shooed away towards me—in other words, into the center of the protected area.

It was so they didn't lower morale, probably.

The pompous academic called Yujilas was also hiding here sneakily...

This guy. There would definitely be a punishment coming to him later.

In any case, I believed that Julius' actions here were the right ones.

If even a portion of the wall was destroyed, the monsters would trample over us.

Fearing this, the teachers had lured the poison tiger away. However, with over a hundred monsters facing them, this was a battle too severe for the students to fight alone.

This wasn't about Julius' ability as a commander, but the fact of the situation.

As I said before, it was their opponent that was just too strong.

But still, Julius fought hard.

While my order to Moss to prevent any lethal blows played a big part, he had still avoided being hit by the monsters for quite a while.

Combat members of the exploration team, such as Karma and Magnus, were also cooperating.

“Don’t let your guard down, Julius!”

“–Karma, huh. Thank you.”

“Don’t mention it!”

Karma had moved in and blocked a monster who had rushed towards Julius in order to attack.

After that, Karma, who had transformed into a red werewolf, stood next to Julius and continued to fight. His power was as great as the adults, and he was just as strong as Julius.

Karma was acting on Magnus’ order, as he had said that everything would be over should their commander fall.

Karma obeyed without question, and Julius also seemed to have discarded his usual composed attitude, and readily accepted Karma’s help.

While Julius may have said various things in the past, he did in fact, accept that Karma had a true ability.

The students were crossing the borders of their schools and working together.

It was all very good up until this point.

This point...



What I first thought was strange, was Magnus' movements.

He had sent Karma over to help Julius, while he relocated to where the monsters were relatively weaker.

With Magnus' ability, it would be more appropriate for him to stay in an area where the attacks were more vicious.

As I was curious, I used 'Magic Detection' to get an overhead view and observe Magnus' actions.

Then I saw that Rozari, the girl who seemed praise Magnus a whole lot, had left the frontlines. She was running towards the group of spare forces.

Spare forces—the people who had finished being treated for their injuries or put on their summoning items. Or so I had thought, but on further inspection, it seemed like that was not the case.

They were not treating the wounded there, instead, the wounded were being roughly carried to a different tent.

As for the group...

When I looked closely, I saw that they had finished putting on matching white robes.

There was Clad, who was one of the knights that guarded

Julius, and even the combat teacher from Ingracia, who had not joined the fight at all.

Could it be that they are... Just as I thought this, things started to move at once.

First, the teachers who were fighting the poison tiger were poisoned and fell.

There was Master Brown and Master Peter from the Tempest Human Development Resource Academy.

Master William and Master Blum from the Ingracia Academy.

And to combat teachers whose names I did not know from NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy.

The six of them had been holding the poison tiger back, but now it was free.

The teachers weren't dead.

They weren't dead, because Moss was protecting them. However, they might as well have been, as they were unconscious.

And so the poison tiger was now ignoring them and was now attacking the wall of students led by Julius.

"Julius, this is bad!"

"Tsk! If only there was a Hero..."

"Lord Julius!?"

Karma.

Even Maria and Carole, who always followed Julius.

They were all looking at Julius with expressions of anger and despair.

As for Julius...

“I...I won’t give up. Masayuki would have...”

Hmmm... I wonder about that?

If anything, he would probably just run away. Yes, there was a good chance of that.

He would ask Venom to stop the monster and in the meantime...

And then that person, who could now be called Masayuki’s director, would lecture him and bring him back.

However, the timing would also be perfect, as it would be

right before Venom was about to be defeated.

Spectators of the scene could not be blamed for seeing this as a Hero coming to save the day in the nick of time.

It wouldn't seem too lucky for Venom, but that was their problem.

I don't care about Masayuki, anyway.

Right now, the students were important.

Julius gripped his sword with strong determination, and without showing a hint of fear, he stood in front of the poison tiger.

"I'll be joining you, Julius!"

"Sorry about everything, Karma. As someone who is in a

position of power, I have...”

“Don’t mention it. I understand. But we can be friends from now on, right?”

“...Yes. Let’s make it out of this alive!!”

Julius and Karma, and the other students as well.

They were in a hopeless situation, but they did not give up.

I wanted to give them all a passing grade.

I liked their spirit.

As for Julius, it would be necessary to guide him a little in terms of the way he thought, but I felt that he had at least the bare minimum of what a leader needed.

He wouldn't win this round, but I thought that I would help a little after he was defeated by the poison tiger.

That was what I thought, as I observed them fighting.

As I knew from the beginning that they would not be able to beat the poison tiger, I had planned for Moss to beat it back once everyone had been defeated.

The only thing left was to see what these suspicious-looking people in the white robes would do. Also, Magnus' movements...

But they did not look like they intended to join the fight until all of the students and teachers had fallen.

What horrible people. I thought with anger as I viewed them.

And once they saw that the last of the combat students had fallen, they began their move.

Two of the figures in white robes moved out and began to dispose of the monsters at a much faster pace than the teachers had been managing.

And then another stepped out in front of us survivors and activated a magic barrier.

The survivors were overwhelmed with shock and confusion.

“Don’t worry. I will protect all of you.”

Said Magnus.

As if to prove this claim, he went off alone to face the poison tiger.

Stupidity? No, it wasn’t.

Magnus’ movements were full of confidence, and it seemed

that he understood that his victory was a certain thing.

And of course, he was right.

He began to fight with the poison tiger with a power that exceeded that of an A-ranker.

And so he was successful in driving it away.

“Tsk. It escaped. Ah, well. At least I accomplished what I wanted.”

Magnus said this as if it was nothing.

In fact, it seemed like Magnus had yet to show his full potential. And the poison tiger was not much of a problem in his eyes.

At this point, it was all but proven, that it had been Magnus

and the others who had tricked Julius.

As Clad was Julius' guard, he would have had plenty of opportunities to mix the herbs in his food.

And more than anything...

“Now, all of you. There are two options for you now.”

Out of nowhere, a single woman came out and made this declaration.

Her words were directed at us, the non-combat students.

It seemed as if she had been waiting for this moment when all of the fighters had been defeated.

This woman, if I was not wrong, was one of the research instructors from the NNU Magic and Science Investigation

Academy. I think her name was Irina.

Her silver-rimmed glasses shined coldly as she continued.

“You can obey us and cooperate. Or you can continue to live here freely.”

Irina paused here and made sure that the students had understood her meaning.

Once she saw that they had been listening to her carefully, she continued.

“Now, we will request help from the mainland. We can go and defeat the Greed Circus if we want, but those people will likely be able to serve a different purpose. In any case, about all of you. We will take you with us if you agree to cooperate. Your safety will be assured and you will have a degree of freedom. Of course, you are also free to return to your own countries. However, you will have to undergo certain ‘restrictions’ and there will be ‘oaths’ to be made first. If you do not want to cooperate with us, that is your choice. You can just stay here

and live freely...”

So saying, her eyes moved through the group as if she were looking into the eyes of each student.

“Now, what will you do?”

She said.



The students were thrust into the worst kind of chaos.

Of course, part of the reason was that they were assuming that all of the teachers and Julius and the others, whom they had depended on, were dead.

“Wait! Who are you people?”

I was Master Pury who asked the question as she came out of a tent, her expression was severe.

Her exhaustion nearly ruined what was a pretty face.

It showed how long and how desperately she had continued to treat the wounded.

“Yes, Miss Irina. What exactly do you think you are...”

After Pury, it was Heinrich who came out next, as if to protect the students and find out what Irina’s true motivation was.

These two were the only teachers who were unharmed.

Neither of them liked to fight much, and so they would not have been useful in combat. Of course, it wouldn’t have mattered anyway, with the strength of these white-robed people in front of them.

“Yes, I suppose we have not introduced ourselves yet. We are the ‘Humanity Emancipation Alliance.’ Our purpose is the end of the domination of the evil Demon Lords and to win back a future for ourselves. This plan was built with very long-term goals, so all of you will be useful in it as well.”

Here we go. A weird organization.

The ‘Humanity Emancipation Alliance’? What is that?

All I selfishly wanted was to enjoy a little vacation...

Really? Where did I go wrong?

No, now that I think of it, perhaps I had gone wrong the moment I decided to ride that airship?

<<I am saying this just as a precaution, but please do not cast doubt on me.>>

No, no, I would never...

No matter how I look at it, there is guilt. How could I merely doubt?

I've been used. There is a mysterious organization... I'm not even sure if they are real...and someone wanted to crush them.

The real culprit behind this is surely...

<<You suspect me! You are horrible. Hmph. Hmph.>>

No, I don't suspect you at all.

I am sure of it.

Nevermind.

If it comes to this, I will see it through.

<<That's the master I know!>>

So it is according to your calculations, after all, Ciel! I thought this, but decided to not let it appear on the surface layer of my consciousness.

It was a little late, and there were some things that I thought were strange.

While I reeducate the students, I will have to do something about this Humanity Emancipation Alliance as well.

These organizations tended to be dangerous while they hide in the shadows, but are surprisingly easy to crush once they are exposed.

Thinking of it like that, Ciel's plan was perfect.

The Humanity Emancipation Alliance was over the moment that I knew about them.

Well, even if that hadn't happened, I am sure that Diablo or Souei would have caught them eventually.

“And I am a member of the Glory Knights, one of the factions within the Humanity Emancipation Alliance. I was pretending to be a student in order to investigate from the inside.”

Magnus said this, just as I had decided to crush the Humanity Emancipation Alliance.

I see, since just about anyone could become a student, it was easy to sneak in.

But using the school for such a purpose seemed like nothing short of a declaration of war to me.

I mean, I could see why Ciel would not ignore such a foolish organization existing here.

She had looked for the perfect timing to get evidence and then had me move.

I was perhaps not the smartest, for being so easily lured by the word 'vacation,' but the people who were unlucky in this situation were those of the Humanity Emancipation Alliance.

Ciel was even more frightening than any Demon Lord once you made an enemy of her.

Irina and Magnus appeared to be in high positions within the organization.

They talked on of how wonderful it was, and of how horrible the Demon Lords who ruled...in other words, me and the other Demon Lords, were. They insisted on the validity of the right of humans.

After that, they went about trying to persuade the students.

This was so that they would testify that the students that they

had abandoned had just been killed by the monsters.

Also, they wanted to place all of the students in important positions in the country once they had become older, therefore extending the power of the Humanity Emancipation Alliance.

Perhaps Julius and the others had denied their invitation to join.

And so they had become a nuisance to be rid of, once the opportunity presented itself.

And such an opportunity had arrived, and so it had now come to this.

“I suppose it will be too difficult to give us an answer this instant. We will return again once we finish going to the shore and requesting help from the mainland. I hope that you all would have come to a conclusion by then. It would not be a good thing for us, to have colleagues and fellow students die. And so I pray that you make the right decision.”

Irina said and ended her speech.

Magnus had created a barrier around the area to keep out monsters, ensuring the safety of this place.

This was likely done to calm us and minimize the amount of hostility we might feel.

“Magnus. So, you were tricking everyone?”

“Ah, Satoru. Sorry to involve you in all of this, when you aren’t even a student.”

“You, are you really fine with having allowed Julius, Karma and the others to be killed?”

“...I am not fine with it. But...those who think differently than you are only in the way.”

Magnus muttered in a slightly saddened voice.

However, he seemed very convinced that he was in the right.

This idiot was a student at the school.

“Hey, Magnus. You made me very angry. You better remember that, the next time we meet.”

Magnus did not understand what I meant, and he could only shrug.

And once he had finished setting up the barrier, he reunited with Irina and the others, and they left us.

And that was how the long night ended.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 14

It was a tragic spectacle.

I didn’t think it would get like this.

I feel like I have been outwitted by Ciel-san.

Well, I guess it’s just the usual.

But about the mysterious organization which got involved —‘Humanity Liberation Alliance’...

It’s quite brave of them to even aim for Tempest, which is directly under my care.

I might have overlooked the infiltration of a few spies in these few decades.

These people, who have taken important positions in fields such the economy, technology and even culture, are aiming for the moment when generations change to rise the movement of 'Humanity Liberation Alliance'. They would slowly encroach like that and before long would have the state in their palms.

To make such a long-term plan—It seems it was made by someone who has a broad outlook.

Let's say I didn't become aware of the organization at all—I don't think it would have affected me still, since I don't have a life span... It would have been really bothersome to crush their plans one by one, by adjusting the course.

But now that I do know of that, all I need to do is get a well-qualified person and order them to deal with it.

It would also be easy to crush them.

If they are looking for a fight with me, I will just have to crush them in their own game.

Well, leaving that for later...

Even still–

That Magnus, it felt like he had strength left to spare even when dealing with a semi-demonlord class... isn't that a bit abnormal?

Semi-demonlord class... to simplify it, they are as strong as Arch Demons.

Although, for what it matters, having seen the fight myself, it felt like the opponent was lesser than a just-born Arch Demon in terms of strength but their strength was very much similar.

That's probably because Poison Tiger is reigning over this island's ecosystem from the summit and has probably never had to fight seriously. On top of that, he's probably not used to fighting against someone on the same level as him.

But either way, the threat he posed was real.

There aren't many people who can go up against that alone.

Among the humans, it's probably a handful of the high ranking Holy Knights.

If Magnus is of the same level as a high ranking Holy Knight, he is too strong for a student.

No, if he's a spy, there's a chance he has been lying about his age as well...

Well, either way, Magnus surely possesses unshakable strength which you can't acquire with just weapon ability.

The way I am now—with powers of a human, can I win against him?

Of course I can.

It would be a piece of cake if I just had to win.

I only have the abilities of a human at the moment and my energy is low but my level is the same as before.

It wouldn't matter if the opponent is a arch demon or a lesser demon lord. I would just dodge all their attacks with 'prediction analysis' and 'teleportation' and end them with 'imaginary blow', ignoring any kind of attribute and defense.

However, if I were to do that, they would know my location.

But if I don't teleport and use as low energy as possible to stop —no, let's not.

I even escaped to enjoy the ordinary life.

There's no need to expose my identity intentionally and show off my omnipotent powers.

That's right, it doesn't have to be me who defeats Magnus.

There's Julius and Karma and their friends as well.

I should give them the chance for revenge as well.

However, as they are now, they won't be able to beat Magnus.

On the contrary, even Julius' envoy Clad or Ingracia's battle-type instructor won't stand a chance.

As I thought, this is my time, the Rimuru-sensei's time.

I thought that with a grin and gazed at the exhausted students as they slept.

First, I prepared for the meal.

One can't fight with an empty stomach. Meals are important to revive one's willpower as well.

As such, I started my work while everyone was still asleep.

I have an abundance of preys today.

That's because monsters are lying everywhere around these areas due to the battle last night.

And among them, I chose the ones which were really lively and appropriate for eating and lined them up.

'Appraisal Analysis' is extremely useful in these situations.

And then, I processed a large amount of it which can satisfy all the students and started cooking and preparing them in a large cauldron.

I will go with a easily made soup this time using the wild grasses and vegetables we didn't use yesterday.

I cut them in small size for easier digestion and made them soft by boiling. I also didn't restrain in going the most optimal path drawn out by Ciel.

One might wonder how I know of all these cooking methods but that doesn't really matter.

I can give whatever excuse I like if I get it done before everyone wakes up.

Once I was done boiling the soup, I lit the fire.

I put the cauldron on gentle heating.

While the soup was being done, I crushed some potato like food and made a paste by mixing it with a salted fruit.

Then I flattened it out like a pancake.

Now if I just stick it in a stick and roast it, it can act as an alternative for bread.

We do have a stove so it might be better to roast it on top of the net we used when roasting the meat.

And like that, I finished preparing.

All that's left is to wait for everyone to wake up while the soup is made.

And in the morning, the soup was almost done.

A very savory scent spread from it.

I felt the presence of the comparatively livelier bunch waking up after smelling the scent.

I was using 'Heat Operation' to control the temperature but it seems it would be better to do it naturally about now. Otherwise, they would notice the abnormality immediately.

And just when I increased the fire by putting in more firewood, the first student woke up and came.

"Satoru-kun! You prepared everyone's meal?!"

Marsha was surprised.

It seems the scent went all the way into the tents.

"Yeah. It was terrible last night and everyone must be tired too. And I wasn't able to be of any use in the battle either. I could at least do this much."

"Not at all! I think everyone will be really happy!"

Marsha smiled happily.

And while we were doing that, the students woke up one by one and came out.

Even the instructors who were in critical condition came out and thought it was weird that their wounds had healed but they all understood once they saw me.

I will applaud them that they didn't say anything unnecessary.

"It will be done soon. Could you prepare the bath in the meantime?"

As I asked that of Marsha, she replied 'got it!' and happily nodded before going off to the for-bath-use tent.

It seemed like she was in shock because of the events last night but now that she saw good food and has something she can do, she had regained some willpower.

At times like this, it is good to do something to change gears.

First, we have food.

And then, we get in the tub to wash away all the dirt from the battle.

There are probably those who were bathed in the others' blood too so it would be good for them to be clean.

And after that–

As Marsha left, William came up to me seeing I was alone.

“Is now a good time, Rimuru-sama?”

He came to speak as the representative.

I nodded and decided to plan on what to do from now on.

“Are all the wounded healed?”

“Yes. With the help of the healing potions you gave us, everyone has healed.”

“That’s good. I think you understand but—”

“Of course, I told them these are healing potions Pyuri the health doctor prepared.”

“Yeah, that’s good.”

“–However, how exactly are we, still alive?”

“That’s because Moss was there.”

To introduce him to sage William, I called out Moss.

[It is very nice to meet you. I am Testarossa-sama's aide, who is of the equal rank and is a coworker to Diablo, who is Rimuru-sama's trusted retainer. I am called Moss. Pleased to make your acquaintance–]

The small Moss showed hypocritical courtesy as he introduced himself to William.

But William didn't take any offense from that, rather he said,

“A-ah, yes, same here. I thank you for saving us.”

Although Moss is being used as a handyman, his position in Tempest is indeed high. I guess he would be a god-like existence even to the academy's elders.

Besides, even though Moss looks like this, even arch demons don't match up to him.

It isn't weird for the sage William's expression to stiffen seeing a being who can destroy large countries with ease.

"Then, will this 'Human Liberation Alliance' thing be taken care of by Moss-sama?"

William asked me, pulling himself together.

He's probably worried about the instructors and students who affiliate with Human Liberation Alliance.

"No, I won't do that."

"Why is that? I had completely assumed that anyone who opposed you would be annihilated..."

It's vexing seeing how my image is being passed on like this.

I mean, sure, I would annihilate people who are clearly

enemies but I won't go killing everyone like a barbarian just because their position is in opposition to mine...

“Now listen here, ‘enemy’ can mean many different things, alright? I would have crushed them if they were destroying towns or killing people but the Human Liberation Alliance is different, right? I will just fight them in their own ring and have defeat etch into their mind and body so that they never think of opposing me again.”

Right.

In the first place, it is hard to charge anyone this time.

What the Human Liberation Alliance did was persuading the students and instructors to agree to their thinking—which is to free themselves of me, the demon lord's rule.

Even if money is involved in this, it would be hard to judge it as a crime.

It is clear that they are opposing me but they are innocent in terms of law.

That is the tough part.

It is true that I hold absolute authority but even then I wouldn't around tampering with the laws freely.

I can suggest a certain law in the parliament but a majority vote can only bring it to shape. Well, even then, most of my laws would pass but I never really presented a law to begin with.

I had decided to not touch politics since the time I started leading the Goblins.

All I had to do was watch over the management after fixing a set of rules.

I could easily reject an absurd law suggestion by a lower legislature house and even if they do pass, I could reject them later. Even I need to go through the proper procedures to set a

new law.

I don't have any plans on trying to do anything absurd like 'to death with him!' and even if I did, it wouldn't pass.

This time around as well, I am upholding such values.

Even the actions taken in this island—I can condemn them in terms of humanity but there are no concise law.

They had been hiding their identity until the instructors or students who could pose a problem were defeated.

But to say that is a crime is difficult.

There's no doubt that they left the others to die but it can't be said to be a crime just because they didn't save them.

They probably plan on leaving the students or teachers who

won't cooperate in the island and have the monsters deal with them—but that can't be charged as a crime as of yet.

After all, they can't be charged unless they directly had a hand in it.

They haven't committed any clear crimes at present and the actions which they are assumed to take when leaving the island are just assumptions.

It's a pain but since I don't have any charges I can file against them, I can't do anything yet.

“If so, what do you plan on doing?”

“It's simple, William-kun. The students who are angry at Magnus for the betrayal will try to take revenge. That too by a legal and formal way—by a duel.”

“–Don't tell me, Julius and Karma? However, with the skill difference between them...”

“There shouldn’t be a problem. We still have 3 days. Once they are done eating, I plan on going full spartan coaching on them.”

“O-oh... I don’t know what to say...”

“I will have you cooperate as well. And then we will win and return triumphantly. They probably plan on leaving anyone who don’t align with their ideals in this island. However, if we are able to escape this island with everyone alive, we will win. Right?”

“That is, true. That’s exactly right!”

It seems the sage William also got my intentions and was gushing with motivation.

He didn’t look hesitant anymore and a strong light was burning in his eyes.

“If there’s anything I can do, please let me know!”

William vigorously nodded.

The students who had lost all hope also regained their liveliness after having the freshly baked bread-like food and the soup.

Delicious food is the best medicine.

After all, it's a special recipe made by Ciel-sensei which even I get to eat rarely.

As I made it with 'auto-mode', it would be impossible to recreate it by myself.

If I want to eat it again, I will have to ask Ciel.

And since they had such a God's (Ciel) cooking, of course the students' reaction was this.

“So deliciouuuussss!!”

“Seriously, what is this?!”

“Wha—the stew last night was amazing too but this is even better?!”

“Satoru-kun, you were a cooking genius, huh?!”

“I would very much like you to be my bride.”

High praises here and there.

Although there were some idiots asking me to be their brides, I guess it just shows that they are lively enough to say that.

And like this, the gloomy atmosphere was blown away with one shot and the youth-like cheerful atmosphere returned.

Seeing that, I stood up.

“Well, what will you guys do? Will you cry yourself to sleep here and beg Magnus for help?”

“No... well, even if you say that, Satoru-kun...”

Karma answered me as the representative of the students.

The instructors only watched over.

Exactly how I planned it with William.

“Oi, Karma, was it? What about you? if you lose then that’s the end? Aren’t you frustrated being called a dejected loser?”

“What did ya say?!”

Karma's burning eyes filled with anger glared at me, unlike a honor student.

That's fine.

Anger will fuel your will to live.

“Oi, Julius. You too. You act all high and mighty all the time but you aren't anything special, are you? ‘It is the royalty's job to protect the people’, ‘it is the responsibility of the people who stand on top’—these are phrases someone with strength should say. What kind of a leader are you? Can't even see through a guy like Magnus' real intentions?”

“Real intentions? He has been fooling us from the start. He easily abandoned me after asking me to join him. I also believed my envoy, Clad, because he introduced him to me... In reality, I actually thought of him as my best friend... I had thought of him as my best friend.. who would bind us together... me, who can't live as I will because I am royalty... with the school friends and Karma...”

It seems Julius was shocked the most.

After he was defeated by the monster, he was being protected by Moss. And even in that vague state of consciousness, he probably heard their conversation.”

And then, after being healed, he got to know of Magnus’ true strength and realized that they had been abandoned.

Above all, it was all clear when his envoy Clad didn’t move.

If they didn’t cooperate, then their half-hearted strength would only be a hindrance.

Julius was probably thought as the epitome of that and a target to be dispose of right away.

“Then, why didn’t you speak freely with him?”

“What?!”

“Shouldn’t you have spoken freely with your hearts out with Magnus before something like this happened?”

“That is—”

“Did your title of royalty hinder you? But you know, that’s just an excuse!”

“Kuhh—”

Julius frowned but couldn’t talk back.

It seems he is looking back at his actions without trying to talk back imprudently.

“Well, what will you do?”

“What do you mean?”

“Will you cry yourself to sleep like Karma here?”

“But—Magnus is way stronger than....”

“Oh what, you will give up just ‘cause you can’t win? You know, if there’s one thing that bastard Masayuki didn’t do, it’s giving up?”

“....That bastard Masayuki?”

Ah, this is bad.

I ended up calling him as I normally do.

“Ahhh, no, no, I meant the Hero Masayuki-sama, yes. What I want to say is, basically, you need the spirit to at least be able to call that hero-sama a bastard!!”

The group of instructors were watching over me with warm eyes as I tried to gloss it over.

When I glanced at them, thinking I would reduce their salary, they hurriedly looked away.

And among all that,

“That’s right, it’s exactly as Satoru-kun says. You people, it’s unforgivable to stay defeated like this when you are the proud students of the academy. It seems the battle instructors are also going to train so you people should also work hard! Even if you get wounded, I will patch you up properly. The founder of the academy, the Great Demon Lord Rimuru-sama is also probably watching over us from our country so show him your pride and dignity as the students of the academy!”

The health doctor Pyuri came following up.

Her fluttering gray waver reflected the sunlight, making her look truly as the Goddess of victory.

It seems the simple male students were motivated with just that.

“That’s right! The hero Masayuki’s divine protection will surely protect us as well!”

I don’t think there’s even a tiny bit of such protection but I guess I will nod to William’s words as well.

“What will you do, Julius? Won’t you stand in front of everyone and lead us? Decide already!”

In response to my words, Julius discarded all hesitation and looked me in the eye and said.

“I will do it. I won’t be able to settle down either if I don’t say a thing or two to Magnus. The next time, whether it’s some monster or Magnus, I will win!”

It seems Julius is also motivated.

Just as I had predicted.

“Alright! Let’s all work hard and show them what we’re made of! If we win, I will consider treating you all!”

I declared with a complacent smile.

And immediately afterwards–

“Uuuwwoohhh!! I will do it!!”

“Leave it to us, Satoru-chan!”

“Kyaaa—Satoru-kun! This onee-san will protect you, alright?!”

“Would we perhaps have any right to that reward as well?”

Such excited cheering shook up the place.

The frenzy was so much that I had to put myself on guard for a moment there.

It seemed like the plump instructor said something about the reward there as well but I will pretend I didn't hear it as the other instructors took him away.

Either way, I succeeded in lighting a fire in them.

And like this, the special training for the day of counterattack began.

Author note:

It seems the complacent smile was = divine smile.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape

Plan – 15

And like that, the fourth day ended. It was now the morning of the fifth day.

With all of the students standing in a line in front of me, I put on a pair of swirly glasses and stood in front of them.

After eating lunch yesterday, the students had taken baths and focused their attention on recovering from their fatigue.

We had plenty of meat from the monsters, and Julius had even offered some vegetables from his ‘space storage,’ and it was clear that it would be possible to feed everyone here for two to three days.

And so there was no need to go exploring. So instead, everyone rested.

In the meantime, I talked with the teachers as we prepared for this position of ‘new teachers for the study of a new type of

magic.’

“This introduction comes a little late, but this is Satoru, my confidant and a leader in magic research. In fact, I had requested that he become a teacher before, but he refused. However, fortunately, he has agreed to help you all after hearing that you want to become stronger! Now, Satoru. I would like to say a few words.”

Old William came out and introduced me to everyone.

I generously nodded back to him.

All of the students had expressions of shock upon hearing that I was an acquaintance of William, and was also a leader of magical research.

Which was no surprise.

I looked younger than all of them, and yet I had the qualifications to stand with the teachers.

Among them, George, Mondo, and others of the same group, were especially surprised, which was quite entertaining to watch.

But perhaps Marsha had realized that the magic cards were my idea, because she seemed quite satisfied with this explanation.

She must have been suspicious of the conversations between me and Old William.

Marsha wasn't only good with magic, but she had great intuition. I felt as if I acted too carelessly, she would find out my true identity. And so I had to be careful.

Well, there were only three days left. And I would deal with it when or if it happened.

I observed the students' reaction like this and then said:

"I am Satoru. I was actually thinking about waiting for help

and keeping out of it, but I changed my mind when I saw how driven you all were. I want to meet your expectations and lead you to raise your base combat abilities within a short time. Well, then. Did you all get a good nights sleep? From today on, I and the research students will be in charge of the cooking, so the combat and magic student should focus on bettering themselves to the best of their ability. I want you to prove to me that what you said yesterday was not a lie! Now, let us begin...”

Here I raised the swirly glasses again and looked at the students.

“Sato-, no, teacher. What are we supposed to do...?”

I smiled mischievously at George’s question.

“For now, I want you to run.”

The students looked at me and gulped as I made the order and then smiled.



The first thing was to run.

That was the basics.

Well, I set the quota for magic-type students quite low, so they would return without taking too much time.

Until then, I would discuss our future direction.

But before that, I also had to instruct the remaining students on how to cook.

I was very, very busy.

I had the students who were in the research field gather around so I could teach them how to cook.

There were the girls who were always close to Julius, Maria, and Carol.

Apparently, it had been the butlers, Niel and Cast, as well as his guard knight, Clad, who prepared the food for Julius and the others.

While Clad was a knight, Niel and Cast were very good at cooking.

As Clad had been helping, it would have been easy for him to mix in the spices.

The problem was whether or not he knew about the effect they would have.

What I did know, was that a researcher named Irina was behind it, and had given the order.

But did Magnus know about it?

I'm sure they were trying to get rid of anything that could hinder them, but perhaps they had not intended for everyone to die.

But the result...

Had I not had Moss protect them, the teachers, Julius, and the others. The truth is that they would have all died.

In my opinion, they were guilty. But it would be hard to prove whether or not they meant to kill.

And so I wouldn't bother.

It would be easier to just ignore the details of the plan, and just completely crush the entire organization.

Well, enough about that.

I watched them for a while. They were doing their job well.

They knew how to make use of the help that the students offered, and they cooked while following my orders.

There was no problem here.

I think we would be enjoying a fine dinner tonight.

I looked forward to it as I left them there.

And then I went over to the tent where the teachers of magic had gathered.

The combat teachers were participating in the running, and so they were not here.

They wouldn't understand it anyway, and would be in the way.

Within the tent, Old William was holding the magic cards and explaining to the other teachers what they did.

“Ah, Lord Rimuru. I just finished explaining it to them.”

“Oh, thank you. By the way, I hope you can be careful to not call me that in front of the students?”

“Hahaha. Of course.”

Old William laughed. It seemed a little forced.

But I needed him to be very careful. It wasn't something that I could just shrug off.

And I was scared that I needed to warn him before he made a mistake.

I needed to hammer it into him once and for all before

beginning.

“I want you to take charge of the magic-type students. You will use these cards and oversee their training.”

I said. Then one of the NNU researchers raised their hand and looked at me.

I think his name was Heinrich. He was one of the first to see what was happening on this island.

I nodded and allowed him to speak.

“First, allow me to apologize. To think that someone from our own school was involved in this incident...”

“I know. I accept your apology and so there is no need for you to worry. Let’s think about the future now.”

I accepted his words with this answer, but...

“...But, how can you easily trust someone who is associated with a teacher who would do such a thing? Though, I do intend to follow any order that is given...”

Heinrich continued to insist.

Perhaps the other teachers had said something to him while I was away.

“Well, don’t think about that. You can show me with your actions. That is all. And while I can understand if you are unable to meet my expectations, I hope you will at least refrain from betraying me.”

I added a little warning, just in case.

“All of you who are present. Rimu-, no, Lord Satoru...”

“Let’s just use Master Satoru.”

“Of course!”

Really. Old William’s slips of the tongue were scary.

I would have to constantly be warning him and covering for his mistakes.

“We would never do anything like betraying you, Master Satoru!”

I nodded at this speech by Old William while thinking about something else.

Heinrich seemed satisfied by this, and so we continued the discussion.



It was a virtual meeting of ultrafast thought, conducted through 'Thought Acceleration' and 'Thought Transmission,' both of which were quite familiar to me.

The magic cards were distributed to the teachers with the intent of deepening their understanding of their contents.

Obviously, it was virtual, so no real magic would activate.

However, with the use of Master Ciel's ultra calculating abilities, even this virtual environment would be able to immerse you to the point where it was indiscernible from the real thing.

And it would all have a physical effect on you.

Once you understood it, and you could use the magic, you would be able to use that experience acquired in the virtual world in the real world as well.

It wouldn't quite work with physical training, but the use of

magic was all in the mind, and so it was the perfect place to practice.

However, most human brains were incapable of processing the information quick enough, and so only people who had reached a certain level were able to use it.

Even with these teachers, acceleration was limited to about three hundred times normal speed. And they could only stand it for about one hour of real time. If they did it any longer, their brains would suffer possibly fatal damage.

But well, training for an hour under these circumstances meant gaining the experience of three hundred hours. Which equaled twelve and a half days.

And that was enough for those that were talented.

It was really only me and Guy who had been capable of this, so that meant these teachers would be the first humans to have this incredibly rare experience.

When there was only a little time left, everyone was able to use the Anagram Magic.

But then again, the principals were rather simple.

Even if the combination was right, it would not activate if there was not enough magic power.

“However, this...”

“How can I say this...”

“I suppose it’s as if all common sense concerning magic has been rewritten?”

“This will make things much easier for my magic research, but it almost feels as if I am cheating.”

These were the reactions of Old Willian, Heinrich, Pyuri, and

the chubby Blum.

While Pyuri was the public health doctor, she seemed to be interested in healing magic, and so had participated willingly.

“However, it took us all over ten days. How can we teach the students...”

Old William said rather sensibly.

He was right.

No matter how much we crammed into them, it would not be possible to understand a new type of magic within a few days.

It would be impossible even if you were some kind of genius.

“Don’t worry. I thought that this might happen, and so I prepared a simplified version of the magic cards in advance.”

No, that was a lie.

I only just made them.

I would alter them to fit each student's talents and distribute them. If we did it like this, then each student should be able to easily do one or two spells that they are good at, without chanting.

However, it was a pain to have to explain all this, so I decided to persuade them with some random words.

"I see. So we will pass out cards that they are good with?"

"Yes. And once they become confident, they will be able to use the official magic cards."

"I see. I see."

They were satisfied, and I was grateful for that.

“Wait a moment. You said official version...does that mean you intend on revealing these cards to the general public?”

Blum looked at me with wide eyes and an expression of disbelief.

“Yes. Why?”

I answered. Blum’s mouth clamped in horror.

But he seemed to come to a decision after a momentary hesitation, and then he continued cautiously.

“But it will mean reevaluating the entirety of magical education. Not only that...”

“The very idea of magic will change greatly. Students of the

Sorcerer's Dynasty Sarion will not be silent about it.”

“Magic engineering and anything that relies on the current structures of magic will have to be greatly altered to be efficient. It's not just about efficiency...this could cause the kind of uproar that a cultural revolution would...”

They were first-rate teachers.

And so they were quick to see what kind of chaos might be caused.

Of course, I had considered it myself as well.

“Well, don't fret. I will publicize it, but not right away. As this has to do with the original text, I will have to make many new spells and improve upon it in order for normal people to be able to use it. In other words...”

I said, and then explained to them my ideas for this new type of magic.

The cards that I had given to Marsha were cards that could do anything.

However, those who had little power to imagine, would not be able to make much use of them. You would need something that showed you the steps, much like the instructions I had given to her.

But it would be hard to memorize all these steps, and it wouldn't do much good to have these cards do everything.

By good, I mean profit.

To be exact, each one of these cards will have a single effect carved into them.

The amount of mana used will be the same between spells so that as long as they had the concentration, normal people would be able to use it.

–To explain it more accurately, unlike monsters, humans are

incapable of turning mana into energy.

There are some with magical power. And aside from them, there are also others who have power such as spiritual power that can be changed into magical power. But they are rare.

Of course, that doesn't mean that they can't control mana at all.

Just as it is possible for people to use magic, it is possible for them to control mana.

This was done through chanting.

Aside from that, magic could be done through contracts with spirits.

Spiritual power=spending energy to access the truth of the world or to command spirits.

To put it bluntly, energy=magic.

These magic cards were meant to be used by humans.

In other words, it turned energy into magic in the most efficient way, which allowed humans to use magic easily.

That's what it all was.

A magic card that anyone could use.

It would sell incredibly well.

For instance, you could learn attack magic like Fireball. It would be great for defending yourself.

Convenient magic that could control gravity would become vital for transporting heavy loads.

As for flying magic, there will definitely need to be some training to be able to control it.

And it was these kinds of magic skills that would be carved into the cards.

It would make it possible to activate these kinds of magic through combining words.

These combinations would be studied for the purpose of allowing normal people to use them and so they can spread.

And I planned to have the students of Sarion participate in the research. With free thought, they could create all kinds of new magic.

All kinds of magic would be carved into the cards.

Users would have to buy the cards that they required, which meant I could expect tremendous profits.

And to the most advanced users alone, I would sell all-purpose cards that were simplified versions with some limitation.

They would allow you to bring about all kinds of effects with your imagination alone.

“...Something like that. It won’t be right away, but after thorough preparations over ten years, I think. That is when I could announce it to society?”

And with that, I ended my explanation.

If it was made public, it would mean the birth of a new type of magic, following Element magic and Spirit magic.

Its high applicability would mean that it could be used in combination with Curse magic to do all kinds of things.

There was no doubt that it would do wonders for the development of magical science.

“It is like a dream...”

Old Willaim said with an emotional sigh.

“Right? I had planned on doing this secretly at first, but I revealed it here because I believe in you all. Besides, I found someone with incredible talent who I thought would be able to really use this magic.”

The teachers all exchanged glances as I said this.

And then Old William spoke for all of them and asked me.

“Do you mean Marsha?”

“I do.”

I nod.

To be honest, I did intend on taking my time with revealing it. I hadn't decided on who I would leave it to.

But amidst all of that, there was something about Marsha's ability that was head and shoulders above the rest.

Magic for humans, not demons or monsters.

Needless to say, it had to be a human who researched and developed it.

I would give texts and hints, and leave the rest to them.

And the academy was the best possible place to conduct such research.

However, I could not allow the Humanity Emancipation Alliance to exist at the same time.

I wanted everyone to be friends and cooperate with each other while they did their research.

“Teach and lead Marsha. You must all work together as you study it. Well, before that, you will have to teach the magic students at least one magic spell each.”

“Of course!”

“I will try and meet your expectations!”

“Please leave the healing to me. And then a little danger won’t matter.”

“We will have to work hard, so as not to lose to Marsha.”

It seemed that the teachers understood my meaning very well.

Now I knew I could leave it all to them.

“I look forward to your future accomplishments and seeing you meet my expectations of being worthy of being named one of the founders of this magic!”

All of the teachers nodded strongly at these words.

By the way...

“But, what if this information were to leak...”

Blum asked as sweat dripped down his face.

I replied with a smile.

“My subordinates will not hold back when dealing with people who are careless with information. This is something that William Roaz knows very well. I want you to tell them very clearly what my subordinates do.”

Old William must have remembered the time he spoke with Souei directly when I addressed him.

He looked a little pale as he faced the others. He then told them earnestly that they must keep it a secret at all cost.

And there was one other thing.

“Um, I have a question...”

Pyuri said hesitantly.

“What is it?”

“Yes...Irina. The Humanity Emancipation Alliance. What will you do with them? Do you really think that students can beat them?”

She asked worriedly.

Hmm. As for that, there was only one way to find out.

“I have a plan. But, the most important thing is that my identity remains hidden. Winning alone would be easy, but the most desirable outcome is if I could have the students win without drawing attention to myself. If not, it would be rather troublesome for you all, wouldn’t it?”

“What do you mean?”

William asked me. His expression suggested that he had a very bad feeling about what I was about to say.

“Yes. The moment that my location is discovered, I expect troublesome people to force their way here. The truth is, I’m here in secret, and am on my way out while trying to remain undiscovered. In a way, I’m trying to escape. So you know, do I really have to explain the rest?”

What?! The teachers looked as if they wanted to scream.

Oh, well.

I guess I could understand why they would look like that. I had just told them that they were now involved in my little escape plan.

If something went wrong, they could be mistaken for abductors.

This small suggestion was enough to ensure that the teachers cooperated with me from the bottom of their hearts.

“Also, around now... I think that one of my most dangerous subordinates is using his brain to profile and purge each school. So it’s only a matter of time before these Humanity Emancipation Alliance people are smoked out... If anything, it might be kinder to have the students defeat them first...”

I said, keeping my words a little cryptic.

“...Do you mean Diablo?”

Pyuri asked, and the rest of them became tense.

“Uh, well, I guess?”

I answered.

“AHHHHHH!! That means I might be able to meet Diablo?!”

“Ahh, those guys are finished.”

“They were so foolish. So very, very foolish...”

“Ah. With innocence being proven. I am so relieved from the bottom of my heart.”

Each teacher blurted out their reaction.

One of them was strangely excited, and another seemed a little

weird...but nevermind.

“In any case, you all might become targets of Diablo’s judgment if my identity is exposed. So, do your best!”

It was a simple threat, but the effect was amazing, and all was good.

Now, as the teachers braced themselves, the virtual meeting came to an end.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape

Plan – 16

The course of education for the students who use magic had been decided.

And right in time, those students came back, all worn out.

About an hour had passed in real time, so it would have been quite a tough long run for the students who mainly use magic since they don’t have much stamina to begin with.

The magic users also need stamina but this should be sufficient.

Leaving the rest to the instructors, as we planned in the meeting, I turned to look towards the leading actors, the combat-type students.

And then–

“Run, run! Even in your dreams, you can’t even win with Magnus and his party like that!”

The combat type instructor Brown shouted passionately, as if he was a different person. Even the three other accompanying instructors also looked like they were having a hard time. Instructor Brown’s last spurt was that bloodcurdling.

One of the instructors, Peter, even said,

“B-brown-sensei, the-there’s no need to be that intense from the start now—”

And acted as proxy for the students.

However, such a remark from instructor Peter too was thrown away easily.

“Be quiet! If we’re doing this, we’re doing this to win! Shouldn’t we make frantic efforts with that spirit? Am I wrong? If you’re going to be like that, you’re never going to get the

reward from Rimu—Satoru-sensei!”

But still, this guy...

Hasn’t his objective changed?

Moreover, wasn’t he just about to casually call out my name? That is kinda worrying.

“Right, it seems I was in the wrong. Rimu—I mean, Satoru-sensei is watching. We are not allowed to be lenient—You guys, get psyched up!!”

“That’s right, Peter-sensei! We are in no position to be compromising! Now, you guys—run as if your life depends on it!”

“””YEAHH!!”””

U-umm...

It seems instructor Peter was also the same.

Why are the instructors being all serious?!

You're leaving the students behind.

But, that's fine.

That's fine but... the students, did they get brainwashed over this past week or something?

Their eyes fired up and they started running desperately.

They ran at full speed, using all their remaining strength and even more perhaps.

Using the optimum distribution of their energy and magic to reduce their exhaustion simultaneously.

What is it that's stirring up these students this much?

Don't tell me... they aren't aiming for the reward I talked about... are they?

I could only pray that it was my imagination that made it look like they wanted the reward more than letting Magnus and the others have a piece of their mind.

Until night came that day, they had been doing the long runs.

As expected, everyone was completely exhausted.

They were flat out empty of mana and couldn't even stand up properly.

But after drinking the drink I made, with a hint of the restoration medicine mixed in, they were able to recover enough to at least walk.

One shot for stamina!

I didn't add taurine in it but seems like the effect was amazing.

Not only did it heal wounds, it also recovered their stamina.

“Satoru-san, this is...?”

“Ah, it's a drink I made with a secret recipe. I had the ingredients so I prepared enough for everyone.”

I answered with a smile.

It's a complete lie but I can't really say that “I made it by

mixing with the restoration medicine I had on me all this time” so I don’t really have a choice.

Ah, that reminds me, this is a bit late but I am glad that the “monsters can’t lie” thing has no effect on me.

It’s not like I like deceiving people or anything but considering my personality and position, I am in situations where I can’t say the truth a lot.

....No, it isn’t really a lie either, is it?

If you were to broadly interpret it, “secret recipe”, “I had ingredients”, or “I prepared for enough for everyone”–all these aren’t really lies.

Just the “I had ingredients” part would be more accurate if I had said “I had it in my Imaginary Space so that might just be a bit strained.

Well, that stuff doesn’t really matter either way.

The moment everyone recovered from their exhaustion after drinking the beverage I prepared, they realized that they were starving, as well.

And it immediately became time for the left over squad to prepare dinner.

It seems the group in charge of cooking gave it their all so the dishes this time around were satisfying, as well.

I had the magic using students go through practical training of making containers using earth magic and tempering using combustion magic.

As a result, everyone's tableware was also prepared.

Although there are some which are oddly-shaped, they have their own attractiveness.

And like this, we were able to enjoy a good meal on the night of the 5th day as well.

Now then, hunger has been satisfied but...

It is about time their ability to think also recovered and they start to feel discontent.

“Satoru—sensei.... there’s something I would like to ask.”

Julius said and stood up.

It seems he had some resistance in calling me sensei but he appears to have suppressed his pride and acknowledged me as their teacher.

A more honest guy than I had first thought.

“What is it?”

“We didn’t really do anything other than running today but will we really be able to beat them like this?”

“You stupid? Of course you won’t get strong by just running. If you could win with just that, nobody would have to work hard.”

“Wha-!?”

It seems my words offended him as he looked on the verge of losing it.

We made them run all day long without letting them think. And on top of that, I just said something that could also be interpreted to mean that there’s no point in running.

In a manner of speaking, it is like saying that you wasted the entire day.

Julius probably thinks he has been made fun of.

However, one would understand it if they thought about it normally.

There's no way they can get stronger just by running.

That's just proof that they are shocked by many things and can't think straight.

Inversely, it can also be said that by just running all day long today, they have regained their presence of mind.

“-In other words, this was all to have us regain our calm, Satoru-kun?”

“Well, it's fine if you take it that way. Also, call me sensei, Mondo.”

“Uh, yes. Understood, Satoru-sensei.”

“Hmm.”

I nodded.

There's no need to add that it was all a revenge plan for getting back at Julius for his poor treatment towards me.

After all, the other students would just think they just got mixed up in it.

Besides, it seems everyone is content with that answer so I will just go along with it.

“Now then, it seems like you guys were able to cool off your heads. Then let's start the strategy meeting.”

After the meal, we gathered around by a camp fire to discuss strategy.

Julius and Karma also seemed content with that explanation and didn't complain.

It's weird for me to say this but they are quite simple.

Now then, let's start.

“First off all, lets talk about Magnus' strength. Is there anyone who realized the secret behind it?”

Everyone seemed agitated in response to my question.

Not only the students, but also the instructors.

“Instructors as well, if you noticed something, please speak up.”

I also urged the instructors to talk about their observation.

Is there anyone who has noticed?

“Now that I think about it... Magnus was a very excelling guy but it didn't seem like he was hiding that amount of strength...”

Karma, who seemed to have been in good terms with him, muttered.

I guess that's true.

If someone has that amount of strength, a portion of it would show when they are taking the lessons.

At the very least, even if the students didn't realize, the instructors would.

If a instructor didn't even notice someone so strong, then they fail as an instructor.

"I don't want to make excuses but I didn't think he would be that strong of a student."

"Rig...ht. It didn't seem like he was hiding his strength, more like he suddenly gained strength—or rather, it felt like he borrowed strength."

Jiddah, a combat type instructor of NNU muttered.

Heinrich, who had been observing the combat agreed with him.

As expected of researchers, they make good observations.

“Borrowed strength, you say? That makes it sound like—”

“Sounds like Element Fusion?”

I cut off sage William.

And the place fell silent at once.

And that’s only natural too, since, Element Fusion is–

Using a superior elemental spirit, the final hidden technique

for an elementalist

—after all.

That's right.

It's truly what can be said to be the strongest technique known to mankind, only permitted to those who are worthy of being called 'hero'.

The only ones who can use this as a group are the strongest squad known to mankind, the Holy Knights.

“No, but—”

“There's no way a student can perform Element Fusion!”

“The only ones who can probably do that are the legendary hero “Ruler of the Flames” or the new-generation hero and his

allies!”

“Exactly. It’s not something a mere student can pull off!”

The discussion turned vigorous at once after that.

A display of denial rather than a discussion.

However, we won’t get anywhere if we were to discuss things here.

After all, even the instructors don’t really comprehend what actually is Element Fusion.

“Calm down. I will first explain what Element Fusion exactly is.”

The moment I said that, the noisy ones went silent at once.

They all turned to me in unison.

The instructor group's gaze were more piercing than the related students.

“If possible, maybe we can get close to that secret ourselves”—it's clear that they were thinking as such.

Well, that's fine too.

After all, it's not something you would be able to use immediately even if you were to understand it.

“Element Fusion is—”

And like that, I started my explanation.

The most easy to comprehend example would be Shizu-san.

She had fused with Ifreet and had transformed into a demon of flames.

Although in Shizu-san's case, it was due to a unique skill called Deviate so she might be an exception.

It would be extremely difficult for a normal person to fuse that much with an elemental spirit.

Ifreet, the superior flame spirit, possesses energy equal to a semi-demon lord class.

Fusing with that is basically becoming as strong as a semi-demon lord class while being human.

If I were to give that a human rank, then it would be an A+.

S rank is given to demon lords so that is the highest ranking.

Anything above this can only be a 'hero'.

An existence completely opposite that of a demon lord—those who can be said to be the strongest beings in humankind, also get the S rank.

In fact, at this rank, it is also possible for a hero to fuse with the strongest elemental spirits, the light spirits.

That's different from an awakened hero in sense.

To awaken, one needs the "hero's egg" and other factors also come into play so that's more complicated.

At the very least, I haven't heard about Kenya's "hero's egg" hatching.

Although it does seem like he has acquired it.

That 'blessing' thing Ramiris was talking about was a ceremony to ascertain the adaptability percentage with the spirit.

The ones who can make the spirit's strength their own and use it freely are the strongest of these practitioners.

Now then, about the ones below that...

Lower ranking Holy Knights would be a good example.

They are the people who have become able to borrow a portion of the spirits' strength who are compatible with them.

The mysterious power these spirits possess.

These people, despite being human, become able to utilize the power which has the same nature as magic.

That might sound good at first but taking in that kind of energy into one's body is extremely difficult.

Or rather, it's impossible for your general public.

And that's exactly why they train their bodies into a suited vessel, discipline their mental capabilities and strengthen their spiritual body.

It seems like the demon lord Ruminas optimized this and has already created a breeding ground for producing quite strong Holy Knights.

However, even then, apart from a portion of the prodigies, others only can go as high as to borrow a portion of lower rank elemental spirits' strength.

And that too comes with a time limit.

They momentarily exceed human limits and overwhelm the enemy.

That's one of the many techniques which make the Holy Knights the strongest knights.

The strength of a spirit and the techniques of a human.

That's the secret to the strength.

Once you are able to completely use the strength of a higher ranking spirit and the strongest techniques devised by mankind, that's the hero level.

Shizu-san fused using a skill but she had reached this territory.

The reason I won was only because I was lucky.

To be completely frank, it was because my compatibility against her was good.

When I inspected the fight later on, I was told that by the Great Sage.

Say that earlier!—or so I thought then but I wouldn't want to hear something negative like that during a fight. And so it was all good as a result.

Kenya and the others fused with the spirits at the soul level.

Their bodies grew and got used to that power.

—Putting aside exceptions like Shizu-san and Kenya and the others.

I kept on explaining these to them while keeping the concrete stuff hazy.

Now then, it's about time.

Let's change the topic here.

“I think you now properly understand that it is extremely difficult to freely handle a spirit's powers in a human's body. If so, then acquiring this strength in a human's body—in other words, being able to use this mysterious power, what must one do to be able to do this?”

I looked around at everyone listening to me while asking that question.

Being asked a question suddenly, they were perplexed.

However, there were those who were fast in catching up too—

“The way Satoru-sensei phrased that right now—not use the spirit's strength, but use the mysterious power. In other words, if it's a high ranking being other than spirits, it might be easier to use even in a human's body?”

He came presenting a conjecture coming straight for the core.

I smiled and said,

“As expected of the prodigy of Ingracia Synthesis Academy. That’s quite some insight you have there, Julius-kun. Or is it that since the royalty of Ingracia kingdom are well acquainted with spirits, it is only natural for you to know? Then, let me ask specifically. What do you think that is?”

Before I realized, Julius’ noble-like attitude of looking down on me had disappeared.

His anger probably disappeared too while he was listening to the explanation.

It seems that he has acknowledged me as a teacher—no, maybe as something more.

Julius looked hesitant to answer to my question.

However, the answer was already in his mind.

As if he didn't want to speak of it, he opened his mouth only to close it again. But then he drastically went ahead and said it.

“Demon?”

I deepened my smile and applauded.

“That's correct.”

Not angels, but demons.

There's also a reason for that.

As angels are pure, it is harder for them to exist in places other than the heaven.

Although the situation has somewhat changed now.

In the first place, demons were more suited for battle.

Well, there are a few more reasons to it other than that...

There are quite a few who can employ a demon.

Most of them do it by a ritual summoning but there are also some who summon demons with magic.

First class wizards, called the Dark Summoners.

The limit for the employment is up to greater demons but a human's body is enough for that.

On top of this, if the vessel is trained...

They can acquire extraordinary strength without training like a Holy Knight.

Moreover...

“If I were to add, there’s an effective way to strengthen one’s body. Surely there are people here from NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy who know of it?”

As if the NNU students were nervous, they flinched.

But no one answered.

“Armored Corps—one of the previous Empire’s 3 biggest army corps. The soldiers who were enlisted there seemed to have undergone black magic remodeling surgery and became super soldiers but—”

After I said that much, the instructors also realized.

“You don’t mean...”

“Black magic remodeling surgery is supposed to be forbidden due to inhumane methods... Besides, the surviving scientists are—don’t tell me, those scientists are...?”

“No, even if it’s so, it doesn’t make sense. Even if black magic remodeling surgery can strengthen the body, it would only go as high as A rank at most.”

Heinrich declared.

As expected of a researcher, he knows more than combat types.

“Exactly. Certainly, from the information I gathered, there are very few who have gone up to A rank. And that strength wouldn’t come close to a semi-demon lord class. However—what’s important here is, strengthening the body.”

After I hinted that much, Heinrich also realized.

“I... see, a demon only wants a strengthened body, eh... If a

demon dwells in a strengthened body, even if it's a greater demon, they might have the strength to beat a holy knight. And that—"

In other words, that's Demon Fusion.

Well, that's about right.

The strong being of this island, Poison Tiger, who has little combat experience, seemed crude considering it is a semi-demon lord class.

In contrast, if Magnus, who has a ton of combat experience, were to acquire the strength of a demon...

It wouldn't be weird even if he acquired strength exceeding that of Poison Tiger.

Moreover, the chances of black magic remodeling surgery progressing in these past 10 years is quite high.

There's probably no mistake in thinking that Irina, the researcher who seemed to be the mastermind behind this, is the leading person behind that research.

“Well, that's about pretty much it. With this, Magnus' strength should be easy to comprehend to a certain extent.”

Saying that, I brought the talk to a finish temporarily.

Side Story – Rimuru's Elegant Escape Plan – 17

It seemed that they had understood my explanation up until this point.

To be honest, it wouldn't be surprising for the remnants of the empire to have those kinds of skills.

Though, it was really something so poor that it couldn't be called a secret art in the truest sense...

However, I could at least admit that it was a true and stable art.

Besides...

It wasn't as if you were always assimilated to the demon. And it was an interesting idea to be able to use that power only when you needed it.

For instance, looking at the power that Guy gave to Leon's subordinates—'Secret art of Hybrid Soul Fusion,' it was the fusing of two demons with equal strength.

This secret art allowed the party with the stronger will to take over. It was like poisoning someone.

It was a forbidden art. And of course, you could not undo it.

It was all or nothing.

It was dangerous, as you had to have the resolve to wager your own soul.

On the other hand, Demon Fusion, which was the art that the empire had developed, was founded on creating manageable contracts with demons who were willing to serve.

Once safety had been guaranteed, it was possible to fuse when needed.

Unlike fusing with spirits, you could gain power easily without strengthening your own astral.

That seemed very convenient.

But—

It was a mistake to use demons.

The price that was to be paid was a fixed sum of magic power. But with that, you could at least feel that pleasure of using the power of the demon that you fused with.

If you could not honor the contract, then the demon would just leave.

In other words, when you are unable to go up against stronger opponents.

It was convenient for opponents that were weaker than you... but it was not very reliable when it mattered.

Also, the demons left when you were out of magic.

There were even demons who hurt their summoners because they were bored.

In the case of Magnus and the others, such actions were prevented by the contracts...but it was likely impossible to control the actions of the demons once you had no magic to use as payment.

You could not make them work if you had nothing to offer.

In that case, I could think of a number of ways to beat them.



They all listened to my explanation and their expressions brightened.

Up until now, they had despaired because they thought they had no chance of winning.

Damn it. It really was too bad that they were so quick to give up.

“How can...”

“That Magnus. To have such dangerous power... When it is so dangerous for us to fight even a Greater Demon...”

Julius and Karma muttered with pained expressions.

With this much of a discrepancy between them, they were still serious about fighting. So I could understand why they were so self-pitying...

–Still, it’s not like it was necessary to fight head-on through conventional means.

But they still wanted to fight properly after hearing my explanation. I didn’t know if I should call it honest or just stupid.

“Hey, hey. Have you been listening to what I’ve been saying? Didn’t you understand that you cannot win by fighting head on, like some honest idiot? Then start thinking differently! Are those heads on your shoulders or just decorations? Why don’t you use those brains!”

I blasted them a little.

At these words, the faces of the students became animated again after having been full of despair.

And then all at once, they began to discuss possible ways of beating them.

“Usually, when you summon a spirit or demon, it requires a lot of magic. According to a story that I heard, even an advanced summoner can only summon a Greater Demon for about ten minutes at the most!”

“I heard that too. Though, they do say that an Elementalist that is recognised as the contractor can have spirits materialize for much longer...”

“I never heard of a demon recognizing a human. And if it’s done against their will, it should only be for a short-”

“Hold on? Does that mean there is a time limit to Magnus’s power?”

Hmm. Hmm.

The discussion was getting rather heated in a good way.

There were advanced demons like Venom, who had recognized Masayuki, but let’s forget about that for now.

It seems that the students had realized that there is a time restriction to Magnus's strength.

And now that they had realized it, the discussion was becoming more lively.

“In any case, we need to buy more time. Once we confirm that the devil's power has been activated, we need to draw out the fight to be as long as possible.”

“I see. So that's what all this physical training was for. Right, Master Satoru!”

No?

It's just revenge.

As if you guys would get stronger after running for one day.

The only thing you'll get is aching muscles.

“So you noticed. You guys sure grew a lot in one day!”

I suppressed my true feelings and nodded heavily.

And with that alone–

“Master Satoru!!”

Several of the idiots shouted with emotion.

They were too simple... Well, that part of them was also a little cute.

After that, the discussion continued. And they eventually had an outline of their new strategy.

“...So, like that. The combat types will rotate as teams and push Magnus back. The magic types will support them while also disturbing Magnus and the others. What do you think about that?”

Julius represented the others and explained their plan to me.

This plan was created with consideration to advice from the other teachers as well.

It seemed that they believed that this was the best thing to do at the moment. And I could see that Julius’s expression had regained much of its confidence.

I see. Yes.

Well, it’s definitely well thought out.

For the most part, it matches my own thoughts on the matter.

<<It's no good at all. The important thing is their direct combat ability against Magnus. It's completely inadequate. This rotation idea has a zero percent success rate. They won't even have time to activate any disruption magic. If Magnus gets serious, he will kill their entire vanguard in ten seconds. >>

True.

My own thoughts had been way too sloppy.

“That's no good. This plan will end with Magnus and the others killing everyone.”

I didn't actually think that Magnus was that ruthless. That's why I had thought this plan would be fine...

But Ciel disliked taking the emotions of enemies into account while making calculations.

She wouldn't rest easy unless she considered the worst possible scenario, so she could be ready for anything.

<<Damn it all. Why don't they use their brains and at least think of something, such as taming the Poison Tiger.>>

What? You can do that?!

And, 'at least?' Is there something even higher they can aim for?

Well, it would be easy for me, I guess...

<<Master, you sent Laplace all the way here to settle things with the owner of the island, but... It is just deplorable that these students are incapable of thinking. Don't you agree, Master?>>

Uh, yeah.

So that's what it was...

Had I been giving Laplace such orders without knowing it?

I had sent Laplace to greet the Rock Elephant that ruled the center, and told him to be careful not to be rude...

But in Ciel's mind, I had been reading much further ahead.

I understood everything, she seemed to want to say.

Well, I didn't understand it myself. But it was probably better to be quiet about that.

Just then—

(Lord Rimuru. Sorry that I'm late. The matter has finally been settled! The ruler of this island, the Rock Elephant, that is, has more than just instinct. There is intelligence as well. However, not much common sense. It took so much time for it to understand my ideas. Still, eventually, it accepted my talk of the building of the secret base. So everything is fine!)

I received a thought transmission from Laplace.

But wait, Laplace? How far are you taking this negotiation?

How about a little restraint?

It seemed like Laplace had just interpreted my orders in the way that suited him best.

(What! You even negotiated about building a secret base?!)

(Of course! And it was readily accepted. Ahh, it was a lot of work, you know? I had to make it understand my power and then took four days to teach it. Thought transmission is very useful. Thanks to it, this Rock Elephant gained quite a lot of knowledge!)

Laplace proudly made the report.

This seemed completely different to what I had intended when I said 'greeting'...but it was too late.

In any case, this was fine in its own way.

(Well then, can you order all the monsters on this island to stop attacking the humans?)

(Very easy! They are like my underlings now. They will listen to anything I say.)

Seriously?

I hadn't sensed any great movement of mana, so Laplace must have showed his power very carefully.

It was rather clever, I guess?

Or maybe he was just that passionate about this secret base?

Well, it didn't matter what it was.

If a base could be built, then my plan to build a giant leisure land should also be fine.

Oh, I was about to forget our main objective.

Magnus was the problem we had to deal with first.

(Alright, Laplace. You continue to wait there. I still have some things to deal with. I will clean that up first.)

(Understood!)

I had decided to prioritize the Magnus matter, and ordered Laplace to wait.



I looked at the reactions of the students.

As I thought, it would not be easy to think of an alternative.

Everyone's expression was dark, as if they were once again locked in the shadows.

My complete rejection of their plan had made their outlook turn very tragic.

“Then Master Satoru, what will you have us do!”

“Even if we can't win, is it so wrong to want to fight back?!”

“Do we have to obey Magnus and the others...?”

“No...”

The mourning voices rang throughout the group.

They weren't wrong. I would cry too if I were rejected so bluntly.

I had thought that buying time was the best strategy...

Ciel had also suggested taming the Poison Tiger–

“Poison Tiger, huh...”

It was easy to say, but asking these students to capture a semi-demon lord ranking monster was insane.

It was impossible, reckless and unreasonable. Yes, all three of those things.

But, just then.

“–Did you say, Poison Tiger...?!”

Marsha had heard my muttering.

And she shouted as if coming to a realization.

“Could it be...! Satoru...Master Satoru, are you suggesting that we should capture that monster?”

“Are you stupid, Marsha? There is no way that we could do that.”

Aina said as if to calm Marsha down.

Indeed, you would think it was impossible.

“But, wasn’t this Poison Tiger weaker than Magnus? In that case, maybe it will be the perfect practice partner for us to judge our teamwork?”

That was what I had thought, but Marsha continued with bright eyes.

The students reacted in their own unique ways, but they were all against it.

“I told you, it’s impossible, Marsha! You say that it’s weaker than Magnus, but don’t you know, that monster is so strong that you’d have to call the Knight’s Order in order to do anything!?”

“That’s right, Marsha. And since we cannot communicate, the burden will be heavier for the vanguard. That’s not going to buy us any time.”

“In the first place, Magnus has a time limit, but the Poison Tiger does not. Do I really have to say which of them is more dangerous?”

That’s how it went.

It was nice that they said everything that I had wanted to say.

But Marsha did not back down.

“We have lots of meat to feed the monster. We can get it used to feeding like that maybe? And besides, if I combine these magic cards, I might be able to control the monster.”

She began to say.

Indeed, if she could use anagram magic, then the forced control of monsters would be possible.

However, that required a lot of understanding and immense magic—

That being said, Marsha did have a lot of magic. And I think she still held the original cards?

It seemed unlikely, but what if she did understand it? If so, she wasn't so much a genius, as a child prodigy who would one day represent the age we lived in.

A Hero...

<<Finally, a student appears who understands what you were thinking, Master.>>

Ciel said with satisfaction.

This confession from Ciel meant that Marsha was–

She was moving just as Ciel had thought she would. And so I decided to believe in Marsha and keep my mouth shut.

Marsha's words reignited the heated debate.

They argued about whether it was possible and what the

success rate would be.

And then they assigned roles in the event that they would carry this plan out.

Etcetera.

The result was, that their eyes burned with enthusiasm and their faces were filled with hope and expectation as they looked at me.

“Master–”

Julius began, representing the others.

I nodded for him to continue.

“–that is our new plan. May we hear your opinion on it?”

It all came together very nicely.

<<It is rather good, but if I could make a suggestion->>

I repeated Ciel's words to them.

It hurt that their expressions were filled with such awe and respect.

I was hiding most of it with my swirly glasses, but my cheeks were quite red with embarrassment.

It really was not good to pass on other people's ideas off as your own.

I would be more cautious about it in the future.



The direction they would go in was decided during the night, and it was the sixth day that it was put into action.

They went outside of the barrier that Magnus had placed around the camping grounds and cooked some meat with herbs that would attract monsters.

After a short time, the monster they were after appeared.

The Poison Tiger.

It looked just the same as on the night of the attack, but the fiendishness in the eyes were now gone.

From what I saw, it actually looked like it was wagging its tail.

It seemed that Laplace had convinced the Rock Elephant to send out the message. That was a relief.

–And.

The students carried out their plan to capture the monster, and they succeeded.

At this point, all of the surviving students had exceeded 100 points.

After all, they had not only fought an A-Rank monster, but had captured one.

So they had all exceeded the passing mark.

And their preparations were complete before the day of the battle.

Now, it was time to end things with Magnus–

Q & A

Q: Did Milim get a makeover?

A: She did! There will only be one goth loli.

Q: What color is Milim's hair?

A: It looks like an ordinary pink, but it is supposed to be platinum pink.

After all, silver hair sounds night, but I was told that it's actually kind of dull...

And there are already many characters with silver hair.

Q: What about Milim's clothes-

A: Clothes change. There will be many types!

That's it.

The end. Sorry for hurting your eyes.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 18

Four days after Rimuru’s escape.

Diablo and Souei were preparing to leave the Kingdom of Ingracia.

They were in the middle of investigating all of the western countries, but as they would not be traveling through ‘teleportation,’ they decided to put it off for now.

Because of this, Souei made several ‘clones’ and sent them to each territory so that they could investigate more efficiently.

On top of that, he had also mobilized their subordinates.

“Normally, it would be better to take our time in the investigation...”

“Yes. However, we have an idea of who is behind all of this, don’t we?”

“Yes, I have an idea. I think that we would be wasting time by going to the west side. Besides, it will be troublesome, Souei.”

“I don’t agree. This is the information departments fault for being negligent and missing accurate information.”

“Hehehe. But we are not so familiar with financial issues, so I don’t think we can be blamed for not seeing how important that information was. However...”

“Well, maybe you’re right. Even if we missed it, he would have noticed it, I think.”

“Exactly. So there is no problem. If anything, there is reason to start moving now. That’s how we should look at it.”

“Yes, exactly.”

For Diablo and Souei, not being able to reach the person who

was behind it all was not necessarily a problem.

This was because they were sure that as long as they identified the unnatural flow of money and figured out who or what organization was responsible, then they would eventually see who the mastermind was as well.

Rimuru's command to them was that they remove the corruption from the academy.

So that meant they had to investigate to see which schools were corrupted and then remove any corruption they found.

Thankfully, they had not seen any sign of corruption in the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy. And so they had concluded that they were receiving no illegal financial aid.

Of course.

Tempest was closely associated with Rimuru, and if they were

known to have done something wrong, it would be a huge incident that could not be swept away as mere scandal.

As for the Ingracia Academy, only a few of the noble teachers were involved in corruption.

As it was very light, it was a level where they could deal with it themselves.

They had already made a list of these aristocrat teachers who were accepting funds, and so Souei's clones had arrested them in order that they could trace where the money had come from.

They would use every method: power, authority, money, people, and things to push the enemy to the brink.

It was a direction that you might call a money game.

However...

Diablo believed that the money was not coming from the western countries.

The empire to the east—from those loyal to the old emperor. That was where Diablo's suspicions lay.

And they had received a report to support it.

That morning, Moss had contacted them and told them that the situation had suddenly changed.

All of the students were safe, but a group of them had formed a 'Humanity Emancipation Alliance' and left the others.

And they had attempted to kill any teachers and talented students that got in their way...

With the situation as it was, it was obvious what needed to be done.

Just in case, they decided to have Souei's subordinates continues their investigation of the eastern countries.

They finished the procedures and had two airship tickets prepared for them.

And after that, Diablo and Souei headed for the Nasca Namrium Ulmeria Eastern Alliance Union Empire.

◇◇◇

And-

Six days after Rimuru's escape.

Diablo had entered the NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy alone.

Souei had sent out his clones into the immense territories of

the empire, and it was from there that he gathered information.

He had gathered much information in the past two days, but this was the first time they had made contact with the NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy, which was the most important thing to do.

Souei did not like that Diablo was to go alone, but ultimately, he accepted Diablo's reasons for it.

“You won't run wild over there?”

“Hehehehe. You're really persistent, Souei...”

They had argued, but in the end, Diablo was able to get this most coveted role.

The sofa was simple but comfortable as he sat on it and brought the tea to his lips.

He had arrived on the first airship that morning, and so it was still about midday.

“Why, Lord Diablo. I have heard the rumors. You are most esteemed among Great Demon Lord Rimuru’s subordinates...It is a great honor.”

“Heheheh. Hello. It seems that I won’t have to introduce myself then. You must be the headmaster?”

“Yes! My name is Godama Silver. I am in charge of this academy.”

The person who appeared before the relaxing Diablo was a nicely plump and noble-looking man.

He looked like he might have been muscular at one time, but age had caught up with him, and his waist was starting to grow thick.

However, his eyes were very sharp, and he exuded energy

from his whole body.

The staff he carried was not to aid him while he walked, but it was a high-quality magic rod used to control magic.

It looked rather plain, but upon appraising it, it proved to be most unique.

In other words, he was either rich or very capable. Perhaps he was both.

(Surely, he did not think I would not notice it...)

Diablo was a little confused, but he did not show it.

Diablo was wondering why anyone would come before him while carrying a weapon.

He could understand why someone might be cautious, but

holding a weapon meant you were resolved to fight, and that suggested you actually believed that you could win.

He didn't want to think that this man was so stupid as to think that this disguised weapon could fool him, but if that was the case, he had made a big mistake.

After all, it would mean that such fools were a part of the human resources operation within the three great academies that Rimuru cared so much about.

In any case, coming before Diablo with a weapon was outrageous in itself...

While Diablo rarely did so, this time he decided to hold back his impulses and discuss the subject at hand.

“Yes, you have done good here. Lord Rimuru is very excited to see the growth of the students.”

“It is an honor. By the way, on what business have you come

here today?”

“Yes. Well, I happened to have heard that there is a trend of revering nobles within the school.”

Diablo smiled beautifully as he stared at Godama.

“I know of it. Indeed, there was a request from the Ingracia Academy. It was suggested that the students learn how to deal with nobles before being sent out into the world. And we thought that this opinion had enough merit to be taken seriously.”

“Oh? Was it accompanied by financial aid? Taking advantage of the equality of the three schools like that will result in their ideal losing all substance. Am I wrong?”

Diablo looked at him as if he could see right through his skin, and yet Godama did not seem to be moved as he replied.

And so Diablo had continued bluntly.

“Hahaha. It is true that we received funds, but that is a separate matter! In fact, it offends me greatly that anyone could suggest that our opinions were bought. Please refrain from insulting us further. I believe that learning about how to act towards nobles is necessary. That is why I agreed to it!”

Godama explained. His face had become a little red, but he was still composed.

It was true that the nobles of Ingracia had offered funds for research, but it was not related to the talks between the three schools. That was what he was insisting.

“Hmm.”

Diablo nodded.

Even when looking at him with his Demon Eye, he could see nothing unusual in Godama’s breathing or heartbeat.

He was either saying all of this from the heart, or there was an

entirely different motive for accepting the money.

Yes, for instance—putting the blame on the nobility of the Ingracia Kingdom, etcetera.

Diablo had already looked through Souei's investigation data and confirmed that Godama was not suffering from a lack of funds.

All of this suggested that the latter theory was the correct one.

There wasn't likely much more to be learned by talking with Godama, and so Diablo asked his final question.

“We'll talk about that in depth some other time. I have just one more question. The thing is, something rather important has happened...”

He prefaced, then Diablo laid out the scenario that he and Souei had agreed upon.

It was a made up story that he had repeated many times at the Tempest Development of Human Resources Academy and Ingracia Academy.

–On the surface, it was just some entertainment for the Great Demon Lord Rimuru, while in fact it was training for the students.

And so the students had to be protected, and they explained to everyone that there was no need to worry.

But things were different this time.

“We had already contacted you about that before, so you must be aware. But this is where things are different. The thing is, we have lost contact with them.”

He said, then inspected Godama with the demon eye.

“What...!? Is that true?”

Godama asked in amazement.

But in spite of his words and attitude, Godama was quite calm.

(So he isn't moved at all. In other words, he knew. I see...)

Anyone else would have been fooled by his acting surprised, but it did not work on Diablo.

Godama was a former warrior who had conquered many trials in the past, and he had a personality that was not easily shaken.

That was the kind of man he was, and now, he had made a terrible mistake.

If he wasn't surprised, he should have accepted it and moved along.

But acting like this had made Diablo's suspicions turn into

conviction.

Perhaps this just meant that this was the limits of Godama as a man.

At this point, while Diablo didn't think Godama was the mastermind here, he did believe that he was part of the 'Humanity Emancipation Alliance.'



Godama's mistake was thinking that he could fool Diablo.

He would protect himself with an expensive magic item and toy with Diablo with a skill he had honed over the years. He would lead him into thinking the nobles of the Kingdom of Ingracia were the enemy. That was what he thought, and it would end up leading him to his ruin.

"You aren't surprised. Could it be that you know something?"

Diablo continued to smile as he asked this.

“Haha, hahaha. Lord Diablo, what are you...”

Godama finally looked a little flustered.

At the same time, he seemed to have become aware of that fact, and it shocked him even more.

He was supposed to have been perfectly protected by magic, and yet with Diablo in front of him, it seemed to not have any effect. Such were the anxieties that plagued him.

And it was true. As Diablo said, Godama had been informed of this news earlier.

Just this morning, Magnus and the others who were his comrades, had sent him a long distance message. It was a simple message that contained the information about the crime at the survival place and data showing their location. There was also a rescue request.

On the seventh day—in other words, tomorrow, they had plans to meet a mysterious pair known as the Greed Circus. They would defeat these two and steal their airship. However, there was a possibility that they could fail and the ship would be damaged. It was also possible that the Greed Circus had more than two people, and so they wanted reinforcements as well as a rescue team.

That was the summary of it.

Within this report, there was a line that said that they had gotten rid of those who would interfere.

It was because Godama had read this that he understood the meaning of Diablo's question.

If this whole abduction was done spuriously under the Great Demon Lord Rimuru's orders, that meant that the Greed Circus were working for Rimuru.

And as long as they acted under their watchful eye, it meant that the Great Demon Lord Rimuru would have been notified of

the events.

This information had to be relayed to his comrades who were yet unaware. It was when he had been thinking this that Diablo had visited him.

(This was bad. Very bad...)

Godama panicked.

The likelihood of him being suspected was very low, that was what he had thought, and yet he had still brought his magic weapon as a precaution.

It was the 'Staff of Heart Protection' that he had carried for many years.

As long as he carried it, his heart would be protected. He had been so confident in that fact.

And yet now, the effects of that magic had been lost.

And there was enough reason here for Godama to lose ability to think calmly.

While this was happening, Godama received a message from his secretary.

–Diablo’s energy is estimated to be at 7,000–

Godama saw the message and returned to his usual calmness.

The arch demon who had plunged the empire into the pits of terror many times over in the past was at about 10,000. And so he had used a machine that calculated the energy of others to calculate Diablo’s energy.

And just now, he was informed of the results.

7,000—that was quite strong indeed.

However, it was not so strong that he was unbeatable.

In fact, the empire boasted royal knights who were strong enough to kill arch demons alone.

(What, so the rumors were just rumors then. I had heard that he was beyond comparison with arch demons, but that is hardly true! So this is what I was afraid of all along? He is nothing. Still, at least it means I need not fear.)

And with that, Godama smiled mischievously.

And then he signed the order that would mean his own execution.

Immediately—

“Lord Diablo, no, Diablo. I think I want you to die right here.”

“Hehehehe. Is that a joke?”

“That pompous slime who calls himself a Great Demon Lord seems to have stretched himself too thin. I think it’s time we cut some of it away. Don’t worry, I’ll make up some excuse, so you can die in peace.”

He turned to Diablo and said exactly what one should never say to Diablo.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 19

Diablo doubted his ears for a moment.

He could not understand what this man in front of him was saying

No, he could understand the words, but he was so angry that he wasn’t able to process them as quickly as he would have otherwise.

After all, for Diablo, lowering his guard even a little could result in him allowing his emotions to run wild.

And he had been holding back. He wanted to know for sure that he hadn’t misheard or misunderstood what had been said...

But the answer he received was enough to blow every bit of reasoning out the window for him.

–The pompous slime who calls himself a Great Demon Lord–

At that moment, Diablo started to consider the ways he would execute Godama.

(Hehehe. It's been a while since my emotions have been so heavily affected. To anger me like this... This man is rather impressive, in a way...)

The only reason he didn't act on his urge this very instant, was because he had made a promise to Souei.

Diablo was managing a great feat by restraining himself once again as he began to stand up from his seat.

But in that moment, the floor beneath him disappeared.

Having to hold back this rage that exceeded his own capacity had caused Diablo's attention to disperse slightly.

Godama smirked.

The floor in front of the chair he was sitting on had disappeared completely.

The table, chairs and the floor under Diablo seemed to be getting sucked into the ground.

This was not an advanced trap such as a magic teleportation trap. It was a simple hole in the ground—a pitfall.

“Ahhhahahaha–ahahahha! This room and the underground pit are ‘Absolute Magic Spaces.’ They are sealed by absolute magic protection, and no magic can be used within them. No matter how strong a demon you might be, you will be much the same as any powerless human once inside! This is the power of human intelligence!!”

Godoma was full of glee as he laughed loudly.

This was his declaration of victory.

As for Diablo, who had fallen to the bottom of the pit, he calmly and lightly landed on his feet.

He could hear the hideous laughter from above, but it only helped in bringing back his sense of calm.

His emotions had already returned to normal, and Diablo found that he was even able to smile now.

“Hehehehe. As a reward for making me angry, I allowed myself to get caught in your trap. Now...”

It was possible for him to react the moment the floor vanished, but he felt that he was in danger of killing Godama out of sheer anger, and so Diablo had jumped into the hole himself.

Now that he was down there, he saw that the space was as large as a school gym.

The ceiling above was about ten meters away.

Diablo could have easily flown back up there, but there was something that bothered him and so he looked at his surroundings.

There was a line of golems that were unfamiliar to him in shape.

They were barebones in design, but he could see that they were quite practical.

A very thick armor of magic steel covered their entire bodies and they had huge bodies that were three meters tall.

And there were thirteen of them.

They were very imposing.

“Oh, how wonderful. Lord Rimuru will be very happy upon seeing this.”

Diablo muttered to himself. Just then, an eerie voice entered his ears.

“Hehehe. Can you hear me, Diablo? I am sure that your eyes have adjusted to the dark now, so you must have noticed the golems in front of you. Yes, those golems will preside over your deathbed. This Absolute Magic space contains no mana, and yet they have inside of them, magic storage units. They are the strongest of executioners. Still, as long as you do not resist, you will not have to feel any pain or fear. It will be easy. I will give you just enough time to pray. Be thankful for my generosity.”

Of course, it was the voice of Godama.

He was confident that he was in an advantageous position and was completely safe. His voice was insolent and haughty.

“Oh? You mean to kill me? You tell the most amusing jokes.”

“What? I am not joking. I am quite serious. After all, I am going to tell that slime that you went missing after leaving us. I will be sure that the others corroborate my story, don’t worry.

Everything should go very smoothly.”

“I see. So, how do you mean to kill me?”

Diablo asked again. Godama snorted with irritation.

Then, as if explaining to a particularly stupid student, he began to talk with much venom in his voice.

“I merely have to give the order to those golems in front of you. They will kill you very easily. The Accommodationist scum also died down there, screaming and pleading when they realized they couldn’t use the magic they were so proud of. You will die in the same way.”

“Hmmm. Accommodationists? That’s very interesting.”

Diablo’s demon eye saw it. The traces of blood on the floor.

It was clear that it wasn't just one or two people that had been executed here.

This was a holy place of education, and this was a crime worthy of death.

“Now, our conversation has started to get interesting, but it's time to say goodbye. Do you have any final words?”

“Heheheh. Final? I have too many questions. Well then, since I have to cool down anyway, I think I will play along for a little while.”

“You arrogant little... Kill him! Destroyers!”

With Godama's order, green lights appeared in the eyes of the golems.

–Immediately after, the underground space was filled with the sound of intense battle.



After giving the order to the golems, Godama sat deep into his chair.

He was biting back the cry of victory that was welling up inside of him.

I did it!

I beat that demon. That Demon Lord, Diablo!

Now that he has been caught in the trap, there is no mistaking it. He is finished.

One Destroyer was equal to an Arch Demon. And there were thirteen of them. Magic was the strongest weapon for a demon, and he would have to fight while this ability was sealed...He would definitely lose.

With this, his fate was decided.

Godama relished the excitement.

Arch Demons were feared for their strength and were seen as demons of disaster.

During the empire's long history, there had been many times that it was threatened by an Arch Demon.

It was because of this history, that the people of the empire saw Arch Demons as the embodiment of fear.

And yet the mystery of these great demons was slowly starting to unravel through painstaking research by humans.

And the thing that had been most useful was the 'Absolute Magic Space.'

Mana used for summoning was replaced with a magic stone, then the room was completely closed off and sealed.

There were times when the summoner was killed, but the experiments with summoning horrible demons continued in secret.

As they did this, they eventually succeeded in capturing several Arch Demons.

And when they measured their abilities, they discovered that their energy was not consistent.

Weaker bodies had less energy, and those who had an established will tended to have much greater power.

The great demons of legend had likely been special beings who had lived for a very long time. That was the conclusion the research team came to.

And if they were right, then these Arch Demons were nothing to fear.

After all, all they would have to do was to call them once by partially summoning them. Once they confirmed whether or not it had a will, they could just send it back if it looked too dangerous.

Through these experiments, they became very adept at controlling demons.

Once they had the data, they had no use for the captured demons.

Godama had decided that there was no more need for experiments, and he had the demons exterminated.

And it was the Destroyers that were the most useful for doing this.

The most powerful golems that hunted down demons.

Godama was very proud of their power.

And he had thirteen of these reliable Destroyers, which meant that Diabo's death was a definite thing–In any case, Godama believed this without doubt.

And so Godama thought:

They said he was the leader of the Great Demon Lord's 12 Guardians. But it was absurd. He was just a demon, and everything else had been rumor.

However, this has great meaning.

Diablo was a demon who was called the right hand of the slime. Killing him would mean cutting off a huge portion of the Great Demon Lord's power.

In that case...

It is not too unlikely that because of my contributions, I will become the leader of the Humanity Emancipation Alliance. That is what this means.

I will lead them to a new world!

Still, it had been so incredibly easy to trap him.

His eyes had been full of the confidence of the strong.

That's why a wise man like me was able to easily lead him, just like taking the hand of a baby.

He had used the pitfall before in dealing with the Accommodationists, in other words, those who were in favor of recognizing the Great Demon Lord.

It had gone much better than expected, and Godama remembered just how surprised he had been.

It was the same this time as well.

The feared demon who was known by all, Diablo.

But the truth was that he was weaker than even an Arch Demon.

Godama laughed at this idea.

It was a common thing though, where rumors ran wild but the truth was most disappointing.

He was intelligent, and was able to have a physical body in this world while having 7,000 in energy, which made him a threat.

But that was all nothing now.

Godama was only thinking about his own future. He was drunk on fantasies of fame and glory.

“How silly it all is. I had heard that the Royal Knights that protected the emperor were no match for the Great Demon Lord’s 12 Guardians...but now we know that that story was false. Even I would not have chosen...”

“Really? The 12 Guardians are not so weak, you know?”

“Hahaha. What are you saying? I just finished taking care of their leader, Diablo. With my own hands.”

“Oh, that is impressive. Well then, who are you talking to right now?”

“What?”

Godama had been so absorbed in his own bliss, that it took him a moment to feel that something was wrong.

He had made sure that no one would disturb him in this room. And so no one should be here but him.

“Who are you...!?”

The voice came from behind him, and so Godama frantically

turned around.

The person who was standing there was a beautiful demon with eyes that burned bright like fire.

The person who would throw Godama into the pits of despair.

–It was Diablo.



“Giii, gieeeee!!!”

Godama’s shriek echoed in the room.

His eyes were widened as if he could not believe what he was seeing.

Diablo should have been turned into mince meat by the Destroyers, and yet, not only was he not wounded, his clothes weren't even dirty.

Godama was too shocked to speak, but his eyes asked, 'are you real?'

Diablo gave a thin smile and nodded.

"Too bad, eh? Turns out I am perfectly fine."

Godama heard those words and was finally able to speak again.

While still in shock, he shouted at Diablo.

"It cannot be! Bastard. How did you escape my Destroyers..."

At this point, Godama's brain started to function again.

His brain was finally able to understand who this person in front of him was.

“Gaaahhh!! Are yo-you really Diablo...!?”

His brain had tried to persuade him that this was not the case, but his brain had failed.

Godama’s face filled with panic and fear.

“Hehehe. Those golems were very entertaining. I was almost sorry that I had to break them.”

“Ho-how?! How did you break them?”

“How?”

Diablo tilted his head to the side as if he did not understand the meaning of the question.

“Don’t act dumb! You could not use magic. You had no power to use... And yet, how did you...?!”

Diablo nodded.

He knew now why Godama had been so surprised. And so he decided to be magnanimous and explain.

“It should be obvious. If I can’t use magic, then I just have to fight physically. What don’t you understand?”

Diablo answered as if it were the most obvious thing.

However, Godama was not satisfied.

“You’re talking nonsense! Those were Destroyers! Just one of them are capable of defeating an Arch Demon, and there were thirteen of them!! And you...you could not have beaten them without magic!!”

He was screaming now.

Godama's brain was telling him that it was impossible. And he would not believe Diablo's words.

As for Diablo, he smiled gently at Godama.

He wanted to show respect to someone who had so triggered his emotions. And while it was rare for Diablo, he decided to spend time to talk to him.

Either that, or Diablo had been so angry that he had started to grow numb...

“Yes, it wasn't exactly easy. I was barehanded against those heavyweights, after all. However! That's when I had an idea. Lord Rimuru had once said that 'willows are weak, yet they bind other wood.' And so I decided to take advantage of the opportunity and calm myself down while fighting.”

Diablo explained.

However, while Diablo may intended to follow Rimuru's words, the truth was different.

He had grabbed the arm of a golem that rushed at him, and tore the arm off with his strength.

The golem's punch came with overwhelming force, and yet Diablo's fist easily shattered it.

Diablo's hand didn't even look like it had much force behind it, and yet whenever it came in contact with a golem, that part would cave in and then blow away.

It was devastating.

It was simple. The greater power had crushed the weaker. That was all.

Indeed, he had not used any magic, but it wasn't because he couldn't.

He could have used it if he wanted, but he had no need for magic.

Not only that, but Diablo was also careful about how he destroyed the golems.

He thought that Rimuru would be very happy if he could make a gift of the golems to him.

And so he was careful to destroy them in a way that at the end, he would be able to take the parts and reconstruct a few that were perfectly whole.

For Diablo, the Destroyers that Godama was so proud of had no more value than a toy.



“No...it can’t be...”

Diablo's complete lack of conventionality was causing Godama to doubt everything that he had ever believed in.

Fearfully, he bent down and looked over the edge into the hole. There, as Diablo had said, was the broken Destroyers.

Finally, Godama started to regain his calm.

But that also meant fear.

Before he knew it, Diablo had sat down in his chair and was relaxing in a graceful pose.

Godama realized that Diablo was looking right at him, and his face turned pale.

It was at this point that Godama finally realized what kind of person he was up against.

One of Great Demon Lord Rimuru's 12 Guardians.

They were demons with great power. And among them, Diablo was considered the head and the strongest of them all.

Someone that no one should ever touch–It was only now that Godama realized this.

(This is bad, bad-bad-bad-bad, bad!!)

His calm quickly left him again.

He was now ruled by fear and confusion.

(So that's why those Accommodationist scum and the Moderates had said that the use of force was to be avoided at all cost...)

The Humanity Emancipation Alliance was an organization of

people who were concerned about the future of humanity.

Not all of their members had the same ideas or principles, but they all believed that it was wrong for humans to be ruled by demons.

Among them, the Moderates were the great majority, and they had the largest voice.

Their argument was this, 'direct hostilities towards the demon lords was to be forbidden and they would send their own people to various fields in order to widen their influence.'

As long as they were all human, it was only natural that their opinions would differ, but Godama could not forgive them.

He believed that the will of humans should be united, and that they should move to destroy the demon lords.

As for the Accommodationists who wanted coexistence with the demon lords, they weren't even worth discussing. Both of

these sides were nothing but groups of cowards to Godama.

And so Godama had always laughed in the shadows as the Accommodationists and the Moderates talked about the danger that the demons lords could pose...

(But it was I who was the fool...)

While Godama now knew the truth, it was too late.

Much too late.

The energy numbers that he had been so confident about meant nothing to the demon that was in front of him.

Because the person in front of him was so powerful that no numbers could be used to measure his strength.

The truth was that he had antagonised this incredibly

dangerous person. And it was impossible to take it back.

“For-forgive me...”

He knelt before Diablo and begged as if praying.

Diablo’s smile did not move as he stared at Godama.

“I-I was a fool. Please, have mercy... Please spare my life...”

His eyes and nose were running as he pleaded with Diablo.

And then—

“Hehehe. Don’t worry. I don’t intend on taking your life.”

Diablo answered with a kind expression.

Godama shouted in his heart.

(Yes! He is not as cold as they say he is!)

“I-I am grateful...”

He was careful so that his expression did not show too much relief as he offered Diablo words of gratitude... However, he then realized that there was something strange about Diablo.

“Hehehehe. Yes, you will not be killed. Lord Rimuru does not like it when humans are harmed, and Souei scolded me about it. But more than anything, I still have some things I would like to hear from you.”

Diablo said. His expression suggested that he was truly enjoying this moment.

“Ah, right. So I cannot use magic in this room, was it? Then let me test it to see if that is true.”

He muttered, and then a chill ran up Godama's back.

He had a bad feeling about this.

As this room was connected to the Absolute Magic Space, it was impossible to use magic behind the door. Or at least, that was supposed to be the case.

However, a magic circle now appeared in front of Diablo. The shadowy light was proof that magic was activating.

“Ho-how is this!? Magic within an Absolute Magic Space!?”

Godama had been shocked so many times today that his brain felt like it was about to explode.

This reality was not possible, and yet it was occurring right in front of him.

No—he realized that for this demon called Diablo, this was normal.

(So this is the kind of person I have provoked...)

Even considering it from his position as the first of the magic researchers, Diablo was completely abnormal.

And just as Godama became fully immersed in his regret, Diablo's magic was completed.

And that magic was...

“That...”

“Very basic magic. Demon Bug Summoning. I summoned the bugs that live in the demon world. Aren't they cute?”

The bugs crawled on Diablo's hand.

They had many legs and resembled centipedes as they began to cover Diablo's right hand.

Godama felt his heart begin to beat wildly as he watched.

His breathing became rough and the sound of his heartbeat seemed like it would destroy his eardrums.

(He, Diablo, what is he going to do with those...)

"Wh-what are you..."

"By the way, have you ever heard of treants?"

Godama's question was ignored.

Of course, Godama did know what treants were.

They were a type of monster that looked like trees and were intelligent.

Godama wondered what Diablo meant by talking about them. Diablo continued.

“It’s good that you know. This demon bug is called Majuju, you see, and it has the ability to turn its host into a plant. Of course, this includes animals, monsters, demons and even humans. It can deal with any living thing, so do not worry.”

Upon hearing this, Godama felt as if he had been thrown into a deep pit of despair.

He had figured out what Diablo intended to do.

“You-you can’t! You don’t mean to...!?”

The Majuju was a fearful demon bug.

It was a bug from the demon world that made monsters and even demons its food.

There was no way for a human like Godama to resist it.

Godama felt fear deep within his heart.

The drawing room was filled with a very unique odor.

The hot vapors that rose from his groin were accompanied by something more solid that dripped behind him. Godama let out a sob.

“Forgive me! No-no! Anything but that!!”

He begged with desperation, but Diablo’s smile remained the same.

“Now, here is your new host.”

And then he unleashed the demon bugs on Godama with a look of pleasure.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 20

Melhis, who was Godama’s secretary, was shocked.

The scene of destruction was not something that the mind could easily comprehend.

That was the degree that Diablo was outside of the norm in Melhis’s mind.

She had been monitoring Diablo from the security room, just as Headmaster Godama had ordered...

And after having measured the energy, it had been unmistakably 7,000.

(Lower than I expected. He should not have much trouble in that case.)

She thought as she made the report to Godama.

The result of this, was the horrible sight beyond the screen.

Since Melhis was examining the situation, she knew what was now happening to Godama.

And yet, when put together with what she knew to be normal, it was nothing short of ludicrous.

The Destroyers that they were so proud of were ultra powerful machines with energy up to 15,000.

And there were thirteen of them.

It was overwhelming power. If anything, it seemed like too much to throw at the likes of Diablo.

Melhis had been sure of Godama's victory the moment that

Diablo fell into the pit.

And yet this Diablo, who only had 7,000 in energy, he had easily defeated the thirteen Destroyers.

And there was even more shocking information that made her tremble with fear.

As she had watched them through her monitors for a while, and been able to measure the combat data, she had come to the conclusion that Diablo's energy was constantly at the same level.

But for the numbers to stay exactly the same throughout the whole time—that was just not normal.

For instance, a single punch from a Destroyer would have to have energy that is less than 15,000.

They had found out through a mountain of combat data, that it was usually about 0.2%.

This was obvious, as energy was the combination of all of the person's abilities.

Mobility, reflexes, attack power, defense power, intelligence, mental strength, luck(uncertain element), all of these and more were combined to create this number that was energy.

The actual energy that was used in an attack was very low. This had all been established even before they began their research.

However.

Diablo's numbers were at 7,000.

(It was impossible...how can this happen...!! It doesn't make any sense. I will not accept something so preposterous!!)

There was always a fear that your reality as a researcher was in peril.

However, the data right in front of her proved that the results of the tests were correct.

She was watching a person who could freely control his energy at MAX level at all times. If someone had ten times as much energy as him, they would still not be able to beat him.

With this fact in front of her, Melhis could not be blamed for feeling such fear.

Melhis was usually a calm researcher, but she was now at the height of confusion. However, the fighter within her remained calm, and was telling her to escape as quickly as possible.

At this point, Melhis had already abandoned Godama.

If anything, she was already thinking how this sacrifice, called Godama, would distract Diablo and give her time to leave.

And so without further delay, and without seeing the end of Godama's fate, she started to make her leave.

That is why she didn't notice.

She had been the one who was monitoring him, and yet, a demon with bright red pupils was looking up through the screen with an evil grin.

Melhis's fate had been decided the moment she made an enemy of Diablo.



Melhis was afraid of being followed and so she was extra careful while fleeing.

To Melhis, Godama was not so much a respectable superior, but a pawn to be used.

And so she had no regrets over betraying him.

The only thing that was important to her now was that she protect herself and run to a place of safety.

She had to share this newly acquired information with the others. And now that they knew where Magnus and the others were, it would be bad if she didn't contact them.

Because of all these thoughts, Melhis was full of anxiety.

Still, she was able to calm herself and act carefully because she was a first-rate warrior.

It was late in the night when she finally arrived at the secret hideout of the Reformists.

Melhis was so worn out that she looked like a different person in just one day.

The people that greeted her realized that something must have happened, and they ran to her with pale faces.

“Melhis, what happened?”

“What is going on?”

Melhis stopped them with a raise of her hand before opening her mouth.

“Headmaster Godama has been caught by Diablo. He may even be dead now. As our rules demand, I prioritized the sharing of information and fled instead of rescuing him.”

She paused with a sigh.

“What!?”

“So then Godama is...”

“How did this happen? How are things now?”

They asked her excitedly.

And just as Melhis was about to open her mouth again–

“Silence!”

Came a shout from one of the people in charge.

It was a group of Glory Knights in their white robes–they were the strongest of the ‘Humanity Emancipation Alliance’.

There were some who were a part of the Accommodationists and Moderates, but the majority of them sided with the Reformists. After all, it had been the results of Godama and Melhis’s research that had allowed them to devise ways to fuse demons and control them.

Furthermore, Melhis herself was one of the Glory Knights, and also had a demon dwelling within her.

In a way, it could be said that Melhis herself had given the Glory Knights the power of the demons and made them powerful.

“Melhis. How did this happen, with you there?”

One of the knights asked Melhis.

The others seemed to have calmed down now that the Glory Knights were present, and so they decided to listen to what she had to say.

Melhis nodded and explained to them the events of the day.

“Alright, I will tell you. But first, at least two people must guard the door. We cannot be too careful.”

They obeyed her order and two knights stood by the door.

Melhis was very relieved by this and so began to talk.

“The truth is...”

She told them that they had been contacted by Magnus, who had been missing that morning.

According to a message from the Great Demon Lord Rimuru, Magnus and the others were supposed to be in the middle of training. And yet it was said that they had attacked teachers from the other schools and the students as well.

In other words, Magnus and the others did not know that they were being monitored by the Great Demon Lord.

But as they had already acted, there was no turning back now.

They had been trying to contact him to abandon his position as not only a student, but the entire plan and run away as soon as possible.

And it was then that Diablo visited.

In any case, if it was discovered that the students had accomplices, then the school's management would come into question.

Both the headmaster and Melhis assumed that they would be replaced.

And so they had decided to be rid of Diablo while his guard was down, before he realized that they were his enemies.

“Diablo. You tried to...”

“How reckless...”

They audience muttered with shock.

Diablo's reputation was known far and wide. He represented a

kind of terror that exceeded even the Great Demon Lord Rimuru.

“Yes, I will not deny it now. But when I measured his energy, it was only at 7,000. I assumed we could easily kill him with the Destroyers hidden underground...”

“Thirteen Destroyers should not be able to be defeated by someone who is at 7,000...”

“Did you make a mistake when trapping him?”

“No, he fell right into the trap. He was in the absolute magic space. The situation was to our advantage. And yet, we could not win.”

“Impossible...”

“They were utterly defeated. Diablo came out without a scratch.”

“...!?”

They all gasped.

This report was so shocking that they did not want to believe it.

Melhis continued, as if to dispel the oppressive air.

“It’s true that Diablo’s power was stronger than what we imagined. The Accommodationists are not worth discussing, but the Moderates did have a point about being against hostilities. I understand that now. He saw my face, but the rest of you who have not made contact, it’s not too late. You should join the Moderates-”

“I cannot allow that. All of you are to be arrested right here.”

Melhis’s words were interrupted by a cold, echoing voice.

“Who-who is it?!”

The person who answered Melhis was a single man who stood in front of the door.

The dark skin and blue hair—it was Souei.

“Hmph. There’s no need for you to know, but I will be polite this once. My name is Souei. One of Lord Rimuru’s faithful servants.”

Souei said in answer to Melhis.

“Tsk, what happened to the guards?”

Melhis looked around frantically. Their mouths had been sealed before being made unconscious on the floor.

And not one person in the room had noticed. It was done

silently.

Damn it! Melhis cursed inwardly.

She had been so careful about being tracked. This was the worst possible thing that could happen now.

“Do not panic! Glory Knights, prepare for demon fusion! There is no future for us unless we defeat him first!!”

Roused by these words, the Glory Knight started to act.

They called the demons within them and made the power their own.

With such comrades surrounding her, Melhis told herself that it wasn't too late.

The enemy was alone.

And there were five of the Glory Knights here.

Diablo was one of the 12 guardians of the Great Demon King. But they had never even heard of this Souei before.

They could win! This single demon could not stand against them.

That's what Melhis thought.

No, that's what she tried to believe.

She could never have imagined that the person standing in front of them now was the equal of the guardians.

In spite of her instincts raising the highest alarm in her head, Melhis made the worst decision.

Go hostile-immediately.



Five Glory Knights stood in front of Souei.

However, they did not act against him.

No, they were not able to.

“Wh-what? I cannot move my body?!”

“What’s happening? Damn it!”

“What the hell...!?”

The knights realized the change and became frantic.

But there was no answer coming, and Melhis was left confused, unable to understand the situation.

The only person here who grasped everything was Souei.

And Souei did nothing.

He had no need to.

Because...

“Souei, would you like me to finish them for you?”

Out of nowhere, a woman had arrived and stood in front of Souei.

The beautiful dragonewt, Souka.

“Don’t let a single one get away.”

“Certainly!”

Touka, Saika, Hokusou and Nansou were also there.

This hideout had already been completely surrounded by the information department working for Souei.

“Damn it!”

The Glory Knights shouted.

However, their shouts faded into the air.

To Souka and the others, these knights, who had merely overcome the barrier of A-rank, were nothing.

Besides...

“Well then, I think it’s time we take our leave...”

The greater demons that had been fused with the knights now attempted to escape.

“Wait! Do you mean to ignore the contract!?”

The knights shouted in horror. But the demons snorted.

“Fool! Our contracts are voided if we are not able to run wild as we please!”

So saying, they began to escape.

Unlike spirits, demons tended to be self-centered. And so they often abandoned their masters the moment that the situation became unfavorable.

However, this time alone, the demons were unable to avoid the disaster.

“Do you really think I will let you get away? Souei said that I was to let no one escape.”

Souka’s cold voice rang in the room.

“What? How!?”

But it was too late for the greater demons.

Because now the entire building was surrounded by a magic circle of envelopment that isolated the place.

“I have no use for those demons. Kill them so they can repent for a few hundred years.”

“Yes!”

And so the demons were dealt with just as Souei ordered.

Before the demons could even say anything, Souka and the others had turned them into dust.

It all happened in an instant.

The members of the 'Humanity Emancipation Alliance' were speechless.

Some of them fell weakly to the floor while others moaned audibly.

Seeing the greater demons disposed of like this had made them certain about their fate.

Melhis as well.

(...It's over. Great Demon Lord Rimuru's subordinates are so... Magnus, I am so sorry...)

They were strong on a level that defied her understanding.

Like Godama, Melhis now realized that she had come in contact with something that should have been avoided at all cost.

But it was much too late now. And there was no way for them to get out of this.

That was enough to break her spirit.

And like that, the majority of the Reformist members fell at the hand of Souei.



“Hahaha. So it is done, Souei?”

“Yes. Thanks to you scaring them out of the nest, I was able to

find them all gathered together.”

“That is wonderful. I too was able to capture one of the leaders. And don’t worry, I treated him very carefully and without killing him.”

“Hmph. I’ll be the judge of that.”

Souei brushed this comment aside.

In fact, he thought it would not have been a problem to kill one or two of them.

No mercy for our enemies! It was an unspoken rule, and Rimuru was not likely to be angry about it.

The only reason he hadn’t related this to Diablo, was because it was too much trouble.

Besides, there would be no stopping Diablo once he went out of control. And so it was best to avoid the possibility altogether.

Especially since he would likely be given the role of having to stop him. And Souei did not care to be bothered with that.

“Even now he is being eaten by demon bugs. Can you hear his gleeful screams?”

Diablo said as he threw the tree-like thing off of his shoulder.

It was a ravaged Godama.

His entire body was being eaten by bugs and he was barely breathing.

Of course, Godama’s fate was more than that. The places that were being eaten were slowly turning into tree bark.

“He-help me. It hurts. My whole body hurts...”

In this pitiful state, he plead for mercy.

However, Diablo did not respond to his pleas.

“...Hey, while he is alive, there will be little point if he loses his mind, you know?”

Souei said. Diablo nodded as if he understood this perfectly.

“Hehehehe. Don’t worry. These Majuju do not eat the brain. And they excrete two kinds of liquids when eating flesh. One has the effect of turning the host into a tree. The other is a pleasure substance. This means that while they can feel pain, it is not so bad that they would lose their minds. Besides, he had something that was perfect.”

So saying, Diablo pointed to the staff that was practically a part of Godama now.

It was the unique magic rod that Godama had carried for many years—the ‘Staff of Heart Protection’

Due to Godama’s excellent equipment, his heart was protected, preventing him from going mad.

“I see. Well, he did insult Lord Rimuru. So it is his own fault.”

Diablo nodded with satisfaction at Souei’s words.

And then in a rare display of affection, Diablo slapped Souei on the shoulder and said,

“Very good, Souei. I am so glad that you have an understanding of my hobbies.”

“...No. I’m not saying your hobbies are acceptable...”

Souei had a bitter expression, a strong contrast to the one of

pleasure that was on Diablo's face.

However, Diablo did not mind. He laughed happily at the prospect of having someone who was of kindred-spirit.

And with that, they left the rest to Souka and the others, and headed for their final destination.

Maldoland Island.

–The place where their beloved Rimuru was.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 21

The day finally came.

And we were fully prepared.

Even the poison tiger looked enthusiastic about it. If things went according to plan, victory will not be too difficult to attain.

Of course, I myself wasn’t going to fight. So I would just be cheering them on.

“Master, will we be able to win?”

I answered these anxious questions without hesitation.

“How should I know!”

Yes.

Will we be able to win? Are they still thinking in such weak terms?

It's not about questioning yourself. We'll win! That's the kind of intensity you needed...

“Don't worry. We will win!”

“Yes, Julius is right. Do what you have to do and don't think about anything else. If everyone fulfils their roles, we will surely be victorious!”

Oh, Julius and Karma. You guys do say such good things sometimes.

Yes, that was exactly right.

Just give it a try. If it doesn't work, then we'll think about it when the time comes.

We won't have a chance of winning if we've given up before even starting.

“Exactly! It seems like Julius and Karma really understand it. Well, just give it your all. I and the other teachers will be watching!”

“Yes!”

“Yes!”

“Yes!”

Perhaps those words encouraged them, because all of the hesitation and worry seemed to disappear from the students.

They would be fine if they could continue like that.

Still, Julius and Karma were two people that thought very differently, and yet they had come a lot closer than I would have expected.

One of them was a noble. And a royal heir.

The other was the son of a soldier. A beastkin, who are connected with monsters.

They stood in very different positions, but they helped each other unpretentiously.

This fact alone showed that this survival training had worked.

Create a dangerous situation and expose the true nature of people.

It was a drastic form of treatment, but it had succeeded this time.

In this world now, beastkin were a part of humanity.

Even goblins and orcs were part of a group known as demi-humans, who were in the same group.

And yet, there was still a strong, deep-rooted prejudice there.

It would be hard to be rid of it completely, but I always thought that children could overcome this barrier known as prejudice with ease.

No, perhaps it was still difficult.

It took a lot of time to change the way people think, and it was better to do it slowly.

You can tell someone to start liking someone they hate, but they won't come around to it so easily.

However, I did feel that if you ignored the opinions of adults, and relied only on your own eyes, ears and experience to judge others, you would have a surprisingly different way of looking at people.

You would be able to see things more honestly...but maybe I was just being idealistic.

Well, there was no point in forcing it, as irritating as it was.

When you become an adult, you are exposed to the harshness and waves of injustices in the world.

And so I wanted their time as students, at least, to be a time where they could live with fairness without being affected by birth or race.

During this time, your personal abilities and determination

was everything—that was how things should be.

Equality and fairness were not the same.

People are not born equal.

It was not possible for everyone to be the same when they varied in gender or abilities. Once you add circumstances such as parents and the countries policy, things become even worse.

We should eliminate inequality as much as is possible. Adults should help children and be as fair and accurate as possible when evaluating the students.

It wasn't about giving everyone first-prize in order to be equal. Every student should be looked at individually and treated correctly based on that.

And so, in this special school environment, I had decided that the symbol of adulthood that is the states expectations, should have no reach here...

And yet these 'Humanity Emancipation Alliance' people have challenged this right to my face. They must really want to die.

Even I had to make compromises instead of pushing my beliefs onto others. How could they be so selfish?

To bring in their differences in class into a space that is supposed to be fair... It was a violation that could never be forgiven.

I would have to think about how we would handle this in the future, as well as a punishment for Magnus. At the very least, something will have to be done to make them stop influencing the school.

I had hoped that the graduates of the school would become teachers to take charge of the next generation, but that made this early part all the more important.

This was something that required serious thought.

In any case. Magnus had to be dealt with now.

I looked at Julius, Karma and the other students and smiled. Just then, the magic circle that Magnus and the others had set up began to glow.

It seemed that they had come, just like they said they would.

And since they came all the way here, they deserved the warmest welcome.

Now, how would it go down?

Well, I guess I would relax and watch this fight with the students until the end.



Julius and Karma stood in the front as they greeted Magnus

and the others.

Magnus saw them and his eyes bulged.

The people he had thought that he'd killed were alive, so it was no wonder he was surprised.

“You’re alive...”

While Magnus was surprised, there was something about him that seemed relieved as well.

Perhaps he had struggled with the decision.

“Yeah. Sorry to disappoint you. But I’m fine.”

“Me too. And not a single teacher died.”

“What?”

“Is that true?!”

It was not Magnus who reacted to Karma, but the guard knight Clad and the research teacher, Irina.

“It is too bad for you, but yes, it is true.”

Said Old William as he stepped forward, proving that Karma was speaking the truth.

There was no point in hiding it.

Someone had suggested that the teachers could hide and then spring a surprise attack. But that idea had been rejected.

The students wanted to fight fairly and openly.

Aside from winning, this fight also had the purpose of finding out what Magnus's true intention was.

This was the will of all of the students.

I want to know if they truly betrayed us, said Mondo.

Perhaps Magnus had an entirely different intent? Said George.

As students from NNU Magic and Science Investigation Academy, both Marsha and Aina wanted to believe in Magnus.

And it wasn't just the NNU students, because Julius and Karma were the same.

Especially Karma. He had been friends with Magnus, and so he had an even stronger desire to believe him.

There must be a reason behind his actions! He declared.

They betrayed us.

Perhaps they were being naive.

Still, they had decided to believe them.

And all I would do is watch.

–Regardless of the outcome.

Irina was the first to regain herself.

She quickly took stock of the situation and decided on their direction.

“...It can’t be helped. And there is no turning back now. I will ask you all just in case, are there any of you who agree with the Humanity Emancipation Alliance?”

Irina said as if this was a final warning.

Though, unsurprisingly, there was no answer.

“I see. Well, that’s too bad...”

There was a chilling glimmer in Irina’s eyes.

The eyes of someone who knew what had to be done.

“I do not think that my way of thinking is wrong. And so the rest of you should have conviction and-”

“Enough of this. If they do not agree with us, we should kill them all!”

The person who had interrupted Irina was a figure in white robes who had been standing silently behind Magnus.

A combat teacher called...

“Berna! What the hell are you...”

“Exactly. We can’t act without foresight just because some people don’t understand our views...”

Yes, yes, it was Berna.

Incredibly competent as a combat teacher but with a forceful personality.

He was usually very quiet, and wasn’t very close to any of the teachers.

Though, I hadn’t heard of any problems until now...

Magnus and Irina tried to warn Berna, but he just snorted.

“The Demon Lord is our enemy. The very idea of humans and monsters helping each other makes me sick! Don’t the rest of you also have a hatred for Demon Lord Rimuru? Then you should hate anyone who sides with him!”

Apparently, Berna had a hatred for me.

And according to his words, so did Magnus and Irina.

Unfortunately, I had no idea why that was the case.

Berna continued.

“Julius. Even you should have a reason to hate Demon Lord Rimuru. Anyone from the Kingdom of Ingracia should understand how I feel! If you could only dauntlessly face the Demon King, none of the other students will suffer!”

He said to Julius.

It would not be odd for someone from the Kingdom of Ingracia to hate me?

After all, the place had once been a central pillar of politics, finance and culture. It had the proudest and most advanced city.

And Tempest had taken their place now, causing the decline of Ingracia. It was true.

However.

I had my reasons as well.

I thought, but I continued to listen quietly.

“...I see. Your older brother is Reiner, wasn’t it? He plotted together with my brother, and then father died... But don’t you think it is too much to force the responsibility of the plot on the Great Demon King?”

Julius did not have the best impression of me, and yet his reasoning was surprisingly decent.

Instead of pushing the blame onto everyone else, he understood correctly the consequences of your actions.

“Bah, shut up! As long as you continue to act so cowardly, my allegiance will never be towards you!”

Unlike Julius, this Berna had a very narrow way of looking at things.

He was so sure that his way was the right way, and he had no intention of allowing his mentality to change.

He would only support thoughts that were advantageous to him. A most dangerous kind of person.

“Listen, Berna. It’s true that the Great Demon King Rimuru is unfair and does whatever he wants...”

What? Julius, it looks like you haven't had enough training yet...

“...He's selfish and erratic. And it goes without saying that it was his influence that caused our country to fall from the position of leader of the west countries. However...”

Yes, keep going.

But more importantly, I was interested in a certain student who kept looking at me.

It seemed like the words 'selfish' and 'unfair' triggered the glances towards me...

Could it be that this student was saying that I was those things?

“It is also an unarguable fact that the Great Demon Lord gave our country another chance!”

Hm? A chance?

What are you talking about, Julius? I wanted to ask, but now was not the time.

“I’m going to speak very clearly, Berna! I hate Great Demon Lord Rimuru. However, I do not believe that all of his actions are evil. And we made plenty of mistakes ourselves. He left the school in Ingracia, and even if we are no longer the center of politics or finance, he showed us a way to survive as a place that exports culture. He even opened the great transport system called a train! These facts prove that he is acting fairly. You cannot argue with that!”

Ohh. There were a few spots I didn’t like, but his estimation of me was more positive than I had expected.

Still, it did hurt a little that he was so clear in saying he hated me.

But well, it was his honest opinion. And I wasn’t in a position to complain.

“You’re weak! It’s because you say such things that Ingracia is looked down upon! Never mind this. I don’t want to hear anymore. If that is your opinion, you can fall with the others!”

Julius’s attempt at persuasion failed, and Berna unsheathed his sword.

As if on cue, Magnus, Irina, Clad and Rozari also pulled out their swords.

People with different mindsets often found it difficult to talk.

It was unfortunate, but this fight would not be resolved through talking with each other.

And like that, the fighting began.



There were five of these Humanity Emancipation Alliance people including Magnus.

However, it seemed to me that these individuals were not completely united in will.

Well, they were humans after all. There was no way that they would all think exactly alike.

And so I had already factored in the possibility of such anti-Demon Lord organizations popping up...

Now, what would happen?

Irina and Rozari could fuse with demons, apparently, and so they supported the others with magic.

However, with three A-rank knights here, one poison tiger may not be enough.

Magnus and Berna were especially strong.

This looked like it would be a tough fight.

Berna was the first to move.

He unsheathed his sword, full of animosity and went straight for Julius.

It was the poison tiger who stopped him.

It jumped out in a quick motion and blocked the attack with Voice Canon.

Unlike the last fight, the poison tiger was moving so smoothly that it seemed like a different monster entirely.

Which was no surprise, because Karma's friends were behind it and giving orders.

There was a kind of telepathic way that monsters could communicate, and they could understand each others' will.

“Tsk! Very sly!”

There was also the support of various magic spells, which meant the poison tiger was greatly enhanced in terms of combat ability.

It had been beaten by Magnus the last time, but now it seemed to have the advantage against Berna.

“Let me help.”

Clad said as he joined Berna.

They would fight the students later and focus on the strongest enemy. It was a good decision.

However, things would not be so easy.

After seeing Berna struggle, Irina and Rozari immediately activated some magic.

They were trying to dispel the magic buffs on the poison tiger and replace them with weakening magic.

However, Irina and Rozari's magic was just erased by the students.

“Impossible! How is our magic being beaten by student-level magic!?”

I could understand her surprise.

She knew how the students were just a few days ago, and she could not have predicted that their magic would surpass hers in that amount of time.

But that was the reality.

Not only Marsha, but the other magic students had learned to use the magic cards.

Each student learned one spell.

They were given one card each, and it contained a type of magic that they were good at.

Strategy-wise it was not going to be possible to have them learn more than that in just a matter of days.

And so I had them focus on just one spell that they were good with.

And then they were separated into groups and then into smaller teams.

For instance, there were fifteen that learned healing magic.

They were then separated into five teams of three.

There were three in the front.

Julius, Karma and Mondo. And then of course, the poison tiger.

In other words, there was one team for every front guard. And there was one team left—which meant there were three people who could move freely.

Mondo was inferior to Julius and Karma in terms of combat ability, but he was quite brilliant when it came to defense. “But I can’t do that...” he had hesitated at first, but he eventually accepted the important role after much persuading from the others.

With six people taking turns healing them, the front guard would be able to fulfill their roles just fine, unless they received

significant damage.

And of course, it wasn't just healing magic that was being used.

There was support magic, interference magic, defense magic and attack magic as well. Everyone had their own role.

In fact, it was because of the few students who were in charge of interference magic that Irina's spells were being erased now.

The enemy only had two people doing magic.

They may have been much more capable, but that was with the old style of magic.

This new type of magic was much faster when activating and had short cool down times.

So even if the students were less capable, they could team up and overwhelm Irina quite easily.

“We can do this! Let’s continue to protect them!”

Marsha shouted.

As if encouraged by her, the students grew more determined.

And like that, the battle of magic shifted to the students’ favor...or so we thought.

“What is this? This magic. As annoying as this is, I never would have predicted that such magic exists. Still, they’re not the only ones with a trump card.”

Irina probably thought that this new magic was the result the teachers’ research.

It seemed like she stopped focusing on it and switched gears.

An incredibly calm person, as befit a researcher.

And with that, she took out the trump card she had been hiding from her ‘storage space.’

“I will ask you one last time. Will you really not join us?”

“Master Irina! You are wrong. Trampling over the opinions of others and forcing your will onto them, is that not oppression! Isn’t that the method that you hated the most!?”

Marsha answered Irina’s question.

They were words of persuasion that were both a rejection and a plea.

Irina’s expression was full of pain for an instant–

But she quickly regained her calm.

“Yes... I am a failure as both teacher and researcher. I have a tendency of prioritizing my own emotions instead of what is right. I never had the right to teach you in the first place. But still... I cannot bring myself to forgive Great Demon Lord Rimuru! I know we could never beat him in an honest fight, but still, I want to hit him just once. We cannot allow our plan to leak.”

Irina seemed to have some deep hatred for me.

We weren't acquaintances, so where did it come from...

It was difficult.

She might have tried to address her grievances to me directly, but it would not have seemed very realistic at all.

She must have decided that there was no choice but to quietly make preparations and take control over the world from the

shadows.

They couldn't win in an honest fight, so they had to move from the back.

I would have done the same, and it seemed like the right decision—that is, had it not involved the school.

There were things in this world that you just could not do.

“Master...”

“If you at least promised you wouldn't interfere—no, no attachments. I must be resolved.”

And then with perfectly clear eyes directed at the students, she administered to herself the thing she was holding.

It was a syringe filled with liquid.

Irina, who was well versed in herbs, had formulated it herself. It seemed to be some kind of strengthening agent made of various concentrated medicines.

“If magic doesn’t work, then I will just use this body to cut my way through. Now, those of you who are ready, let us fight!”

There was no hesitation in those eyes now.

It was not the face of a teacher, it was the face of a warrior.

And Rozari...

“Magnus, I will be of use to you as well!”

So saying, she injected herself with the medicine, just as Irina had.

Irina and Rozari’s muscles expanded as a strength that

exceeded human limits entered them.

According to 'Appraisal,' their power was just as strong as Berna and Clad, who had Greater Demons inside of them.

It was an insane increase in power.

On the other hand, I also just noticed that Magnus had not called a demon at all.

He was fighting the three defenders with his own ability.

Julius and the others had planned to bear all of the attacks without concern towards anything else, until the poison tiger had taken out at least one knight.

And so it was lucky for them that Magnus had not been going all out...

But now that Irina and Rozari had joined, the sense of balance in the fight had crumbled.



“If Miss Irina joins, we will fight her!”

Brown and two other combat teachers shouted as they joined the fight.

I would have liked it if the students handled everything, but I guess it couldn't be helped.

If you compared Irina and Rozari, you would see that Irina was overwhelmingly stronger.

So even with four A-rank teachers against her, Irina was managing them quite well.

Irina's fighting style was magic fighter.

You directly converted magic energy into attack power and attacked with it.

It was why she was able to fight weapon-wielding teachers with her fists.

“Very well. If you wish to protect the students, come and stop me!”

And that was how the battle between Brown's team and Irina began.

While Irina was being attacked by the four teachers, Rozari was still free.

The remaining students were no match for her now, and the situation immediately became dangerous.

It was Mondo who acted first.

“Woahhh!!”

With a shout, Mondo rammed into Rozari, just as she was about to disarm the magic team.

This meant that Julius and Karma would have to deal with Magnus without him, but it was a good decision.

Mondo could not defeat Rozari.

However, he could buy them some time.

I was looking forward to seeing what he would do in the rest of the fight.

As for the fight between the poison tiger and Berna and Clad, it was at a stale-mate

“Damn it. Blasted beast!”

“Don’t get so worked up, Berna. We will only be defeated if you do not keep your calm.”

“You don’t have to tell me that!”

A stale-mate here meant that the students were doing very well.

There was support from the magic team and directions from the beast people.

They were functioning well as a group.

The outcome of this battle would depend on the tide.

If just one of the main fighters on the enemy side fell, then we would gain a huge advantage.

But if the poison tiger was defeated, the students would lose for sure.

It all depended on making the right decisions and the healing of the magic team.

It was a heavy role for these students with little experience, but I could only pray that they would do their best until the end.

And the last group.

Julius and Karma vs Magnus...

Magnus must be struggling with something still, because his sword seemed slower when it came to a direct fight.

Perhaps Magnus did not wish to hurt his friends.

He had looked pained when Julius and Karma had tried to

persuade him.

Regardless of his true feelings, it was nearly time for the fight to end.

The heart was a complicated thing, and it was difficult for people to truly understand each other.

But if you still wish to do so, then there is no other way then to clash with your real feelings.

It might cause you to break apart, but that cannot be helped.

I thought such things as I continued to watch the fight.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 22

The fight between the poison tiger and Berna continued.

It was the same with Irina and the four combat teachers.

Mondo was being beaten into a pulp by Rozari, but thanks to the capable healers, he was able to continue.

“I-I feel quite good now...”

He was starting to say, which had me worried.

Mondo, don’t push yourself too hard.

Don’t go there. It was annoying that I couldn’t warn him.

In any case, out of these three groups, it was Magnus who was

the problem.

I had hopes that Julius would be able to persuade him, but it looked like I was just naive.

The four groups were in a sort of deadlock now, that is, until Magnus made a move.

“Why are you doing this?!”

“I didn’t just think of you as a classmate, I thought of you as a friend that I could share everything with!”

Julius asked. Karma shouted.

Magnus’s reply was filled with self-deprecation.

“Julius. I thought so too. But still, surely you can understand why I feel the way I do?”

“What?”

“Just like me, you had the burden of a country on your shoulders. I knew that you actually wished you could be closer with everyone. That soup, wasn’t it good? Everything tastes better when eaten with friends. But compared to that...cold food, it is hardly edible. It doesn’t matter how fancy or how great the ingredients are. Or how talented the cook is. The food that you eat alone has no taste...”

They must have been words from the heart. Because Magnus’s voice was tinged with sadness.

“Magnus...what do you...”

Julius asked.

Magnus’s answer was most surprising.

“I am a relative of the late emperor Rudra. The empire is now fighting over choosing a new emperor. The late emperor had

not been married. So of course, he had no heirs, which means that one must be chosen from his relatives. And I was the one singled out. During these last ten years, the House of Lords have been in charge of the government. A House of Lords made of those who are selected by the Demon Lord. This means that they are under his management, and in this situation, we cannot be considered to be truly independent. The empire's safety is assured and the subjects are moderately happy. However, there are those who are not satisfied with that. As I was a noble who had left the capital to live in a countryside town, I was deemed as having not been under the Demon Lord's influence."

Julius remained quiet.

They stared at each other, swords raised. But there was no strength in their grip.

"Magnus...you..."

Even Karma did not know what to say.

It was no surprise. This was a much heavier story than what you'd expect from his usually cheerful and friendly personality.

Even I found myself deep in thought.

Yes, the House of Lords really did govern the empire.

But they had only been under my management for the first year after the war. I had left things entirely to them after that.

However, they were under the impression that I was ruling them this whole time...

I could conquer the world if I wanted, but that didn't interest me.

And so it was rather shocking to find out that the people of the empire saw me in that way.

The fact that there was no one who could replace the emperor, and that the seat had remained empty for so long was also a problem... But that was their problem.

Maybe it was irresponsible of me, but I never had any intention of looking after them to that degree.

Besides, peace that is bestowed on others can be lost just as quickly.

Whether they continue as they are now or do their best to achieve total democracy, that was not a problem that I would interfere with.

If someone who could do the right thing became their leader, then an imperial government would not be so bad.

<<That is a pipe dream.>>

Maybe it was, but democracy wasn't much good if the people were all fools. There would probably be those who would keep

the people ignorant and far away from politics. So they could do as they liked... A democracy was not always the right thing.

There wasn't really a true answer when it came to politics.

And so I always thought that it would be more interesting to have some diversity in the way people thought and have multiple types of political styles.

In Tempest, what I think is correct becomes the law.

However, I could always be wrong. And so I do not tell other countries how they should be run.

That was what I thought...

But if I was going to be misunderstood like this, it might be a good idea to have an official discussion with everyone.

<<I don't think it will be of any use. There are too many people with too many ideas. And it is not as if all of them could attend such talks.>>

That's true.

In the end, everyone is selfish.

What they want to believe become justice, and everything else is evil.

There was no choice but to have people talk, compromise to different degrees and learn to work together.

<<Master, if you would only use 'Thought Manipulation', you could make them all united with a single will.>>

I did not like that.

A world full of 'yes men' would be boring and have no future.

Even though I could tolerate wars, I would not tolerate the binding of human will.

But, leaving that aside for now, if unhappy people like Magnus really were created due to my negligence, then I wished there was something I could do about it...

“Even I don't believe that we can win against the Great Demon Lord. However, hundreds of thousands of soldiers have been killed. And it is those who are unable to forgive that are turning their blades against the Demon Lord. If he is angered, it could mean the ruin of the empire... And so I have no choice but to stop them...”

Magnus said as if he were spitting out blood.

That being said, did they really fear me that much...?

Did they think that I was some blood-thirsty Demon Lord?

“Magnus. The Great Demon King will understand you if you were to talk!”

Old William glanced at me before saying this.

I was so happy that I could nearly cry.

The other teachers were also trying to persuade Magnus.

But I felt like half of them were doing it to cheer me up, and not exactly for Magnus’s sake.

However, their arguments did little to change Magnus’s expression.

“I already know that! But what can I do... This is the only way...the only way we can...”

Hmm? He seemed a little strange...

<<Magnus's mental energy is declining. On the other hand, his demon energy is increasing greatly. This reaction is above that of a Greater Demon. It is a Demon Lord.>>

A Demon Lord!?

He bypassed the Arch Demon and is going to call out the big boys? However, it is hard enough for a human to control an Arch Demon...

“Magnus, stop this! That is not something you can control! No human can!”

The person whose voice rang in order to stop Magnus was, surprisingly, Irina.

She was shouting desperately, but her voice did not seem to reach him.

<<The demon reaction is getting stronger. Mental contamination of the host is in progress. It seems that this...>>

According to Ciel, it seemed that Magnus had been hiding the core of an Arch Demon.

She said that he had probably had it securely sealed away and intended to draw power out of it when the need arose.

And for some reason, it had started to become active, and was working on Magnus's conscience little by little.

Perhaps it was the events of the previous night... Maybe the demon had used the guilt he felt over abandoning his friends.

And now.

A black energy was surrounding Magnus's body, changing it into the inhuman flesh of a powerful demon.

It was Magnus but it was not Magnus... It was something no longer human.

A being that was equal to the old Demon Lord.

Right in front of their eyes.

“Finally. I have finally gained a body that gives me freedom!”

That was what the Demon Lord said, with Magnus’s voice.

I ignored the voice and started to shout.

“Everyone, retreat! Come back!!”

Upon hearing my voice, all of the students moved at once.

The Demon Lord looked at all of this with deep interest.

But here the poison tiger stepped forward and looked threateningly at the Demon Lord.

“Hey, you guys come over here as well!”

I said to the members of the ‘Humanity Emancipation Alliance.’ But only two of them reacted.

“Let’s go.”

“But, Miss Irina...”

“Quickly! That thing will not differentiate between friend or foe!”

After this short exchange, Irina and Rozari crossed the defense line.

It was inside of the defense barrier that the magic team had created.

It was also a barrier between life and death.

“Hahaha, Magnus. You did well to make this decision. Good! Now, let us take the world together!”

“Phew, finally. If you hadn’t taken so long to go all out, we wouldn’t have been so underestimated by these students.”

Berna and Clad said as they walked towards Magnus.

No—the Demon Lord that looked like Magnus.

“Berna, Clad! Come back here!”

Irina shouted. But it was too late.

“Hehehe. No. I need more, more! Blood! Flesh! Despair and fear! Now, since this is my birthday celebration, I will allow you to partake by offering me your grief! Today! This day, now! Celebrate with me!!”

The Demon Lord shouted as he spread his arms.

This was very bad.

A Demon Lord could not be compared to an Arch Demon.

It had more power than the weakened Demon Lord that ruled this island—the Rock Elephant.

And on top of that, it's energy was only increasing.

It had its own will and was clearly an old demon.

A demon with intellect.

He could not be compared with any simple monster. This one was much more dangerous.

And—

The Demon Lord began to move.

Ggkka!

Mkaa!

There was a blunt crushing sound.

In just a blink of an eye, several students began to scream in horror.

“AAAAAAAAAAHHHHH!!!!”

Yes, they were afraid.

The Demon Lord had moved forward and crushed Berna’s and

Clad's heads in his hands.

And with such ease.

Neither of them would have had a chance to understand what was happening.

Perhaps it was the one relief in this situation. They had not tasted the fear...

In any case...

“Hehehe. That felt good. I will take on your ‘names’ along with your souls.”

Because Demon Lords eat souls.

Berna and Clad were not only brutally torn apart, but their very souls were lost.

That meant that they would fuse with the demon and suffer an eternal pain that's worse than death.

It was their own doing, and yet, it was a disappointing end.

As for the Demon Lord...

“That is stupid... Giving yourself a ‘name’?! Impossible...”

Irina was right to be alarmed.

From birth, demons were not able to do such a thing.

But this demon seemed very strange to me.

It seemed like the anger that motivated him was much stronger than usual.

What if Irina and the others had done something very foolish during their experiment?

Something to enrage an intelligent demon...

“Hey, Irina. Let me ask you this, did you do any experiments with the demons? You wouldn’t happen to have done anything to an Arch Demon, would you?”

“I...”

“So you did? You idiot! You cannot even control them. How could you not understand that there are things you should not get involved in!?”

I was so exasperated that I could barely speak.

Ridiculous. That was all that was in my head.

According to her brief explanation, they had captured several Arch Demons and killed them.

Among them, one was chosen and sealed within Magnus.

They had thought it was safe, as they had made it so that it could only use as much power as a Greater Demon.

I've never heard something so ridiculous.

During the short time that I listened to Irina, the Demon Lord finished naming himself.

The incredible amount of energy was now stable, and I could tell at a glance that it was perfectly controlled.

Demons really were formidable beings.

“Kept you waiting, huh? I am ‘Bernaclad.’ You should all feel

honored to have witnessed my birth.”

The Demon Lord introduced himself proudly. Bernaclad.

It pretty simple, just putting two names together. However, what was important was having a name. There was no use worrying about what it would be.

But the only people here who seemed to understand the significance of a name, was me and the teachers.

Now, what to do...

Perhaps I should no longer consider myself a spectator.

Because things had become much more complicated than I had been expecting.



The first one to move was the poison tiger.

It roared loudly and then fearlessly moved in front of Bernaclad.

“Y-you... Are you trying to protect us...?!”

The students looked confused as it faced the demon.

“Hahaha! This is an amusing joke. A mere beast thinks he can match me. Very well, I shall play along!”

Bernaclad laughed happily.

And then he approached the poison tiger.

“Everyone, concentrate and support the poison tiger!”

Karma shouted.

It was as if his voice brought sanity back to the group. They all looked serious again as they began to move.

They were starting to gain nerves of steel.

Not a single student was crying or looked afraid.

Numerous colors of light rained over the poison tiger, strengthening it.

Against Bernaclad, no human would survive a single blow. Regardless of how buffed they were.

And so they all understood that the poison tiger was their lifeline.

Now, what was I to do?

I was happy to see how much they had grown, but it was still very likely that they would all end up very dead.

The poison tiger would only buy them a little time.

What was important for me, was that we did not lose anyone else.

And that I had to save Magnus.

Even more, I wanted to defeat Bernaclad without revealing my identity, if it was possible.

The third one might be difficult.

Well, I would figure it out when the time came.

The students watched the fight.

Perhaps Bernaclad was still playing, because it almost looked like an even match.

But as I said, it really was just a matter of time.

Because I could see clearly the difference in strength between Bernaclad and the poison tiger.

Just then...

“I didn’t expect this to happen... I’m sorry. We didn’t mean to involve all of you. I won’t ask you to believe me. But you should all escape to the shore. Master Jujilas has sent a request for rescue, so a boat should be here soon. I will buy you some time to make up for what we did. Now hurry!”

Irina stood up and said.

Rozari was the first to respond to her.

“Miss Irina, I will stay with you. I cannot leave Magnus alone.”

And then she stood next to Irina.

Oh, what now?

She was probably telling the truth about Jujilas calling for a rescue boat, but I had a feeling that part of it was just a hope that she had.

In the first place, that man could not be trusted. It would probably be bad to put any faith in this boat.

“Hey, Irina. Do you also have a hatred for Demon Lord Rimuru?”

“Hate? Yes, of course. My friends were killed. Old friends from back home. At the very least, I wanted him to experience the same pain as me. I would ruin the academy that was so dear to the Great Demon Lord...”

“You couldn’t have. Not with such a soft personality where you can’t watch as the students are killed off...”

“Be quiet. You don’t know anything until you try... And what is wrong with you anyway? You keep calling me, Irina, Irina, as if you know me. It’s very annoying, you know?!”

She had answered my question, but was also a little angry to have a younger student treat her so casually.

Well, she didn’t know who I was, so it was no wonder.

“Really? Well, that’s not important.”

I ignored her grievances and thought about what to do.

If the poison tiger couldn’t do it, there was no point in even considering Irina and Rozari.

Even if the teachers joined them, it would be of no use.

So...

“Karma. I got a telepathic message from the poison tiger! ‘I called my friends. You should all run!’ That’s it! It wants to help us...”

This report came from a teary-eyed beastkin student.

It seemed that they had bonded over a short period of time.

Still, this poison tiger was being very admirable.

A strange cry came from the sky above, and then a hedro griffin swooped down and attacked Bernaclad.

The friends that the poison tiger had called were the monsters of the island.

Bernaclad easily blocked the attack of the hedro griffin.

But then its feet were swallowed by the sand.

The sand scorpion had used its power to turn the earth to sand.

It then sunk into the sand, which was its domain, and when least expected, it appeared on the surface and fired off heat needles with its snake-like tail.

And yet, even that was not enough.

Bernaclad's large hand emitted a hexagon-shaped magic shield that erased them.

There was too much of a difference in power.

Even the freezing dance of the ice naga was of no use.

Ice bullets shot out from all sides, leaving no room for escape. And yet Bernaclad's barrier protected him.

And finally, the Rock Elephant appeared...

The ground quaked as the Rock Elephant fell from the sky.

Its immense body suggested incredible weight, and it was four meters tall.

A body with hard, rock-like skin and the head of an elephant.

It was a distorted creature, and it now made to attack Bernaclad.

As if to show that it was the ruler of this island, and that outsiders could not do as they pleased.

“DDDDOOORROOOON!!”

The roar was loud, and usually had the ability to bind and overwhelm any opponents.

However...

It seemed like little more than a light breeze to Bernaclad.

He smirked knowingly. It was the moment that he was sure that he was the strongest of all.

“Ahahaha! Yes, yes! More. Entertain me even more! Your rage, your hatred. You will forget all of it when you see how much fun we are having! And then after it all, we will eat that tasty looking food over there!”

He was looking at us now. Bernaclad’s expression was full of evil glee as he slobbered.

What a creep.

“Now, hurry! You must all escape!!”

Irina urged us on.

But it was clear that no one would be able to escape.

Bernaclad—a demon who was exceptional enough to give himself a name.

Apparently, he started as an Arch Demon, but through eating a number of other demons, he had evolved into a Demon Lord.

And through acquiring a name, he was able to stay in this world and gain even more power.

He exceeded the old Demon Lords. A true monster.

And he was in the upper ranks among the Demon Lords—as strong as Moss, who was Duke in rank.

No, perhaps he was even stronger than Moss.

Humans had hurt his pride as a demon... In spite of being a spiritual life form, this demon had become mentally ill.

The result was this. Increased power through eating your brethren and evolving into a different being.

As Moss was only a clone, he would just become food for Bernaclud.

(Lord Rimuru. What should I do? Do you want me to go and give him a good punch?)

Came the 'thought transmission' from Laplace.

He must have been watching us and realized that the Rock Elephant was not going to win.

Hmm, what to do...

(Though, that might not be a bad thing...)

–But I wanted to save Magnus.

It was probably time to end this whole charade.

These past few days have been very entertaining.

I was satisfied. And so maybe it would be a good thing to end it here.

In that case, I might as well...

“Alright, I made my decision!”

I moved in front of the students and stopped just before

passing the defense line.

The students and teachers were trying to decide whether to run away or not.

But now they all looked at me.

“Hey, what are you...”

Irina called out to me as if in panic or anger. But I just laughed.

If things continued like this, the Rock Elephant and everyone else would die. I could not let that happen.

But more than anything, this Bernaclad bastard was insolent enough to joke about eating my precious students.

He had to be properly punished for that. Or it wouldn't feel

right.

I was sympathetic about his mental issues, but it really had nothing to do with me.

(Moss. I'm going to deal with that demon. In the meantime, I want you to heal the monsters.)

(Certainly!)

Moss bowed and then disappeared.

(Laplace, Tear. Come over here.)

(As you wish!)

(Understood!)

Laplace and Tear immediately moved on my command.

They appeared before me in an instant and kneeled.

The students watched this in shock.

“Wh-what?!”

“Ah!? Aren’t those guys the abductors? Why are they with Master Satoru!?”

Shock and confusion spread among them.

The teachers were the quickest to understand. Old William took the lead as hr came up next to Laplace and kneeled.

I gave them a sidelong glance as I moved forward again.

This time, I took a step outside of the barrier.

“I will show you all a very special type of magic. A one-time magic of dreams.”

“Sa-Satoru...no, Master...what are you...”

“Come back, it is dangerous! You aren’t a student, and we’re grateful for your instructions during the past few days. But the rest is our duty as students...”

“Master Satoru, the magic you conceived is wonderful, but I still don’t think it is enough to beat a Demon Lord level monster!”

Mondo shouted.

Julius tried to stop me.

Marsha questioned whether it would work.

I raised my hand to silence them all and answered them.

“Yes, yes, be quiet. As your teacher, I am going to protect you all from that demon.”

I said as I took off the swirly glasses.

My hair, which had been dyed black now changed into a glimmering silver. And my eyes changed to gold.

This transformation was quite dramatic, and the students were all taken in by the sight.

And there were a few sharp ones who saw this along with the attitude of the teachers, and came to a realization... However, they didn't seem quite brave enough to admit it...

“Could, could it be!?”

“...Yes...The Great Demon Lord...Rimuru...!?”

“N-no... It can't be. Why would the Great Demon Lord be in a place like this?”

“But, Master... Master Satoru even cooked for us! There is no way...”

“Right? Why would the Great Demon Lord cook for us!?”

“All of you, enough with the jokes! If he really was the Great Demon Lord, would I or Julius still be alive!?”

“...That's true?”

They argued like that, trying desperately to deny the conclusion they had almost reached.

Some of them rejected the reality while others sat weakly on the ground, too exhausted to think.

Irina also rejected this idea, and so I was currently able to fool them.

I still considered it only a matter of time before their suspicions turned into conviction...and I would be exposed... But I needed to get rid of the danger before that happened.

Bernaclad.

I didn't harbor any hatred towards him, but his fate had been decided the moment he started talking about eating my students.

–Now, let me show the real power of a Demon Lord.

I smiled and took another step forward.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 23

Then it suddenly came to me. Had it really been necessary to return my hair and eye color back to normal?

I had gotten a little carried away, but it was nothing short of an act that would accelerate the exposing of my identity.

<<Do not worry. You looked very cool.>>

Uh, is that a good reason?

...Well, alright then.

It wasn’t the most convincing argument, but it can’t be bad if Ciel says it’s fine.

Now, before I quickly defeat Bernaclud, I should think about the students, just in case.

“Laplace! Protect the students here!”

“Sure thing!”

Faithfully, Laplace obeyed my order and constructed a defense barrier over the barrier that was already there.

In fact, it would be rather difficult for me in my current state to hold off the shockwaves of Laplace and Bernaclad, should they battle.

And of course, neither could the students.

And so I could not leave the fighting to Laplace.

Tear was not likely able to beat Bernaclad, so the best option was to fight him myself.

In any case, now the students’ safety was assured.

No matter how strong a demon Bernaclad was, Laplace was an awakened demon lord. If he created a defense barrier, no attack would break through it.

The only thing left to do was for me to defeat Bernaclad.

“Hahaha. You think one little insect is going to be enough to entertain me?”

Bernaclad said confidently as he looked at me.

“...Well, he’s dead.”

“But, if the others find out later that he talked to Rimuru like that, and that we didn’t do anything... Won’t they be furious?”

“...Tear. Don’t say such ominous things. If Souei and Diablo found out about this... I don’t want to even imagine what they might do to us. They won’t stop, regardless of Lord Rimuru’s forgiveness.”

“Right? Right?”

“Well, thankfully, we’re the only ones here now. So let’s keep it a secret.”

“Okay! I won’t tell anyone.”

“Good. Otherwise, we’ll end up in the worst kind of danger.”

I could hear their hushed voices whispering to each other, but it was me who said that I would fight, so they were not responsible.

Besides, in a way, it couldn’t be helped that people would underestimate me now.

After all, I was no different than any other human.

So Bernaclad’s estimation of me wasn’t particularly wrong.

“Sorry, but I don’t think it will be that fun for you. It’s nothing personal, but I don’t like to hold back. If you want to be angry about it, don’t hate me, hate yourself for having the wrong amount of strength.”

I said to Bernaclad, without much interest.

Really, there wasn’t any deeper meaning to my words.

If he had been just a little weaker, just enough so that the Rock Elephant and the others could have stopped him...I would not have had to annihilate him.

Or if I had one other awakened demon lord with me now, I would be able to disarm Bernaclad while still protecting the students.

But then again, Diablo, Souei or Shion and Benimaru would have turned him into dust without a second thought. So perhaps there really was no other fate for him other than death.

Now that I think of it, it's not I, the Great Demon Lord, but my subordinates who are dangerous and extreme.

It was quite impressive that I was able to hold everything together.

I was doing quite well, really.

<<...>>

Oh.

Ciel seemed like she wanted to say something, but I'd rather not hear it.

I have to stop thinking about stupid things and deal with Bernaclud.

Bernaclud did not exactly like what I had just said.

I had condescendingly informed him of his impending defeat, so it was no wonder he wasn't too amused.

“Haaaahaha. What a delightful person you are. However, you should know that such foolishness and misunderstanding of your own worth will do nothing but invite misfortune.”

He smiled and showed no sign of moving.

Then he shrugged, sending great bursts of magic from his hands.

The nuclear strike magic, ‘Nuclear Flame’ burned everything around me. And burned the students behind me as well—or so it would have looked to Bernaclad.

“Oh? Dying in one hit is hardly entertaining, you know? Not only that, but I was looking forward to slowly savoring the taste of those students. But a few of them seem to have been caught in the attack.”

There was a hint of regret in his voice as he watched the blazing furnace he had created.

He believed in the energy and force of the magic he unleashed without any doubt.

Too bad!

“Is that right? You said it was one hit. But I was merely offering you the first move. Didn’t I tell you? It’s nothing personal. And so I thought that I might as well show off a little.”

I had used ‘Teleportation’ to move to the top of a boulder that was behind Bernaclad, and sat down. That is when I spoke, all the while feeling a little sorry for him.

And of course, the students were all fine.

Laplace had predicted this, and created a ‘Multi-purpose Barrier’ that isolated the students from the battlefield.

It was when Bernaclad finally realized this truth, that he was overcome with shock.

“You did what? Just now, what happened!?”

Even as he asked the question, he slashed at me at a speed that even my eyes could not follow.

Apparently, Magnus’s sword was quite sharp, and it cut the boulder I was sitting on in two.

But, it did not hit me.

While my eyes couldn’t follow it, ‘Magic Perception’ and ‘Godspeed Thought’ allowed me to see Bernclad’s movements and predict them.

Bernaclad had measured my strength by the amount of energy alone, and that was his mistake.

But then again, he had used his strongest magic attack as his first move, so he hadn't exactly been holding back, either.

Not that any of it mattered.

“What? It's called ‘Teleportation.’ I gave you the first move and even gave you enough time to attack me just now. Satisfied?”

So saying, I used ‘Teleportation’ again to move right in front of his chest, and unleash an Imaginary Blow with minimum force.

“Gggbgah!”

Bernaclad collapsed in agony.

It was actually impressive that he was alive. Well, I had to save Magnus, and so I had adjusted it so that the physical damage would be at a zero...but it seemed that I had forgotten to erase the damage from the actual punch.

Still, Magnus deserved to be punished a little, so this was nothing to worry about.

In fact, my own right arm, which I had used to hit him, hurt quite a lot.

Human bodies broke very easily, and so I was using ‘Godspeed Regeneration.’

Thanks to it, my limbs had not been blown off, but it was clearly not a move I should be repeating.

I hadn’t felt such pain in a long time, and tears were welling up in my eyes.

In other words, it was time to stop toying with Bernaclad.

Alright then.

Much of Bernaclad's energy had dissipated after the Imaginary Blow, and he was in a dazed stupor.

It wasn't so much pain, but the diminishing of the power of his being that was shaking him.

"Wa-wait! Who are..."

"There's no need for you to know. But if I was to tell you something, it is that this world's order is maintained by the Octagram. Your power was just a little too strong, and so you're in the way. Do I need any more reason to be rid of you?"

"Octagram? No, you cannot be--no, you..."

I smirked instead of giving him an answer.

Bernaclad's confusion was turning into fear.

He was already falling into my trap.

“So, how about a deal?”

I said as I rubbed my right arm, which was still throbbing with pain.

“De-deal?”

“Yes. A simple deal.”

I continued my words of conviction, but said them in a soft, whispering voice.

“If you’ll agree to return that body, I will grant you one thousand years of doom. But if you insist on any futile resistance... Well, just you try.”

“What?”

“Because if you do, you will experience what true fear in this world looks like.”

“...!!”

I could see his soul wavering.

As soon as I gave him a hint of Azathoth, Bernaclad realized that the power exceeded what he could imagine.

He understood now that I had a power that he could never even comprehend.

Tremendous fear.

It welled up from the core of his soul. It looked as if it was struggling against what reason remained within Bernaclad.

But it was no use.

Bernaclad had lost the moment he felt fear as he saw me in front of him.

He closed his eyes and hesitated for a second–

“Just as you say. One thousand years, I shall repent for the foolishness that caused me to go against you. That is how I shall spend my time...”

Shrunkened, with drooping head, Bernaclad agreed as if requesting for forgiveness.

Good.

Now I wouldn't have to feel anymore pain.

Things would be easy now.

“A wise decision. I will allow you to work for me after a

thousand years. Now, go.”

Bernaclad’s Spiritual Body left Magnus, then turned into dust, leaving only the soul. I used a mysterious light to hide the fact that the demon’s body had vanished.

Any students who had been watching would assumed that I had won through the use of some unknown magic.

At least, I hoped they did...

No, it should work. I told myself, as I made sure that Magnus was alright.

He was.

He was unconscious, but his mind and body were intact.

The mind pollution had vanished along with Bernaclad.

That meant that Bernaclad had kept his word.

<<It seems like he was trying to possess and fuse with the soul. It would have been possible to annihilate Bernaclad alone. However, that would have led to damage to the body, so I think that this was the best solution– >>

As Master Ciel was in agreement, my method was clearly quite impressive.

Winning alone would be easy, it was getting Magnus back unharmed that was difficult.

This body could not stand ‘Nihility Collapse.’ It would have meant victory without a doubt, if I used it, but at the same time, I would have been forcefully sent back to Rimurun’s body, which should be with Shuna and Shion.

I was prepared for that worst case scenario, but thankfully, Bernaclad was smarter than I had thought.

It was all over now.

Magnus was unconscious and Berna and Clad were dead.

Irina and Rozari were fine, but it seemed like there was not much time left until the effects of the medicine would wear off.

According to Ciel's 'Appraisal,' there were dangerous substances mixed inside, and they would not be able to move for quite some time as a side effect.

So essentially, none of the members of the Humanity Emancipation Alliance could move.

Irina and Rozari slumped, powerless.

The teachers moved to have them bound up.

The students had won.

Cheers echoed around us. I felt as if the many eyes that looked towards me were filled with passion.

“Did you see it? My special magic?”

“YES!”

The students all stood in a line and nodded.

Due to Moss’s efforts, the monsters of the island were also safe. And just like that, the matter finally came to a close.



Now I just had to bind them all and take them back for questioning—or so I thought, but it seemed like I was getting ahead of myself.

There was someone who was so insignificant that I had

forgotten him until now. He came to me while laughing in a high-pitched voice.

“Waahahaha! That Magnus was nothing after all. It seems that he cannot do anything without me, Jujilas. To think he would lose to such children. Irina and Rozari, what are you doing? Where is Berna and Clad? Won’t you hurry up and kill the rest of these people?”

What was wrong with him...

He had appeared from a magic circle after I had defeated Bernaclad, so he understood pretty much nothing.

Still, that had not stopped him from having convenient delusions, and he continued to give out orders in a pompous manner.

“Mister Jujilas... It’s...over...”

“What? What is? What is over?”

“Jujilas. We have been defeated. Any further fighting would be meaningless. Magnus has been taken. We have no choice but to surrender.”

Irina and Rozari understood their situation.

There was no other way to twist this.

However, Jujilas only snorted at them and replied in an arrogant voice.

“What! I had no idea that you two were such cowards. Headmaster Godama will grieve when he hears of this. But do not worry. I had thought that this might happen, and so I have arranged for a platoon to be sent from the land division. Thirty soldiers in prototype enhancement armor. They say that each soldier is as dangerous as an A-ranker. I doubt we have anything to worry about. Those monsters are nothing to us! As for you, abductors that call yourself the ‘circus’ or whatever, you should stop this meaningless resistance now!!”

And like that, Jujilas tried to convince us that they in fact had

the advantage here.

However, Irina and Rozari had seen my power. And so Jujilas's words were nothing short of ludicrous.

“Give up. Didn't I tell you? We have already lost.”

Irina had accepted it and was now making an admirable attempt to persuade Jujilas.

But Jujilas would not listen.

“What a foolish thing to say! How can we give up now? The Demon Lord robbed us of our status and honor as nobles! Headmaster Godama has promised to accept me. How can I suddenly act as if nothing has happened! You will be treated well if you come with me. Now, you must think hard on that!”

They clearly weren't seeing eye to eye.

Jijilas was still not able to understand his situation.

These kinds inconsequential people were always so stupid. In a way, he was unbeatable.

Just then, something happened that only fed into Jujilas's convictions.

An airship had appeared.

Jujilas saw it and his face lit up.

But it did not last for long.

He had been at the height of glory for a second, but then his face froze over.

“I-I’ve been waiting for...you?”

The airship landed and the gate opened.

The person that climbed leisurely down the stairs, was not a soldier, as Jujilas had hoped–

“Who-who are you!”

It was Diablo.

Jujilas got his answer from a most unexpected direction.

“A-ahhhhhh!! It’s Lord Diablo!!!”

Came the surprisingly loud roar from the crowd.

Even the doctor, Master Pyuri was screaming along with the students.

Actually, she was basically leading them.

If only she had a little more self-respect.

Diablo was apparently hiding his identity now, which meant wearing casual clothes that appeared quite plain at a glance.

But still, there was an aura that oozed out from him. This overwhelming sense of importance that he had was evidence of who he was.

Basically, his disguise was pointless.

“Di-Diablo!? Bu-but, what will happen to me...?”

Jujilas swayed and then crumbled to the ground.

What indeed...

But one thing that was for sure, was that he would no longer work as a teacher.

“No way?!”

“Is it really him?”

“Why is he here!?”

“But he is dressed rather roughly...”

“And he still looks gorgeous!”

Came the scattered voices.

Even those who had not immediately recognized him were soon informed of this fact by the zealous women in the crowd.

There was no hiding it now.

Some of the students were finding it difficult to keep up. So many things had happened in succession that it was difficult to process. And so I had planned to use a dream spell to trick them...

But Diablo's sudden arrival had been so outlandish that it somehow had the opposite effect, and they had become cool-headed.

Some of them were looking at us, back and forth. Then realization seemed to kick in.

Souei was next to show himself, and another round of cheers erupted.

“Oh, my. Who is that man standing next to Lord Diablo?”

“He is very handsome as well.”

Like that, even the less known Souei became the center of much attention.

In spite of this, he kept calm and collected.

“Hehehe. I finally found you. Uhhh...”

Diablo tried to hide my identity, perhaps as a precaution.

However, as he was completely exposed, there was not much point in trying to protect me now.

“It’s fine. People know about my escape already. And I planned to return after going to the Forum. So there’s no point in being secretive.”

I said to Diablo with a sigh.

“Then what now?”

“But let’s keep it a secret that I’ll be participating in the Forum. Also...”

I glanced towards the students...

“You can be responsible for ensuring that they keep their mouths shut. I shouldn’t have to tell you this, but no violence and brainwashing, alright?”

I said, dumping everything onto him.

Diablo nodded with a look of pleasure before kneeling with a bow.

And then–

“Certainly. Lord Rimuru.”

He said in a very clear voice.

Just then.

A cheer much larger than the previous ones erupted.

It wasn't just cheering, but shrieking as well.

“The Gr-great Demon Lord!!”

“He was real!?”

“So beautiful...”

“Hey, wait... So I was rambling on about our plan in front of the Great Demon Lord!?”

“-No, Irina... If anything, it was I who talked about hating him right to his face...”

It was that moment. Every single person who was present knew who I was.

Yes, among them were those whose voices were so pained that even I wanted to cry.

Don't worry.

I'll pretend I didn't hear it—well, I could deal with those things later.

After all, maybe a little revenge was acceptable.

“Well, that's what it is. And wasn't that magic great?”

I said with a wink.

Some of the students bled from their noses as they fainted.

Some of them were stunned into a stupor.

The teachers were both laughing and crying.

And some students were screaming hysterically. Ahhhhh!!

In any case, the students were engulfed by a great chaos for quite some time after that.

Side Story – Rimuru’s Elegant Escape Plan – 24 END

Afterward.

The students were put on the airship that Diablo and Souei came in and sent off to the Kingdom of Ingracia.

While I was going to miss it, this was the end of the survival training.

Laplace stayed on the island and talked with the monsters about the plans for building Wonderland.

This was in order to listen to their requests and to insure habitat segregation.

In the future, this island would have a secret base for mysterious airships and an amusement park from hell for the training of the students.

We were also considering allowing civilians inside while accompanied by guards.

And—

Within the airship, I decided to listen to what Diablo and Souei had been doing up until now.

“This must be some kind of mistake!”

Screamed Jujilas as Souei escorted him. He was tied to what looked like a dirty log.

But on closer inspection, it wasn't a log, but a person who had been turned into a tree.

“What's this?”

“Ah! This guy had crawled into the NNU Magic and Science

Investigation Academy, and so I punished him. As you commanded, I refrained from taking his life.”

Diablo answered proudly.

While it was true that he had not killed him, what did he intend to do now...?

“Hehehe. Once the questioning is finished, I intend to put him in the treant labyrinth town.”

“Uh, I don’t know if Trainee would like that?”

“Do you think so? Then what if I give him to you as a present, Lord Rimuru?”

“I don’t want him! This isn’t just a questionable hobby, you know? They will question my sanity!”

“That is true. I am very sorry. Shall I burn him now?”

“Hmm. Maybe...”

The conversation was like some kind of comedy sketch. Just then, the log—I mean, Godama, began to cry.

I felt a little sorry for him.

But upon further questioning, it turned out that he was causing the most mischief in regards to my plans for the school... I could not forgive him for that.

I had no reason to forgive him.

“Oh, well. After making him an example for other fools and enduring one hundred years of tree life, he can be released. He may even be able to start life again if his brain is fine. In the end, it is important to repent.”

“That’s wonderful, Lord Rimuru. You are always overflowing with mercy!”

Oh, really?

I felt like I was being rather harsh.

He was feeling a lot of pain but couldn’t die. He couldn’t faint or even go mad. Perhaps it would be better to just die.

However, he would be much more mentally stronger if he came out of this intact after a hundred years.

Depending on his attitude at that time, I may just hire him at Tempest.

It was not particularly pleasant, but it would work as an experiment.

And there was one other person.

Jujilas, who had been crying for quite some time now...

His heart certainly would not be able to survive turning into a tree...

Hmm. In fact, just like the small fry he was, he hadn't actually committed that grave a crime.

On the other hand, he had affected the school and put meaningless status systems in place and shown open hostility towards me.

"What should we do with him?"

"I could kill him for you?"

Souei was quick to say.

Do you mean it? Diablo seemed to ask as he looked at Souei with surprise.

Wait a minute? I just remembered something.

“That’s it! This guy is fixated on class. We can strip him of his status and make him labor as a prisoner.”

“I see. He can help clean the labyrinth.”

“Hehehe. And there will be no worry of him dying if he wears the bracelet.”

It seemed like a very harsh punishment indeed.

The bracelet would cause him to resurrect every time that he died.

And cleaning the labyrinth was very dangerous work.

A certain number of the monsters had been dealt with, but there was still parts that needed work.

It was Trainee and the other labyrinth managers that went their periodically, but they would need people to help them.

Or course, it was all very dangerous.

There was a possibility of being killed by monsters repeatedly. So it was usually work for prison laborers.

The least popular job in Tempest.

However, this was not the kind of conversation we could have in front of the students.

It wasn't just a matter of having a bad influence on them.

So all of these thoughts remained in my head as I decided on

Godama and Jujilas's fates.

After that, there was also Magnus, Rozari and Irina.

Irina would sometimes look at my face and shout.

"Tsk. Just kill me!"

Ah! How typical!

"Hehehe. Then without further ado!"

Diablo began to move, and so I stopped him frantically.

You can't kill the person who begs to be killed.

It was against the rules.

“Um, I understand that you hate me and everything. But, it’s not exactly justified. The ruler cannot just stand by without resisting during a war. A country cannot exist without protecting its citizen’s safety and assets. It is fine if people want to sing about being pacifists, but the ruler cannot. Or else the country will fall. Can you understand that?”

“Yes... I understand that I am wrong. But! I cannot help but hate you...”

Well, she couldn’t help herself then.

And she had no hope of changing, and so she wished for nothing but to die at my hands now.

This was all very annoying.

“By the way, who do mean when you talked about someone from your home? The people who died in the war with the empire were mostly brought back to life.”

The reaction of those three to my question far exceeded mere surprise.

Apparently, it was news to them.

“Hey, hey. Didn’t the resurrected soldiers tell you anything?”

“N-no. We had heard, but we couldn’t believe it. We thought perhaps they had hallucinated it amidst the horrors of the war...”

“Yes. How could we believe such a thing...”

Magnus and Rozari shook their heads in firm denial.

Hmm, I suppose so.

But, it did happen.

“Shinji Tanimura. Also Mark Lauren and Shin Ryusei... People from my home... They were ‘otherworlders’ who came here. I searched for them desperately, but could not find them. You killed them, didn’t you? Even if it was the work of your subordinates, it is ultimately your...”

“STOOOP!!”

It was probably her answer to my question, but Irina looked me straight in the eyes and began to talk.

And the names that came out of her mouth were all familiar to me.

I told her to stop and gave her the truth quite plainly.

“You know, they are alive?”

What are you saying? I shall not be fooled! She seemed to say as she glared at me.

But it's the truth...

“I mean, I guess they haven't bothered to contact their friends?”

“As for that, Lord Rimuru...”

Souei seemed to know the reason.

Shinji, Mark and Shin had all betrayed the empire and defected. That was why they could not contact anyone.

And...

“They are very obsessed with their research and rarely leave the country. But they do enter the labyrinth occasionally for exercise and stress relief.”

Well, there you go.

Ramiris would have laughed loudly in this situation.

Now that I think of it, Ramiris and Veldora were rather quiet recently.

I was worried that maybe they were plotting something, but it looked like it was just their research.

“Hehehe. Now that I think of it, they had been asking for more personnel. Among the documents in Benimaru’s room, there was a request for an increase of workers.”

Diablo had a sharp eye and had looked through the documents addressed to Benimaru.

In fact, I had known about it.

However, there was no one that we could send, and it had been ignored.

It had to be someone knowledgeable with a resistance to mana.

Such personnel didn't come easily...

Hmmm? Personnel...

"Irina. If you don't believe me, why don't you go and see them?"

"What!?"

"On one condition!"

I could see that Irina had tensed up.

I smirked and continued.

“You will have to work there as a researcher too. And if you refuse this offer, you will be subject to a one hundred years sentence. Then you will not be able to confirm that what I have said is true, and you will not be able to meet them if it is. It’s up to you. Choose as you will.”

Irina’s expression was deeply troubled.

However, she came to a decision surprisingly quickly.

“Regardless of it being true, research is preferable to a sentence. I will work there even if you are lying to me. Besides, you...protected the students. I do not think you are the kind of Demon Lord who would lie and toy with the hearts of others...”

I did not know if she was being sincere, but she said this as she accepted my offer.

Just one last push now.

“Of course. After all, you were honest enough to tell me your

plans. Quite freely too. How could I not have taken that into consideration?”

I smiled devilishly and nodded.

“But! Do not say that.”

Irina looked very embarrassed.

“Hehehe. Irina. While I do not lie, it is no difficult thing for me to play with the hearts of people. I might tell Shinji and the others about this. Especially when we are drinking. It can’t be helped, can it?”

“AHHHHH!!!”

Irina imagined this scene and shouted with embarrassment.

“I, I swear to be loyal to you. But, please don’t talk to them

about this...?”

“I will think about it!”

I said victoriously and nodded.

Magnus had listened to this whole exchange.

“Satoru...no, Great Demon Lord Rimuru. I, no, I don’t care what happens to me. But could you not forgive Rozari for her crimes?”

“Lord Magnus!?”

“I am very aware that this is very selfish of me. But she was only following my orders. If you could at least allow me to take the blame for it and forgive her...”

I had thought he was one of those shallow types, but this was

rather dashing of him.

Well, he was actually part of the imperial family.

I wanted to avoid earning anymore hatred through dealing with him too harshly.

It would be a diplomatic issue, and I didn't care to act so extremely just because I could.

So, what to do?

As I wondered about this, I heard a knock on the door.

I felt the presence of two people.

It was probably them.

I was expecting them—well, I wanted them to come.

Good.

Now I could prepare a point of compromise.

“Come in.”

I gave them permission before Souei could stand up.

As expected, it was Julius and Karma.

I had told the teachers to stop them if they tried to come in here, so it meant that the other students must have helped them.

I could feel my mouth curling into a little smile.

To think they would come here to talk to me directly after finding out that I was the Great Demon Lord.

Well done! I thought.

“Master Satoru...no, Lord Rimuru! Please forgive Magnus!”

As soon as they entered, Karma bowed deeply and said those words.

And then Julius followed.

“Magnus is our friend. But we didn’t realize he was troubled, and we didn’t consult him. We hadn’t talked together about what we really felt. We couldn’t. However, we would like to now. I want to say what I really feel, from the heart! So please, could you not give us that chance?”

Julius expressed himself before lowering his head just as Karma had done.

This was good.

I now had a reason to forgive.

“Very well. You can all share the responsibility for what happened.”

At these words, Julius, Karma and Magnus all raised their faces at once.

Rozari also looked at me with uncertainty.

“You can all help each other. If one of you looks to be going down the wrong path, stop him. Do you agree that everything happened while you were my students? Teachers are responsible for what their students do. And so I will close my eyes in this case.”

Diablo sat back in his chair gracefully and enjoyed his tea.

Souei was pouring me a second cup.

Neither of them said a word in protest.

“So-so...does that mean that we are forgiven...?”

Rozari asked hesitantly.

It was not me, but Diablo who answered her.

“Hehehe. Can I tell you something? When Lord Rimuru says he forgives you, he has forgiven all of your sins. He says he is going to close his eyes, so that means that you have all gotten away. But remember, there won’t be a next time.”

And then Souei added,

“Yes. The real problem was with the school. In a way, you were all victims. This plan of raising personnel and sending

them to the center was quite interesting. That alone is hardly a crime.”

He said.

Exactly.

Ultimately, brainwashing students was not good, but the rest was hardly an issue.

“Well, that’s how it is. I said as much to Irina, but when it comes to war, your perspective will change depending on which country you are with. Such is history. It cannot be helped that people wish for their country to have an advantage. That is why it is important to study the history of other countries as well as your own. It will help you understand both sides and judge fairly. Well, perhaps this is not the most convincing argument, since it’s coming from the mouth of a Demon Lord.”

I finished.

I was about to tell Magnus and the others to leave, when Godama caught my eye on the floor.

“...Oh, yes. Julius. You were shouting about how much you hated me, weren’t you?”

“Oh?”

“...”

Diablo immediately reacted to this. Even Souei’s eyebrows twitched.

“Uh, no...that...”

Sweat dripped from his handsome face as he desperately searched for the right words.

Hehehe.

I had mostly ignored his words, but I couldn't say that I wasn't just a little hurt.

“Even I was a little wounded by having such words said to my face.”

“It was just a...a figure of speech...”

Julius had tears in his eyes.

I decided to let him off here.

“I'm joking. All is forgiven. But on one condition.”

“Condition?”

“Yes. Take care of this.”

So saying, I pointed at Godama.

Julius looked less than enthusiastic, but he agreed without complaint.

“As you are all responsible, you can take it around to the other schools. It will be a punishment for you, so you can take turns every year. I am sure that any student who thinks of doing something foolish will have a change of heart when they see this. It’s two birds with one stone, isn’t it?”

Rozari and the three others looked very unenthusiastic about it.

That made me quite satisfied.

I was able to get rid of the thing and also punish them at the same time.

Hurrah!

After that, I had all of the revolutionaries, or ‘Human Emancipation Alliance’ members taken in, as they seemed to have very extremist views.

Souei’s subordinates had already received the order, and they would be finished with this task shortly.

I would hand them all over to Laplace, as they would make good workers.

I was sure they would prove to be very useful.

And just like that, the great cleansing of the school and driving out of the troublemakers was complete.

—Afterward.

Julius, Magnus, Karma and the others of their class became legendary warriors whose names went down in history as the people who the Great Demon Lord once cooked for.

Some of them, like Marsha, became actual heroes. As she was known as the forebearer of the new style of magic.

My escape resulted in several other amusing stories as well, but those were for another time.



After returning to Tempest.

My body, Rimurun, was cruelly split into two.

Well, as it was a slime, it had just split into two smaller slimes... Still, it was not a good feeling when you thought of it as your own body.

“Th-this is...um...”

“No! It was because Shuna wouldn’t let go!”

It was surprising enough that Shuna would resist Shion's great strength.

But more than that, I was shocked that my incredibly resilient body had been split into two.

These two should not ever be angered.

I promised to myself once again.

By the way, I was able to return to normal by absorbing the two Rimurun bodies.

Shuna and Shion looked a little sad, so I thought that I would give them a doll next time.



The Forum was held in the Ingracia School City–The

development of magic and science. The 8th...

Mai gave a wonderful lecture.

She had succeeded in stabilizing the Different Gate after ten years.

But the fact that I listened to her and thought, 'maybe it would be fun to visit another world next time,' will be our little secret.

Side Story – The Everyday Lives of Certain Adventurers

Cabal, Ellen and Gido tottered down the road.

Their faces looked exhausted as they stopped in front of the building they had passed by often. Then they weakly pushed the door open and entered.

It was a cheap inn and bar. As all three were rather poor, they came here often.

After securing their rooms, they met up at the bar.

Once they had let out a series of deep sighs, they opened their mouths in order to let out all of the anger that they had built up inside.

“That’s why I argued against it!”

“Exactly. I remember saying that I had a bad feeling about it!”

“It can’t be helped now! I never would have thought that a Twin Serpent would appear when we were just supposed to hunt some great snakes!”

“But, but we had already hunted four of them...”

“And there was only one left to hunt...”

“We should be thankful that we were at least able to negotiate it so that the quest wasn’t a failure.”

Cabal spat, as if to say there was no point in arguing. Cabal understood why the others wanted to complain. But being the leader meant you had to listen to the complaints of others.

Just then, their beer was brought over to their table. It was the perfect timing.

As if wanting to forget all those bad memories, the three of them immediately tipped the cups into their mouths. While they hadn't failed the quest, their reward money had been halved and the acidic saliva that the twin serpent had unleashed on them as they ran away, had made it necessary for them to have their equipment repaired. The more they thought about it, the worse their loss seemed. They could not go on without having a drink.

They didn't have enough money to buy new equipment, and so they had to make do with having it repaired...

"Ahhh. I want dwarf-made armor too. But they cost several pieces of gold even at the lower end..."

"That's too expensive, Cabal. I would like to buy new robes myself, but I know that I can't."

"We're way too poor... We should just be happy that we're even alive after what happened."

"True. We got away from the Twin Serpent. And they sent out

a hunting party because of our report. We should just be glad that no civilians were hurt!”

“Yes, yes. Having our savings disappear due to repairs. That’s no big deal!”

Cabal tried to be optimistic like Gido, but Ellen’s words were enough to remind him of how depressing their reality was. Ellen also looked gloomy, and an oppressive air fell over them. Cabal was just about to suggest that they should drown their troubles in drink, go to bed, and start again tomorrow! When–

“Hey, did you hear about it?”

“Ah. You mean the mansion deep in the mountains passed Giena village? They say there is a quest that is offering ten gold pieces as a reward.”

He heard the conversation of two men from the table next to theirs. They were quite drunk, and unable to tell that their voices were loud. The trio became sober at the mention of ten gold pieces, and they perked up their ears with serious

expressions.

“So you get paid ten pieces of gold for killing the monster...”

“Hey, hey. That’s ridiculous. Why would they pay you so much?”

“Well, it’s a quest that is not going through the guild. So as there is no commission, you can earn more.”

“But doesn’t that mean that the strength of the monster is uncertain? Surely no one would be so stupid as to accept it?”

“Ten pieces of gold is mighty enticing. But Giena village is far away. I wouldn’t go all the way over there if I wasn’t sure that I could kill it.”

“Exactly. It would be smarter to take smaller jobs.”

The men said with a laugh. They soon forgot about the subject and went to boasting about their personal exploits.

Cabal, Ellen and Gido all looked at each other.

“Well, we just finished the last quest and have nothing to do...”

“Yes... And I hear that mountain vegetables are good this time of year...”

“It might be a good idea to relax and enjoy being in the mountains once in a while.”

With matching opinions, they nodded at each other.

Their eyes were full of greed and it was clear that none of them gave the slightest thought to the danger.



Cabal, Ellen and Gido ran desperately.

They were so close to the exit when the thing appeared in front of the door.

It was a lesser demon.

The lesser demon was 'B+' rank, and so there was no telling whether or not their party, which was 'B' rank, could beat it.

According to the guild, you were only supposed to fight monsters that were the same rank as you or lower. As there was no gurantee you could win against a stronger monster, it was considered an act of suicide.

But why had this happened to them in the first place...

The party had stayed one night in Giena village before visiting the mansion in the mountains.

That was where they heard the details of the quest. And as it was late, they were invited to stay for the night.

They did not realize that it was a trap until they sat down for dinner with the master of the house.

“Oh, do you really not mind that we eat all of this food?”

“Everything is so delicious!”

“You just leave this ogre bear to us. We’ll handle it for you!”

“Hahaha. You young people are so reliable. Now eat up. We still have plenty more!”

“Thank you!”

“Yes, it is so good! Could you be fattening us up so you can eat us later on?”

“Hahaha...what? What did you just say?”

“Uh, umm... Could you be fattening us up so you can eat us?”

“...”

“.....”

Ellen’s joke caused the master to laugh uncomfortably.

It was so unnatural that even Ellen forced a smile.

“Uh...are you...actually serious?”

“Hehehe. Ahahaha! Very good, you humans. This isn’t exactly going the way I planned, but I’ll just kill you here and take your flesh.”

The master said. Then he dispelled his disguise, revealing his true form.

The three of them decided to retreat the moment they saw it. And that's how their desperate escape began.

It was after much running that they finally arrived at the door.

“We should prepare to meet our fate now! Let's kill it!”

“Lady, that's easy to say, but... Oh, very well.”

“Hey, hey. I'm the leader here. Alright, let's do this!”

The two men agreed with Ellen. And so began a battle where they used all their items, fully aware that they would be ruined after this was done.

Several hours later.

“Tsk...no... How can I be defeated by mere human scum... If only...I had been able to maintain this flesh...”

With those last words, the lesser demon vanished. He was not dead. He was just no longer able to maintain the body which was not whole. And so the three had been victorious.

“Ye-yes! We killed the lesser demon!”

“We did it! I knew that we could accomplish anything if we tried!”

“Good. I am so relieved. I was so sure we were going to die...”

They celebrated for a moment, but then the coming flames made their expressions change.

“Damn it! The fireballs he unleashed are starting to burn up the building!”

“This is bad! We have to get out now, or we will be burned into a crisp!”

“Don’t stand there in shock. Let’s hurry up and get out of here.”

The three of them frantically began their escape.

Thankfully, the door had been destroyed during the fight, and they were able to get out...however...

“By the way...the ten gold pieces...”

“Don’t talk about that! We just came here to rest. Right?”

“...Yes. The mansion is burned down and...”

“What! So we worked for free again!? But I want to live in luxury already! I was thinking about buying beautiful robes with the reward money!”

“I told you, don’t bring that up! It’ll only make you sad.”

“Well, I’m hardly surprised this happened again. I guess we should just be happy that we’re alive!”

“Ugh, it’s always that... We say the same thing every time.”

Still, in spite of the complaining, all three of them looked cheerful. This kind of thing happened all of the time, and they knew from experience, that as long as you were alive, good things will come to you.



They finished making their report at the nearest guild and then stayed in a bar until late into the night.

After that, the three of them were summoned by the guild master.

They nervously entered the room.

“It seems that you let greed get the best of you again, and you took on a job that you never should have.”

The guild master said, before Gido had even closed the door behind them.

“Oh, but we didn’t make any money. Please don’t punish us!”

Cabal said frantically.

However, the guild master just snorted and continued.

“Well, that’s fine. If you survived it, you must have gained something at the same time.”

They were at a loss over how to react to this. But they were at least relieved that the guild master seemed to be in a good mood...

“Still, you three are too reckless! Idiots!!”

The guild master continued in a fashion that was scarier than any ogre. The lecture continued for hours, which was odd, considering how busy the guild master should be. Things just kept getting worse for them, and they wanted to cry.

Finally, the guild master said to them,

“However, the Twin Serpent was discovered because of your report. It was far from the village, just outside the forest. That was because you lured it over there, right? Well done. And you made it out alive. Next time you should be more careful.”

“No, we weren’t thinking about anything but running. And we only went in the opposite direction as the village by accident. You know...we don’t have the best sense of direction...”

“Yes, yes. It was so frantic!”

“How clumsy of us. There would have been soldiers waiting for us in the village.”

They said in denial, but the guild master seemed to see through it and said, ‘Fine. That will be all,’ and then turned away from them and towards some documents. That was the guild master’s way of showing gratitude.

The three of them bowed and left the room behind them.

Several days later.

The three of them had come to a certain village for work.

“Ah, miss! Thank you for killing that scary monster last time!”

Small children shouted as they came running towards them to crowd around.

They were all smiling.

When the three of them had come here last time, the children were all worried about their parents and couldn't stop crying—but there was no hint of that now.

“Just seeing your smiles is all the reward that I need. That's what I think!”

“Yeah. Not bad.”

“True. There are things that are more important than money!”

The childrens' smiles were infectious, and it did not take long for the three of them to smile as well.

And just like always, they looked forward and started to walk.

Their adventure had only just begun.

Side Story – Night Butterfly – Toranoana/Volume 1 Extra

The body of a slime is surprisingly comfortable.

It was easy to move in and I didn't ever feel tired. And since I did not have an overly particular personality, it was mostly convenient.

However, there now arose a very big problem.

I had come to a place called the 'Night Butterfly.'

Kaijin had brought me here to celebrate and as a thank you.

I didn't have any interest really, but Kaijin would not back down, and so I had no choice.

Really, I had no interest in it at all. It was Kaijin who forced me...

...

Alright, I will admit it.

I was actually very interested. It had been a long time since I last had a drink with pretty girls, and so I entered the place quite happily.

But then!

No matter how much I drank, I could not get drunk. You could say it was an incredibly serious problem. Kaijin had gone through all the trouble of bringing me here. But now the fun was halved. I tried my hardest to get drunk, but I couldn't even taste the drink. I was dauntless and unyielding in my attempt, but it was no use.

However, there was more to enjoy than the drinks.

I was a man who was quick to adapt. I would not give up so easily!

And so I thought that I would like to enjoy the company of beautiful elf girls that would do justice to the name, 'Night Butterfly.'

And here arose yet another problem.

I had not had any complaints about my slime body up until now, but now I had nothing but complaints.

My next issue was the lack of hands. Here I was with these pretty elf girls, and yet I could not touch them. It was a huge problem indeed.

Their lithe, delicate arms wrapped around me as their ample breasts pressed against my body.

Wonderful! Was I in heaven!? I wanted to shout out loud. That's how amazing the situation was...

But tragically, I had no hands. And so there was nothing else that I could do.

I thought back on all the animals I had preyed on, and wondered if I couldn't create a hand or tentacle or any other organ to express my feelings.

Then I thought of using the unique skill Great Sage. And so I sent out the order.

However—

<<Answer: Insufficient data. Creation of the specified limb has failed.>>

How useless!! So much for 'Great Sage'! It was completely unreliable when I needed it the most.

But then I recalled all the monsters that I had preyed on—snakes, centipedes, spiders, bats, lizards, wolves...indeed, none of them had that ability.

Unfortunately, I would have to give up being able to squeeze any breasts.

But! I was not the kind of man to give up here.

If I couldn't squeeze anything, surely I could still enjoy the sweet-smelling scent of these elf ladies.

Being surrounded by breasts while enjoying the smell of heaven. That was the best way for an adult man to live.

And so I would go about doing just that.

I took in as much air as I could. And here I was able to reach the world of aroma.

This was when the skill, 'Super Olfaction,' which I had received from the Fanged Wolves, came in handy.

And so I continued to smell the beautiful elves as a way of satisfying my desire to know more.

<<Answer: The substance is a mixture of perfume, the female hormone estrogen, oxytocin...>>

Stop! That's not what I meant!!

I don't want to know those kinds of details... Knowing all of that will decrease the beauty.

Was it only a 'Great Sage' in name? The skill was completely useless.

And so explained to the 'Great Sage.'

While I did want to smell the scents and know its wonders, I did not want to know too much.

There was just a right amount. There was always a line you shouldn't cross.

Things you couldn't know even if you wanted to. Things you couldn't see even if you wanted to.

That was the great secret.

People lost interest in things if they knew too much. And so you had to go until you almost arrive, but then restrain yourself from going any further.

You could say it was the art of only getting a brief glimpse of something.

By suppressing your intellectual curiosity, you can gain much more excitement. It's an adult thing that only professionals can manage.

I said all of this and more to the 'Great Sage.'

<<...Answer: I understand.>>

For real? That's the Great Sage for you.

My passion must have got through, as it understood me now.

The Great Sage was wonderful after that.

It allowed me to sense things right up until that point when I became desperate for more.

To be precise, I was able to understand their emotions by their smell.

It was emotions such as joy or anger. But these things were worth a thousand pieces of gold in this kind of place.

I was able to establish myself as a type of king here.

And it wasn't just about the smell.

My sight as well. Things that you cannot see were recreated as images in my brain.

Currently, I was still relying on 'Magic Perception' to see.

It was surprisingly difficult to recreate the eyes alone, and not only was it easier to use 'Magic Perception' to create the images, but it had a wider view.

I was able to use this wide view to see things that people shouldn't. For instance, it would be possible to see under people's skirts.

However, that golden triangle was tightly protected by the elf ladies, and I was never able to see anything through the faithfully recreated images.

'Great Sage.'...was almost frighteningly accurate.

And so, my tireless pursuit in this place of the night continued. That is, until some people came to hinder us.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 01

Different Gate

On the day of Rimuru's great escape, there were those who laughed out loud in the far depths of the labyrinth.

It was Veldora and Ramiris.

Veldora was in the shape of a human as he stood in front of the magic circle and laughed.

Ramiris flew happily around him.

“Kaaahh-ahahaha! Finally, it is finished. Now we can journey to other worlds ahead of Rimuru.”

“Ohoho. Encounters with the unknown! Rimuru is always so cautious about everything, so this is our chance, master!”

“Yes! I was thinking that too, Ramiris. At the forum that is to

take place in Ingracia, a thesis on the Different Gate is to be revealed. However, we shall be the first to succeed before that even happens!”

“Yes, yes! Rimuru is guaranteed to start saying, ‘I’ll go and play in that other world,’ so we have to go first and see what it’s like!”

“Exactly!”

As their conversation suggested, they had completed the procedure of opening a Different Gate.

Of course, they did.

This was because they had been helping with Mai Furuki’s research, and were in a position to know what its contents.

But it wasn’t that they wanted to steal the results of the research and take credit for it.

Their reasoning was simple. They were just looking for an opportunity to ignore Rimuru's warning that it was dangerous, and go on a journey to a different world.

And if circumstances permit it, they would learn all they can and then surprise Rimuru with it later on.

And so neither of them hesitated.

Now that Rimuru was gone, they would hurry up and activate this new method and take off for a different world—the two of them could think of nothing else.

Rimuru's warnings were like a distant wind, and they cared not at all about whether or not this other world would be safe.

They had no plans at all.

However, they were both full of confidence and did not care about the small details. As always, they would cry only when the trouble arose.

“Hehehe. Now that we’ve decided, we should go at once!”

“Yes! Let’s go!!”

Ramiris held onto Veldora’s shoulder, and once Veldora was sure she was secure, he began to send magic energy into the circle.

Beretta realized this and frantically ran towards them–

“Wait just a min–”

However, it was much too late!

Light flowed from the magic circle and filled the room in a flash, engulfing even Beretta.

And when the light disappeared, all three of them had vanished without a trace.

.....

.....

...

Shinji had become worried that they hadn't come out for so long, and went to check on the room.

There was a cup of coffee on the desk that was half empty.

"Huh? Lord Ramiris is gone, and Mister Veldora... Where... no, they couldn't have!?"

He looked down at the magic circle on the ground with startled amazement.

"Oh, damn it. So they must have been waiting for a time when Lord Rimuru is absent... Really, those two are so selfish. Ahhhh.

It will not be my fault if they get scolded later. Damn it.”

He muttered in defeat. Then he worried over how he could prove that he was not involved in this.

But now that he thought about it, he had only helped in the research as Ramiris’s assistant. And he was not an actual accomplice.

And he had evidence, including the schedule in the research journal, so there really was no need to worry.

“Well, it’s fine then. And it will be good for them to be harshly reprimanded once in a while, or they will never learn.”

Shinji thought as if it had nothing to do with him.

However—

Shinji would find himself in danger as well, in one weeks time.

This was because Irina, who he had not heard from for a long time, would be arriving as a new research member.

But Shinji could not predict the future, and so he hadn't the foggiest idea.

His master was not here, and so he started to think that he could take a few days off.

-As for the encounter with Irina that awaited him, it was a story that only God would know.



To put it simply, the Different Gate had been opened.

And as the three of them had gone through it, they came out into the land of a different world.

Well, maybe they didn't quite land, to be precise.

“GAAAAHHH!! Have we been thrown out into the sky!?”

“Hey, master!! We're falling. We're falling!?”

“Kaaaa-hahaha! Well, I cannot fly well. But we won't die even if we fall. Now, hold on tight!”

“Huh? Whaaat!?”

The three of them had been thrown from a point that was three-hundred meters above ground.

Veldora, Ramiris and Beretta.

It wasn't as high as it could have been, and they hit the ground in less than ten seconds.

The ground approached them even as they talked, and they made contact with a thunderous crash.

“Wh-what a shock! Master, what do you mean you can't fly?!”

“Hmm. Well, energy seems to be very thin in this world. I couldn't move like I wanted.”

“...Now that you mention it, the power of spirits is weaker here as well! Hey, what does this mean?”

Ramiris said in shock after hearing Veldora's explanation.

However, Veldora seemed confident.

The impact upon landing had done nothing to them, and he

began to take stock of the situation with calm movements.

Ramiris also looked around with deep curiosity.

And then, right in front of them—Beretta slowly floated downwards.

“...Oh, dear. This is exactly why Lord Rimuru said we must be careful... Well, it’s too late now. But don’t blame me if he is furious about it.”

“...What!? Beretta. Why are you pretending to be some goody two shoes that has nothing to do with this! You’re our accomplice in crime!”

Ramiris frantically tried to implicate Beretta, but it would be hard to say that she succeeded.

Beretta stayed calm and ignored her words.

And just like Veldora, he began to look around and inspect this world they had come to.

He understood that trying to argue with Ramiris seriously would only result in her putting the blame on him. And so Beretta decided to end it immediately.

‘Oh, fine. We’ll talk about this later, when there’s time,’ Ramiris said, temporarily delaying her victory over Beretta.

And it would indeed be temporary, for she had every intention of having Beretta take responsibility.

It was done in the spirit of wanting to lessen the degree of anger directed towards her.

Veldora was in total agreement concerning this, and so Beretta’s position here was very dangerous.

Honest people are not always rewarded for being honest.

And as someone who had known Ramiris for a long time, Beretta had experienced this first-hand.

Not only that, but the embodiment of irresponsible, Veldora, was also present.

While Beretta's position was bad, he was able to buy some time.

After that, he would just have to tell Rimuru what really happened and prove that he was not involved—but then he realized that the situation was much more serious than he had thought.

“This is bad. We have lost any connection with our world. The Different Gate has closed...”

“Yes. After all, we used the ample energy available deep within the labyrinth, and that's what kept the magic circle working. So it only makes sense that it could not continue to stay up in this world, where there is no energy.”

“Hey, master!? You sound very calm, but we will be able to get back, right?”

“Hmm...”

“What, are you serious? Beretta. What’s going on here!?”

“Didn’t I tell you? This is because you ignored Lord Rimuru’s warning and acted on your own...”

Beretta said with an exasperated shake of his head.

Veldora looked away and whistled unconcernedly.

He had actually expected the other world’s energy to be enough in maintaining the gate.

He had not expected this at all. That it would require energy on the other side as well.

“Wait! What! What! That makes it sound like it’s all my fault!!”

It was Ramiris and Veldora’s fault no matter what way you looked at it. And so it was a little horrifying that they weren’t conscious of it.

Or so Beretta thought, but he didn’t waste his time voicing it.

There were more important matters to deal with now.

“Hmm. What a predicament. Not only is there no energy, but the oxygen is also very thin. And there are places with some very serious pollution too?”

“Are you serious? Now that I think of it, it is quite cold. And dark...”

Ramiris now noticed it as well.

The sky was covered in thick clouds, covering the sunlight.

Because of this, the temperature on the ground was near freezing point.

While they did not require oxygen and had a resistance to toxins, it still did not feel very nice.

Besides—

“...Hey? What if there are no people here, or life of any kind? I was looking forward to communicating with different cultures, but it doesn’t look likely.”

Ramiris muttered with disappointment.

There was no point in coming to other worlds if there was no life there.

Still, it was possible they had just landed in a bad location, and she had not abandoned all hope just yet.

“This is really bad. This world is a miss.”

“There are ‘hits’ and ‘misses’ with worlds?”

Beretta asked.

“Hmm. Why wouldn’t there be?”

“Exactly. I told you. We came to look at other world cultures and try to search for something interesting!”

I see. Beretta was satisfied.

This place was polluted and the temperature was near the freezing point.

There wasn't much hope of there being intelligent life here, and so Veldora and Ramiris's wish was not likely to come true.

(I understand what they mean by 'miss.' However, to run such an operation alone and in secret...perhaps they just wanted to discover a new civilization first and brag about it to Lord Rimuru...)

Even as Beretta thought about this with exasperation, Veldora and Ramiris were having a conversation.

"Oh, I hate this. The cold aside, there isn't much spirit power here, which is weakening me. Besides, it's dark and all you can see in the distance is wild flatlands... It's, you know... Like those planets Rimuru knew about. Like Mars."

"Ohh...you know a lot, Ramiris. I was actually thinking the same thing."

"Right! Right!"

“Judging from how polluted this place is, maybe there was a nuclear war here!”

“Ohhh! Very impressive master! You sure know a lot!”

“Kaaaha—ahahahaha! Oh, you are exactly right about that!”

Veldora and Ramiris continued their carefree conversation.

As he listened to them, Beretta started to feel like it was stupid for him to think about this problem alone.

Still, there were certain things he needed to ask them. And so he waited for them to calm down before asking Veldora.

“So, Lord Veldora. Do you think it is possible for us to return?”

“Hmmm...”

Veldora took a long pause and closed his eyes to think.

Ramiris was also very interested in his answer, and so she waited quietly.

“In order to return, We will have to reopen the Different Gate that is three-hundred meters above our heads, or create a new one. If we do make a new come, we should have no trouble setting the coordinates due to being connected to Rimuru’s Soul Corridor...”

Then Veldora stopped as if he wanted them to ponder this.

In spite of appearances, Ramiris was a quick thinker, and she realized what it was Veldora was saying.

“I see! Even if we make a new gate, we can’t get it to open without energy?”

“Yes, exactly. Regardless of what we do, we need energy. And so I think the quickest method would be to release my aura and

fill the ground with energy. What do you think?”

Ramiris nodded as if in agreement.

Veldora was suggesting that he release his own aura. He had judged that with the immense amount of energy stored in his body, he could fill this world up with energy.

“Ohh! Good thinking, master. I know that you have a shocking amount of energy inside of you!”

“I see... It may be possible if you do it, Lord Veldora. However, won't it be a problem if you just go around changing the laws of this world like that?”

Unlike the carefree Ramiris, Beretta's observation was rather sharp.

And it was this point exactly, that had caused Veldora to hesitate.

If Veldora released his energy, there was a high possibility that it could mess up the ecological system of this world—this would be a breach of the rules that Rimuru had set in place when going to other worlds.

That being said, it would also be impossible for them to return without using a gate.

Veldora's 'Space Transfer' would not let him travel to other worlds.

“Well, if it's just me, I could just use Rimuru's 'Simultaneous Existence' and return by being born again over there! So it's no problem if I die here...”

“What!? But doesn't that mean only you can return?”

“Is that so bad?”

“Of course it is!!”

Ramiris was furious.

Veldora wasn't actually serious, but this suggestion was quickly dismissed.

Well, of course, it was.

“However, creating a new Different Gate will take a long time. I can prepare the necessary minerals, but I don't have enough of the other magic materials I would need. And if I had to start from scratch, well, who knows how long it would take...”

“Yes... It took years just to make the prototype...”

Beretta said nonchalantly, which caused Ramiris to hold her head in frustration.

In fact, there had been quite a few mishaps back when they were still testing it.

And as they had no facility here, it was not very realistic for them to create an entirely new gate.

It wasn't impossible, but it was exhausting just thinking about it.

“Right? And that's why I think it would be the quickest to just reactivate that thing.”

“Yes... If that's the case, we should have used a system that required you to infuse it with energy directly, and not have it gathered from the air...”

“Not only that, the storage type required extra magic circuits, which was a huge bother.”

“Yes. That's true...”

Then Beretta said as if suddenly remembering something.

“Wait a minute. We don’t need to panic. As the ‘Soul Corridor’ is still connected, won’t Lord Rimuru notice our absence and call us back?”

However, Veldora and Ramiris’s reaction upon hearing those words—

“Hahh. Oh, Beretta, you really don’t understand anything. We don’t want that to happen. That’s why we are trying so hard to think of a solution!”

“So true. Don’t you see? Rimuru will be angry if he finds out about what we’ve been doing! And you are just as guilty. Rimuru won’t return until a week at the earliest, and so we have to return and destroy the evidence before then!”

And so they completely rejected Beretta’s suggestion.

Still, it was incredibly simple and easy for him to understand.

Basically, they were frantic because they did not want to be

scolded.

Once he knew this, Beretta did not argue back. And so he quietly tried to think of what would be the best way to return.

At this point, Beretta was fully implicated.

Perhaps he was just too softhearted.

And so quite some time passed after that.

And then finally, all three of them looked into each others' faces, but none of them had had a good idea.

“Well then, does that mean we can go with my idea? Then we can just move along...”

There were no signs of intelligent life in this world. So there was no point in staying long. And it wasn't just Veldora who

thought this, as Ramiris agreed with him.

As for Beretta, he was just following orders now, and so had no reason to complain.

He was a little worried that they might continue their experiments once they returned, but he would worry about that when the time came.

Ramiris and Beretta showed their agreement, and so Veldora nodded.

And then, just as he was about to release the aura he had been holding in—

—The thunderous sound of an immense explosion overwhelmed the ground's surface, and they saw a mushroom-shaped cloud in the distance.

“Hmm!?”

“Ohh!!”

“That...is a sign of life...and it seems like they are fighting. Yes.”

Veldora and Ramiris looked at each other. They grinned and nodded.

“Our plan to return is temporarily on hold! Let’s go and see what’s happening!”

“Understood, master! I can’t wait to see what they are like!”

The two of them laughed over their shared interest in spectating.

Ramiris jumped onto Veldora’s shoulders.

And then the two of them, as if forgetting how depressed they

had been a moment ago, began to move in the direction of the explosion.

This master and apprentice were of one mind.

And—

The abandoned Beretta sighed deeply before he started to run after them at full speed.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 02

First Contact

Zaza's tongue clicked as it attempted to retreat from the combat zone.

Five of its subordinates were no longer detectable, and it was clear that they had been finished off.

The plan had failed.

Zaza had to attempt to return as quickly as possible in order to prevent any further casualties—in other words, its own death.

Zaza was a cyborg.

An important part of the fighting force of the resistance—Light of Dawn— that was able to move on the surface.

The surface world was polluted by poison.

Not only that, but apart from Zaza's own will, there was a setting that prioritized the command, 'return alive.'

And as a loyal warrior of the organization, Zaza obeyed the order.

Of course, Zaza also had a fear of death.

However, Zaza knew from experience that there would always be another chance as long as you lived.

"Damned bastards. They used the nuclear missiles without hesitation! I won't forget that you killed my team. And I will have my revenge!"

Zaza spat before leaving the area.

Battle-no, it was more of a one-sided assault-and Zaza was the only survivor.

They had come all this way. The five subordinates and the Remote Robot.

And yet they had all been so easily destroyed by the nuclear missile the enemy had used.

The Remote Robot had avoided destruction through the use of an electromagnetic pulse, but it was no longer usable after that.

The mission was a failure at that point.

They had lost their method of transportation, and so it was no longer possible to steal resources.

It was hard to even see.

The massive explosion had filled the air with dust.

There was nothing else to do.

Zaza decided to take advantage of the situation and escape while the enemy would have trouble seeing.

Furthermore, Zaza needed to hurry in order to avoid the flames that were closing in.

And so Zaza cautiously stayed away, all the while keeping an eye on the oxygen supply device that was inside of its body.

The device made if possible to extract oxygen from the atmosphere and store it, but on the surface, where radiation and poisonous gasses were thick, there was hardly any oxygen at all.

And so it was necessary for Zaza to return to the closest base before its supply of oxygen depleted.

And if that was not possible, then it would have no choice but to descend into the depth of the underground, where the pollution was relatively lighter.

But the underground world was dangerous. It was filled with

strange life forms that had mutated. It was something that Zaza would prefer to avoid.

“Thirteen hours left. That’s enough.”

Zaza was relieved by that.

This mechanical body hardly required any oxygen at all.

It wasn’t just synthetic muscle, but the chemical fibers that connected each part also expanded and retracted though electricity from an internal power reactor.

The only part that required oxygen was the ‘brain,’ which was encased in the head and the only part that was not synthetic.

The oxygen only had to be thinned and sent to the bio-solution storage cylinder.

A little oxygen could keep the brain running for a long time.

Zaza sighed after moving away from the area of the blast.

“Phew. No pursuers then. It seems that I was able to escape...”

Just as Zaza felt relieved...

An alarm went off in its head.

“...!?”

Zaza frantically jumped away.

Immediately after, just by the boulder that Zaza had been hiding behind, a rain of fire came down.

It was a blaster.

No sound. No presence—and yet the killing machine had approached Zaza.

It looked a lot like a doberman. However, it was not very cute. It was a horrifying killing machine.

Along with quick mobility and ability to hide, it had high pursuing ability that came from its multitude of sensors.

It was also known as the—Murder Dog.

It could run three times faster than the speed of sound and could even fly for a short time.

Its main weapon was the blaster, which currently rained down.

The heat rays were created in its throat and then unleashed at a temperature that ranged from thousands of degrees to tens of thousands.

As Zaza was a cyborg with thin armor plating, vaporization would occur instantly.

The best thing to do was to attack it at close range before it could unleash this attack, but that was not always realistic.

Besides, its fangs were also a great threat.

The fangs were a titanium alloy with an electric current running through them. A bite of those fangs would destroy the electromagnetic balance.

As long your body was ruled by electric signals, and your armor could not repel those fangs, there was no real way to deal with this opponent.

The Murder Dog could be said to be the mortal enemy of the Cyborg.

“Damn it! Three Murder Dogs!?”

Zaza's face twisted in despair.

It had only been by coincidence that the burning flames had made the Murder Dogs hot enough to be detectable by Zaza's heat sensors, allowing it to dodge the attack. But now that Zaza was surrounded, there was no escaping it.

In the first place, Zaza was not a model specialized for battle.

A fight against a Murder Dog was foolish from the very beginning.

"I'm sorry—it appears that fate would have me die here..."

Zaza gave up trying to escape, and dropped its head weakly.

Zaza said words of regret towards its dead subordinates and to those who waited back at the base. Then Zaza waited to die.

It would not take long for the three Muder Dogs to attack.



Veldora ran.

Ramiris sat on his shoulder.

Beretta ran beside them.

None of them looked tired as they made their way towards the site of the explosion.

As they moved, Ramiris began to talk in a thoughtless voice.

“Let me just say this! I don’t appear to be able to use any magic, so one of you must protect me!”

Well, it was quite important to her, so maybe calling it thoughtless was too much.

However, a magic user not being able to use magic. She was practically declaring that she was of no use in battle. And yet she acted as if it was no concern of hers. So one could not be blamed for thinking she was thoughtless.

However, there was, of course, a reason that Ramiris brought this up.

Beretta was a guardian and always acted in order to protect her.

She was not worried about that. The problem was with Veldora.

He may attempt to do a wide range, large-scale attack, supposing that Ramiris would use her protection magic.

That would be incredibly dangerous.

And so she had to say it now, or either herself or Beretta would get hurt.

“Hmm. Indeed. I have many methods of attack, but most of them cover a wide area. You really can’t make a barrier, Ramiris?”

“Actually, there is a very weak barrier up right now. But as there is no energy, I am worried about how much it can withstand...”

“You were always a weak one.”

“I’m not weak! It’s just that you and Beretta are strangely tough and way too strong!”

“Kaaa-ahahaha! Well, yes, I am the strongest indeed.”

“Hmm...hmp. I admit that you are amazing, master, but I think there is room for debate as to whether you are the strongest. I am quite impressive myself, when I care to try. If

you want, I can show you my forty-seven special moves?”

“Oh? How interesting. Yes, let’s see how useful your power can be!”

That was Veldora’s reaction to Ramiris’s words.

It really wasn’t the time for Ramiris to start boasting, but her dislike of losing did her no favors in this instance, and she said something she shouldn’t have.

In the first place, it didn’t matter how serious she got. Ramiris could never win against Veldora, and there was definitely no room for debate.

Ramiris herself understood this, and her eyes swam over to Beretta for help.

“Lord Ramiris. Your many wonderful skills and secret weapons should be saved for another time.”

Beretta said in a calm voice.

Many wonderful skills—he had said, but the truth was that he had never witnessed anything of the sort.

But Beretta was perceptive enough to leave that out.

“Uh, um, yeah. Yes, yes! It would be a waste to show my special attacks in a place like this!”

Ramiris was simple.

And so she quickly switched gears and nodded at Beretta.

Beretta smiled gently and then turned to Veldora.

“And Lord Veldora, don’t tease her too much.”

“Uh, yes. But, Beretta. Aren’t you too soft on Ramiris? I have a feeling that it’s because you spoil her that she becomes so full of herself...”

“Maybe it’s just your imagination?”

“Yes! Full of myself? I would never be like that!”

I don’t know why, but Beretta is always so cold towards me...
Thought Veldora.

However, he didn’t want to argue here, because it would be two against one.

In any case, it was indeed important that they think of safety measures while they were in this unknown world.

As Veldora agreed with this, he nodded and thought for a while before speaking.

“Alright. Alright. Then I will protect Ramiris. As for these special attacks you have, those can be saved for the very end.”

“G-got it. Yes, this attack is quite dangerous, so that would be for the best. Okay, so you can protect me then, master!”

“So Lord Veldora will guard Lord Ramiris and I will focus on attacking them.”

“Hmm. Perhaps it’s because I can’t sense any energy, but my ‘Universal Perception’ is not very sharp. Beretta, don’t let your guard down.”

“Understood.”

When all was said and done, Veldora was also very soft towards Ramiris.

And so in cases like this where there was danger, it usually ended with Veldora protecting her.

And-

Then the three of them encountered the battle.



I'm dead! Zaza closed its eyes as the fangs of the Murder Dog approached.

However-the moment did not arrive. There was only the sickening sound of hard metal scraping against hard metal.

(Hmm? What had happened?)

Zaza's eyes opened cautiously. An unfamiliar figure stood there.

(Who is that...? The shape was strange... Was it an Automata or a Machine Doll that was made for combat? Or perhaps...it

was also a Cyborg?)

Of course, it was only Beretta.

Though, it was no surprise that Zaza wouldn't be able to tell what it was.

After all, Beretta was a Chaos Metalloid, which did not exist in this world. But he looked like a doll with spherical joints.

Of course, the body was formed of Adamantite, and Beretta could freely mold it as he willed. It was like a fluid metal that allowed him to look like any other human.

However, Zaza knew none of this, and had no idea if Beretta was a friend or an enemy.

But in the moment, Zaza decided that it was very unlikely that Beretta was hostile.

After all, it had saved Zaza from the fangs of the Murder Dog.

“Hey, I don’t know who you are. But thank you. Those things have fangs with a special magnetic current...”

Zaza said that much before suddenly realizing something strange.

Why, the person who stood in front of him had the Murder Dog’s fangs lodged in his arm.

No.

The fangs were slowly being pushed out now.

Its arm was beautiful, like a work of art as the surface rippled like liquid, slowly pushing the fangs out.

And after it was finished, there wasn’t a single scratch left.

(Is this real!? I have never seen or heard of such a thing? What laboratory invented it!?)

Zaza was in shock.

And it didn't end there.

Right in front of the Murder Dogs, Beretta began to calmly talk to Zaza.

“...Analysis of language patterns complete. It seems that I can use ‘Thought Transmission’ even without energy, as long as I read your mind waves directly. Also—I believe I detected some unknown electromagnetic wave lengths. It was I who interrupted the fight, now...man or animal. Which one should I aid... I would prefer it if we could stop the fight for now and talk. What do you think?”

Beretta had been saying things that Zaza could not understand, but suddenly, he started to talk very smoothly in his language.

There was a strong will behind it, and Zaza felt that the stranger was more human than robot.

Beretta looked at his own arm to confirm that it was in good order.

The Murder Dog's fangs had really gone through Beretta's armor. But that didn't mean anything.

Beretta had transformed the shape in order to weaken the impact, molding it to the enemy's attack.

As for the electromagnetic waves... Beretta wasn't a precision machine, and so it had no effect at all.

It was a meaningless attack.

"Hey, you! This is no time to be talking like that! That thing is called a Murder Dog, and they are the strongest anti-human murder weapons. You can't run from its numerous sensors. You have to kill it!!"

Zaza shouted. Beretta raised a hand for silence and then said:

“You must calm down. For now, I shall guarantee your safety. And in exchange, you can tell me what I want to know.”

“Alright. I’ll tell you anything. But we have to run away—what!?”

Once Zaza had agreed to it, Beretta moved before Zaza could even finish.

It was so fast that Zaza could not even follow his movements.

And neither could the Murder Dogs.

The Murder Dogs were not going to wait for Zaza and Beretta to finish their conversation, and they moved to attack any in sight.

However, Beretta acted as if he had predicted this very thing.

And the fang attacks were no use against Beretta.

The Murder Dogs had advanced artificial intelligence, and so they analyzed the reason. But they did not find the answer.

No, before that...

The Murder Dogs weren't even aware of their situation, because they were destroyed too quickly.

—And that was more than enough for the people monitoring the scene to determine that Beretta was a threat.



The Murder Dog's master—Lieutenant Hiragi of the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine's southern security force, was

very shocked by this sudden event.

Recently, or as far as he could remember, even, no surface weapon had been able to go against the Murder Dog.

They were mobile weapons on four legs that moved three times faster than the speed of sound. Even the forty meter Monster Tank: Mammoth, which had once been the strongest weapon, was no match for it.

It had a 200mm Railgun as its main weapon, but it was difficult for it to target the small Murder Dogs, which were 1.5 meters in size.

And while they could have equipped them with the incredibly expensive super computing machines in order to auto-target them, the Murder Dogs were capable of dodging bullets that that moved at mach 7 speed.

All they would see is a rare reaction speed and amazing detection ability.

-But that wasn't the only reason the Murder Dogs were valuable.

While they could not fight for quite as long as the Monster Tanks, they outstripped them in many other ways.

The Blasters they were equipped with could easily tear through the armor of the Monster Tanks.

Once you allowed them to get close, the Cyborgs that protected the tanks would not be enough to deal with them.

After all, all it took was for their fangs to rip the armor open, and then the internal machinery would go haywire and become inoperable.

The Murder Dogs were not equipped with engines, instead, they were rechargeable. That was their one weakness, but it did not affect them much during combat.

They only had an ultra small output amplifier that could run

for 72 hours on a single charge—however, not if they went all out during combat.

As resources were currently very valuable, it was the development of weapons that were small yet deadly that became the key to becoming dominant in this new age.

The unbeatable Monster Tank had used a thermonuclear fusion engine which allowed it to move almost forever—but when ten Mammoths were destroyed by just one Murder Dog, the world's rules of weaponry were overwritten.

The age was now about miniaturization.

And for the last twenty years or so, the Murder Dog had remained the strongest of all.

It wasn't just against humans, they were known as the strongest weapons on the surface, period.

And yet...

This ‘thing’ had three of these high-performance Murder Dogs in front of him—determined they were hostile—and then ignored them in order to have a calm conversation with their prey.

It was a huge blow to Lieutenant Hiragi’s pride, but there were more important matters to deal with.

“Hey! Do you have the results for the analysis of that fight? Are you sure that the Murder Dog bit into that thing’s arm?”

“Yes. There is no mistaking it! However, we cannot confirm that it had any effect on the enemy...”

“I have completed my analysis as well. No abnormalities have been detected in the Murder Dog’s abilities. The system is normal!”

Ohhh. Lieutenant Hiragi groaned.

If there was nothing wrong with the system, then there was

only one answer.

–The enemy had nullified the Wave Blast from the Murder Dog's fangs.

(Impossible. But, who even...is this person? Could it–what if it is one of those Bionoids, who put a lot of importance in the utilization of life forms? But only a few people even know of that technology. And I have never heard of anyone being successful with it...)

Lieutenant Hiragi was troubled.

If he was correct in his guess, if the enemy really was a Bionoid, it would explain why the Wave Blast was ineffective.

After all, Bionoids involved a modification technology that took the human body and raised the power of the cell to the very limits.

It was a new technology that allowed you to convert all of

your cells to be identical and repair any part that had been destroyed.

It would be possible to adapt to any environment, turning you into a new type of human with evolved cells.

As these cells were all given individual roles and could calculate independently, an immense amount of data could be processed at once.

This meant incredible performance.

In spite of having the same capacity as the human brain, it could calculate at the same speed as the super computers on 100 meter battleships. Another way to look at it would be that it usually required a battleship of that size to maintain such a computer.

Aside from the abilities, it also came equipped with the still very secretive space dilation technology. And with the ultra miniaturized thermonuclear fusion reactor, it became a bio-weapon with extreme firepower.

It was like a dream. Like a lie.

–It went without saying, that Bionoids were a top secret within their country.

Lieutenant Hiragi shook his head in order to dismiss this suspicion.

Bionoids were really just a rumor. And there was no way that one would exist right here.

But then, what was that thing–

“Lieutenant Hiragi! The analysis of the enemy is complete! But...”

“What is it? Tell me!”

“Yes sir!! I have detected a change in the enemy’s energy

levels. It seems to be quite low usually, but it increased dramatically and at great speed when the Murder Dog attacked it. This is not possible according to what we know of thermonuclear fusion reactors!!”

“A-and how much power are we talking about?”

“From what was measured with the graph, it exceeds 100,000 kilowatts...”

“Impossible!!”

Lieutenant Hiragi said in shock.

That was two-hundred times more than the Murder Dogs—it was unbelievable.

In the first place, if it was using a thermonuclear fusion reactor to move, then it did not make any sense for the power to change like that.

It didn't make any sense.

The enemy must be a super weapon that used unknown technology—that was the most plausible.

Lieutenant Hiragi thought as much before giving his subordinates an order.

“Prioritize the study of this mysterious enemy's abilities. We can kill this rebel scum any time we want. But first, we must capture that thing that has technology even we are not aware of. And steal it for ourselves!”

“Yes, Sir!”

His order was promptly put into action.

And like that, this mysterious enemy—in other words, Beretta, had three Murder Dogs set on him once again.

Even if they did not get their answer this time, just watching the battle should give them a lot of combat data.

And so it had been decided that three Murder Dogs were not too much to lose.

And with that, Beretta and the Murder Dogs entered a true state of battle.

The result of which was that Beretta killed all three of them in the blink of an eye.



As the three dogs charged at him, Beretta prepared by thrusting both arms outward.

Immediately after, a sharp slab of ore shot out of the ground and pierced the first dog.

Simultaneously, Beretta's arm stretched out like a tentacle and skewered the other two dogs with its spear-like tip.

It was an attack that used 'Mineral Manipulation' from Beretta's Ultimate Gift, 'Deus Ex Machina,' and the Chaos Metalloid favorite, 'Liquid Metal.'

The Murder Dogs had been feared as the strongest weapons on the surface, but they were no match for Beretta.

And so the first contact on this world which they had visited without invitation, came to a close.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 03

Food Situation

Zaza was stunned.

It could not believe what was happening in front of its eyes.

Of course, Murder Dogs were known as the embodiment of fear, and Beretta had killed three of them in an instant, so it could not be helped.

(Is-is this real!? I cannot believe it...)

Without being able to accept it, Zaza stood in shock.

Then a voice sounded from behind Zaza.

“Kaaaa—hahahaha! Oh, Ramiris, I have found a survivor! We thought this world was a miss, but there may even be other life if we look for them.”

“Hmmm. Master. That’s fine and all, but my whole body feels tingly and it hurts...”

Zaza jumped and then turned around.

A beautiful brown-skinned man with blonde hair was standing there.

Not only that, he looked natural, as if his body had not been altered at all. He just wore casual clothes and stood there.

Of course, it was Veldora.

“He-hey, you! Are you crazy!? You can’t dress like that with all of the radiation!?”

Zaza could not help but shouting. And Zaza could not be blamed.

Veldora's clothing was completely abnormal.

In fact...

This entire surface world was full of danger.

There was the thin oxygen and poison in the atmosphere.

The reason that the enemy could use nuclear weapons without regard over the destruction of the environment was that the environment was already polluted beyond repair.

This world was already on its way, at a rapid speed, towards destruction.

But there were those who had a will to fight this fate and created an organization. The resistance that Zaza was a part of—Light of Dawn—.

“Hahaha. Isn’t it cool? This outfit was designed by Rimuru and made by Shuna. What do you think?”

“Who cares about how you look? More importantly, this thing about thick radiation has an ominous ring to it. And my body kind of hurts. It’s important, so I’m going to say it again. It’s tingling and painful!!”

It was here that Zaza noticed another strange thing about Veldora.

A voice. Something was sitting on Veldora’s shoulder and saying they felt pain–Zaza’s eyes went to Ramiris and widened.

“No, no. This is not about pain! Are you really fine...? And what is that small thing!?”

Ramiris ignored Zaza and continued to wail.

“Hey, master! I just remembered something. Didn’t Rimuru say that radiation was bad for human bodies!”

“It should be fine, I think? He said that it was fine if it was only a small amount. After all, if the sunlight is fine, then there should be no problem...”

“Hey, wait! Wait! It may be fine for someone like you, since you can live outside of the atmosphere, but it’s bad for a weak fairy like me! And that young man over there just said that it was very dense!!”

“Hey, don’t cry like that. Oh, well. I shall make a little barrier then and nullify this radiation thing...”

Veldora mumbled excuses against Ramiris’s complaints as he started to strengthen the barrier.

Fairies took damage from radiation? Zaza wondered about this, but decided not to ask.

Ramiris finally regained her calm after Veldora was finished.

If she really had been taking damage, it would already be too

late for her. But seeing as that was not the case, it was clear that she had been imagining the pain because she was scared.

“I was wondering, master... If you can do that, I would have liked it if you did it in the beginning. Didn't I tell you? You're supposed to protect me! Oh, I knew it. I should have had Beretta protect me instead...”

“Let go of it already. I will do better next time. Don't worry about it.”

“Really? Are you sure? You better mean it!?”

Veldora and Ramiris continued their bickering as Zaza stood in shock once again.

Ultimately, Veldora gave in and the matter was settled.

But while they talked, Zaza was so stunned that he could not open his mouth.

He didn't know what to do, and his reasoning could not keep up with the situation.

And so it was Beretta, who had killed the Murder Dogs in an instant, who spoke first.

“I meant to capture them, but they were accidentally destroyed. This is not good. I tried to use magic to restrain them at first, but I could not activate it. There is no energy here. Not being able to use magic means that I will have to completely rethink the way I fight. But it is so hard to adjust...”

Beretta said as he finished inspecting the destroyed Murder Dogs before standing up.

Veldora and Ramiris heard him and stopped their fighting.

At the same time, Zaza realized that what was happening now was not a dream, and he was finally able to speak.

“He-hey. I don't know what is happening here, but you have

my thanks for saving me. But this place is dangerous. I want to retreat to a safe area. Will you people come with me? I would like to repay you and ask some questions...”

“Oh? Would this place happen to have other intelligent creatures—that is, humans?”

“Yes. We will have to take a longer route in order to avoid being followed, but my comrades will be there.”

Veldora and Ramiris listened to him and then looked at each other and nodded.

If there were others here, then there would surely be someone who knew a lot about the culture of this world.

And so they decided to follow Zaza.

Beretta had known them for long enough to see what they were thinking, and so he obeyed without any objections.

“Very well. We have things we would like to ask as well. You may lead us to this place then!”

Veldora said, representing the others. Zaza nodded.

As for Zaza, he did not completely trust these two–three, including Ramiris–just yet.

But he decided that if the Empire had sent these three for the purpose of finding their hideout, then they would not have gone as far as to destroy three very expensive Murder Dogs.

(As angry as it makes me, three Murder Dogs would be worth more to them than being able to crush us...)

This was his conclusion after giving it some thought.

And so like that, Veldora and the others were led by Zaza to the hidden abode of the resistance organisation, the Light of Dawn.



While on the road, they introduced themselves to Zaza.

Though, Zaza did not appear to take Veldora's bold claim, that they had come from another world, very seriously.

However, he did not pry any further.

(Maybe they just want to hide the truth. After all, they have such advanced weapons...)

That's what Zaza thought.

He looked at Beretta and felt that his will was to obey Veldora's orders.

And then there was that miniature Automata called Ramiris.

But then again, he was not even sure if she was an Automata.

To Zaza, this Ramiris seemed like it was the result of unbelievable technology.

It was only about 30 centimeters tall and it sat on Veldora's shoulder...

“What’s wrong with you? You’ve been staring at me all this time. Don’t tell me you have fallen in love? Well, I am quite cute, so it would be no surprise. But too bad! I am not that kind of girl!”

Ramiris laughed haughtily. She had clearly misunderstood something.

Zaza looked away.

“See? Even the people of this world are no match for my allure!”

She began to boast to Veldora.

(What kind of mechanism? I've never heard of a cyborg of that size. Is it a robot then? No, those smooth movements are that of an Automata. It was saying something about pain earlier, so it must have some kind of sensory organ replicate. But an Automata of that size... No, more importantly, I have never heard of such advanced artificial intelligence. Is it a brain transplant? Or...Memory Install...!?)

Zaza thought all this while giving a sideways glance. He decided that there was no way that Ramiris was an artificial intelligence.

Surely it was not possible for even an advanced program to think and react just like a human.

Well, maybe it was possible if you had the same ability to process information that the quantum computers aboard the Empire's battleships had... But it was surely not possible on something as small as Ramiris.

(I feel like I am going crazy. This cannot be real...no, wait?)

Then Zaza thought of something.

(That's it! If they used the rumored space expansion technology to compress and store the brain...)

This person called Ramiris must have transplanted her brain into this small Automata—that is what Zaza started to believe.

It answered a lot of questions he had had.

(Yes, I see. So this Ramiris person is the most important among them. And this defense cyborg called Veldora and the combat weapon that is Beretta are here to protect her...)

There were too many things that were unclear, and so Zaza came to this conclusion.

Of course, he had thought a little too much about it, and had ended up reaching a conclusion that was completely wrong.

To begin with, Veldora had not told a single lie.

They had come from a different world, just as he had explained.

However, considering that the scientific ability of this world, where there was no actual confirmation of other worlds existing, Zaza had to believe that they were fugitives who had escaped from some laboratory.

And it was this that led to his great misunderstanding.

That being said, it was not exactly something that would lead to much trouble...

All it resulted in was Ramiris getting a little carried away and Veldora sulking.



“...and so, this here is Ramiris. And this is Veldora and Beretta. They saved me from the Empire’s Murder Dogs.”

The person who Zaza explained this to was Sharma, a mid-level executive in the organization.

She was a middle-aged woman whose appearance suggested gentleness.

The other person, who was standing behind Sharma, was a nervous-looking man in his thirties whose name was Rindo.

As Sharma and Rindo were ordinary people, they looked their age.

While he looked like he was in his twenties, Zaza was a cyborg, and actually much older.

However, Zaza was with the line troops, and so he answered to Sharma, who managed them.

They were currently at one of the bases of the resistance organization—Light of Dawn—that Zaza had led them to.

It was not very far from the underground shelter that was their main base.

They had moved through the maze-like underground passages to get here, careful to make sure that they were not followed.

The reason that there were only two people to greet them was because Light of Dawn were wary of Veldora and the others.

Zaza had sent a report electronically in advance. But of course, Light of Dawn did not feel that the strangers could be trusted until they saw them with their own eyes.

While the strangers may have killed three Murder Dogs, Rindo felt that it could still be a trap by the Empire, and his

opinion held a lot of weight.

Zaza trusted Veldora and the others, but it was not so easy for those at the top.

And so Veldora now sat on a chair that was facing the three others.

Behind him Beretta stood and Ramiris sat on his shoulder, just like she always did.

“I see. It is too bad that Jitta and the others died. But we are lucky to have you back, Zaza. And we have you three to thank for it. Thank you for saving our comrade, Zaza.”

After hearing Zaza’s story, Sharma bowed deeply and thanked them.

Rindo kept silent and continued to observe Veldora and the others.

Veldora did not seem to mind as he began to laugh.

“Kaa-hahahahaha! Oh, it was really nothing. In any case, Sharma. Are there more people in this place that you live in?”

“Yes. Almost a thousand... But not many of them are warriors...”

Sharma said in a vague, guarded voice.

She was not sure what reason Veldora had for asking this question.

As for Rindo, who stood behind her, he narrowed his eyes at Veldora now.

(...Hmm, I see. So they are targeting our base after all. It will be dangerous to tell them of our fighting force...)

That's what Rindo decided.

But...

“Only one thousand? That's hardly anything. Is it a small village? In that case, I don't know if we can expect any good food or amazing art that would draw our interest.”

“Master, I guess this world is a miss after all. I mean, they seem too busy with their war to build an interesting culture.”

“Hmm... You are probably right. But, well...we should still check it out anyway.”

“That's true. We came all this way, after all...”

That is what Veldora and Ramiris started to say upon hearing Sharma's answer.

Rindo could not hide his confusion.

It was not what he had expected at all.

Their purpose was the search for new entertainment. They had no interest in their military power at all—but as Rindo knew none of this, he was left to be confused.

“Oh, right-right. We still haven’t finished thanking you yet. We cannot offer you much, but we prepared a little meal for you. I’ll bring it right now.”

Zaza seemed to have sensed the awkward atmosphere, and he said this as if to help lighten things up.

This was one of their bases, and it had the facilities for several people to live here for a few weeks.

Food was very valuable at this time, but as long as there was a need to monitor the Empire, it was necessary to keep this place stocked.

And yet Zaza meant to serve this valuable food to Veldora and the others.

It was his way of showing his appreciation.

Zaza prepared the food himself and set it out in front of them.

However–

“I do not require food. Ramiris, you can eat it if you want.”

“Oh, really? Thank you.”

“Hmph. So you do spoil her after all, Beretta? Oh, well...”

He did not need food–but that meant he could eat it–and yet Beretta pushed his food towards Ramiris.

Veldora watched this with jealous eyes, but the real problem occurred after that.

“Let’s eat then! Huh, what is this? It feels like playdough and has no taste! And this water is muddy!?”

“...Disgusting. What is this tablet?”

“Hey! Hey! What is the meaning of this!? Are you trying to bully me?”

“Exactly! Someone as great as I will not allow this insult to go unpunished!!”

To Veldora and Ramiris, the food was of unbelievably low quality.

It wasn’t poison.

It was actually very well balanced in terms of energy.

However, it did not seem like the kind of thing to give to guests as a show of gratitude.

Hate based off of food was strong. And Veldora and Ramiris were very gluttonous.

They had been served something inedible, and now the fires of rage burned hot within them.

Zaza became frantic.

“Hey, hey. Please wait! This is our precious ‘water,’ ‘energy tablet’ and ‘solid food’! Taste? Who would ask for something so luxurious!?”

Zaza was truly shocked as he fired back at Veldora and Ramiris.

Their resources were so scarce now, and a single meal was very valuable.

One of the reasons that they attacked the Empire was so that they could take food supplies from the enemy's food production plants.

In this situation, taste was hardly important.

They were lucky to be able to eat enough to survive.

As a cyborg, Zaza only needed a cup of water and one energy tablet to run for an entire day.

However, this was not the case for most of the residents. A full meal consisted of water, energy tablet and solid food. It was the bare minimum for them to survive.

It was the same for Automata, who had enhanced cells through cultivation.

Unless the majority of your body was a machine, like Zaza, you had to consume valuable food resources.

Zaza was so serious that even Veldora and Ramiris saw that it was not a joke or an attempt to offend them.

“Ramiris. Perhaps this food really is incredibly valuable to these people...”

“That’s a surprise, master... He wouldn’t be lying, would he?”

Ramiris and Veldora looked at each other with amazement.

Just then, Sharma opened her mouth with a gentle expression.

“Calm yourself, Zaza. It seems that the food was not to our guests’ liking. But this is the best that we can do. And...if you don’t mind, may I ask you one thing?”

She sounded gentle, but firm.

And she was now looking straight at them.

“Yes. Ask whatever you like.”

Veldora said. And so Sharma did.

“Then let me ask you this. You put the tablet in your mouth just now. Does that mean you do not know how to eat it? I am sure you find me rude, but can you answer me that?”

She said.

Zaza and Rindo were more surprised than Veldora and Ramiris by this question.

“Sharma, what did you just say?”

“No, no. I am a cyborg with no taste buds, but normally... Now that I think of it, you took the solid food and... What? Could it really be...?”

Veldora and the others had no idea what Sharma meant.

“How to eat it? What are you talking about?”

“Huh? What’s wrong with just putting it in your mouth?”

They were very confused.

After that, Sharma demonstrated it for them.

While it was fine to just swallow the tablet, it was considered normal to mix it in with the solid food.

The tablet dissolves into the dough and adds some flavour to it.

“These tablets are incredibly expensive tablets that allow you to enjoy five different flavors. The taste changes with every bite.”

Sharma explained as she demonstrated.

Oh! Veldora and Ramiris were quite impressed, and they imitated her.

As Veldora had already swallowed his tablet, he put Ramiris’s tablet into his solid food and mixed it. Then they tasted it together.

As for the result...

“Oh? It’s not bad at all.”

“Hohoho. Very interesting. It sends false information to your tongue and makes you think it has taste. I think it would be quite fun to research this as a gag toy.”

They were both quite excited by this new food experience.

“I am relieved that you enjoy it.”

“Yes. It is very interesting indeed. By the way, does the taste change if you put it in water?”

Veldora’s curiosity was limitless.

He wondered if the muddy, odorous water would be drinkable if the tablet were mixed with it.

However, the answer was most disappointing.

“This tablet does not dissolve very well in water.”

“Aye. Didn’t you taste it earlier when you bit into it directly? It tastes very bad if you take it by itself. And us cyborgs, who do not require solid food, will swallow it down with some water.

There are also ways to remove your taste buds, but that is quite sad.”

Sharma denied it and Zaza explained in detail.

So cyborgs still had taste buds.

There were some who discarded it as unnecessary, but not Zaza.

Zaza took out a taste ball—which was an incredibly expensive luxury item—and showed it to them.

“This thing send low-frequency waves to stimulate your tongue. Feeling it with your tongue cause special electric signals to be sent to your brain. It won’t satisfy your hunger, but it’s an important thing in keeping what’s left of your humanity.”

Veldora and Ramiris watched Zaza explain this with dazzled eyes.

“Master, master!”

“Don’t get ahead of yourself, Ramiris. I understand your excitement at this, but you must calm down.”

But they were both very excited.

Beretta was calm and stood quietly behind them.

Sharma looked at the three of them and thought.

(–I do not understand these people. Did they really not know? But if they were lying. Why? I cannot understand it and...)

In her fifty years of life, Sharma had never eaten anything but this food.

It had the perfect nutritional balance, kept you from getting underweight or overweight and made it difficult for you to get

sick.

And so it was not like Sharma at all, that she now felt like asking them about it.

She waited for them to calm down a little and then asked them quietly.

“Hehe. But I am quite interested. If you do not know how to eat this, what kind of food do you normally eat?”

If these two had been lying to her, what would they say now?

What lies could they have prepared—she wondered.

However, the answer that Sharma received exceeded anything she could have ever imagined.

“Oh, you mean like cookies or cakes? I also like eating fruits as

they are, but the tarts that Shuna makes are even better!”

“Ramiris, those are snacks! For food, I like tempura a lot!”

“Yes, tempura is delicious! If that’s what we’re talking about, I like barbecued meat and hamburger steaks too!!”

Veldora and Ramiris seemed to be fighting over who could offer the most answers to Sharma’s question.

However, none of the words had any meaning to Sharma.

These dishes did not exist in this world—to be precise, they stopped existing three generations ago.

Only Zaza, who was the oldest of the three, knew what Ramiris meant when she said cookies.

He understood.

(Cookies? Yes, before the war started... I had assumed that such things did not exist anymore, but what if we were to search? No, no, if there were any left, they would be in the center of the imperial city... So is that where they came from...?)

Zaza wondered.

But as if to disregard the confusion that Zaza was currently feeling, Ramiris did something most unexpected.

“Oh, right! I thought something like this might happen...!!”

Ramiris shouted. Then she cast magic on the cup that was on the table.

The cup was half her size, but it now floated up into the air where it was enveloped by a sphere of water and purified.

“Yes, yes. My spirit power is weak, but I can still do this much.”

She nodded with satisfaction, and then pulled out a bottle that was the same height as herself.

It was a thermos.

It contained some hot tea that had been made beforehand.

“Ramiris. I would also prefer some tea over this muddy water.”

“Okay! How about you? Do you want to drink it too?”

Sharma and the others were stunned by what they had just witnessed.

“Huh? What?”

“Hey, wait! What just happened? Water is so...no, but...!?”

“Is it a trick? An illusion? No, it can’t be...”

None of them could understand it, and they reacted with confusion.

“Okay! Then you guys can have some too!”

Ramiris interpreted their reactions as assent, and so she purified their cups without waiting for further answer.

The cups and plates were all sucked into the sphere of water that appeared in the air.

And then after a few seconds, cleanly washed cups and plates were lined up on the table.

Ramiris ignored the shocked spectators and then took something else out of her breast pocket and put it on the table.

“Look at this! It’s some snacks I smuggled in!”

It was pound cake and cookies.

She served them on each plate.

And the cups were filled with steaming and fragrant tea.

“Alright then. Let’s eat!”

And with that, Ramiris began to eat the food that was quite huge relative to her size.

Veldora happily grabbed a cookie and shoved it into his mouth.

Then he nodded with satisfaction.

“Mmm. Yes, this is the stuff. Oh, please don’t be so modest. Eat up.”

Veldora said, encouraging Sharma and the others to eat, as they were still frozen.

Upon hearing this, Sharma and the others began to move, even though the situation felt too bizarre to be real.

Zaza moved first.

He looked away from the plate of cookies and pound cake, saying, ‘I do not require food...’ and his hand went for the tea.

He took a sip and closed his eyes.

(It’s real... How nostalgic. But that means...)

He realized what it meant, and he suddenly opened his mouth.

“Sharma. Rindo. Let me warn you—you must be prepared if you are going to eat this.”

“Is it...poison?”

Rindo said cautiously.

But Sharma knew what he meant.

“Oh. I see...Zaza. So it is real...”

She muttered under her breath.

And then she continued.

“However, we have a duty to eat this food. After all, it was without a doubt I who asked them about what they usually eat. And I must take responsibility for my actions...”

Sharma said. And then she quickly grabbed one of the cookies as if to allow no hesitation to come over her.

And then she put it into her mouth.

It was so deep and spread so wide. This unknown taste.

It wasn't the artificial flavor that deceived. It wasn't electric signals. It was real taste.

This was the true thing that fulfilled one of the three great desires of humans.

It wasn't about gaining energy. It was about satisfying the soul.

It was the first time Sharma realized this truth.

And as for Rindo...

“I cannot allow you to carry all the weight. I too will learn of the truth.”

Veldora and Ramiris watched this display and wondered why they were exaggerating so much. Rindo cut himself a piece of pound cake and brought it to his mouth.

And–

(...Impossible!? Is this what real taste is...!!)

He was shocked.

It was as if everything he had ever known was a lie.

The first thing that had filled Rindo’s heart was a sense of mistrust towards Veldora and the others.

He had thought that they were spies from the Empire that had

been sent to find their hideout.

However, they turned out to be very strange.

As he wondered about this, they had then ridiculed the food that had been offered as a show of gratitude.

After that, Rindo's heart became full of rage towards them.

But the ability to calmly make decisions was always required of him, and so he had repressed these emotions and watched silently...and now, the small girl called Ramiris had served them food.

The distrust. The rage. The shock.

Rindo's heart swayed between the emotions in confusion.

Where had the thermos and snacks from from? And the

thing—the magic that Ramiris had used—what was that?

It would take immense power to gather the water from the atmosphere like that... Was this miniature Automata really that powerful?

How did it work?

And if they used this technology, could they create lots of water?

Would they be able to solve their very serious concern regarding water shortages...?

There was no end to his questions.

And not only questions, but ambitions.

But he pushed all these thoughts and questions aside for now

in order to follow Sharma in eating the food—and that was when all his questions were blown away.

The insult of having their precious water referred to as mud water—he understood it now, with the tea in front of him.

Ah, damn it all! So this was what the real stuff was like.

He had not known.

He should not know...

But now that he did, he would have to eat the imitation that could never satisfy him, and bear it.

—Yes, it had happened already. He could feel it.

(Ahh. And Zaza knew it more than anyone...)

Rindo now understood the meaning behind Zaza's warning earlier.

Zaza was an older cyborg model, and so he had had to bear this pain for over a hundred years.

He had known some of it, but he had no idea what that pain might feel like.

And now he would be just the same as him...

"Zaza. Do you mind if I ask you something?"

"Ah. What is it, Rindo?"

Zaza answered with a look of concern.

But he knew what the question would be...

“A long time ago...were such wonderful foods accessible for everybody?”

It was exactly what Zaza had expected.

“...Yes. My daughter once baked me cookies. They were good. Very good. Even if they were a little burnt and odd in shape... but it’s not about those things. There was a warmth...”

Rindo nodded and thought about it.

The food in front of them made Zaza’s argument so much stronger.

He had never heard of Zaza having a daughter before, but it seemed rude to ask about it.

The fact that he had not mentioned her before suggested that the war had...

And then Rindo began to mutter to himself.

“Why. This war, why did it...”

The thirty-year old Rindo and the fifty-year old Sharma were forced into this lifestyle because of the scars left by the war.

The responsibility for this was with their parents’ generation. Or perhaps the generation before that.

He knew that it was pointless to complain about it now, but he could not help but think in this way.

They had to attack the Empire’s food producing plants and steal—that’s what they had to do to survive in this world.

They purified the polluted water and secured the bare minimum.

Luxury was not permitted. Everyone worked together in their desperate struggle to survive.

And this was all possible because they didn't even know what luxury was.

But now that he did, he could not help but hate the 'great war' which was the reason they were now suffering...

"I'm sorry... It was because we were weak..."

"No, I'm the one who is sorry. I got a little excited..."

Rindo accepted Zaza's apology.

Zaza was not at fault here, but it seemed like the natural thing to do.

The air in the room felt very oppressive now.

“Hey, hey. Master...”

“What is it...Ramiris?”

“Did I do something wrong?”

“Uh, yes. I tried to stop you, remember?”

“No you didn’t! You were happily eating the cake!!”

“Tha-that’s not true. Well, nevermind that...”

“But that’s important! Oh, well...”

The two culprits became frantic.

They began to whisper to each other so that Sharma and the others could not hear.

“...If they like it so much that they can cry, maybe we should give them more?”

Ramiris started to suggest, but Beretta stopped her.

“Lord Ramiris, I do not think you should do that. Lord Rimuru will not be pleased.”

“Why?”

“It is irresponsible. Lord Rimuru believes that interactions with other words must be conducted with the utmost caution. We are already involved enough as it is. If we go in any deeper, we will be held responsible for these people. And it is unthinkable that we could choose a side when we do not even know which side is for true justice in this world.”

Beretta was warning her—if she had no intention of looking after them after this, then she should not give them any false hope.

It would not be difficult for Ramiris to prepare food for a thousand people.

However, it would not continue on forever.

Only a demon would do something so irresponsible when they had no intention of taking care of them until the end without receiving anything in return.

Beretta was a former demon, and so he knew more than anyone, the pain felt by humans when dropped into the pits of despair from the heights of joy.

“...That’s true. Okay. I shall be more careful.”

“That would be for the best. At least, we should learn more about the situation in this world before choosing to side with these people.”

Veldora and Ramiris looked at each other and nodded after hearing Beretta’s warning.

It may already be too late, but neither of them wanted to create more reasons for Rimuru to get angry.

And so the two of them took Beretta's opinion into account and then used Thought Transmission to talk about what direction to take from there.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 04

The Empire's Reasons and Okonomiyaki

Colonel Gratham looked nervous as he bowed to the person on the other side of the screen.

It was Lieutenant General Michelle, the highest in command of the southern security force.

So it was no surprise that Colonel Gratham was nervous.

Not only was Lieutenant General Michelle the highest in command of the southern security force, but she was the Governor-General of South City.



Before the great war, this world was separated into seven 'cities.'

The cities were complete sustainable cities that were the product of the best technology of the time.

The population was fifty million.

The whole world worked together to create this dream-like robotic utopia.

In these complete cities, humans did not need to work.

To be precise, under the total control of artificial intelligences, they had a comfortable life guaranteed for them.

There was only a small number of people that helped manage the cities and decided the direction they would take. All of the other labour was done by machines.

People had the bare minimum when it comes to clothes, food and shelter and were also able to enjoy public entertainment.

This was promised to all fifty million citizens.

However–

The entire population of the world was actually ten billion.

Due to a rise in population, the world was becoming oversaturated.

There were those who were promised comfort and those who were not.

Only a small fraction of those ten billion would be chosen as residents of paradise.

So perhaps it was no surprise that hatred would be born from this difference.

The plan to build these cities continued to be carried out by

the one world government.

But before they were finished, there were those who raised their voices in discontent.

They were blind to their own laziness, no, perhaps it was because of their laziness, that they despised and hated those who would be allowed to live in the cities.

Wars often occurred over small things, when thoughtless people are quick to anger.

Faster than the computers had predicted, the environment began to change, and water shortages began to become desperate.

The predictions that there would be mass starvation before the rest of the cities were complete started to look like a reality. It was then that it happened.

Riots.

Those who could not get into the cities began to attack.

These riots spread throughout the world, and the flames of violence began to grow.

And turn to war.

–And now.

Of the seven original ‘cities,’ only five remained.

This was the territory of the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine.

Almsbine, the supreme leader of the cities’ administration was made Emperor, and the surviving citizens were made subjects of the empire who would guard its territories as soldiers.

It was the best way to live in this harsh environment.

Everyone had agreed to this.

The city where the first riot had occurred—it was the last place to be rebuilt as plans had been delayed, and so after the riots, it became the first place to be hit with nuclear bombs.

As the rioting citizens had gone deep within the city, the defense system was not able to activate.

The other cities were so alarmed by this that they immediately cut off contact with surrounding cities and became independent.

Even amongst nuclear war, they were able to survive through their defense systems.

Once the war was finished, there was one city that tried to reconcile all the survivors.

This 'city' that accepted survivors of the nuclear war for humanitarian reasons, were then attacked by those they tried to

save. And the city fell.

It was at this point that the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine decided that they would trust no one outside of their city.

This definitive event happened not one year after the end of the war.

Those who could not live in the cities ended up living in the vast underground shelters.

These shelters spread out through the undergrounds of the whole world, but they were not environments where people could live for long.

Furthermore, animals who escaped to them mutated into beasts. It was a place that seemed to reject human life.

Eventually, the beasts started to evolve to have super abilities, and became too big a threat for humans who were not armed.

The humans of this world were on a fast course for destruction.

The population that was once ten billion was now just a few hundred million.

And yet the places where humanity could survive were very limited, and it was not enough to house everyone.

And so the survivors of this world were forced to fight for the chance of continued survival.

–It wasn't about what was right or wrong. It was just a base survival instinct–



The Governor-General of the five remaining 'cities'—that was immense power.

In other words, she was the queen of South City.

Her cold blue eyes shone with an unshakable will.

Her light blonde hair was cut slightly above the shoulders as if to accentuate her fastidiousness.

Beautiful and cool, it was the perfect image to make her subordinates firm believers in her.

Judging by her appearance, you might wonder if she was even twenty years old.

Had she gained her position through her blood ties...

However, such assumptions would be considered laughable to those who knew her.

After all, Michelle was undoubtedly one of the monsters.

Her official name was Machinery Four–Michelle.

She was one of the strongest of the Empire.

Michelle heard the report and sighed.

Regardless of how polluted the word already was, using nuclear weapons, the most infamous of the old weapons, was overstepping one's authority.

However, her expression did not change, and she hid her anger from showing.

“–We shall consider the possibility that the resistance have developed new weapons later. So, what have you done since then?”

Asked Michelle's adjutant, Jegyll, as she gave Colonel Gratham a hard stare from the other side of the screen.

Jegyll was a young woman with a long history with Michelle.

She had the kind of sharp eyes that kept men away.

Even Colonel Gratham, who was twice her age, became uncomfortable under her stare.

“Yes! According to the report, they had currently formed a party to pursue them and to search for their base. As for the mysterious weapon, they have been told to capture it if possible.”

Michelle furrowed her eyebrows when she heard Colonel Gratham’s reply.

She wondered who they could have possibly sent that could stand against an enemy that killed three Murder Dogs at once.

Michelle was against the use of soldiers as disposable objects, and there was no way that Colonel Gratham was not aware of it.

In that case, it would make sense to think that he had sent a sizable force...

“...Colonel Gratham. Did you perhaps send the armored troops led by Second Lieutenant Karman?”

Michelle said as she sat coolly in her chair.

Colonel Gratham looked a little surprised. But then he smiled confidently and answered her.

“Yes! You are very perceptive! Furthermore, First Lieutenant Hiragi is continuing the combat analysis, so they should be prepared for anything.”

Colonel Gratham said with a bow, but Michelle was even more angry now.

As the person who was the highest in command of the south security force, she knew well the names, abilities and personalities of her subordinates.

When she considered all of it together, the only thing that fit with Colonel Gratham's ability to act, was the armored troops.

That being said, it was actually the worst possible action in Michelle's mind.

Colonel Gratham had said that they were prepared, which was him hinting at the possibility of defeat, yet the problem went further back than that.

First Lieutenant Hiragi and Second Lieutenant Karman.

These two did not work well together at all.

It wasn't that they didn't like each other. If anything, it was the opposite.

They had very similar personalities and the success rate of an operation went up if they worked together.

It might seem like a favorable point then, but the problem was in the process.

Just as there had been a report of Second Lieutenant Hiragi using nuclear weapons without hesitation, the two of them did not act with any regard towards damage.

They only pursued results.

Of course, they did make an attempt to minimize casualties towards their own. However, there was no such regard for the enemy.

They did not think of the circumstances of others, and only cared about completing the task they were given.

First Lieutenant Hiragi was obsessed with research and had no mercy when it came to operations.

Second Lieutenant Karman was obsessed with battle and pursued victory alone.

It was said that when these two teamed up, the battlefield would grow increasingly brutal.

Perhaps these were not reprehensible traits for the military.

However, Michelle could not make herself like these two.

She would even go as far as to say she disliked them.

In general, Michelle was against murder.

As was clear from the name, Southern Security Force, their purpose was to maintain peace.

It wasn't the annihilation of the resistance.

They were a part of humanity and may have been their comrades had things been a little different, or so Michelle thought.

It was just that their positions had ended up a little different...

Of course, as long as the cities had limited capacity, there was no question of letting them in.

They would not go down the same path as that city that had been destroyed.

And so, in spite of her feelings, Michelle had agreed to all of the operations that her subordinates had submitted.

Even if a report came that said nuclear weapons had been used, she did not complain that it was going too far.

While she didn't see the resistance as an enemy, they were not friends or allies either.

It was only natural for them to prioritize the residents of the city and her subordinates.

And-while it was not public knowledge, there were informants within the resistance.

Indirectly offering them abandoned food processing plants, having them attack unarmed food storages...

They were roundabout ways, but Michelle had done what she could to give the resistance just enough to survive.

And now...

She sank into her chair and closed her eyes to think.

It was not possible that the resistance could have developed a new weapon.

There had been no reports from their informants, and the resistance did not have the resources.

In that case, could it be someone from the other cities...or...

(Was there a laboratory that had survived? It wasn't impossible... But unlikely. No, perhaps...)

She stopped thinking about the abilities of the enemy and instead tried to predict what would happen from here.

First Lieutenant Hiragi was not likely to allow them to escape.

In that case, the resistance base might already have been discovered.

And with Second Lieutenant Karman there as well, the place would turn into a battlefield.

There were problems with Second Lieutenant Karman's personality, but it was quite the opposite in terms of combat ability.

The armor unit consisted of five of their best soldiers who wore powered suits.

These cyborgs that had been altered through the power of science, were now even stronger with the help of the powered suits.

Among them, Karmen was exceptional. A genius.

Stronger even than the Murder Dogs.

It was very likely then that the powerless people in their hiding places would be murdered.

(I believe that nearly a thousand live in a single base. So it would not be hard for them to kill them all...)

Michelle came to a decision after a few seconds of thought.

“...Our biggest priority is understanding the abilities of the mystery enemy. While the resistance are not a threat, we cannot ignore them if they have something that is stronger than a Murder Dog. Tell First Lieutenant Hiragi to analyze it thoroughly. And tell Second Lieutenant Karman not to go further than what is necessary.”

Then Michelle paused for a moment before deciding to make it clear.

“Colonel Gratham. I will say that it was not wrong for you to send the strongest force at your disposal at the time. However, when going against an unknown enemy, it would have been better to send machine troops which can be replaced. I do not want to lose any more men. Is that understood?”

“Ye-yes!! I am deeply moved by your kind words. I shall remind them that they are to pay the utmost attention to avoiding any loss of lives. Do not worry on that account!!”

“Good. I eagerly await a positive report.”

She said, and then the transmission ended.

The screen blinked off and Michelle let out a deep sigh.

Now that she had said that, they would focus on the mystery enemy rather than the destruction of the resistance.

Unfortunately, for this mystery enemy, it would have to be used to buy them some time.

Now she would just have to contact her informants and give orders and somehow use the situation to help them recover.

Jegyll smiled wryly as she appreciated the work her friend was doing.

“You must be tired, Michelle. I cannot imagine what it is like, keeping your subordinates happy while helping the resistance...”

“Yes... But it cannot be helped. What they say is right, and in terms of fairness, we are not without fault. The truth is, we do not have enough resources for everyone, and we make them suffer a little...”

Michelle answered with a small smile of her own.

The Mechanized Empire of Almsbine had no real intention of annihilating the resistance—thought none actually knew this.

Only a few of the top people in each city were aware.

The first great war would never have even occurred if there had been enough resources.

If people cared too much about themselves, it became easier to grow discontent when others made profits.

Even more so when your life was on the line.

In reality, it was just not possible for the Empire's food processing plants to make enough food for all of humanity.

It was even less realistic to provide clothing and shelter. And so there was no avoiding having people bear their situation.

It was clear, since a city had already been destroyed.

That was the reason that Michelle's father, the Emperor of Almsbine, had abandoned those who lived outside of the city.

–Reconciliation was not to be wished for.

They would not destroy them, but they would not save them either.

They would be given scraps from the city, without even knowing it...

Those were the words of the Emperor.

No one knew about this.

This was because it would not gain any support.

“Well then, I will send word.”

“Yes, thank you. Jegyll.”

Jegyll bowed and left the room.

Michelle was now left alone.

“...Destruction. In this situation, we are probably just delaying our last days... But having an enemy to fight against might...”

She closed her eyes and thought.

Even if the world was headed for destruction, Michelle was determined to fight it.

To that cause, she was willing to be merciless and cold.

The resistance was not a threat now. If anything, as enemies, they provided her men with a reason to live.

Michelle wished that things could just stay as they were.

And yet–

(...This mystery enemy.)

Then a thought came to her.

From what she had heard, it was incredibly strong.

As long as they did not know where it was from, it could not be ignored.

In any case...while they were problem cases, the subordinates who were sent were good.

So everything should become clear soon.

(...However, I hope that the resistance don't become arrogant through this...)

If their existence became a threat to the city...

Michelle thought about this dark possibility.

(...A storm might as well come and just wipe us all away...)

The fear of annihilation, suspicions and doubts. This was a world where people only felt a reason to live through finding enemies.

The atmosphere was polluted and you could not even see the sun during the day.

While it seemed childish to want help from god, you could not help it.

Michelle sighed again, as if to mock herself.



The sound of something sizzling on the grill filled the air.

The smell of something delicious wafted as several children gathered around with bright eyes.

“Kaaa-hahaha! It is almost ready. You should all wait in line. And do not forget to bring the parts!”

It was Veldora.

Veldora was cooking okonomiyaki on a grill.

Where did the grill come from? What about the heat? Such things were of no concern.

It was Veldora. And anything was possible.

“Oh, it’s ready. So, you want to be first? Where are the parts?”

When the okonomiyaki was ready, Veldora called to the child who was first in line.

“Here it is! It is a drill arm with a powerful electric motor

inside!”

“A drill arm!? That sounds very cool! Alright, let’s trade!!”

“Thank you!!”

“Who is next?”

“Me! Can I trade this?”

“Oh, a caterpillar. Hmm, very well. It’s hot, so don’t burn yourself.”

“Yes! Thank you, mister!!”

“Yes, yes!”

These transactions continued as Veldora gained more parts

and passed out okonomiyaki to the children.

He looked very satisfied and his smile widened as he looked at the increasing amount of parts he was getting.

The children happily ate the okonomiyaki and let out cries of overwhelming delight.

“It’s delicious! This is so good!!”

“What is this!? It’s hot. My tongue hurts. But I can’t stop eating it!!”

While the taste changed so you would not get bored, the children still ate the same thing everyday.

And it was of course, neither cold nor hot, and the taste did not spread.

It was clear what the difference was between artificial and natural.

And so the taste and heat of Veldora's okonomiyaki practically exploded in the mouths of the children.

In spite of his warnings, some of them got burns in their mouths.

"Kaa-hahahaha! How is it? Good? Don't fret, there is plenty more!!"

The children gathered around Veldora.

He had become their hero in no time.

While he was just luring them with food, Veldora was on top of the world.

Just how had this happened...

The adults lived as always in this claustrophobic space, with no hope for the future.

But among all of this, the children tried to find some fun in their days.

And so they thought of a game-robot wrestling.

This involved gathering discarded parts and creating robots to fight each other.

Robots that were especially well-made would be made part of the Remote Robot force and sent out into the field.

This was considered to be the highest honor for the children.

They looked through the mountain of junk that the adults

brought back and searched for promising parts.

They would then learn how they worked on their own and install them into the robots.

This was to make the best possible machine they could.

The elderly taught the young everything they knew.

It was believed that friendly rivalry would make this game even more fun.

A race where the winner was obvious was boring.

And so they praised each others' skills while trying to raise their own...

In this environment, the children were able to achieve a high level of understanding in technology.

That day...

The children had gathered as usual and were making adjustments to their robots.

And then out of nowhere, Veldora appeared before them.

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Veldora was sulking.

The reason was simple.

Ramiris and Beretta had been praised to high heaven while he

had been abandoned.

After the talk with Sharma and the others, they had been led to the base.

It was not because they were trusted completely, but it had been decided that they could do no harm.

But more than anything, Ramiris's abilities were very appealing.

“So, Lord Ramiris. You can control water?”

Sharma asked. Ramiris laughed haughtily.

“You could say that! You know, I’m just a woman of many talents, alright?”

“Ohh! Wonderful. Then we have a request we would like to

ask you...”

“What? What? Well, let’s hear it. I am a gentle person, so I will at least hear you out!”

“It is really nothing for something as great as you, Lord Ramiris. At least, I don’t think it is?”

“Great!? Me? Why, you have a great eye for seeing people. I am impressed!”

“Hahaha. Oh, you flatter me. As for the request...”

As soon as it was known that Ramiris could freely control water, Rindo knew what Sharma would want, and acted quickly.

And so he raised Ramiris with flattering words before beginning to negotiate so she would listen to him.

The request was that he wanted her to fill their water tank.

It would surely not be possible for her to fill it completely, but even a little would be adequate. He asked with this desperate hope.

In this world, water was more valuable than anything.

Not only did it rarely rain, even if it did, the rain water was polluted.

And it took an incredible amount of time to filter it until it was no longer harmful.

This underground world where super beasts roamed was not friendly to humans. But the beasts and plants had evolved to be able to filter and store the water.

However, this stored water was at the watering holes of the beasts...and in order to steal water from them, the resistance—Light of Dawn—had to accept the possibility of casualties.

While some problems couldn't be solved without making sacrifices, it was usually a last resort.

And then Ramiris had appeared. So it was no wonder that they would want to ask this of her.

“Leave it to me! Something like that could not be more simple!!”

Ramiris was the one that was simple.

She was happy at being praised, and so quickly accepted their request.

Now completely carried away, Ramiris was led to the water tank, where she filled it completely with water.

To this, Sharma, Rindo and Zaza could only stare with their eyes and mouths widened.

It was more than they could have expected... No, that was an understatement.

They believed that even if they used the bare minimum to survive, the water would not last another year. And now they had enough to live for three years even if they used it lavishly.

“This-this is wonderful, Lord Ramiris! You must have been sent here from the heavens. We are thankful from the bottom of our hearts to have met you!”

“Thank you so much! Now, if only the filtering of the water was smoother...”

After hearing Sharma and Rindo’s praise, Ramiris smiled and nodded.

“Filtering the water? That’s so easy. Beretta. Do it!”

She ordered Beretta.

While Beretta wondered if this would not create problems...he believed it was less harmful than what they had done with the food, and so he accepted.

“If that is your wish, Lord Ramiris...”

He said. Then he used the Ultimate Gift, ‘Mineral Manipulation’ from ‘Deus Ex Machina,’ to gather all of the metal and harmful substances inside of the water tank and then purified the water.

And with this, Bereta was showered with praise as well.

“Th-that’s amazing!! You can not only fight, but do that as well!?”

“An all-purpose weapon...it is hard to believe such technology exists...”

And so it went.

Unlike Ramiris, Beretta finished the job silently and only when he was finished, did he open his mouth.

“I might as well tell you then. You wished for the water filter to be smoother, well, the problem is that the filtering device is not working well. Lord Rimuru once said that machines need maintenance. Has this machine been running for a very long time without rest?”

And he was right. The filtering device had not undergone any maintenance at all.

Turning the machine off meant turning off their water supply, so in away, it could not be helped...but it was also true that it was shortening the machines lifespan.

If that was all, then they would not have been so surprised...

“Beretta, can you fix it?”

“It’s possible, but...”

“Then you should fix it for them!”

“... ”

Ramiris had fallen prey so completely by now, that she happily gave the order to Beretta.

Beretta was about to protest, but gave up and obeyed her.

And like this, Beretta not only pointed out the issue with the device, but even repaired it.

“Lord Ramiris, surely you must be a renowned scientist?”

“Well, yes!”

“Would it be possible for you to look at the other machines as well?”

“Okay! Leave it to me! Let’s go, Beretta!!”

They talked together like this, and left Veldora behind.

“Uh, what about me?”

Veldora muttered. But his voice only echoed in the lonely water storage room.

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Not at all amused with how things had developed, Veldora returned to the base.

And that was when he met the children who were tinkering with their robots.

They would choose whether or not to help these people after learning more about the situation—that had been their conclusion just a moment ago, but Veldora was sulking. And so it no longer had anything to do with him.

He discarded that discussion into the farthest reaches of oblivion and became the king of these children.

And now, among the delicious smells and cries of admiration, even adults were starting to gather around Veldora.

This clamour of course eventually reached Sharma and the others.

And it did not take long for them to come running frantically back to Veldora.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 05 Veldora's Excuse

“–What are you doing, master...?”

Ramiris asked Veldora, who was cooking okonomiyaki with a big grin. She had been the first to return.

As Veldora had gone against their agreement after being left alone for just a short while, it could not be helped that there was a sharpness in her voice.

However, Veldora did not seem to take notice. He kept pouring more batter over the grill and added shredded cabbage on top.

It was a mystery as to where these ingredients were coming from, but he handled them expertly as he mixed them into the batter.

And then he said:

“Kaaa-hahahaha! Ramiris, do you want some too?”

“Yes. But, that’s not the problem!!”

Ramiris nodded to Veldora’s light-hearted response but quickly remembered herself.

I won’t be tricked by food! It was with this strong will that she rained down words of reproach over Veldora.

“We just talked about this earlier. We are supposed to act with caution!”

However, Veldora just snickered at her.

“Ramiris, calm down. If you’re just going to complain about everything, I will just have to keep these spoils of war for myself, won’t I?”

“...What?”

“Look at this. If you put it together like this...”

While waiting for the batter to cook, Veldora quickly assembled a robot.

It was a torso on top of what looked like a tank.

A simple machine with two arms.

However, the left arm was distinctly shaped like a drill.

“Huh. That’s an interesting combination.”

“It looks so cool.”

“I’m going to copy that...”

The children watched it with interest and were clearly impressed.

This only made Veldora more and more arrogant.

“Hehehe. Of course. It should be no surprise that I can create a partner who is both cool and strong!”

He said with a satisfied nod.

And then he glanced at Ramiris and continued.

“What do you think, Ramiris? Will you still pretend to be uninterested?”

He must have been sure of his victory because he said this with a puffed-out chest.

Veldora’s words were more than enough to make Ramiris

hesitate.

“Huh? Uh!?”

Ramiris’s head seemed to spin as she began to wonder what to do.

And it was then that a freshly cooked plate of okonomiyaki was put in front of her.

It was an exquisite dish that used lots of shrimp and pork.

Savory sauce, seaweed, and bonito flakes covered it. The smell alone was enough to make her drool.

Ramiris gulped.

“This is for you. Eat up.”

“Uh, aah...okay. I will then...”

That strong will to resist any trickery now disappeared from Ramiris’s heart.

Veldora thought he had won then, but it did not last for long.

“Lord Ramiris. Do not be deceived.”

Ramiris was looking at the okonomiyaki with sparkling eyes when Beretta’s warning reached her ears.

“Huh? What?”

She was clearly shaken as she looked around her.

She looked at Veldora, then Beretta and then back at the plate of okonomiyaki. It was obvious that her heart was not sure.

Ramiris really did want to side with Veldora, but her brain was telling her that it would not end well.

She didn't know what to do.

Veldora watched her and smirked. Then he suddenly shouted, 'Rocket Puuuuunch!'

And then, right in front of Ramiris's eyes, the newly made robot began to move.

Bang!! There was a loud sound.

And then the part passed the elbow of the right arm fired off like a rocket.

The fist slammed into the wall.

Veldora shouted again.

“And now the deathblow! Drill Break!!”

The robot heard this and started to move again.

The caterpillar groaned and then the string attached to the right arm began to pull the body in.

Once the right arm was back in its socket, the left arm rotated like a drill at a tremendous speed and slammed into the wall.

There was a deafening sound.

And then, destruction.

“WOOOW!!”

The children were greatly excited by this.

And so was Ramiris.

She stood up while still gripping her chopsticks and then shouted excitedly.

“Amazing! That was amazing, master!!”

“Kaahahahahaha! Kaa-hahahaha!! Of course, it is.”

Delicious okonomiyaki.

Children to play with.

A cool robot.

New entertainment.

Everything was here.

And so it went without saying, that Ramiris gave in.



Ramiris began to happily eat the okonomiyaki. Beretta sighed with exasperation.

However, he had not given up yet.

Ramiris was simple, so he had fully expected her to be tricked by Veldora.

What was important, was when it came to determining who was responsible—and that would happen for sure—was how to ensure that Ramiris would not get in trouble.

Because Ramiris's mistakes = him being rebuked. Or so Beretta thought.

–You were there, and yet you could not stop them?–

Beretta could imagine Rimuru's face as he asked this.

You ask too much of me–was how he really felt, but he would never say it out loud.

Beretta took things very seriously.

And so he wondered what it was that they needed.

For instance, what he considered the ideal, was the relationship between Milim and Frey.

As self-centered and forceful as Milim was, she somehow always obeyed what Frey said.

Veldora also could not go against his sisters.

If it was an order from Velzard or Velgrynd, Veldora would have no choice but to quietly listen.

In the world, everyone had someone they were no match for.

It wasn't necessarily about combat ability, but there was a special relationship that determined who was above who.

(Perhaps if I was trusted by Lord Ramiris more...)

Beretta thought.

Beretta believed that Ramiris would listen to him more if she trusted him.

But Beretta was mistaken.

When it came to Milim and Frey, she also got quite the headache.

It was the same with Veldora and his sisters.

If Veldora really did listen to them obediently, then they would not have had such a hard time with him.

While Veldora did not do much mischief these days, he had been responsible for much in the past.

As for trust...it wasn't something you gained overnight—and Beretta had gained more than enough of Ramiris's trust over the last few decades.

It just so happened that she had been susceptible to Veldora's tricks on this occasion.

Had it only been Beretta and Ramiris here, Beretta would not have had as hard a time.

But Veldora was here too.

And that was the biggest reason for Beretta's misfortune.

Beretta watched as Ramiris hungrily stuffed the okonomiyaki into her mouth. He sighed once again.

Then he switched gears and talked to her.

"Lord Ramiris. Please calm down and listen to me. If you continue with this, you will become an accomplice to Veldora's crimes."

"Huh?"

Ramiris froze in surprise.

Beretta tried to continue on with his warning, but...

"Hehehe. Ramiris, don't you worry. You already are an accomplice!"

“What!?”

“You can’t make any excuses now that you have taken a bite of the okonomiyaki. We must now walk on the same bloody road!!”

Veldora said with a laugh.

“Lord Veldora, this is no time to laugh. Please stop involving Lord Ramiris in such things.”

“Kaa-ahahahaha! Don’t worry, Beretta. I am not stupid. I have this all thought out.”

I wished you wouldn’t think of so many things, thought Beretta.

He was sure that whatever it was that Veldora was thinking, it would not be good.

Still, Veldora did not listen.

He just laughed, ‘Ka-hahahaha!’ and continued to cook his okonomiyaki and trade them in for parts that the children had brought.

“–Hey, you. What are you doing!!”

Just then, Sharma, who had finally caught up with Ramiris and Beretta, looked at Veldora and shouted.

Next to her, Rindo stood with a shocked expression as he looked at the grill.

Hey, hey. Said Zaza as he sighed.

Beretta knew all too well what they were feeling, but he did not know what to do.

However, Veldora did not look like he cared at all...

“Oh! Do you want some too? I intend to stay here for a while, so there is no need to act so reservedly!”

He said with a blinding smile.

“Now, now wait a minute. What is this you are giving the children...!?”

“Ho-how outrageous. It was one thing for us to have to do it, but to force children to have to suffer as well...?”

Sharma and the others were furious.

However, just like he had been with Beretta a moment ago, Veldora just laughed without a hint of remorse.

“I don’t see any problem. From what I hear, this ‘city’ has

natural ingredients, no?”

“No, that’s...”

“–That is only a rumor. We do not know about what happens inside of the city. However, we have heard stories when we were children...”

“But, well, unlike the food production plants outside of the city, the security seems to be very tight there. It would not be too surprising if they had ‘real’ ingredients that were not synthetic.”

Hmm. Veldora nodded.

This enemy that the resistance fought–the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine–he had heard much of them during their last conversation.

But Veldora did not think of such difficult matters such as, which of the two sides was in the right.

He just heard the fact of it and accepted it.

Enemies should be crushed, but this Empire wasn't exactly an enemy to Veldora.

But they weren't allies either.

If there was food there, then they should share it with the resistance. That was the idea that flashed in Veldora's mind. And he did not stop to consider their reasons for a second.

In any case, it was pointless to even expect Veldora to care about their circumstances.

"Is that not right? So we should just take it by force."

"Are you stupid!?"

"That's impossible!"

Zaza and Sharma shouted at the same time.

Of course.

Just like the most recent incident, they could attack a food production plant that had the weakest security and still lose men.

As for attacking the ‘city’ itself with all of its tight security, it was practically suicide.

“Ka-hahahaha! What a joke. You cannot think like that and then expect the children to have hope, can you?”

Veldora said as he looked at the young faces that surrounded him.

Then he turned serious and continued.

“I have an idea. I want to show these children that the world is full of wonderful things. This food that changes flavor is not bad in itself, but it is not enough to satisfy the heart. You have to know the heights and then want it. I believe that it is that pursuit that is noble!”

He declared.

“No, but...”

“That will only make the Empire furious. In a way, they overlook us. But they will start showing their true power if we push any further.”

“Indeed. While we call ourselves the resistance, we do not really have the power to overthrow the Empire. Even if we could unite all of the districts, it would still not be enough to take one city...”

The three of them rejected Veldora’s words.

And they were right, judging by the known facts.

Even if the resistance went out in full force, they would be easily rounded up by the city's defense troops.

They had worked so hard up until now so that did not happen, so it was no wonder that they didn't agree with Veldora.

However.

“Soft!! You're too soft! Wasn't there once a time of prosperity? Don't you want to get that back? Do you really want these children to have to walk down that same road of despair as you!?”

They all became quiet at this argument, which seemed serious at a glance.

Veldora himself thought that he had said something rather good, and he looked smug.

As he looked around with a satisfied face, Ramiris asked him hesitantly.

“Bu-but, master. This okonomiyaki is delicious, and the children are happy. But what will you do if they don’t have this kind of food in the city? They might know what true despair is then, you know? Beretta is right. I don’t want to get involved and then get in trouble over it...”

Ramiris did not know what to do and her eyes constantly shifted around.

She was afraid that doing something without permission now would just make a bigger mess.

Beretta’s words had made her realize that she was getting too involved.

And while Ramiris was usually the carefree type, this was finally taking things a little too far.

It was here that Veldora suddenly smiled and laughed.

“Don’t worry, Ramiris. I have thought about it. And I have come to a conclusion.”

“...A conclusion?”

Ramiris looked at Veldora and waited for his answer. This time she rearmed herself with a strong will. She would not be tricked again.

Veldora nodded solemnly and said:

“I have decided, that even if everything fails, we can just relax and leave it all to Rimuru!!”

“I see!!”

“Don’t listen to him, Lord Ramiris!!”

Beretta screamed, but his voice did not reach them.

Veldora and Ramiris were already smiling as if the problem had been solved.

“Rimuru would be able to solve a problem like this very easily. We only have to wait for him.”

“That’s true! It would be easy for Rimuru!!”

It was nothing.

If they had trouble, they could just leave it to Rimuru. That was what Veldora said.

And Ramiris had agreed.

There was no worry on her face now. And she bit excitedly into her okonomiyaki.



These two were hopeless—Beretta lamented.

Leaving a mess for Rimuru to clean up was a good way to make him angry.

But neither of them seemed to want to consider that.

Besides, the original plan had been to return to their world before Rimuru got back, and destroy all of the evidence.

But they must have forgotten this because Veldora and Ramiris were laughing as if they had solved everything.

(They really are hopeless. Lord Ramiris is completely involved now, but she doesn't seem to even realize it...)

Beretta alone realized what situation they were in.

It was quite simple. Veldora had been sulking and wanted to become popular. And he merely dragged Ramiris into his plan.

And now Sharma and the others were dragged in as well. And they were going to declare war on the Empire.

He just did whatever he wanted.

Unfortunately, even if Beretta knew why Veldora was doing this, he could not do anything to stop him.

While he was quite exasperated inside, he was at least able to steel himself for whatever the angry Rimuru might do.

“So, what will you do? Now that it has come to this, we shall help you with all of our power.”

Veldora said.

Come to this? It is all your fault! Beretta thought. But he kept his mouth closed.

He would just watch.

Sharma was calm.

Veldora could not sweep her off her feet with his talk. And so she did not give him an answer immediately.

If it was yesterday, Sharma would never have dreamed of allowing an attack on the Empire's city.

She would have ignored it as the laughable idea of a madman.

However, after witnessing the powers of Ramiris and Beretta, she began to wonder if they could use them.

Even if they didn't attack the Empire, she did not want to lose

their cooperation.

–Know the heights and then want it–

Those words burned in her chest.

(You make it sound so easy. And yet you don't know how much we have suffered because of what we wanted—but, maybe it is the same for him? Perhaps he has also experienced a time of such hardships?)

Sharma realized that those words had really moved her.

Still, she had to be careful.

“Attacking the Empire. Such a thing cannot be decided so lightly. We must contact Light of Dawn's headquarters and discuss what we should do.”

So she avoided an immediate answer.

Still, within her heart, Sharma was thinking of it in an optimistic light.

Rindo was also thinking.

–Making the children walk a path of despair–

No, that could not happen.

It was a reality that he had not wanted to admit, and therefore looked away from.

It was so hard just living, that he didn't know if he did it while looking forward to anything.

But this man named Veldora had only come here today, and yet the children had already accepted him and played happily.

Rindo felt jealous.

(Indeed... What had I been looking at all of this time? It was just the adults who were in despair. The children were having so much fun—perhaps true happiness was not something given or taken, but something you find on your own. If possible, I would like to talk to someone from the Empire, just once.)

That is what he thought.

Then something might change.

When he looked at the incredibly confident Veldora, he started to feel that he too could do anything.

“I agree with Sharma. However, I am personally very pleased with your offer.”

Rindo said with a smile. For once, he allowed his true emotion to show a little.

Zaza had a similar opinion to Sharma.

The only difference was that he knew how strong Beretta was in combat.

And so he couldn't help but wonder; what if?

Beretta's strength could give them a chance.

(However, it couldn't be so easy, could it? The Empire was huge. This was like stepping on the tiger's tail. But...)

Zaza had many years of combat experience, and so he knew first-hand just how powerful the Empire was.

And that was why he couldn't agree to it so lightly.

But that wasn't the only reason...

(What if...)

Zaza has seen a new hope in Veldora and the others.

He had lived desperately in this claustrophobic place for so long, and so in his eyes, the carefree way that Veldora and the others acted was almost blinding.

After thinking about it for a while, Zaza came to a conclusion in his heart.

He felt that this situation would be the catalyst.

It would be the first step to changing the relationship between the Empire and the resistance.

However, one wrong step could lead to a disaster.

And so in order to avoid that, Zaza looked at Veldora with

determination.

At the man who smiled with so much confidence.

(Heh. What a strange person. He doesn't fight at all and leaves everything to Beretta, and yet he acts so importantly. But...)

I do not dislike him. Zaza thought.

In any case, things would only get worse if they did nothing.

They had to make a decision somewhere, or they would just run out of luck.

They did not know how long the energy plant in their hideout would continue to run.

“If we are going to do it, I'll call my friends too. We can contact all the surviving mercenary troops here. If we do it, we

have to go in full force.”

Sharma had delayed her decision, but the time would come soon enough.

It was just a matter of acting sooner or later.

In that case, it would be better to make that decision while they had reliable allies.

And so those were the reactions to Veldora’s words.

They were mostly favorable.

Well, except for Beretta...

(...Well, well. It looks like they have all been fooled. Veldora is not thinking about it very hard at all. He just wanted a reason to cook okonomiyaki for the children...)

—Why?

They had only left him for a short while, and it had turned into this.

Beretta could not understand it.

And now it seemed the world was about to be thrown into a great war.

While Beretta was annoyed at how wrong it all was, he also started to consider what he could do to minimize the casualties.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 06 Attack

Everyone who heard Veldora's words felt something different.

And then it happened. Before any of them could put their feelings into action.

The attack.

There was an explosive sound as the ceiling of the underground shelter, that was the resistance's base, collapsed.

“What!?”

Zaza shouted as he frantically looked up towards the ceiling.

Black smoke rose into the air. He could see the grey sky between the cracks.

He was stunned.

Sharma ignored him and was the first to react.

“This is bad! The toxic fumes will come in!!”

Sharma shouted. Rindo quickly moved.

He gathered together the adults and children and led them to the lower floors that were used as an emergency refuge.

As they had trained for such an event in the past, they moved with impressive speed.

Only the youngest of the children cried or screamed.

But for the most part, everyone disappeared from the top floor without much in the way of chaos.

“How can...but this is a shelter that withstood a nuclear blast...!? What kind of power would it have taken to pierce through to here...no—is it a Bunker Buster!?”

Zaza was frozen with shock.

If he was right about it, this meant that the Empire was finally putting its full weight behind the attacks.

And they had been the first to strike. There was now a danger of them all being slaughtered down here.

However, Zaza had one doubt.

“...No, wait a minute... If that really was a Bunker Buster, this floor would be a sea of scorching heat...”

And yet the blast seemed to have stopped as soon as it hit their ceiling.

Zaza was so puzzled that he said this out loud.

Veldora looked at him and smirked.

After all, it had been Veldora's power that had saved them right now.

He had just become popular with the people, and he wasn't about to let these intruders interfere with that. That is what was on Veldora's mind when he cast a barrier around this floor.

“Kekehehehe. Oh, Zaza. As for that...”

This was the time to show that confused Zaza how wonderful he really was—it was just as Veldora thought this and began to explain, that it happened.

Five mobile weapons dropped down from the opening in the ceiling.

“Master. Something just came in!?”

“Tsk. How much must they pester me...”

Veldora said in frustration.

Even when he tried to be good, no one appreciated him. It happened all of the time.

“What shall we do, Lord Veldora?”

“Hm? Beretta. We’ll do as we discussed. I shall protect Ramiris over here and you deal with them.”

“Understood.”

They said casually, and then Beretta stepped forward to face the five enemies.

Zaza saw this and frantically tried to stop him.

“Wa-wait-wait-wait-wait-wait! Those things are dangerous! Judging by their silhouette—they are the armored troops led by that bastard, Karman. I think he was a second lieutenant or sergeant, but he is also a highly experienced cyborg. He’s insane. There are rumors of him annihilating several mercenary groups. You won’t stand a chance against him if you’re alone!”

Zaza knew Karman.

How aggressive and cruel he was.

There were mercenary groups that he knew personally who were destroyed by just a few of these mobile weapons.

Some had been let go on purpose, and they all spoke with fear in their hearts.

This man who was said to be the worst of the south was here in front of them.

And so it was no surprise that Zaza was worried.

“Be careful now, Beretta!”

“Don’t kill them, alright? I think Rimuru would get really angry if you did that.”

“I understand.”

The three of them showed no signs of having heard Zaza’s words.

Zaza could not hide his alarm as he said,

“Don’t kill them... Are you serious? What are you talking about!? I will admit that Mister Beretta is very strong, but these guys are not the same as Murder Dogs. They are real anti-army weapons! And there are five of them. We have no hope of winning. We have to escape now or we’ll be wiped out...”

“Zaza. Calm down. I am here too. How could we lose?”

“And what the hell do you think you’re going to do!? They won’t let you go just because you cooked them some okonomiyaki!!”

Veldora had only been trying to calm Zaza down, but it had no effect.

It could not be helped.

After all, to him, Veldora was the least useful of the group.

“What!? What you just said...I...that kind of hurt...”

Veldora was shocked by how little they thought of him.

Ramiris tried to comfort him.

—And then.

Leaving Veldora's stupid conversation behind him, Beretta faced Karman.



The five mobile weapons advanced towards Beretta—the Powered Suits, led by Second Lieutenant Karman—but Beretta stood his ground.

They had landed on the ground from above.

As the ground shook when this happened, it was clear that they were quite heavy.

They were at least three meters tall.

Humanoid knights in heavy, thick armor.

“Giants?”

Beretta whispered as he took a step forward.

The machine that stood in the front addressed Beretta first.

“Oh. Jackpot already, eh? So you must be the resistance’s new weapon. The one that killed our Murder Dogs. I am Karman. A second lieutenant. I lead this troop.”

It was second lieutenant Karman.

He held a cigar infused with emotion-suppressing agents. And he introduced himself while inhaling deeply.

“I don’t know what you mean by ‘new weapon.’ But it was I who killed the three dogs.”

“I see. Bingo. We’ve been quite lucky. And what is your

name?”

“–Beretta.”

“Hoho. Odd name. As you are no famous terrorist, are you a newcomer? Well, that doesn’t matter. I just want you to answer me one question—”

“–What?”

“It’s nothing, really. We used the Bunker Blaster with the intent of destroying this underground shelter... So why isn’t it destroyed? What little trick did you use? I am just curious.”

“Hmm. The answer is simple. Lord Veldora over there, he protected us...”

Beretta said honestly.

However, this only made Karman laugh.

According to the energy calculations, Veldora was nothing remarkable. The data said so.

And so he did not believe Beretta's answer.

"I see. So you won't tell me then. Well, fine. By the way..."

Smoke rose from his cigar.

It was just as the smoke was directed towards Beretta's vision, that Karman moved.

He was fast.

The Powered Suits represented the height of their technology. In spite of its hefty appearance, they could go from standing still to moving at 1,000m/s in just ten seconds.

However, this action was not about attacking.

To Karman, it was merely a casual walk. A kind of greeting in order to witness Beretta's reaction.

Karman's hand was placed on Beretta's shoulder.

The movement was so fast that a shockwave hit Beretta, but otherwise, he stood still as if nothing had happened.

It had been less than a light breeze to him.

"Oh? So that is not enough to phase you then. I am impressed. It will make destroying you all the more interesting. But first, I must listen to this order from Colonel Gratham. You should just surrender and tell us your secrets. Then you may be able to live in the city. I will give you ten seconds, so think about your answer!"

Karman said as he blew smoke into Beretta's face.

He wanted to fight him, but he had to follow orders. And so he made this offer.

“Karman, was it? Do not give me orders.”

While his mask hid any expression, Beretta’s voice was oozing with irritation.

Inwardly, Karman was enjoying Beretta’s reaction.

He tightened his grip on Beretta’s shoulder and continued.

“Well, if you insist on defending these scum, you must be an enemy to me.”

And then he smiled viciously and tried to crush Beretta’s shoulder by applying more pressure...

But Beretta just lightly brushed his hand away.

The hand of a Powered Suit that was applying intense pressure. And with just one hand.

Karman lost his balance and fell back towards his troops.

His shoulders shook with fury and shame over this unbelievable reality. And then he let out a great roar.

“Kukuku-kahahahahaha!! Yes. This is very amusing. It’s been a while since I faced an enemy that was worth fighting, however...”

Karman paused here and inhaled from his cigar.

All the anger then dispersed and he regained his calm.

He continued.

“I will tell you about reality before we fight. It seems that you

have an internal high-power reactor exceeding 100,000kWh. It's your best feature, isn't it? Indeed, it is rather impressive for something created outside of the city laboratories, but not quite good enough. The nuclear fusion reactors inside of our Powered Suits can output as much as 817,000kWh. Do you see? Do you despair at this difference? Do you see that there are five of us? You never had a chance against us. So I will say this one last time. Surrender to us!"

He said as if repressing his natural tendencies. He would obey the order from headquarters. Karman was like a problem child, but he was not an outlaw.

However, he was difficult to control once he started fighting.

This came from his intense hatred of the resistance and had nothing to do with his original personality.

And so it was not possible for him to stop himself.

"Surrender? I have no intention of obeying someone who is weaker than me. But more than anything, I already have a

master. I do not like what you are saying.”

“Hah! Then be ready. You will soon know reality and regret this!!”

“Hmph. Don’t worry, I will not kill you.”

The cigar had now burned away.

That was the signal.

“Ridiculous! I know what you are capable of. I hope you won’t break on me?”

Karman shouted after laughing confidently.

There was no reason for Karman to doubt that he could defeat this enemy in front of them.

And yet...

“Hmm. Perhaps you will put up more of a fight than I thought. Maybe I will have to take this thing seriously.’

Was Beretta’s reply.

At this, Karman’s emotions exploded.

The suppression drug’s effects had ended.

Karman’s ability to reason was now gone. And the only thing to do was to unleash his anger.

The Powered Suit was a part of him and moved according to his will.

The heat and pressure that was usually sealed by the electromagnetic force field now lit up the nuclear fusion

reactor. The resulting plasma stream rushed through his body like blood.

It was directly converted to electricity through the generator, giving Karman frightening strength.

The strength to go wild.

While he was human, he would become like the sun.

Exceed what he was as a cyborg and transform into a weapon.

At the same time, Karman's subordinates finished preparing.

Like Karman, they embodied the sun and released their great power.

While they were a team, individually, they would have been able to fight a whole division of soldiers from one generation

ago.

They would surely win this battle.

Karman and the others could imagine no other outcome.

Currently, Karman was just a single, mad machine...

“I will crush you. I will crush you with my own hands, Beretta...!!”

–He would not stop until this operation was complete.

And that was how the fight began.



Intense shockwaves blasted the area as the incredibly heavy

Karman charged into Beretta.

He was in complete combat mode and intended to crush Beretta.

The great energy from the reactor was compressed as Karman raised his fist.

Hyper Impact—the Powered Suit’s thick plating covered Karman’s fist, giving it immense destructive force.

The power would be overwhelming.

It exceeded a million horsepower. It would surely turn its target into dust.

However—

Beretta saw the attack coming.

Instead of directly blocking the flow of power, he parried it, throwing Karman off balance and into the air.

In other words, a one-arm shoulder throw.

They say that soft methods often trump brute force, but that was just an illusion.

It was not possible to control the direction of Hyper Impact's power with just knowledge of how it worked.

You would only get swallowed up with such lukewarm strength.

So there was really only one reason that Beretta was able to throw Karman—it was that Beretta's power reached that of Karman's.

“What!?”

“He threw Commander Karman!?”

His subordinates were stunned.

He had moved faster than the speed of sound. They would never have imagined that he would be stopped in such a fashion.

Karman was just as surprised.

However, he quickly rose up and admitted his error.

He did not like to admit that he had underestimated his opponent, but he now remonstrated himself for relying on his own power alone.

“Don’t fret! He has combat arts. He is an expert that can react at the speed of sound! Avoid fighting him one on one or at close-range!!”

Karman said without panicking.

His subordinates obeyed, and they surrounded Beretta in an instant.

As for Beretta...

“...Well, well. This is turning out to be quite a hassle. The lack of energy means that ‘Universal Perception’ is not very accurate. The light, wind, heat, sound and my other senses. This fight will be harder than I thought.”

That’s what he had determined just now.

This was because part of his chest and both arms were not deformed by the heat and impact after parrying Karman’s attack.

That meant that even with Beretta’s ‘Physical Attack Nullification’ and ‘Natural Elements Nullification,’ that he had taken some damage.

Had he been slower in reading the information, that blow may have been fatal.

So the lack of energy was effecting him in those ways.

And so Beretta used 'Mineral Manipulation' to liquefy his body.

It healed his body and protected him from attacks.

Still, Beretta kept his eyes on the enemy.

"Hmph. 'Universal Perception,' you say? Is that your sensor? It seems quite advanced, but can you dodge this?"

Karman laughed confidently and signaled to his men.

The four Powered Suits that surrounded him immediately went into an offensive posture.

Their next attack would come in waves.

On the surface, the Powered Suits could move at three times the speed of sound.

It was the same as the Murder Dogs, but the internal conditions were very different.

The Powered Suits were much more advanced when it came to standing still and then moving at full speed. But it wasn't just that.

The Murder Dogs were not good at precise turns. It was like how jet planes were weak against attacks from the side, due to their structure.

Sudden changes in direction would cause both the plane and the pilot to be subject to intense centrifugal force. While Murder Dogs were controlled by computers, they were not built to be able to withstand this from the side.

On the other hand, the Powered Suits allowed them to move freely while going at a high speed.

Of course, moving at three times the speed of sound would have an effect on the person inside.

However, Karman and the others were cyborgs, so there was no problem.

They also had the aid of a support calculation device, allowing them to make the most of their speed and to synchronize with each other.

“Tsk...”

Beretta clicked his tongue as he dealt with their attacks.

His arms and legs were not enough.

And so Beretta used the Ultimate Gift, Deus Ex Machina, to take in the surrounding matter and create several tentacles that were thicker than his arms.

Each of them represented his will and could move freely.

Each of them were sensors and could make decisions immediately.

The sound came later.

So much power was focused in one spot, and anything that got caught inside was turned into dust.

Karman's men moved while staying out of each others' way. But Beretta showed he could deal with them, even though he was facing them for the first time. Both sides had to admit the strengths of the other as the chaotic battle continued.



“...This is pretty crazy.”

“Hmm. That Beretta. He is trying to take my spotlight...”

“No-no-no! That’s not the problem now, is it!?”

Ramiris was impressed. But Veldora had begun to complain after misinterpreting the situation.

As for Zaza, he felt frustrated enough to shout at them.

The information that his senses allowed him to gather was now being replayed in his head through the analysis device in his brain. It was only after seeing this that Zaza fully understood what was happening.

He had never seen a fight at such speed before.

And so he could not understand Veldora’s reaction while

watching this.

“Pretty crazy? Can you even see what is happening, Ramiris?”

“Uh, it’s a little hard. But I can see it.”

“Of course, I can see it. It is clear and crisp for me!”

“No, I am not asking you, Mister Veldora. You don’t need to try and show off.”

“...!?”

If Ramiris said she could see it, she probably could. That was what Zaza thought.

He could not imagine how advanced she was, but clearly there was some unknown technology being used in her small frame.

There was no room for doubt after seeing Beretta.

Karman's troops were like gods of death, and yet Beretta was fighting them without giving in an inch.

This was much more than Zaza had been expecting, and he had to change his perception of Beretta.

(So a weapon that can take on the best of what the city had to offer had been made outside of the city laboratories... It was hard to believe, but had to be accepted.)

And this truth was a ray of hope for the resistance.

Zaza thought.

If Beretta was with them, then they might have a chance of winning with the plan they had discussed.

Zaza could sense that he was becoming excited, and so turned his attention to the battle.

Veldora looked at Zaza sadly.

Why am I being treated like this? He thought. He continued to stare at Zaza, but was ignored.

“Ah, Ramiris...”

“What? Master?”

“Perhaps I should have fought after all.”

“Why?”

“Why...”

Veldora couldn't say it was because he wanted attention.

He was an unfortunate dragon. No, he was currently in human form.

“Hmph! Watch, Ramiris. That person is trying to do something to Beretta!!”

Veldora could not stand Ramiris's inquisitive gaze and he tried to distract her.

“Oh, you're right. Hey, isn't that dangerous?”

“Hmm. I think Beretta should be fine...”

As Veldora pointed out, Karman, who had not joined in yet, was about to do something.

The two arms of the Powered Suit were now joined like a

single cannon.

Zaza overheard Veldora and Ramiris and looked towards Karman as well.

And he knew.

“That...”

Through his own knowledge and what he had heard from surviving mercenaries, Zaza was able to guess what it was.

However, just then...

“Spread out!!”

Karman shouted angrily.

At the same time, in one smooth movement, the four Power Suits moved away from Beretta.

“...What?”

Just as Beretta looked at Karman, it was complete.

His tentacles could not react in time, and they were blown away. A hole then appeared in Beretta’s adamantine body.

And then a stream of light hit Beretta in the face.

Splat. Beretta’s face fell to the floor...

“BERETTTAAAA!!”

But before Ramiris’s scream could reach him, his body crumbled...



Karman smirked.

It was just as he had planned.

No matter how strong the enemy, he had been sure of his victory. And it was so satisfying.

“Whoops. Did I just kill him? Oh, well. As long as we take the body back with us, Hiragi should forgive us.”

He said with a laugh.

Karman’s plan had been to use his subordinates as a distraction as he prepared his most powerful main cannon.

It was the Neutron Launcher.

It utilized technology that could both accelerate and decelerate neutrons through arranging the high-frequency magnetic field. The neutron beam that was created in the nuclear fusion reactor was gathered inside of the cannon that was the combined arms. And then it was released all at once.

The speed exceeded 10,000km/s—it was close to the speed of light.

Even if the atmosphere caused it to slow down a little, it was still not something that could be dodged.

As for power, that needed no explanation.

Regardless of your strength, it would be impossible to remain unharmed after being hit by the destructive force of the Neutron Launcher.

There was only one way to deal with it. Stop it before it launched.

Karman was sure of his victory now, and he took out another cigar.

“Well, you fought well enough. I almost believed that my men could do it alone, but you fended them off. You made me use my trump card. And for that, you should be proud.”

He said, before laughing pleasantly.

He rarely went all out like this. And he had won.

Unlike battles where he just tortured the weak, he felt his blood grow hot this time.

It was a feeling he had not felt since becoming a cyborg.

He laughed until he was satisfied. And then he moved to have his men collect Beretta's body...

And then stopped.

There was a twitch.

Beretta should have been dead, but it looked as if he had moved.

“...Wait. No, he can’t...”

Karman told his men to stop.

It was then that Beretta’s hand moved under their watchful eyes.



Beretta shook as he picked it up.

Perhaps the shaking was because of the damage he had taken.

No, that was wrong.

It wasn't from the damage—

“This is bad. Master...”

“Y-yes. Beretta. He seems to have really blown a fuse...”

“He-hey? Is Mister Beretta alright? How can he be fine after that... What, blown a fuse? What do you mean...?”

Beretta raised it into the air and inspected the damage.

It was his mask.

The mask that he and Rimuru both had. The mask that hid his

true face.

His long, bright silver hair was now free. Though, it covered his face now...

“This is bad. Rimuru said that he made Beretta’s face to fit his own tastes. And he made him wear that mask because knowledge of it would cause trouble. Perhaps Rimuru has already forgotten about it—but the face and mask were treasures to Beretta...”

“I see. Beretta rarely shows any emotion, but now, his expression is full of anger...”

Beretta had been wearing a mask that covered his head.

It was a mask that Rimuru had put on him and was meant to hide his true face.

Beretta had continued to faithfully obey this order that Rimuru had playfully given to him.

And now it was destroyed.

Beretta's anger now exceeded his ability to hold back. It burst through in a second.

—Now, it was time for his revenge.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 07 Retaliation and an Unexpected Encounter

It happened in an instant.

Karman had not even let his guard down.

And yet...

“You must pay for your crime of tarnishing this gift from Lord Rimuru.”

By the time the chilly voice reached him, Beretta, who should have been held down by the five Powered Suits, had disappeared.

“What!?”

He frantically searched the area with his sensors, but Beretta

was nowhere...no, he was there.

“...!!”

There was a scream and then one of his comrades fell.

It was hard to believe this was happening.

And in the next instant, Karman had to rethink everything.

The air seemed to twist as Beretta appeared.

In front of him, another of his–

“Jogg! Behind you!!”

“–Huh?”

Karman's scream did not reach him.

Beretta moved faster than the speed of sound itself as his thin arms pierced and shredded the Powered Suit.

Numerous tentacles pulled Jogg out, and the empty Powered Suit crumbled to the ground.

What had happened to the first man?

He now understood.

"Im-impossible..."

"What the...he got two of us in a second..."

The two others whispered to each other. Karman felt the same.

However, unlike his men, who were merely shocked, Karman was thinking of a way out of this.

(How did he move like that just now? It was as if space had moved—could it be space teleportation!?)

Moving that fast should cause shock waves.

However, no such thing had occurred.

He had moved faster than sound without affecting the atmosphere—Karman had never heard of such a thing, not even as a rumor.

So then—it couldn't have been movement, but teleportation.

And his thinking was close to the truth.

Beretta's Ultimate Gift, 'Deus Ex Machina's' 'Space

Manipulation,' allowed him to change his own position.

It was limited to an area that he could see, but it was the same thing as teleportation.

“What?! Sto-stop!!”

A third man was caught by Beretta now.

Karman saw this and moved.

“Damn it. Don’t underestimate me!!”

He had readied his Neutron Launcher after the second man had fallen, and he now fired it without hesitation.

It was possible that he would hit his own men, but he had decided that it was a sacrifice he was willing to make in order to take down the monster that was Beretta.

The neutron beam turned into a missile that shot towards Beretta at the speed of light.

The effect would be the transfer of an immense amount of kinetic energy as a reaction of colliding with the target, turning the target into hot plasma.

–Or it should have.

“Wh-what the... IMPOOSSSIBBLEEE!!”

A phenomenon that was so unreal was occurring before Karman’s very eyes.

The neutron beam had changed course right before hitting Beretta and disappeared into the ceiling.

In Karman’s machine-assisted vision, he could see the afterglow of the neutron beam as it reacted with the atomic nucleus in the atmosphere and turned into plasma before disappearing into the ceiling.

There was enough information to assure him that this was no observation error.

Beretta was still standing there.

However, he wasn't idle.

Crunch, Crack, Snap—the eerie sounds erupted as the tips of Beretta's tentacles worked to destroy the Powered Suit it had removed.

This process seemed like a display of Beretta's fury, and Karman could not help but feel a sense of dread.

“Wha-what...did you just do?”

He could no longer stand the sight, and so he asked the question.

He didn't even expect an answer, but it came surprisingly quickly.

“It is simple. I determined the nature of the attack and I dealt with it accordingly. I suppose it is a weapon that gathers together particles and unleashes it at a tremendous speed. A frightful thing, however...”

Said Beretta, before continuing.

It seemed simple enough to alter the angle of space and send the beam off-course.

Because as long as the particles did not react to the atomic nucleus of the target, it was not a threat.

“Yo-you are saying you understood it after the first attack? But, how are you unharmed!? I saw you get hit...”

“Unharmed? You ruined the mask that Lord Rimuru gave to me. And you say ‘unharmed’!! And not only that, but this face

that should be hidden...”

Beretta looked like he was trying to control his anger.

While the hole in his stomach seemed like it should have been the bigger problem, he was more preoccupied with the mask he held in his hands.

Beretta was terribly warped and this was making it harder for Karman to think clearly.

However, just then, the last of Karman’s men who had been waiting for such an opportunity, attacked Beretta from behind.

The hands of the Powered Suits had a number of barrels on them. And now one of them unleashed a rainbow of light.

It was thermal plasma.

It came from a thermonuclear reactor and was launched as a weapon.

“I did it!!”

He screamed. And the incredible heat assaulted Beretta—and yet, not a single hair from his beautiful silver locks was burnt.

Beretta stood completely unhurt amidst the assault of the colorful plasma.

It was a mystical sight. So much so that Karman stared at him in a state of awe.

And then—

Beretta chuckled softly.

The only reason Beretta had taken damage the first time the

Neutron Launcher was used, was because it was an unknown attack.

A neutron beam was not something that usually occurred in nature.

And so it was not something that Beretta knew about. And so 'Multiple Barrier' had allowed the attack to go through.

Beretta was lucky that his body had liquified, saving him from a fatal wound.

But now that he knew, it was possible to use Multiple Barrier to defend himself, but he had considered that it would cause a great explosion, and so he has opted to use Space Manipulation instead.

It was easy enough for Beretta to predict the point that the neutron beam would fire from the angle of Karman's arms.

While there wasn't much point in considering other

possibilities—If Karman had used the Neutron Launcher as his opening attack instead of Hyper Impact, Beretta's body would have likely turned into plasma and been destroyed.

And even if he didn't die, it would have taken a while for him to completely regenerate.

The reason that his head hadn't been blown off was that it had evolved into the Ultimate Metal, Hihirokane.

Hihirokane was not only unalterable in nature, but it could not be destroyed from such half-baked outside influences.

And of course, its nature could not be changed.

But now he knew how to deal with it all.

As for the thermal plasma, it was something Beretta was very familiar with.

So there was no problem.

While there were limits depending on the amount of energy stored, Beretta's 'Natural Elements Immunity' could nullify normal high-temperature attacks.

That being said, there was no energy in this world, so he wasn't in the best condition.

And so while it wasn't much, Beretta had taken a little damage earlier.

But that was then.

As he was now, Beretta could not be affected by their thermal plasma weapons.

Because—

“Bastard...what is happening with you...? How are you immune to the plasma...!?”

Karman’s last man saw that Beretta was unharmed after the attack—and he was thrown into a state of fear.

This brought Karman back out of his trance.

Karman could not blame him for his confusion.

What they were seeing was so far from what was considered normal, that it was hard to maintain your sanity.

The plasma that was directed at Beretta had been blocked by barriers all around him and was being sent up through the large hole in the ceiling.

It dispersed in the sky and disappeared.

That had been a feature of the Beam Barrier, which the Powered Suits had been equipped with...

And then Karman realized it.

Beretta had been disassembling the Powered Suits with his tentacles.

“You were...incorporating it...?”

—Yes.

He had been disassembling the Powered Suits and analyzing their features.

And then he had incorporated it as his own power, allowing for him to use all of those abilities.

Not only that, but they had been altered to be more efficient

and powerful.

The new function of The Ultimate Gift, 'Deus Ex Machina,'
'Machine Domination'...

"Uh, captain? What did you just..."

With those last words, the fourth man fell.

Beretta's tentacles had slammed into him, scraping away his
consciousness.

Now only Karman remained.

And there, for the first time, Karman looked at Beretta's—true
face.

The thin eyes and lips.

His nose had a high bridge that brought his features together and enhanced their beauty.

His face was pale like porcelain, though there were patches of pink that surfaced because of his rage—He did not look like something that was made.

And yet it was clear—

(—Yes, this thing...is not human. However, how...)

“Beautiful.”

That was the word that spilled from Karman’s lips.

It had to be artificial, but it was beautiful in a way that conquered the uncanny valley.

Karman could not imagine what materials had to be used in

order to create such detailed features.

His praise was completely from the heart—

He was not aware for a moment that Beretta's tentacles had been unleashed. They came down on him like rain, sending his consciousness into darkness...



Karman was a survivor of that city that had fallen.

That day, along with the news of the refugee uprising, Karman, who had only just graduated from the military academy, received the order from his superior.

“...We have decided to ask for help from the other cities. Our lives are in your hands. I'm counting on you.”

His superior had been like a father to him. And he said this with gentle eyes.

Karman could still remember it clearly.

And now, he understood how he must have felt to a painful degree.

With the technology the cities had, it was possible to correspond.

After all, back then they had communication devices that worked in spite of the high-density electromagnetic storm.

But there were a number of reasons that Karman and the others had been chosen.

There were universal strategic reconnaissance aircrafts that could fly through the electromagnetic storm, but most of them had been destroyed during the great war. And so they could not afford to lose them now. That was the order from headquarters.

Special research was being conducted in the city, and they could not afford to lose the incredible amount of research data.

They did not want such valuable resources to be taken by the mob.

Etcetera.

And it so happened that Karman, who was the youngest lieutenant, was the only one who could pilot a universal strategic reconnaissance aircraft.

But more than anything–

The senior officer had lost his own children during the war, and so Karman was like a son to him.

He had allowed Karman to escape.

Karman and the other four who were still young...

On the airfield that was high above the city, they took what they could on the aircraft and prepared for transmission.

Karman was too young to understand what the officer's intention was, and so he accepted the mission without saying anything.

He believed that they were on a mission to request assistance and that they would return.

He had no doubts about it.

The result was that he would lose his beloved mother, younger sister and the senior officer he saw as a father, forever.

Even Charles, who he had been seeing at the time...

Regret, sadness, hate.

With so much intense emotion, Karman knew he could never forgive,

That was the reason.

Karman hated the resistance. And this was why he could show no mercy.

After that, Karman and his four subordinates were taken in by South City.

At the time, Michelle was the young general who led the military, and they fought the resistance together.

As time passed, the Empire was established and he volunteered to undergo surgery in order to become a cyborg.

He would be a soldier who fought in the frontlines.

Michelle was now ruler of the south. And she gave her permission.

And now, here he was.

.....

.....

...

Karman woke up with a feeling of depression as he recalled the past.

For a moment he was confused about what had happened, but then he looked around him and turned pale.

He realized that Beretta had defeated them and they were now captured.

“So, you’ve awakened.”

He looked up to see the face of a familiar man standing by the door.

It was Zaza.

He was guarding this room that the five of them were imprisoned in.

He checked his internal clock and saw that it had been half a day since the fight.

While he was stumped as to why they had all been kept alive, he tried to question Zaza.

“...Who are you?”

“Zaza. You’re Karman, right? I’m happy to meet someone so famous.”

“Ha. And I feel terrible. I expected to be killed, but we’re being kept alive. Are you going to torture us then? If you are—”

“No, there is no point in torturing a cyborg. I know that very well. As for the reason that you’re all alive...”

Zaza paused here and sighed.

And then he continued as if shouting.

“This guy called Veldora was against it. Why? Who the hell knows! That guy won’t listen to anyone once he has made up his mind. And Ramiris and Beretta obey him for some reason. So there’s nothing I can do. What is he thinking? That’s what I’d like to know!”

He said.

This show of resentment made even the resistance hater a little sympathetic.

Zaza seemed to calm down a little after this outburst.

“However, this all happened just after we discussed negotiating with the Empire, so perhaps it was a good thing that we didn’t kill you. Both for you and for us...”

“But, you do know we are just soldiers? We have no value as hostages.”

“Hehe. Yes, I know that. But you know, I’ve just grown tired of fighting. Besides, I find it rather amusing that some rubbish fool like that was able to survive all of this time. I almost feel stupid for living my life with such tension. Oh, that’s right. The others will be getting up soon. So we should go too!”

Zaza said as he told them all to stand up.

Karman's men had been silently listening to them talk up until now, but they obeyed his order.

While they were cyborgs, Karman and his men were able to operate in any environment.

As everything but their brains was a machine, it allowed them to move under any circumstances.

That being said, without the Powered Suits, their combat abilities were only slightly better than humans.

Zaza was well aware of this, so he called to Karma and his men without much caution.

“Can you hurry up? As I said, this Veldora guy starts doing things the moment you let him out of your sight. While Sharma and Rindo are probably with him, you can never be too careful.”

So saying he rushed them along and through the town square.

And that is where Karman saw it!

“Kahahahaha! Get in line! Get in line! I will serve you until you are all satisfied!!”

Said a good-looking man with dark skin. He was laughing happily.

Obviously, this was Veldora.

And he was cooking something on a grill that Karman had never seen before.

But there was a sweet smell in the air.

And the sounds of food sizzling on the grill was enough to make the heart soar.

Children were waiting in line with plastic plates in their

hands. Adults watched them with slightly embarrassed smiles.

And when the children got their food and ate it, their faces lit up with happiness.

“Do you understand? You are to give me the rarest parts!”

“Yes!”

“I know!!”

“Good! Kahahahaha!!”

Karman could hear the conversation. The atmosphere here was so peaceful. It was as if the fight of yesterday were a dream.

It was so surprising that they could do nothing but stand there in silence.

However, Zaza was to become even more surprised than they were.

After all—

“What do you think you are doing!!”

–Zaza’s shout echoed throughout the town square.



What he was passing out to the children was pancakes.

Ramiris was flying around them and trading honey, maple syrup and a variety of fruit jam for parts.

She was now helping Veldora by gathering them.

“...Lord Ramiris. You too...”

“Uh, Ahahaha...”

Zaza said tiredly.

Ramiris tried to laugh it off.

“Don’t be so angry Zaza. Why don’t you have one?”

It’s on the house, you know? Veldora said as he offered a pancake to him.

“You know I can’t eat!!” Zaza practically screamed as he pushed the plate back.

“Oh, that is right. I forgot about that. Kahahahahaha!”

Zaza was annoyed at how carefree his laughter was, and he wanted an explanation as to how this had happened.

But it was Rindo, not Veldora who answered him.

“Now, now, Mister Zaza. Veldora had thought this whole thing through. There is no need to act in this way now, is there?”

Rindo said this while holding a plate firmly in his hands.

“Uh, Rindo? You aren’t...did he buy you with those pancakes?”

Zaza asked. Veins were popping all over his forehead.

Rindo averted his gaze.

“Uh, not really. There may have been some high-level

political transactions, but that is all. I would never be bribed...”

He said.

Zaza gritted his teeth with anger at this nonsense, but he soon caught sight of something even more surprising.

“Huh? Well, ohohohohoho—”

Sharma, who was holding a plate, tried to run away as she laughed.

“Wait. Wait just one minute. Miss Sharma, you can’t possibly be involved with this!?”

“Oh, how rude! That’s preposterous! What a thing to say. But, you know, Zaza. It is sometimes important to keep an open mind. That is my opinion!”

She said.

Zaza was exasperated.

This was so ridiculous.

“But...”

“Zaza.”

After thinking about it for a moment, Zaza was about to tell Sharma what he really thought, but she interrupted him.

Zaza gave up under her stare.

Sharma nodded and looked at him very seriously.

“Look here, Zaza. I have made a decision. I am not giving up

on everything. We are going to talk to the Empire. Obviously, this will have to be discussed with the rest of Light of Dawn, but I believe we can confront the Empire in a way that doesn't involve fighting. Yes, that is what I believe."

"You want to talk to them. But I doubt the Empire has the ear to listen..."

"Indeed. We may not get the opportunity. But when that happens, we just need to fight them and take what we need. Just like Veldora over there said. Don't you agree?"

"Fight and take? But that is insane!"

Karman said as he butted into their conversation.

While he was chuckling, his words left no room for argument.

"Look. It was quite impressive that you beat us. I am surprised by it myself. However, the Empire's latest cyborg soldiers are monsters that have ceased to be humans in the truest sense.

You'll all be slaughtered.”

Karman said as he looked around them.

The children laughed as they ate their hotcakes.

“Tsk!”

Karman clicked his tongue.

“Don't even try. It's not really for me to say, but you'll probably remain undiscovered if you continue to lay low as you always have. We were lucky this time when we found you... But you know, its all this Zaza's fault, as they tried to steal from us on such a large scale! And so...”

“But!”

Sharma stopped him.

And then with an expression of determination, said:

“I want to give the children hope. You know, we weren’t even aware that such wonderful food as this existed until yesterday! And I was thinking, do we bear the responsibility for that? We polluted the world and then lived on like this... That great war. It has nothing to do with our children, does it!? And so I have decided. It doesn’t have to be every day. Even once a year is fine. But I want to receive some of the base materials and grow them. And then we can all celebrate. Is that so bad?”

Karman was at a loss for words as she stared at him.

He could not argue with her.

No matter how much he hated the resistance up until now, it was really just anger that had lasted this long through not knowing them.

Now, with the children in front of him, his convictions had weakened.

(...She's right. These kids aren't responsible for that...)

It was a problem that Karman had been avoiding in his own mind.

Up until now, Karman had only faced warriors who had been trained for battle. He believed they were in the wrong, and that allowed him to be as cruel as he wanted.

Even when first lieutenant Hiragi used the nuclear missile, he didn't feel an ounce of remorse. The resistance was their enemy. Karman's imagination did not lead him to think of them as individuals.

But now that he knew, something different was in his heart. A struggle.

Even without the cigar—the emotion suppressant—anger did not well up in him. He was that confused.

(Tsk. Damn it!!)

It was a question without an answer, and he cursed inwardly.

“...If we could survive without the city, we would do so gladly. Unfortunately, I have had these hotcakes analyzed, and they are primarily made from flour. And there are also such valuable ingredients such as chicken eggs and cow milk mixed in it. We have no way of acquiring such things. If it were only the flour, perhaps we could read the genetic information and recreate it within the shelters, but it does not work that way with livestock. We cannot solve this problem on our own.”

Rindo said.

Sharma had ordered him to find out if they couldn't recreate the food themselves.

Sadly, the answer was that it was impossible.

“...Indeed. They do have the genetic information of animals from the last century and there are even animals that are raised for food in the city. But still, it is only just enough so that the citizens of the city don't starve! Even if you want it, we can't

just say, 'here, take it!'"

"And that is why we want to negotiate first. Perhaps we could be useful to each other. We wish to make a non-aggression pact and build a cooperative relationship. But..."

"If you refuse to accept us no matter what, we will have to fight for our survival. If there is even a little hope for us in this world, then we will gladly give our lives for the coming war."

But in the end, Rindo added that the resistance was still not unified in their decision.

However, they could predict the outcome of the talks before they happened.

All their branches were barely holding on. They all knew that they needed the help of the cities. Their machines would not last much longer.

Up until now, they had searched for other ruins with power-

supplying machines and used them.

But this was not really a solution to the problem. There was always a desperate attempt to find a replacement as the old machines slowly died.

If the machines were to stop working before they found a spare, then they would lose the ability to provide the bare minimum amount of food they needed to survive.

This unease and fear was something the adults of the resistance had to live with constantly.

If they could receive the cooperation of the city, then they would likely be able to repair their machines.

Even if it was nearly impossible, wasn't it worth a try instead of waiting here to die?

Such opinions were growing strong within the resistance.

If they were able to negotiate with the city, regardless of the outcome, it would at least put an end to these debates.

And of course—

If the city was not willing to give in, even an inch, then they would have to take from them by force—that would be the result.

“Kahahahahaha! Well said! Yes, yes. It is always best to act first.”

Veldora nodded with satisfaction. Zaza sent him a cold look.

This is all your fault! His eyes said accusingly.

“When you do attack the city, I shall accompany you. For that is Lord Ramiris’s wish.”

Beretta said. Karman couldn't help but enter a fighting stance because of this sudden appearance.

“Be-Beretta!?”

“Karman, I think it was. Do not fear. I am no longer angry. Lord Ramiris has repaired the mask for me.”

He said as he looked at Karman and his men.

And then he looked back at Karman and said in a whisper.

“...However, had you not said that one thing, I would have killed you all. You were very lucky.”

Karman could give no answer except for a nod.

Yes, Karman had been lucky.

Beretta had regained his cool when Karman had praised the face that Rimuru had made.

He felt as if it had been Rimuru who was praised, and not himself. And he was happy.

Without that word, Beretta would have gone wild and put an end to Karman and his men.

Beretta told Karman this and then turned towards Veldora and Ramiris.

“As you commanded, I have repaired everything except for the hole in the ceiling.”

“Oh, yes. Thank you! By the way, master. Why didn’t you have the hole sealed?”

“Hm? Ah, that is because we will have visitors soon.”

“Visitors?”

Ramiris and Beretta looked at him with confusion.

And then Sharma and the others did the same.

Karman alone looked at him with an expression of surprise and with suspicion in his heart.

“There is an airship in the sky, isn’t there? It’s been spying on us all of this time. But it’s finally starting to move. It would be most annoying if they used nuclear attack magic again, and so I decided to leave the door open for them.”

“An airship? Do you mean like a reconnaissance aircraft!?”

“You say someone is spying on us?”

“Mmm. Zaza. It was up there even while you were fighting

with those dogs.”

“What!?”

Zaza was horrified.

Veldora saw this and laughed happily.

It looked like people were going to finally start seeing him differently.

“But, what do you mean by magic...?”

Sharma ignored Zaza and asked.

“Hmm? It was magic that tore through the ceiling, wasn’t it? They changed Nuclear Flame into penetrative energy, which is quite impressive. It was very powerful. Does that not mean there are very strong sorcerers in this world?”

Veldora's words threw them into further confusion.

Among them, Ramiris and Beretta alone were calm.

"I see. So it was my fault that Karman and his men found this place. But if you knew about it, why didn't you say so sooner!?"

"Why? Because this is all according to my plan! We now have hostages for our negotiation! Everything is just great!"

"Really? I knew it, master!"

"Are you stupid!! The Empire does not care about hostages!"

"Yes, I can assure you of that. We don't have any value as hostages."

"Indeed!?"

Zaza shouted at the smug Veldora.

It was well known that the Empire did not care about hostages.

And so it was not just Zaza, but Karman and his men were also shocked at Veldora's ignorance.

They all fell silent.

“What are you going to do, master? Didn't I tell you? This plan was never going to work!”

Ramiris—changed her tune immediately and betrayed him.

Veldora was taken aback.

“No, but... I thought it was a great idea...”

He tried desperately to make an excuse. Zaza just sighed.

This had happened just as Zaza was starting to gain a sense of respect for him, because of his highly capable sensors. But all of that went out the window now.

Zaza thought.

Someone who could run Karman's unit and was good at gathering information.

This person had used 'nuclear weapons' on them without hesitation during their fight. The person that was feared as the 'Master of the Mad Dogs'—First lieutenant Hiragi.

It was rumored that he and Karman were close, so it must be him.

“—Is it first lieutenant Hiragi?”

Karman remained silent.

While he was currently feeling conflicted about his way of life, he still felt no obligation to answer.

“Is he dangerous, Zaza?”

“Very... However, first lieutenant Hiragi likes to annihilate his prey with Murder Dogs, so as long as Beretta is here...”

Just as Zaza was answering Sharma’s question, a dramatic change took place.

“What!!”

“No way!?”

“...I cannot believe it. Can it be an Awakened Demon Lord class!? And with energy that surpasses ours...”

Veldora, Ramiris and Beretta reacted at the same time as they stared at the entrance that led to the upper floors.

After a while, there was the sound of footsteps.

The person who arrived was a beautiful woman who did not look a day over twenty.

She had blue eyes and light blonde hair that was cut at her shoulders.

The surprising guest was none other than lieutenant general Michelle.

Her icy glare scanned the room. She was so overpowering that the very air seemed to warp.

And then her cherry blossom hued lips opened and her beautiful voice sounded.

“Hello, everyone. I am Michelle. I am the Supreme Commander of the Southern Security Force and Governor General of South City.”

Silence.

And—

“It-it’s Bakusenhime Michelle!!”

Someone said.

“...No... Why would the Mercenary Four be in a place like this!?”

Once it was recognized as the reality, a sense of despair and defeat came over the room.

And in that situation, eyes met.

Veldora continued to smile as he stood there calmly.

Michelle considered him with interest.

—And that was how Veldora met the most powerful being in this world.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 08

Michelle

As soon as they caught sight of Michelle, Karman and his men saluted her and bowed their heads.

Michelle saluted back.

There was a nervousness in the room then, but it was promptly erased with Veldora's boisterous laugh.

"Kaaaahahaha! Did you say your name was Michelle? Well, you seem very important indeed! See? It seems that my plan to use Karman as bait has worked after all!! My name is Veldora! This is perfect. You will—"

Zaza and the others heard these calm and arrogant words and turned pale in an instant.

Not only the resistance, but Karman and his men were wide-eyed.

“Be-be quiet, you idiot!! Shut up. You are just useless, so shut up!!”

Zaza frantically tried to close Veldora’s mouth.

Ramiris looked amused as she shrugged her shoulders.

Beretta just sighed quietly.

Michelle’s name was well-known throughout the resistance.

The Machinery Four. The flash of light on the battlefield.

It was no wonder she was called Bakusenhime.

It was said that with her combat abilities, she could take on an army corps alone.

And so Michelle had no guards.

Not only did she not need them, but they would only get in her way.

If you made such a person angry, they would be able to turn this hideout into rubble in a second.

And so it was no surprise that Zaza and the others were so afraid.

“I am...shocked. I have only been here for two days and your treatment of me only gets worse...”

Veldora started to sulk, but Zaza took no notice.

“It’s because you never listen to others!!”

He shouted, and Veldora went silent.

Zaza had learned how to handle Veldora in just one day.

There was no point in being kind to him.

Not only that, but you had to tell him clearly, or he would interpret things in his own way or expand on them in order to fit his own desires.

Zaza knew this because he had experienced it.

They had already treated Veldora as if he were unimportant, but they now had to treat him as a problem child.

“Hmph! Do not bother me!”

“You idiot! If we leave things to you, it will only lead to disaster!”

“Grrr. How dare you speak to me like that...”

They continued in this fashion.

(Damn, damn! If I weren't an adult, I would drown you in a sea of blood!)

Veldora said through bitter tears.

He had lost the argument and realized he was going to lose the opportunity to get the spotlight once again...

“Hehe. You scum. As is befitting for such bugs who live underground, you have swarmed around this trash-like food.”

Michelle's words changed the situation.

Some children began to cry after hearing her cold declaration.

And so the adults hurried forward in order to protect them.

They knew it was hopeless, but they wanted to buy time.

However, Michelle ignored them and turned to Karman and his men.

And then she raised a finger to her lips—

“!?”

“Hmph. You traitors. You are no longer worth keeping alive as servants of the Empire. Now die!!”

She said with a voice that held no emotion.

And then she closed one eye and signaled to Karman.

“...!! D-damn it!! We-we haven’t betrayed...!!”

Karman started to shout frantically.

Michelle nodded quietly.

And then she snapped her fingers.

In an instant, purple lightning flashed. It struck right next to Karman and his men and exploded.

“GAAAAA!!”

They shouted. It wasn’t so much the explosion, but their own reflexes that threw them to the ground.

While they were very loud, something about their movements seemed fake.

“Hehe. That is what you get for bringing shame to the Empire. Now that they are gone, it is time to wipe out the threat. Which

one is Beretta?”

Michelle said after lightly glancing at Karman and his men.

It was pretty clear that they weren't dead, but Michelle did not seem to mind.

Sharma and Rindo noticed it and wondered if Michelle was also acting.

What if—they gulped. No, they should wait and see how this would play out.

“I am Beretta...”

Beretta said after Michelle looked back and forth between him and Veldora.

He knew that nothing good would come from making Veldora

wait.

However, this opponent was of the Awakened Demon Lord class, which exceeded himself.

Though, strength wasn't just about the amount of energy, so you could not tell who was stronger until you fought. And so backing down here would be the same thing as admitting defeat.

But more than that, Beretta was able to see that she was just acting.

(While I may be able to go along with it, I am not sure about Lord Veldora...)

Beretta was quite worried about this.

After all, Veldora was never good at reading the atmosphere—he was that much of an airhead.

If he left things to Veldora here, there was a possibility that he would make her angry for real.

However, Veldora appeared as if he had reached his limits in terms of discontentment...

In any case, it was a dangerous gamble.

(This is a most unexpected dilemma. Perhaps I should have flattered Lord Veldora a little.)

Beretta thought with regret.

But here, an unexpected person lent out a saving hand.

“Hehe. Then that means there are two people that I cannot ignore. No, if anything, it is you who are the truly dangerous one. May I ask you your name?”

Nice! Beretta thought.

Michelle's treatment did much to restore Veldora's mood.

“Hehehe. Kahaha. Kahahahahaha!! Very good. You are a smart one. Yes, a clever woman who recognized that I was special with just a glance. Good. I shall tell you, then. I am Veldora! Friend of the Great Demon Lord Rimuru and the strongest of dragons. They call me ‘Storm Dragon,’ Veldora Tempest!!”

Ta-daaa! Veldora said in a grand voice.

He took advantage of his sisters' absence and claimed to be the strongest of the dragons.

Veldora was very pleased with himself.

He was happy.

He was so happy that he was becoming teary-eyed.

(Hehehe. Now people will know just how cool I am. Adults and children alike will grovel at my majesty!)

He was drunk on himself and drowning in his delusions.

Now that Veldora was happy, he continued to talk to Michelle.

“So, Michelle, was it? What do you want? As I am in a good mood, I will listen to whatever you have to say!”

He said.

Everyone who watched became pale by his attitude.

It was not known if Michelle would act like this for long. It would not be surprising if she suddenly became very hostile.

But there was no one who could react in time.

This was because no one would have ever believed that someone could act like his in front of a Mercenary Four.

No one could have imagined that anyone would try so hard to provoke and anger her.

Well, perhaps he was not provoking her that much. It wouldn't have seemed like it if she were an ordinary person.

But she was the leader of the Empire.

They were not sure what reaction would be had from such insolence from a nobody like Veldora.

And so they could only watch it unfold.

“It is nothing really. I just thought I'd nip things in the bud

before they turn into a disaster for the Empire.”

“Hehehe. In other words, you mean to kill me?”

“You can take it in whichever way you like.”

Michelle and Veldora took no notice of the spectators as they continued their conversation.

Neither seemed very eager. It was as if they were talking about the weather.

But Zaza watched with a feeling that reminded him of an upset stomach, even though he didn’t have one.

He was waiting for the right time where he could enter the conversation and change the subject.

“Wa-wait...”

It was just as Zaza tried to interrupt them, that Ramiris began poking him in the shoulder.

And then she whispered.

“Um, this is just my opinion. But we better let Master do something soon, or he’ll get angry, which will be very bad... Besides, I don’t think that person is serious. Why don’t we just let him handle things this once?”

Zaza reluctantly agreed.

He wasn’t persuaded by her argument, but he felt that it would do Veldora good to feel a little pain.

After all, Michelle suddenly looked very different.

There was something very overpowering about her now, and Zaza could not even open his mouth.

“Wha!?”

Ramiris was also surprised and wide-eyed.

“What is—!?”

Beretta quickly moved to protect Ramiris.

He felt that the air around Veldora had changed. The other adults also started to move the children away...

And when they were done...

“So, are you ready? Give it all you got. I will show you how outmatched you are!”

Veldora declared.



Michelle had come out herself for a certain purpose.

After hearing the report from Colonel Gratham, she had waited anxiously for the next report.

It just wasn't possible for the resistance to create new weapons with their technology.

And so there were two possibilities.

The first was that survivors from the fallen city had secretly developed it.

The second was that one of the other cities had developed it and were 'test-driving' it.

There was no way that the resistance could create something

that was as good as the Empire's best.

The reason was clear. They did not have the personnel, facilities or materials.

And so the possibility of it being made by survivors of the fallen city was very unlikely to her.

In any case, she would only need to see the results of Karma's battle to know for sure—that is what Michelle thought...

While Second Lieutenant Karman had issues with his temper, he was very strong. And so she had no doubt that he would succeed.

However, she received a most astonishing report.

'Te-terrible news! Karman and his men have entered a battle with the enemy, but it seems that they have been defeated...'

First Lieutenant Hiragi's report was relayed in a trembling voice last night.

And so Michelle talked with Jegyll, her adjutant.

First Lieutenant Hiragi was ordered to continue his monitoring. And Michelle and Jegyll discussed the report.

"I can't believe it. Karman had the latest Powered Suits. They should be nearly as strong as Cyborg Soldiers..."

"Indeed. They are inferior in terms of catalog specs, but they are equal in terms of weaponry. Perhaps this means they were defeated before it became a match of firepower."

Michelle agreed with Jegyll's answer.

But then again, it seemed very odd that the five of them were together and yet they did not have a chance to use their weapons...

“In any case, we cannot ignore something that is strong enough to defeat Karman and his men.”

“Yes. We should send a special attack corps and have them deal with this mystery enemy. At the same time, I will contact the other cities and find out if they have been conducting experiments with secret weapons.”

“Yes, that is good. Thank you, Jegyll.”

“Aye! Leave it to me, Michelle.”

With that conclusion reached, preparations were made on the same night.

Jegyll contacted all of the other cities, but she could gather no information concerning the mystery enemy.

Which meant that it really was from the fallen city—or...

If it was the result of secret experiments, they were not likely to admit to it.

And so Jegyll requested permission to have the thing destroyed, and the three other cities agreed to it.

While there were official procedures for such emergencies, they just sent word that they would not make an issue of it in the future. And so it was settled.

(—So, did that mean that the other cities really weren't involved...?)

While Michelle wasn't certain, she decided it must be so.

If that was the case, then they could not avoid destroying the thing, as it was a possible threat.

“This thing defeated Karman and his men. Do not think about capturing it. Destroy it as quickly as possible. All restrictions will be—”

Just as Michelle was about to send out the special attack corps, First Lieutenant Hirgagi made an emergency call.

‘We have confirmed that Second Lieutenant Karman is alive! However...as unbelievable as it may seem, he appears to have betrayed us—’

He said.

First Lieutenant Hiragi had been monitoring the sound waves and had been able to hear them. That was his report.

Everyone that was present became speechless by this.

But then the rest of the report came.

They had been shocked by the word ‘betrayed,’ but it seemed that he had only said something sympathetic towards the resistance.

They were just exaggerating and making a fuss about it, saying it was a betrayal of the Empire.

First Lieutenant Hiragi was well known for swearing allegiance to the Empire, and judging how loyal he was, he would not allow his friendship with Karman to affect him.

—Regardless of it being good or bad, Michelle found it rather sad.

But more than anything else, Michelle wondered if this situation could not be used to their advantage, and so she put her mind to work.

Karman and his men betrayed them?

No, they were clearly still loyal to the Empire.

Well, it was less the Empire and more South City, that had saved them.

On top of that, he seemed to be a little shaken by hearing the situation regarding the resistance.

This meant there was a good likelihood of Karman becoming one of Michelle's personal cooperators.

Especially if she gave him internal information, yes, he would definitely help her.

But why did the mysterious enemy allow Karman and his men to live?

It was not a newly developed weapon from the other cities. If it were, it would have killed all witnesses.

So was it really survivors from the fallen city then...?

Nothing was certain, except that it was not related to the Empire.

Then perhaps if she explained the situation...

At worst, it would mean she would have to kill it herself, but it might be worth trying to have a talk with it.

After considering all of this, she came to a decision.

The truth was, that while Michelle was one of the rulers, she had few subordinates she really trusted.

There was her adjutant, Jegyll, and only a few others.

Everyone obeyed her to be sure, but it was only because she had the strength of the Empire at her back.

If she were to declare that the resistance were to be forgiven, then there would be some who would not follow her.

Not only that, but it could result in yet another riot. Perhaps

Michelle and those close to her would be purged.

And...

(From what information I have secretly gathered, there are clearly dissident within the Empire...)

Yes, while Michelle was at the top of the ladder, she did not put her trust in the Empire.

In that case, wasn't there a good chance that this enemy, which had nothing to do with the Empire, could become a valuable collaborator?

She hoped so.

And because of that—

“Damn him! So he has betrayed me!! You shall pay for this,

Karman!!”

She made a show of being furious.

And since all were too scared to approach her when she was like this, she had a good excuse to tell everyone to wait while she went out to the field alone.

.....

.....

...

–And now.

Michelle repressed her feelings of surprise as she faced Veldora and the others.

There was a large man with gold hair and dark skin.

A combat doll with a mask.

And a small girl that she could tell nothing about.

She was able to single out Beretta, as the reports had described the mask.

However—

(This person called Beretta is indeed very powerful. But this man called Veldora—)

—He had immense power that was incomparable to Beretta.

Michelle had a specific method for measuring such things, and she could see through just about anyone.

She could see just just how much energy people contained within them.

Beretta's was immense.

It was nearly unbelievable, but not exceeding understanding.

However, this man called Veldora...

She had tried provoking him, but this was not the kind of person you wanted to get truly upset.

And so she continued her act.

She would use this opportunity to test him.

Judge his true nature and determine whether or not he could be trusted.



The fight began.

“So, are you ready? Give it all you got. I will show you how outmatched you are!”

Veldora declared and Michelle moved.

A flashed cut the air in half.

Michelle’s blonde hair seemed to leave a trail of blinding light as she rushed towards Veldora.

It was her right fist that was unleashed with immense power.

Machinery Arts–Vibration Fist Wave.

Even without making contact with your target, you could apply ultra waves of energy, causing an internal change that put molecules into a high-vibration excited state.

While it may have looked like a simple punch—it was so fast that the eye could not see it—and it had more than enough power to kill in the first hit.

It was a combat art unique to this world—Machinery Arts.

For cyborgs whose joints could move freely, old ideas of combat had to be changed.

Furthermore, as their fists were made of superalloys, the one who punched them would usually be the one who was hurt.

As this was all pointless, it became necessary to develop a new way to fight that allowed you to remain safe while also dealing damage to your opponent.

Machinery Arts was created during this time as a method that

did not rely on direct contact.

Veldora received Michelle's punch head-on.

He parried Michelle's right fist with the palm of his left hand, then his torso moved forward to the left.

From Michelle's point of view, Veldora's arm should have blown off, and his entire body should have taken damage by that point.

She had not meant to kill him, but just deal a degree of damage.

However, Veldora was completely unharmed.

His body was made up of mysterious substances called magic essence and he was able to freely parry the vibrations.

If it had been against Beretta, he would have taken damage by this unknown attack.

However—Physical damage was not effective on Veldora.

And in a world where this magic essence did not exist, Veldora was an anomaly.

There was no time to think about the laws of nature.

Just as Beretta had been stumped by the unknown, Michelle was also confused by the irrationality of Veldora.

Veldora then tried to move behind Michelle, but things didn't go too smoothly.

While she was confused by Veldora, her instincts caused her to act quickly in dealing with any situation.

Her momentum was not killed as she used the right foot she had planted in the ground as an axis and swung her left leg for a swipe kick.

Veldora saw this and pulled in his jaw and bent backwards to dodge it.

He continued to rotate in the air and landed a few feet away from Michelle.

And with that, he had avoided being hit by her attacks twice in a row.

“I’m surprised. I didn’t think you would be able to dodge my attacks.”

“Kahahaha! Very impressive. This is more amusing than I could have ever imagined! Beretta! I think this woman might be stronger than you.”

Veldora said with a good-humored laugh.

It had been a while since Veldora had last looked so important.

But there was one thing that one shouldn't forget, and that was that Veldora was Zegion's master.

Due to Veldora's usual words and actions, it was easy to think that he wasn't much, when he was in fact a first-rate martial artist.

In one strike, he had seen the true nature of Michelle's art, and had even acquired it.

And Veldora always wanted to test arts that he had learned.

“Like this?”

He said as he unleashed his fist towards Michelle.

It was the kind of amateur punch where one pulled their fist back to their ear.

Or so it looked. But Veldora had converted some of his energy to vibrating energy.

Michelle was surprised by this, but she was not so stupid as to be beaten by her own moves.

And so she parried it easily and muttered in an exasperated voice.

“You really are abnormal. I heard about the bending of the Neutron Launcher during the fight with Karman, but it seems that that was no joke. I suppose I will have to be serious if I want to win...”

As she said this, a black sphere appeared in her right hand.

At the same time, she raised her forefinger to her lips and sent the signal by looking at Veldora.

In spite of her words, Michelle no longer had any desire to fight Veldora.

She had finished inspecting him and had decided that this mysterious man was not from the Empire.

As for whether or not she could trust him, that was a different matter.

She hoped he would see her intention—as she turned around, completely exposing her back to Veldora.

If he attacked her here, well, it could not be helped.

It was this daring nature that had propelled her to the top.

Michelle looked at the stairs she had come down, and then she threw the black sphere towards it.

The black sphere then traveled up the staircase as if controlled by her will...

And with that, the upper floor was consumed by the flames of purgatory.

However, it did not affect the lower floors.

Gravitational field-space distortion—the isolation of specific topological spaces.

Michelle was utilizing a paranormal attack that gave a glimpse of her power.

Obviously, its purpose was to prevent eavesdropping.

As First Lieutenant Hiragi was monitoring from the sky, she had to create a situation where she could cover his prying eyes while making it appear natural.

“Ohh...?”

Veldora showed interest but did not move.

It wasn't that he couldn't, he didn't want to.

He looked a little disappointed that it wasn't an attack towards him.

Veldora was too thick-headed to realize the meaning of Michelle's signal.

The only reason that he didn't attack Michelle while her guard was down, was because he felt that it was something only a small fry would do.

Fighting boldly and upfront.

That was true beauty in Veldora's mind.

And Veldora had no intention of killing his enemy now. He would stop her attacks with his overwhelming superior strength and wait for her to surrender.

By doing this, he would be showered with praise from all those who watched. That is what was going through his mind.

However, his plans were ruined when Michelle did something most unexpected.

Veldora had been waiting for Michelle's next attack with an attitude of calmness, but everyone just took it as him not being capable of reacting in time.

No one could understand what he was thinking...

"Thank you. So you must have noticed my signal. Now we won't have to worry about being monitored. We can speak honestly."

Michelle said. The confusion of the others only got worse.

What? Veldora thought. But it was too late now.

In other words—it wasn't that Veldora was so great, but Michelle had just been holding back. That is what they thought.

On top of that, Michelle clearly had no will to fight, as was proven by the explosion she caused on the upper floor. And with that, the tension seemed to leave the room.

All of it was Veldora's miscalculation.

Zaza was the first to move.

"You are truly lucky! You would have been turned to ash by now if she hadn't gone easy on you."

He laughed as he slapped Veldora on the back.

"...Huh?"

“What!?”

It was not just Veldora, but Michelle was surprised as well.

Both of them realized that Zaza and the others had gotten it all wrong, but there was nothing they could do.

There was no malice in Zaza’s voice, he was just saying what they were all thinking.

“So that is the reason. Yes, there is no way a mere cyborg could take on the Machinery Four!”

“Really, I wondered what would happen when Veldora stepped out. But I am happy that he is alright!”

The other adults interpreted the situation in a similar fashion.

“Yes, yes, that woman really wasn’t fighting seriously...”

“Right? Still, I am impressed with him. Even standing in front of the legendary Bakusenime would take real courage!”

“Indeed. It’s no wonder he is friends with Ramiris and Beretta. Is he an evangelist of Machinery Arts? Is that why he is called master?”

They had gotten it completely wrong and were now celebrating Veldora’s safety.

In just one day, they had all come to think of Veldora very favorably. His uninhibited, cheerful attitude must have been looked at warmly.

While he was not nearly as good as Beretta, he had probably taught Ramiris and Beretta the Machinery Arts.

That’s what the adults thought.

That would explain why Veldora seemed to think so highly of himself.

And since Ramiris called him ‘master,’ this assumption seemed to make the most sense.

(What!? After everything I have done, I did not expect this reaction. I don’t know, I thought they would pamper me and praise me to the heavens...)

Veldora was perplexed.

But Michelle no longer looked like she wanted to fight, so there was no platform for him to show off.

It was just as Veldora had given up. He looked around and saw that the expressions of dazzled amazement.

It was the children.

There was respect and awe there as they looked up at him.

“So coool!!”

“I want to get cyborg surgery so you can teach me Machinery Arts too!”

“You went out in order to save us, didn’t you? That was so cool!”

Words of passionate gratitude now rained over Veldora.

(This! This is the praise that I have been waiting for!!)

Veldora was moved.

It was unfortunate that the adults had not understood how amazing he was, but he no longer cared about it.

As long as he was popular, it did not matter if they were children.

“Kaa-ahahahahaha! You all have very keen eyes. Very different from these adults who know nothing! Good! I am feeling very generous, and wish to splurge! Now! Let the grand pancake party recommence!!”

Veldora’s excitement had reached a new high, and he prepared his grill once again.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 09 Negotiations with Michelle

Now that the fight was over, Veldora returned to cooking pancakes as if nothing had happened.

Michele seemed a little taken aback at suddenly being abandoned, but she now walked towards Veldora.

She saw that the children looked afraid, and then she opened her mouth as if remembering something.

“Sorry about what just happened. We were being spied on, so I had to call it trash. But I was really surprised that you were eating something that looked delicious.”

She apologized.

It was the truth.

According to the regular reports from the informers, the food that the resistance were eating was supposed to be tragic.

She had thought it would be the case here, and yet they were eating pancakes.

So it was no wonder that she was shocked.

“Kahahaha! Is that not right? Do you want some too?”

–Well, eating the same thing would be a good shortcut to clearing things up, wouldn’t it? Michelle felt that Veldora had that in mind when offering some to her.

“Thank you. I shall accept.”

She received the plate with a little hesitation.

And then she began to eat. A fork and knife had been brought

out seemingly from nowhere, and she used them to cut out a piece and bring it to her mouth.

The way she ate was like an example of sophistication.

You wouldn't imagine someone like her eating something as commonplace as pancakes, and yet she somehow looked good doing it.

“—It's delicious.”

She muttered.

While it was not all that in terms of presentation, the taste felt so nostalgic to her.

It was not like the refined food she ate in the city. It felt very homemade.

And through eating the pancakes, the sense of caution the children felt towards Michelle began to fade away.

She was human just like them.

Michelle noticed this change and smiled.

That sealed the deal for them.

The smile of a beautiful woman is most potent indeed. Even those who had been sure they were going to be killed a moment ago were softened by that smile.

Everyone was now relieved, as they wholly believed that the battle was now over.

But then again, there were now some who began to feel anxious in a different way. What was Michelle's purpose?

“Uh, um...General...Michelle? From what you just said, you have not really come to purge us afterall...?”

It was Karman who asked the first question.

He had been called a traitor, after all. He anxiously scratched his head.

Then Michelle looked at him with a puzzled expression.

She chewed, her mouth full of pancake; savoring the taste before swallowing it.

It was a childish gesture that did not match such icy beauty.

She smiled with satisfaction and then glanced at Karman.

“Purge...?”

And then she thought about it—

“Oh, that! Hiragi was making such a fuss about it. You know how he can be like. I don’t think you are a traitor just because you let the resistance escape. After all, what would that make me? I’ve been sending them resources all this time.”

—She dropped this bomb as if it were an afterthought.

“What!?”

“Sending resources!?”

“Wait-wait-wait! General Michelle!? What do you mean...?”

Michelle looked at them without concern.

“It’s just as I said. In the first place, if I really meant to have you purged, I wouldn’t have come here myself. Quite the

opposite, really. I came here so you wouldn't be killed."

She said all of this in a light manner as if it were below her pancake in terms of importance.

Those of the resistance were very shocked by this.

"What!? But she is the leader of the empire..."

"So... Who have we been fighting all this time?"

"I can't believe it. Is she trying to trick us?"

Etcetera.

No one could believe Michelle. And they did not know how to react.

And so Sharma stepped forward as if to represent all of the adults.

“I am Sharma, leader of this department. General Michelle, I have a question, if you do not mind?”

“I don’t. Ask me anything you want.”

Michelle replied casually.

She had no intention of hiding anything at this point.

Of course, being believed was a different matter...

“Well then. The first question... Is it true that you have been sending us resources up until now?”

“That is true. I have always felt that we should help each other, as we are the same species. However, the reality is that

this is quite difficult. A city was destroyed through a revolt. It will be quite a feat to change the minds of those who live in the city now.”

“Please wait. Then why do you send us supplies? As protector of the city, are we not your enemies!?”

“It cannot be helped that you would think like that. However, I think it is horribly twisted that we must see each other as enemies when our number as a species has fallen so low. Still, we cannot take in every refugee either. What I can offer now is a place to live and hide. Also a small supply of food.”

“In other words... You could not take us in, but you wouldn’t abandon us either? Why could you not tell us that...? Then maybe...”

All of this fighting would not have happened—Sharma was about to say this, but she was interrupted.

“It’s nothing but hypocrisy!!”

Rindo shouted.

He was glaring at Michelle with eyes that burned with hatred.

And then he continued his attack.

“You want us to suffer while you live in comfort. And yet you have no shame at all!!”

Michelle glanced at Rindo without changing her expression in the least.

This was because she was talking to Sharma, the representative, not Rindo.

“Rindo. Be quiet.”

“But—!?”

“That’s an order. Michelle is talking to me. I am speaking for us all!”

Sharma was intimidating enough that Rindo became silent.

Though Sharma did feel that Rindo’s outburst had allowed her to realize that Michelle had yet to address the real issue here.

“...I see. In other words, the people of the city do not trust us...”

“Yes. You people were unable to trust us as well. You would have suspected a trap and we would not have been able to cooperate. After all...”

It was impossible for every survivor of the great war to enter the cities.

And so there was a need to select.

Fairness was lost. As was justice.

Those who already lived in the city and the refugees. They were all human life. And it was because of this, that individual talent became the deciding factor.

But who could decide?

—How could humans who are not God decide the worth of a human?—

And so the standard for selection became very simple.

Those who already lived in the city and those who didn't.

Such an explanation would not be satisfactory.

Of course, it wouldn't.

And so the Emperor of the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine initiated it without explanation and by using force.

Michelle explained this to them, but it was meaningless.

She never believed that they would understand.

Which was no surprise, as she herself did not understand.

“–That was the decision at the time. No one could go against it. I know you will not understand and I realize you must be angry. However, it is the truth.”

“Understand!? How dare—”

Rindo stopped here and broke into a fit of tears.

The others all listened to Michelle in a state of shock.

It was hardly a surprise.

The difficult lives they had lived, the deaths of friends, all manner of hardships—There was no clear reason why it had to be them who had been burdened with it all...

“And so why...are you helping us? Do you want to prolong our suffering!?”

“No, that’s wrong. The man over there was close. I don’t care if you call us hypocrites. However, I truly want to do good.”

“Bu-but...”

“One day, the cities will no longer be able to function. When that time comes, the people who have been living comfortably will find it very difficult to survive. So, from the perspective of danger management, wouldn’t it be important to consider all kinds of possibilities?”

“In other words, as long as we survive, the cities can fall?”

“Yes.”

“That is—that is an incredibly arrogant way to think!!”

Sharma shouted, but Michelle didn’t budge.

Belief in what you were doing was right. It was something she had decided on the moment she joined the military.

It was justice in her eyes.

“Well then, let me ask you this. What do you think would have been the right thing to do back then?”

“Th-that...”

Sharma hesitated.

She had not been born back then, and yet not a day went by where she didn't think about it.

She hated this world and wanted to know the reason that the empire had made things this way. It was because of those crimes that they felt they were on the side of justice.

But was it really right to say that the empire was evil—Sharma had always had this doubt in her mind.

“You cannot answer? Well, let me tell you then. If they had made the wrong decision back then, humanity would have gone extinct long ago.”

Michelle declared without hesitation.

“You are saying that you helped us because we could possibly be a way for humanity to survive? Do you think we would believe that? The words of someone who stands at the top of the empire?...”

There was pain in Sharma's voice.

She was now finding it difficult to believe that Michelle was lying, however, it was too much to take in all at once.

“Hmmm. We will not be able to start negotiating if you do not believe me...”

Michelle said in a troubled voice—

“Surely it is fine now, General Michelle? Miss Sharma, Rindo. I am working for the empire. I am sorry for hiding this from you. But it was necessary...”

Zaza had been watching quietly up until now, but he suddenly opened his mouth.



There was an uproar after that, but Sharma silenced them with a shout.

Still, it became necessary to move to someplace quieter.

They were currently in a corner of a warehouse that was used for meetings.

“Why was I called here as well?”

“It’s probably because everyone knows you are amazing now, master?”

“Oh? Tell me more!”

“Uh, like I said...”

“Lord Ramiris is right. You did wonderfully in that fight. So that is what happens when Lord Veldora gets serious! I was very

impressed. It is no wonder that your presence was required here!”

“Hoho! I see!”

Such words were exchanged in the room, but no one else chimed in.

Michelle was the only one who looked at Veldora with interest. But she still gave little more than a curious glance.

Ramiris and Beretta looked at each other and sighed with relief. Veldora was quite happy and satisfied now.

It was very peaceful and no one had a problem.

And it was in that atmosphere that negotiations began.

“First, I want you to let me explain.”

It was Zaza who started.

Before the great war, Zaza was a soldier who was supposed to have been stationed in the seventh city, which was the one that had fallen.

He was a first lieutenant in rank and would have led squadrons...but the great war erupted before then.

Zaza's family—his beloved wife and daughter lived in the farming district instead of the city.

Zaza didn't know what to do.

Even if he went to the city now, it was already covered in flames and there was nothing that he could do.

In that case—Zaza took his men and decided to help the refugees instead.

He was worried about his own family, but he prioritized work that was close to the city rather than the countryside.

And his sense of responsibility as a military man led him to prioritize the mission rather than his family.

However, this decision would mean misery for Zaza.

The fighting had started in the city, but it soon spread to the countryside. The whole world was wrapped in the flames of nuclear weapons.

There was no such thing as a safe place outside of the city now.

The countryside was no longer safe, and there was no hope of survival for Zaza's family.

Amidst guilt and regret, Zaza hoped to at least protect those who had survived.

He heard that the sixth city was taking people in, and so Zaza escorted the refugees.

However, this gave birth to the worst tragedy of all.

The fall of the sixth city.

There was mass chaos. Zaza's men were pulled into it and forced to fight.

But who was a friend and who was foe?

The people who he had been escorting attacked him and Zaza was wounded.

But the cannons of the city soldiers who struck back also hit Zaza. All four of his limbs were blown off and his unit crumbled.

It was chaos and confusion.

It was Michelle's troops, who were working at regaining order and retaking the city, that ultimately saved Zaza from death.

And while he was saved, everything was finished by the time that he regained consciousness.

Yes, everything.

I want to die—it was as Zaza was thinking this that Michelle came to see him.

And she said:

–If that life means nothing to you, I will take it. Not for the empire, but to protect those who have survived. Help me–

Perhaps the memory had been idealized, but those words were like a treasure to Zaza.

And so he became a cyborg soldier and worked as an informant for Michelle.

“So, that is how it happened. I pretended to have discovered hideouts that General Michelle prepared. And then I told you all.”

“And...what about the surviving generators and life-support machines...?”

“Aye. General Michelle’s trusted men brought them while making sure that no one knew about it. After all, did you really think there would be machines that had been damaged so little?”

“Now that you mention it...”

Rindo nodded as Zaza’s explanation started to make sense in his head.

Zaza was also the oldest out of all of them.

It was true that without Zaza, the resistance would not have been able to maintain their size all of this time.

They had recognized him as a purely military man who had survived the great war. And so there were some who felt that it was odd that he had never become a leader.

Zaza went around to each base and seemed to find new places to hide before an old one became uninhabitable.

Zaza always called it good luck, but if this was the reason for it, then it all made sense.

So all of his accomplishments were due to Michelle's support.

It was proof that what Michelle said was the truth.

“So that's why. I was wondering why there was a cyborg just like me amongst the resistance.”

“Tsk. So you noticed?”

“No, not really. I just thought that the technology seemed out of reach for them. It wasn’t until you said that you couldn’t eat pancakes that I began to suspect.”

Karman added that he became sure of it after seeing the way he had reacted to Michelle.

Outwardly, Zaza had the same detailed features as humans. He did not look like he was built for battle.

As the resistance was low on resources, they would not have been able to make such changes just to increase his lifespan.

Besides, it wasn’t the new modification technology that used enhanced organs and required food—it was the old type that was the exact same as Karman’s own modifications...

It was technology from over one hundred years ago. If it was still operating today, if only the brain was still human, that

would require an incredibly difficult procedure.

So Karman was able to guess at what Zaza was, as he had undergone the same procedure at the same time under Michelle's order.

“In the first place, I could tell by the way you talked to her. You're an awful spy!”

“Hey!”

Ramiris declared. Veldora laughed.

Zaza scratched his head and said, ‘I am ashamed.’

He said that he could not tell what Michelle was trying to do, and he had been caught off guard once he saw that Veldora was fine.

“Fool. As if I would lose. That’s why I don’t care for weak people...”

“You don’t get it! If General Michelle wanted it, we would have all been dead!”

“And I’m calling you a fool. From what I heard she doesn’t even have a reason to try and kill us all. And so it is normal to think there is some other purpose. Zaza, you should have realized that!”

“Uh, that is true, but... Well, ultimately, it was quite a show. Wasn’t it?”

Zaza chuckled awkwardly.



Now, on to the main subject.

Everyone was shocked by the revelation that Zaza was a spy, but one cough from Michelle had them all tense again.

“I am sure you have a lot you would like to say about me and the city. But I ask that you set them aside for now. The reason that I came here directly is because I have sensed a disturbing presence within the city. I can no longer trust those on the upper level. It has become difficult to determine who is on my side. And so I want collaborators on the outside. Though, it is very sad and ironic that you are all more trustworthy than the people of the city...”

“Wait a minute. A disturbing presence? What do you mean?”

“Exactly. You sound as if you are saying you have enemies within the city. But no one in the resistance has ever succeeded in entering it. What is this enemy you are afraid of...?”

Rindo and Sharma were quick to question her on this point.

Michelle seemed to think about it for a moment before opening her mouth.

“Yes, since I am asking for your help, it is only right that I tell you. However, this must be kept a secret—”

And so she began to tell them.

Even Zaza had not known about it. This ‘shadow’ that Michelle was facing.

In the first place, what was the cause of the great war?

The biggest reason was the forecast about starvation. That and the explosively rising population.

Still, even if that forecast hadn’t been made, you could say that the collapse was only a matter of time.

“Don’t you think it is strange? If those who entered the city didn’t have to work, that would mean less work every time a city was made. It was said that people would be selected through a lottery, but that was not the case. Those who were brilliant or had good genes were selected first. That was how the five cities

gained their population...”

They nodded as Michelle explained.

As long as the labor force was so connected to the completion of a city, it would be difficult to continue building cities once a certain number had been completed.

Whatever the deciding factor was, it was really just a trigger.

No, if anything...

“...Once you have finished acquiring a certain number of brilliant personnel, they cut off and abandoned the rest. That’s what I started to think.”

Michelle paused here.

She looked around to see the reaction of the others.

Sharma was closing her eyes and seemed to be deep in thought.

Rindo looked shocked.

Zaza remained quiet, perhaps he had already sensed it.

Karman was smoking his cigar, processing the information in his own way.

“That... Is there proof...?”

Sharma asked.

Michelle nodded.

“No proof. It is all my own speculation. However–”

-However.

The seventh city did not have enough troops to defend themselves.

On top of that, the defense systems were incomplete and would not activate. That was why the city became the first casualty in the war.

They had taken in refugees from the sixth city, which resulted in their ruin.

After that, the other five cities united. They now had a reason to refuse any refugees entry.

And that was how the Mechanized Empire of Almsbine was born.

The population that had been on the rise suddenly began to plummet. All the technology of the world was now focused in the empire.

If only the radiation that polluted the world could be removed...no, even that...

-What if all of it had been planned?

Every incident may look unrelated when viewed by themselves, but if looked at from a bird's eye view, you might see a different picture.

It all seemed to move too conveniently for the empire.

“Then!! Are you saying that it was all planned by the emperor!?”

Sharma shouted in horror.

However, Michelle remained calm.

“I have no proof. Even circumstantial evidence is weak. Still,

it is also true that the dots connect when considered in this way.
And that is why I have been investigating in secret.”

She continued calmly.

And then...

“And so, I want people that I can trust. Please, will you help me?”

She said.

.....

.....

...

They all sat in silence.

They were unsure about how they should react.

They didn't know if they should say yes or no.

It was in this oppressive atmosphere that Veldora's laugh suddenly echoed.

“Kaaahahahahaha! Help you? Very well! We were just talking about crushing this empire or whatever you call it. So it is perfect. Of course, you will also help, won't you?”

He said as he put a hand on Zaza's shoulder.

“Hey, what!? You know, you really should...”

Zaza was confused, but he soon made up his mind.

“Well, I had already offered my life to General Michelle. And so I will believe that this is for the good of the rest of humanity!”

He said. Then he smiled at the laughing Veldora.

Next, it was Karman and his men.

“Huh. In that case, I will also help you. If the great war really had been planned from the beginning, it would make everything I have done up until now a joke. I cannot stand the thought. Can the rest of you?”

“No!”

“No!”

“No!”

Their resolve was firm and they were united. And so Karman and his men agreed to help.

“In any case, our future is tied with cooperating with the empire. I cannot make any promises regarding what the other branches will say, but this branch, or at least me personally, I will believe you.”

“...Indeed. Even if Zaza was connected to you, I do not see it as a betrayal. My decision is the same as yours after hearing your story. I will believe you, Michelle.”

All her doubts and fears were pushed aside momentarily. Sharma decided to put her faith in Michelle.

And Rindo seemed to have decided as well.

“So we’ve decided then! Well, I just have to follow master!”

After all, he’s the one that will take all the blame if we get in trouble! Ramiris thought.

There wasn't any point in even hearing Beretta's opinion, as he followed Ramiris.

And so they all promised to cooperate with Michelle.

The result of this was that Karman and his men would now work under Zaza.

Zaza had been a first lieutenant, which made him a superior to Karman in the chain of command.

As for Sharma and the others, they would leave this place and head to a new hiding place that Michelle had prepared.

While Michelle's power was currently shutting them off from the surface, she would ultimately burn it all down and make a report about how she had killed all of the members of the resistance.

And under Michelle's guidance, they decided on their future direction.

The only thing left was the role of Veldora and the others.

“It’s finally our turn. So, Michelle or whatever your name is. What do you want us to do? Should we go now and attack?”

“What! What the hell are you!? As if you would have a chance if you went and attacked now!!”

“Yes, Zaza is right. Even if General Michelle is your ally, the empire still has three others of the Machinery Four. And there are other officers as well. You don’t have a chance of winning!!”

“That’s right, Mister Veldora. I am an amateur when it comes to fighting, but it would be foolish to try and fight now. You must allow the investigation to continue so the enemy can be singled out!”

Veldora had volunteered enthusiastically, but Zaza, Karman and Rindo berated him.

As for Michelle, she wondered why Veldora seemed to love to

fight so much. Or at least, her expression seemed to say so.

“Master. I don’t think this is the best timing to go all out like that...”

Even Ramiris moved frantically to stop him.

She felt that it would be very dangerous.

And Beretta...

He was good.

“The star of the show should appear at the very end, don’t you agree? It would be unwise to sell yourself so cheaply. That is what I think...”

“Hmm!?”

He was used to this, and so he knew what to say to get Veldora's attention.

He did not need to rely on skills. One word could be enough to manipulate Veldora.

“At the very end, when you know the enemy well and that woman called Michelle is struggling in the battle. That is when you can swoop down and help them. That would be quite easy for you, wouldn't it, Lord Veldora...?”

“I see. You have a good point, Beretta! So I can make an appearance at the end and take the spotlight, eh? That's basic stuff!”

It was really all he thought about and usually failed at, but Veldora didn't remember any of that now.

He decided to take Beretta's advice and obey Michelle.

“Then, Veldora. I want you to escort these people as they

relocate to their new home. There are many dangers on the surface, so they will need all the help they can get. And I am sure that you are capable of dealing with any situation.”

Michelle was the only one who had guessed at what Veldora was truly capable of.

And quite accurately as well. She believed that he was stronger than herself.

And that was why she gave him the most important task as a sign of respect.

They would fight once she had evidence. In other words, there was more than enough time to take the non-combatants to safety.

And so Veldora listened to Michelle’s request and agreed to go with Sharma on an escort mission.

Once that was settled, Sharma turned to Michelle.

“So, if we are to believe your words, it is possible that the Emperor was behind all of it...?”

“As for that, the investigation is still underway. However, as I said before, we do not have any proof yet. I don’t even want them to know that I have suspicions, which requires that we move cautiously. So I cannot give you an answer quickly...”

“I see... However, General Michelle. Is the emperor not your own father? What will you do if he really was responsible...?”

“What does it matter if he is my father? I will defeat evil. I cannot imagine hesitating in doing it.”

Michelle made this declaration with such a strong show of will, as if to cut through whatever fears and doubts Sharma and Zaza had.

She had carried this suspicion for decades. And she had decided that she would defeat the person behind it once she found out, no matter who it was.

However, Michelle was not sure if her father the emperor really was the man behind it all.

And she would not act until she was certain.

She would decide once she had evidence that she could really trust.

And in preparation for that moment, she wanted to unite the resistance.

—Lastly, she asked that they gather together volunteers for combat personnel. And then Michelle ended the meeting.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 10

Manifestation of Evil and the Super Beast Raid

The Mechanized Empire of Almsbine: Barzephon.

Just as Veldora and Michelle encountered each other, a meeting of leaders was being held under the name of the emperor of Almsbine.

Six people had gathered.

Emperor Almsbine.

Prime Minister Fudora

Governor-General of East City, General Kristoph.

Governor-General of West City, Lieutenant General Alvin.

Governor-General of North City, Major General Amit.

Representative for the Governor-General of South City,
Brigadier Jegyll.

—The most powerful in the empire.

Prime Minister Fudora stood up and scanned the room before
declaring the meeting had begun.

And with that, Emperor Almsbine opened his mouth gravely.

“...Where is Michelle?”

It wasn't the subject of discussion, just a show of concern for
his daughter's whereabouts.

It was Michelle's adjutant, Jegyll, who answered him.

“Unfortunately, Your Majesty, Michelle has gone out to purge the traitors.”

“Hmm. It is fine, I do not blame you.”

Almsbine said.

His voice had no emotion, and it was difficult to know what he was thinking.

It was the same with Jegyll as well. She felt an immense pressure just being here as a representative.

One amongst these few generals.

They were all so different in rank from her.

The Emperor who ruled the empire.

And the one who supported him with his mind, Prime Minister Fudora.

And–

The Governor-Generals of each city were the same rank as Michelle and known as the Machinery Four.

It was no wonder that she was nervous.

“While it is a problem that one could not answer the summoning of the Emperor, perhaps there was a miscommunication? In that case, we cannot fault you.”

Prime Minister Fudora said as he went to the main subject.

“Leaving that matter aside, the reason that you have all gathered here today, was so I could tell you that the time has arrived.”

“The time? What do you mean?”

“Yes. I shall explain.”

Kristoph remained silent, and so Alvin spoke up first.

Kristoph was a hero.

A true military man who led the army during the great war.

After that, he helped his friend Almsbine ascend to the seat of Emperor.

Alvin was Almsbine’s son and Michelle’s older brother.

He was carefree and brilliant.

He was always the first person to ask questions at meetings

like this.

He was not afraid of anything and was the life of the party.

“In fact, several plans have been underway in secret, and they have started to bear fruit. Especially the pollution removal process that we are experimenting with at the sacrificed Six. It is going very well. Most of the underground has been purified and we are thinking about moving to the surface.”

Prime Minister Fudora explained with a thin smile.

Those who listened had no idea what he was talking about, and they bore expressions of confusion.

“Wait, Fudora. What do you mean? Sacrificed Six...!?”

Alvin must have sensed something sinister there because he frantically asked for an answer.

Kristoph remained silent, but his eyes gleamed sharply.

Amit continued to look at the table. His posture had not changed at all since the beginning. It was not even certain if he was interested.

As for Jegyll, she was most surprised by Fudora's words.

Six—the only thing she could think of was that it must be about the sixth city.

That meant...

“Hehehe. You are all very good at pretending to be oblivious. There is no need for that. Surely you all knew? Ten billion people were killed in order to create a foundation for the empire. How can you act so surprised over having to sacrifice fifty million residents?”

There was a madness in Fudora's smile, but no guilt at all.

And it was Alvin, not Jegyll, who stood up with furious rage.

“Bastard! Do you understand what you are saying!?”

He shouted with a look of hatred.

Alvin had been consulted by Michelle, and he was one of those who worked undercover for her.

They had not been able to find any evidence until now, and yet here the culprit was, boldly making a declaration. It was probably more than Alvin could have ever imagined, Jegyll thought.

It was none other than his father, Emperor Almsbine himself, that soothed Alvin.

“Calm yourself, Alvin. It was I who ordered the experiment in Six. Do not blame Fudora...”

He said as he ordered Alvin to sit down.

‘But...’ Alvin muttered, but ultimately obeyed his father and sat down.

“Hehehe. Very good, Your Majesty. Your resolve is most admirable!”

Fudora said to the emperor.

He had an obscene smile on his face, making it very clear that he was not speaking sincerely.

It was too casual an attitude to have towards an emperor.

Perhaps he had gone too far because it was not only Alvin now, but Kristoph also looked at Fudora with a sharp stare.

And just as he opened his mouth to warn him—

“—However, Fudora. Is it not too early to disclose such information? Why did you do it? Is that why you had everyone gather together here in my name? What are you planning!!”

The emperor questioned Fudora in a threatening voice.

No one could defy the emperor who had ruled this empire for over a hundred years.

Yes, until now...

Fudora smiled confidently and maintained his arrogant attitude.

“Oh, nothing serious. I was just...”

“What? What is it, Fudora?”

“I wanted Your Majesty to be unburdened. That is what my

unworthy self was thinking.”

“You lack respect, Fudora!!”

Kristoph had been silent up until now, but he began to yell at Fudora.

Still, the fiery anger of a hero such as Kristoph was not enough to change Fudora’s expression.

He looked at Kristoph coolly and said:

“Kristoph the hero. Surely you also knew of the emperor’s will? Cull the population from a world moving towards destruction, allowing only those who are brilliant to survive. Bring stability to the world while becoming a great criminal. Then have the new leaders judge you. Is it not such a commendable self-sacrifice...”

The words that Fudora unleashed were enough to make the room grow cold.

“...What!?”

“It cannot be. Father, is this true!?”

“No, no...”

Shock ran through the room.

As if expecting this reaction, Fudora stood up and began to talk with a rapturous expression.

“Surely there is no problem now, Your Majesty? You should tell them and unburden yourself!”

“This is ridiculous. Have you gone mad, Fudora!? The world is still polluted, we are far from reaching stability. The time is not right...”

“Silence, you senile fool!! The only reason that I was forced to

take action was that you had complete control of the Mobius System!! If I had that system, all the energy problems would have been solved. And yet you...!!”

“What are you saying!? I told you that it was not complete! It was just a dream, Fudora. It was something that exceeded our capabilities as humans!!”

“Silence!!”

Fudora shrieked as if he had gone mad. But then he suddenly regained his calm.

And then he smiled evilly—

“Your Majesty. It really is all your fault, you know?”

This final part of the plan that had been secretly underway was now activated in front of Fudora’s eyes.

It happened at the same time.

Alvin was the first to move.

He stood up to apprehend Fudora, and took a step forward.

He was able to perfectly control the advanced features of the Machinery Four with Machinery Arts. He was even able to erase the shock waves as he moved like the wind.

However, that was the signal.

The first one to move is your target. That was the decision made between Fudora and the other party.

And that person was part of the Machinery Four, just like Alvin—Major General Amit.

Of course, his exposed back was completely unguarded, and so

Amits attack caught Alvin right in the back of the head.

The energy turned into vibrations and reached Alvin's brain.

A second later, Alvin's head exploded like an egg that had been heated in a microwave.

"I am glad that it was you who moved first. The thing is, I never did like you, Alvin."

Major General Amit was the Governor-General of North city and the younger brother of the emperor.

However, his heart was full of jealousy towards his brilliant older brother. And the sense of inferiority about being related to such a great emperor had eaten away at him.

He was the lowest of the Machinery Four, and that only made him more resentful.

Prime Minister Fudora had seen through him and seduced him with sweet words, leading him to the crime now committed.

“Alvin!? Amit, you bastard!! What did you...”

The emperor shouted.

Amit laughed unconcernedly.

His next target was the brother who was the root of his resentment. Emperor Almsbine himself.

Amit seemed to vanish as he rushed towards the emperor.

However, his murderous hand was stopped by a will of iron.

It was the hero, General Kristoph.

The strongest of the Machinery Four was standing in Amit's way.

“Why don't you abandon that man and help me? I will raise you up if I become emperor!”

“I refuse. My loyalty is to my friend, Emperor Almsbine.”

“So you will get in my way, Kristoph? Well, you will regret that decision!”

A vicious battle began.

It was a battle of the strongest cyborgs, the Machinery Four. And none could interfere.

Jegyll had to back away so that she did not get caught in it.

She tried to move to protect the emperor, but...

“Stop, Jegyll!”

Jegyll froze at those words.

(What!? I can't move...!?)

She was horrified.

“You can't move? I am the one who modified you. And so I can take your freedom of movement with a word. Besides, what good would you be in such a fight? Be quiet and stay out of their way.”

It was Fudora's voice.

“Fudora. What do you want?”

“Didn't I tell you, Your Majesty? I want the Mobius System. It is unfortunate that Michelle is not present, but it has also raised

the success rate of my plan. Only Kristoph and Michelle remain of the Machinery Four. If Kristoph is killed here, then that will only leave Michelle. In other words, I win.”

“You fool. You underestimate Kristoph. Even if they are equal in features, Kristoph’s brain is on a different level. Amit cannot win against the founder of Machinery Arts!!”

Emperor Almsbine sounded quite confident.

The Machinery Four had been modified by the Emperor himself. And among them, Kristoph boasted a strength that made him the greatest of them all.

They could all see that Amit was being pushed back in the fight that played out before them.

It was clear that there was a difference in power.

In fact, Amit’s Ether Ring Barrier had been shut down, and the light was starting to grow dim.

It was only a matter of time before his defeat.

Unless you took them by surprise, it was impossible to take down the Machinery Four in one hit.

And so Kristoph calmly pushed Amit towards the point where he would no longer be able to fight.

However, Fudora continued to look confident.

“I’ve gathered enough data. Now is the time. Kill him!”

The Emperor and Jegyll, and even Kristoph himself—could not understand what had happened.

Everyone but Fudora and Amit could only watch the scene in silence.

A hand had burst out from the chest of Kristoph, the strongest

hero.

And this hand, was the hand of none other than the one whose head had been destroyed; Alvin.

Amit sneered madly.

“–Wh-what!? But your brain was destroyed...how...”

Kristoph asked in shock. He had been dealt a lethal wound.

The person who replied was Alvin. His head had now completed regenerated.

“It’s quite simple, General Kristoph. I am not Alvin. I am an artificial lifeform made by my father, Fudora–a Bionoid. However, I will absorb the genetic information in this human called Alvin, as well as the biocomputer equipped in this body. That includes his personal memories and skills. You might say that I am Alvin reborn.”

“Haaahahahahaha! That’s what it is. Alvin pretended to be dead so he could attack you, Kristoph. But if it had been you that moved first, I would have destroyed you with this hand!!”

“That’s impossible—!?”

“Ggg...Your Majesty, I am sorry...”

Emperor Almsbine was shocked and confused.

And so, leaving his emperor alone, the hero Kristoph ceased to function as a lifeform.

“How can it be...how can...”

Fudora looked at the emperor and declared coldly:

“Don’t worry, Your Majesty. Kristoph may have died, but he will not go to waste. He will be reborn as a stronger Bionoid.”

He said.

And then Fudora produced a sphere, which he then set into Kristoph's chest.

"Your Majesty. It is true that the Machinery Four, your greatest works, have wonderful capabilities. The Auto-Healing ability allows them to regenerate, and then there is the incredible durability brought by the special alloy. They can use space expansion and are equipped with high-output nuclear reactors. Their power is several times stronger than our other weapons. But more than anything, they individually have the Ether Ring Barrier, which is the heart of the city's defense. It is no wonder they are considered to be the strongest... However, that is a thing of the past. The Bionoids that I have created have the flexibility of living beings. See, as evidence..."

As Fudora talked with a look of ecstasy, the fallen Kristoph began to rise from the floor.

It left only the important organs, the rest were absorbed and broken down and then rebuilt.

It still looked like Kristoph, but the insides were completely different.

However, the memories and skills, everything about Kristoph had been replicated completely...

No...

The aging face of Kristoph had regained the features of his youth.

The biological cells and memory cells that do not age were able to read Kristoph's genetic information and recreate it. It was not his current age, but a younger face that was full of the power of his best days.

It would seem that such appearances had little meaning for a cyborg, but that was not the case.

Degradation of the brain, ability to make decisions, recognition and reaction speeds would occur.

Such weaknesses were now gone, and Kristoph had been reborn as the strongest Bionoid.

But he no longer had a heart. His will was to obey Fudora.

“...Greetings, father. I am Kristoph, your shield and your sword. I await your orders.”

And like that, the most terrifying Bionoid was born.

Emperor Almsbine was too shocked to speak.

His most trusted friend had died in front of his eyes.

And on top of that, he had been reborn as the most dangerous of enemies.

It was no wonder that he was at a loss.

“No-no...and Alvin!?”

The Emperor finally realized that Alvin had not betrayed him, but had been remade in secret.

It was obvious, considering he had regenerated a head that had been destroyed.

“Yes, that is very perceptive of you. He refused to help me, so I had no choice.”

“Bastard!!”

“Hahaha. Didn’t I tell you? This is all because you continued to hide the Mobius System. That would solve all our energy problems. With that power, we wouldn’t have to wait for the results of these sluggish experiments. We can purify this world!”

“I told you. That...”

“Silence! I have no intention of following your slow plans!!”

“Exactly. Brother, I agree with what Fudora is saying. I do not want to be the emperor of such a wretched world. I want to rule a planet that is beautiful. And so our aims matched, and I agreed to help. You can die in peace and leave the rest to me.”

Amit surrendered to his evil desires and stared at the Emperor.

Kristop and Alvin—the two Bionoids watched on in silence.

Fudora watched this with the conviction that his ambitions were halfway to completion.

The time had come.

One part of the plan that had been carried out in secret had now been achieved.

These four had been modified by the Emperor himself. They were the finest works from the mind of a genius.

As the old Emperor could not replicate them, they could be called a 'lost art.'

And so it had been necessary for Fudora to develop technology that could go against them.

And he had done it.

Human experiments had been carried out in secret and data was collected.

And finally, Fudora succeeded in his lifeform modification experiments.

He implemented it on himself one month ago.

Things moved quickly after that.

Amit had secretly agreed to help him. They lured Alvin and then killed him.

And then he was reborn as their greatest pawn, a Bionoid.

And now...

Their biggest obstacle, Kristoph, was in their hands. Michelle was the last person in their way.

As for the clown who only had his position because he was the Emperor's younger brother, he could be dealt with at any time.

“Haaahahahaha!! Brother, this is goodbye!! Leave the rest to—!?”

Kristoph's fist slammed into the fool's head, destroying it in a

flash.

Fudora nodded with satisfaction before preying on the body.

And by doing that, he himself was recreated into the strongest being.

—The special lost arts of the Emperor were now combined with the fruits of his research.

And with that, the old body of Prime Minister Fudora also transformed into a youth with black hair.

“Fudora...you...”

The Emperor muttered in shock. Fudora looked at him with a surprisingly gentle expression.

“Your Majesty, no, Senior Al. You really weren’t fit to be

emperor. I will do the rest for you. But I just need to take your knowledge...”

And with that, Fudora granted Emperor Almsbine eternal rest.

That was the end of a man who had ruled an empire for one hundred years.

“...Now. It seems that Michelle really has hidden the Mobius System. I am glad that the plan succeeded, but it’s annoying that we have more work to do. Still...”

Then Fudora looked at Jegyll.

“We have bait. I can use this thing to get her without any difficulty.”

He said with an evil laugh.

“N-No! Stop...!!”

And then—Jegyll’s consciousness was swallowed by shadows.

Her wish was in vain. She would also be reborn as a Bionoid.

Become a pawn for Fudora, stripped of free will..

And like that, his plans went to their final phase.



—Five days had passed since Veldora and the others arrived in this world.

The sounds of something sizzling as it cooked echoed.

That should be enough to predict who it was.

Veldora.

Veldora was cooking again. This time there was meat on his grill.

“Hey—you!! You! What is wrong with you!?”

And the person who was shouting was also easy to guess.

Zaza.

He had been with the rear guard, but the moment they stopped to set up camp, he had been met with a sight that caused him to scream in abandon.

“Kaaa-hahaha! You’re late, Zaza. We’ve already started, you know? But don’t worry. I saved some for you!”

Veldora said with a smile.

Obviously, this was his way of bullying him.

He liked to tease Zaza, who could not eat.

“Stop this at once! In the first place, problems always seem to arise whenever you start cooking! It’s almost as if that grill is cursed!”

“How rude! I had this grill prepared for making snacks. It is by no means a haunted item!!”

“That’s right, Zaza. Master’s grill is a normal grill. But then again, saying that could raise a flag!”

“Kahahaha! Don’t say that, Ramiris. What will you do if something really does happen?”

“That’s true, master. I will be careful!”

“Yes! You should do that.”

Zaza couldn't stay angry while these two talked.

He finally regained his calm and asked the biggest question that was on his mind.

“This is such a dirty place. How did you even...”

Zaza said that much before suddenly freezing.

He had been so angry that it had escaped him at first, but he now realized that the sight before him was incredibly strange.

After separating with Michelle, they had gone down an underground passage that led to the surface.

This was so they could head to a different hideout that Michelle had prepared for them.

As they were nearly one thousand people in all, progress was slow.

And the journey would have been hard even without factoring that in.

This was because they had to gather protective suits that were left at different bases along the underground passage, and everyone had to wear them.

They were like astronaut suits in structure, and supplied the wearer with enough nutrition and water to survive for a week without taking them off.

But while there was some mechanical aid, the suit was still heavy and a burden on the wearer.

It was one thing for adults to wear them, but it was very hard for children.

After some time, there were some people who started to get

sick, and so it had become necessary to stop and rest...

You couldn't even eat with the suits on.

While they did offer nutrition, that just meant drinking liquid food from a straw.

You could not eat the meat that Veldora was cooking unless you removed the suit.

And this was the surface.

The atmosphere was polluted by radiation and toxic gases.

Taking the suits off here was the same thing as committing suicide. Only a crazy person would start cooking meat here.

And yet...

Right in front of Zaza's eyes.

Children were happily eating cooked meat and vegetables.

(What the hell is happening?)

Zaza could only watch in shock.

“While it may be hard to believe, Zaza. This area here isn't polluted for some reason...”

Karman, who was also part of the rear guard and also very surprised, said as he reported the substance analysis results.

In surprise, Zaza asked Rindo, the captain of the advance team.

“Ri-Rindo! What's going on here?”

“Ah, this. It really tastes amazing!”

“You idiot! That’s not what I was asking!!”

“Haha. Mister Zaza. I am only joking. Well, Mister Veldora suddenly said, ‘If we’re going to have a picnic, let’s make it a barbecue! The weathers great for it!’”

“So it was him after all?!”

“Yes. But I thought it was odd that he would say that about the weather...”

Just then, Zaza realized that it was oddly bright around where they were.

As his vision was seen through mechanical eyes, it had taken him a while to notice it.

But in fact, the place was filled with a light he had not seen in years. In other words, it was sunlight that shone down on them.

“...Can it be...the sun?”

Zaza looked up in surprise.

There was a light that shone so bright that it was blinding.

It was the sun.

The sun should have been covered by thick clouds, but now it was showing its face.

The truth was that Veldora had used his power to blow away the clouds and purify the atmosphere in this area.

After that, he had used ‘Probability Manipulation’ to adjust things so that more pollutants wouldn’t fly towards them.

It was an incredible thing to do so casually, but only Ramiris and Beretta knew of it.

“I can’t believe it. The sun!?”

“The environment here is not normal...and...”

Zaza was stunned.

However, Rindo spoke to him calmly.

“There’s no point in thinking about it. According to Mister Veldora, ‘We’re lucky. Such a thing can happen with enough amazing ‘probabilities’ overlapping!’”

He had said it with a smile.

(That’s ridiculous!!)

Zaza screamed inwardly.

However, the reality was that this place was safe, and everyone had taken their suits off and were enjoying the barbecue.

As Rindo said, it was stupid to worry so much about it.

And so Zaza returned to Veldora.

With no purpose in particular, he sat down on a rock and watched Veldora work.

He looked so happy as he cooked the meat—which had unknown origins—on his trusty grill.

Karman came to down to sit next to Zaza and then offered him one of his cigars.

“Thank you.”

“It’s nothing. Zaza, I’ve been thinking. That guy is probably a lot greater than we’ve assumed.”

“Aye. I think so too. I don’t want to admit it, but his boundless cheerfulness has saved us. However, it pains me to see things that way. After all, he’s also quite the troublemaker...”

“That’s true. Even when General Michelle came, he started frying pancakes on his grill.”

“Right? And this meat. Where did he get it from? The more I think about him, the more mysterious he seems. I don’t even know how to talk to him anymore.”

“Hahaha. But he doesn’t seem like a bad fellow. However, uh, ‘flags’, was it? I would not be surprised if something happens again.”

“Hey-hey, stop that Karman. Everyone’s out here without their suits on. We wouldn’t be able to deal with any trouble.”

It was just as Zaza had finished saying this.

Karman’s expression froze on his face.

“Hey-hey, stop it. Do you think this is funny?”

Zaza laughed as he slapped Karman on the shoulder. Then he followed his eyes—and saw it.

That thing that should have been in the world of the underground.

The thing with paranormal abilities, mankind’s enemy.

It was called—the Super Beast.

“I told you this would happen!! That grill is cursed!!”

Zaza’s scream thundered.

And with that, the sudden arrival of the beast turned the scene into one of chaos and fear.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 11

Secret of the Super Beast

Super Beast.

They were a disaster that had suddenly appeared in this world.

It was said that they were creatures who had mutated after the war due to contamination, but the truth was shrouded in secrets.

The one thing that was known about them was that they lived and bred in the deep world of the underground and never came to the surface.

While the underground passages were said to be safe, there were still places that were contaminated.

That was why it was important to wear protective suits.

So even there, there was a possibility of being attacked by a Super Beast.

And since they were escorting nearly one thousand residents, it was decided that the tunnels were too dangerous.

This led to the alternate option, putting on the protective suits and going to the surface...

Zaza and the others of the defense team spread out frantically and looked up at the giant beast that loomed over them.

It wasn't alone.

There were multiple Super Beasts that surrounded them in a semi-circle.

“Tsk. I would be able to fight them just fine if I had a Powered Suit...”

Karman said angrily.

It was true.

With the firepower of the Powered Suits, such a fight would be easy.

However, the only weapon that Karman and his men had now were the cyborg Plasma Gatling.

This was because Beretta had destroyed all five suits.

The Plasma Gatling was a frightful weapon that sprayed superheated energy bullets, but it was still an anti-human weapon.

It was not enough against a giant like a Super Beast.

After all, the most notable feature of the Super Beast was its

ridiculous ability to regenerate.

Even if you severed their limbs or tentacles, they would grow back.

And so the only way to defeat them was by destroying more than two-thirds of their body at once.

This would require burning them or some other method to annihilate them.

It was more than possible with the Powered Suits, but impossible with any small weapon.

Those who were enjoying the barbecue now froze. It had all happened so suddenly that they did not know what to do.

“Damn it! We’ll lure them away. Run when you get the chance!!”

Zaza shouted at the adults.

“We can’t, Mister Zaza! There are Super Beasts behind us!!”

It was Rindo who answered.

As he stated, Super Beasts had appeared behind them out of nowhere.

They were now completely surrounded.

On the other hand, the children did not understand the situation and remained calm.

They were surprised to be sure, but not enough to let go of their plates.

There were even some who were bold enough to snatch meat off of the plates of the stunned adults.

After all, Veldora was their hero, and Veldora continued to cook the meat as if nothing of note was happening.

This was enough to assure them that nothing was wrong.

In fact, when Karma had come, and when Michelle had come, Veldora had always been cooking something. And every time, things had ended without much trouble at all.

The grill may have seemed cursed to someone like Zaza, but to the children, it was a symbol of safety.

As for what Veldora and Ramiris were doing...

They glanced at the Super Beasts with carefree expressions as the meat sizzled.

“Hey, Ramiris. Those things are apparently called Super Beasts.”

“I see. But, Master... Don’t you think...they look pretty unimpressive?”

“Yes. As you can see, they don’t attack us because they are so afraid.”

“Lord Veldora, it cannot be helped. Unlike humans, beasts have an instinct that allows them to see an opponent’s strength.”

“It seems to be the case. But I don’t like this. How will I be able to show how amazing I am...”

“Uh, Master. I want more meat!”

“Are you listening, Ramiris? This is the most important part, alright?”

“I think you should just give up on that.”

“Besides, the children already trust you Lord Veldora. You can make people understand your greatness without rushing to do things.”

“Hoho. I see. That is very true. They might respect me after using my skills, but that doesn’t seem quite right. I won’t say who, but someone from Rimuru’s homeland did the same thing and suffered for it.”

“That’s right, Master. I was just thinking the same thing.”

“Yes, yes. I don’t think it is right at all. There is no need to rush. That is very true.”

“Then that’s settled then, Master. Now, I’ll have another!”

Veldora clicked his tongue at Ramiris’s lack of concern in the matter, but he still gave her another slice of meat.

He was also cooking more for the children.

Veldora was a surprisingly kind and caring person.

Ramiris ate it with a delighted expression. She stuffed the food into her mouth at such a pace that one would wonder how it all fit into such a small frame.

The children also seemed oblivious to the panic of the adults. They continued to enjoy the barbecue.

Unlike Zaza and the others who were incredibly tense, their world was peace itself.

However, this was soon interrupted by Zaza's shouting.

“Hey, HEEEEY!! How can you all be so calm!? Stop your reckless meat-eating and prepare to allow the others to escape!!”

Zaza could no longer ignore it. Blue veins popped on his forehead as he complained.

Veldora looked at him with an exasperated sigh and answered.

“Oh, Zaza. You must calm down. There is no need to escape. Especially since you’d have to wear those pesky suits once you leave my barrier. Besides, don’t you agree that it would be faster to just get rid of these rude monsters who are disturbing our meal? In the first place, I doubt such small fry could even get into my barrier...”

“What are you talking about!? Things are never that easy! Stop this nonsense about barriers. We need to make sure everyone gets changed while the monsters are watching from the outside...”

“I told you to calm down. There is no reason to be alarmed over such weak creatures. I wouldn’t even need to do it myself. Beretta could do it.”

“Mister Beretta!?”

“It would be a simple thing if I were ordered...”

“What...!?”

Veldora realized that Beretta would get all of the credit again, but he didn't mind this one time.

After all, he had already become quite popular through cooking the meat.

And it wasn't just the children, even the adults were singing his praise a moment ago.

They had exhausted so much of their energy during the past few days of tiresome travel, and then he had served the best barbecue meat imaginable.

So it was no wonder they adored him now.

And while he was annoyed that these Super Beasts had interrupted things, in Veldora's mind, they were too weak to pay much mind.

Of course, this was only by Veldora's standards.

When judged as a monster, they were about A-Rank, and an especially strong Super Beast might be the equivalent of the Psuedo-Demon Lord Class.

The Super Beasts came with such dangerous special abilities including ultrasonic waves, poison, and degrading enzymes. Even if there were some who considered them weak, they were still a dangerous opponent.

However, this world did not have magic essence.

The Super Beast was restricted to the laws of this world. That made them a joke to Veldora.

While Karman and his men had weapons of science that had posed as an unknown threat, these Super Beasts did not.

This was all clear through Veldora's 'Seeker of Truth.'

Veldora was not interested in bullying the weak, in other words, he did not care about the spotlight in this particular instance.

Besides, the Super Beasts may have just understood his strength by instinct, because they had not moved in to attack ever since their arrival.

From Veldora's point of view, he did not want to attack any who feared him so much.

“To be honest, they are no different than birds, dogs, cats, rats, or snakes who have had a little genetic modification. Beasts with a little extra power and abilities, I suppose?”

Even Ramiris agreed with him.

Beretta understood it too, but he was not enthusiastic.

He would move if ordered, that was all.

“Damn it, it’s no use! The Plasma Gatling is too weak! They are able to regenerate so quickly that we are dealing no damage!!”

Karman shouted as he approached them.

They had known it would be a tough fight, but now they were out of ammunition.

Without ammunition, they could not attack. And so he had returned.

“Karman. Fear has affected your ability to make decisions. You should stop such futile attacks once you suspect it will not be effective. You could have raised your chances of survival by hitting the ground or boulders instead, causing a dust cloud. However, it is all unnecessary now. After all, I am right here!”

“Yes, that’s true...what? What are you...?”

Karman readily agreed with the first point.

He regretted his mistake deeply.

But at the same time, understanding of the rest of Veldora's words came, and he was confused.

“Look. I do not know why, but there is a mysterious barrier surrounding us.”

“Mysterious? But you did it, Master...”

“Shut up! This safety zone was created against unimaginable odds, and now the Super Beasts are unable to enter.”

Veldora ignored Ramiris and started creating his own story.

He was acting as if his earlier explanation had not happened, which of course, was completely futile.

“No, no. That's not what you've been saying. You said that

the barrier was made by you...”

“Zaza. You really should stop interrupting me. Who cares about what was said earlier? The problem is these beasts. Look, one is trying to come after Karman!”

Zaza was quick to point it out to him, but Veldora was hardly bothered.

Not only that, but he tried to direct everyone’s attention to a monster that was trying to invade the barrier.

Veldora was pointing at a particular monster that had been chasing Karman.

Perhaps it was so enraged that it forgot itself, because it charged forward, ignoring the warning that its instincts were raising.

A most dramatic change occurred the moment the Super Beast touched the barrier.

“GRRRR—GYAGYAGYAAGHH—!?”

It let out a horrible shriek as if it were experiencing unimaginable agony.

Upon closer inspection, the tiger-like stripes were falling away and the tentacles on its back began to crumble like dust.

“What!? What is happening?”

“Mister Veldora. Did you do something!?”

Zaza asked in shock, but Veldora did not answer.

He just inspected the Super Beast quietly and muttered to himself.

The tiger-like Super Beast frantically jumped away from the barrier.

It no longer tried to enter. It just paced in front of it as if it were angry.

The stripes and tentacles had already started to regenerate.

It hadn't gotten through the barrier, but it did not take much damage in the end.

Veldora saw and began to chuckle mischievously.

"I see. Super Beasts, did you say? I understand what they are now."

"Yes. Your Purification Barrier is able to dismantle and purify contaminated material, isn't it, Master? The fact that it began to break down upon touching the barrier means that it is made of contaminated substances."

"It is most surprising. A creature that has evolved from something other than magical essence."

Veldora, Ramiris and Beretta were all nodding with realization, while the others were left behind.

“Hey-hey. What are you talking about...?”

“Can you explain it so we understand?”

As Zaza and Karman looked on in confusion, Veldora and the others explained them their deduction.

And they had gotten very close to the exact truth.

And then, as if to deliberately feed Veldora even more information, two to three other Super Beasts began to attempt to enter the barrier.

However, much like the tiger-like monster, they ended in failure.

However, there was one snake-like beast that was especially large. It seemed to have become provoked by the failure of the others, and it so it came forward.

“Oh? I sense a strong will in this one. Is it a leader?”

It was a great serpent with a purple body and red head.

There were wings on its back. It was imposing in a way that separated it from the other Super Beasts.

As Veldora said, this was likely the one that united the others.

The leader monster hesitated for a moment when touching the barrier, but then it began to force its way inside.

Cracks appeared on its skin, but its regeneration ability was working faster than expected.

“Oh? This will be entertaining. I know. I’ll take care of this one myself.”

Veldora looked on with amusement before making this declaration.

The children all heard this and erupted into cheers.

“So cool!”

“Mister Veldora is awesome!!”

“Don’t lose!!”

Etcetera.

Veldora’s ears twitched at this and he smiled broadly.

“Hey, hey. Are you sure? I know you are probably stronger than I initially thought, Mister Veldora. I am not doubting your skill with Machinery Arts. However, that thing can heal at an incredible rate. You do realize you will have to do immense damage in order to defeat it?”

“Karman is right. We get that you are great. Now, please step back and leave it to Mister Beretta. Surely he is much more suited to the task?”

Karman and Zaza were worried about Veldora.

However, Veldora laughed as if it were not a problem in the least.

“You two have got it all wrong. I have told you many times, I am stronger than Beretta. It seems that this thing is the only one that can enter the barrier, so you do not need to worry about everyone’s safety. Well, just consider that it is impossible for those who believe in me to be hurt while I am watching!”

He said with a boisterous laugh.

The great serpent in front of Veldora was certainly strong.

If you just looked at the physical strength, it was up there with the Pseudo Demon Lord Class.

However, that was it.

Even the fact that it was getting through Veldora's barrier was nothing noteworthy.

After all, while it was called a 'barrier' all it was was a space where pollution was removed.

It was not something like the 'Multi-Dimensional Barrier' that Veldora had used when seriously trying to protect them.

The truth was, there were reasons that up until now, Veldora had concentrated on defense while leaving the fighting to Beretta.

One was so he could decipher the laws of this world.

The other was so that by concentrating only on defense, he would be able to deal with anything that might happen.

It looked like he wasn't thinking about anything, but he actually had considered what was important.

As long as there was no magic essence in this world, the accuracy of 'Universal Perception' would drop.

And that was why Veldora used the power of the 'storm' to use the atmosphere itself as a monitoring eye.

And now, after a few days, through the use of 'All of Creation' and 'Seeker of Truth,' he was able to grasp the laws of this world entirely.

In other words—He completely grasped the nature of this planet.

And because of this, Veldora was currently able to use his full power.

He was able to use the majority of the power he had in the other world without relying on magic essence.

So it was now easy for him to protect everyone without having to focus entirely on it.

“GRRAAAAAGH—!!”

The large serpent charged forward in an attack.

Veldora saw this and smirked.

“Yes, yes. I have no intention of toying with those who are afraid. But if you wish to challenge me, I will oblige!”

And with that, he lightly brought up his right fist and thrust it

out.

“Dragon Punch!!”

Perhaps he wanted to use it since he had just learned it.
Vibration Fist Wave.

“That really is a terrible name. He should take notes from my
forty-seven special moves.”

“Oh, you mean like Drop Kick or Fairy Chop? Yours seem just as
bad...”

“What did you say, Beretta?”

“...Uh, nothing.”

Ramiris and Beretta whispered to each other.

However, Veldora was in such a good mood about being able

to finally take action, that he didn't care what they said.

He ignored them and attacked the great serpent.

Veldora had slipped right in front of the great serpent and his right fist had shot towards the purple scales that were strong enough to go against a tank.

Contact.

The moment it happened, shock waves spread through the great serpent's body.

“GGGAAHHH——!?”

It let out a painful scream.

Scales flew from all over its body and the skin on its red head became visible.

During the previous fight, Veldora had completely mastered the art of converting his energy into vibration waves.

“Kahahahaha! What do you think? Is it not very impressive?”

He looked down at the great serpent that had been thrown to the ground. Veldora laughed confidently.

Everyone watched in awe.

“Wh-what the...!?”

“Hey, hey. Is this real? You can’t be serious...?”

“No-no...it’s impossible...”

“Can it be? His power must be the same as General Michelle...”

“It’s unbelievable. How did he do that with his bare hands...”

“Aye. It is well known that you must use heavy weapons to completely burn Super Beasts. And yet he used his fist...”

“This is beyond ridiculous.”

Shock.

That was all.

They all watched this scene that seemed too far from reality that they could not believe it was actually happening.

Most of them started to wonder if they were in fact dreaming.

However, children were less cynical.

“Amazing!!”

“I knew Mister Veldora was the best!”

“So cool. He really is so cool!!”

They were incredibly excited.

And so was Veldora.

(Kahahaha! Finally, finally, I have entered the spotlight!!)

He was thrilled.

“Oh, dear. Master’s getting carried away now.”

“I don’t see why it’s a problem. It’s better than when he gets sulky. We should think positively.”

“That’s true. Still, master seems to have come to understand the laws of this world.”

“Yes. I’d expect nothing less of Lord Veldora. The spirit power is now becoming more active.”

Ramiris chuckled but was somewhat proud at the same time.

He was a dragon after all. And he wasn’t called the strongest for nothing.

As Beretta said, the spirits had not been very active here in this world before, but that had changed thanks to Veldora.

This was because Veldora commanded the storms and he had activated that power.

All sunlight had been blocked from the surface for so long, and now, while it was only a small area, it was shining down on them.

The effect was most dramatic. The spirits that had been asleep had begun to awaken.

This obviously meant that Ramiris was also able to use a wider variety of magic. And Beretta's power would increase.

The twenty or so Super Beasts were not even close to being a threat.

"I commend your bravery in challenging me! And now you can help me practice some new moves!"

Veldora said as he fell on the great serpent that was on the ground.

The great serpent was roaring.

It was an order.

Even the other Super Beasts that were afraid of Veldora's barrier were unable to ignore it.

And so the twenty Super Beasts all started to move at once.

However, Veldora remained calm.

There was no need to panic.

By completely understanding the atmosphere, his 'Universal Perception' view was now whole.

And so he was able to defeat multiple Super Beasts with one hit.

“Kahahahaha! It doesn't matter how many of you there are. You should stop this meaningless resistance!”

He laughed loudly as he defeated every single one.

It all happened in just one minute.

It was overwhelming.

“...Hey, are we all dreaming?”

“Hahaha. I have been very tired recently. I was also wondering if I was dreaming.”

“We must be. After all, this is not possible!!”

It was possible to kill the monsters with enough firepower.

However, Veldora was keeping them alive while stopping their movement.

Super Beasts.

Their ability to regenerate made them close to invincible. They were humanity's strongest enemy.

Fists, kicks and headbutts...

He wasn't killing the Super Beasts, but making them unable to move.

It was outrageous—that's what all the adults present were thinking.

"Now, you are the last one left. Will you still not give up?"

Veldora was looking at the great serpent with the red head.

Perhaps the snake could understand Veldora, because it hissed with rage.

"The fact that your spirit hasn't been broken is quite

impressive given how weak you are. However, there is nothing you can do now. So, why is it that you hate humans so much?”

The adults were most confused when Veldora began to talk to the great serpent.

Especially Zaza and Karman. As soldiers, they wanted him to hurry up and deal the final blow.

But Veldora took no notice of their questioning stares. He stood as if waiting for the great serpent to reply.

“GRRRAAAA—!!”

A roar.

It was still very hostile, and it’s jaw opened wide in an attempt to eat Veldora.

“Hmph!!”

Veldora’s heel rose high into the air and slammed into its forehead.

The forehead tore open and purple blood flowed.

The snake flailed around as if it had gone mad.

–And then.

Something started to emerge from the tear in the forehead.

It was in the shape of a human.

A young woman with long, red hair.

“I see. So the the base really was human.”

“It looks like it. I suspected it because it would require a high level of intelligence to control the other Super Beasts.”

“The fact that it was not afraid of Lord Veldora shows that it’s instincts were weak. No, perhaps the hatred and anger were just too strong... In any case, fighting battles you have no hope of winning is more than enough proof that something is human.”

Human.

Super Beasts were created based not off of dogs, cats or other animals, but intelligent creatures. Humans.

Zaza and the others were speechless.

“But... These are Super Beasts...? Humanity’s enemy... But you say they used to be...human?”

Sharma muttered this as if she could not believe it.

No one else could say anything.

“I suppose it cannot talk. ‘Thought Transmission’ could be used with magic essence, but I do not like deciphering the actual thought waves.”

“Lord Veldora, that is something I am good at. I can tell that this woman has endless hatred towards humans. It seems that she was betrayed and abandoned by a lover and along with many others, became the subjects of experiments.”

“Oh?”

“What kind of experiments?”

“Mutations, special...toxin decomposition... Her mind is not right, so it is difficult to read much of her memories...”

He could recognize her will and emotions, but even Beretta had trouble deciphering precise information.

Especially since he was a visitor from another world with a different language.

But even before all of that, it was likely that the Super Beast herself did not even understand what kinds of experiments had been performed.

“...However, the conclusion I have come to is that these Super Beasts were created by humans as creatures made to perfectly fit their environment.”

Beretta reasoned based off the information he was able to get.

Upon hearing this, the adults, especially Zaza and Karman, who had memories of the far past, instantly turned pale.

“It can’t be...”

“Man-made... If that is true, wouldn’t it be most likely that it was our homeland...?”

Even Karman's men were muttering to each other in shock.

It was no wonder.

They had all thought of the Super Beasts as enemies up until now. However, the possibility had now surfaced that they were once people from their old home.

And Karman...

"From our homeland...? Lover...betrayal...? No, it couldn't..."

-He was stunned. He could not look away from the thing that thrashed in pain in front of him.

"So, Master. What are you going to do with these Super Beasts?"

"Hmm. Look, Ramiris. These things had been inside of the

purification barrier for a while now. Their skin keeps coming off and regenerating over and over again. Unfortunately, there are no signs of them returning to what they once were. Decompositioning the polluted substances takes away its power, but the once mutated cells will not return to normal.”

“...So, in other words?”

“In other words, it will be difficult to return them to normal. In that case, it would be best to put it out of its misery...”

Karman began to move just as Veldora said those words.

“Wait! Could you not just let them go? I can’t think of them as enemies once you brought up the possibility that they could be from home... At least give us some time to think!”

Karman said as he raised both hands and stood in front of the Super Beast.

Veldora nodded.

“I don’t mind. But...”

Something moved as if to interrupt Veldora’s words.

It was the Super Beast.

The human shape that grew from the red forehead had tried to bite Karman as his back was towards it.

“GGAAA!”

However, it was not successful.

Veldora moved his arm and blocked the fangs.

“...You do know that these things are no longer human?”

Karman looked at the Super Beast as if he were frozen.

What Veldora said was true, it was not human.

Karman could understand that himself.

The long red hair was filthy and clung to her skin.

While she still looked like a young woman, the skin was covered in purple scales and it seemed more monster than human when you looked closely.

But what was the most grotesque, was everything under the torso.

Her body was united with the snake's forehead.

It was a twisted sight. You could hardly believe she had been human.

And yet...

“...I found out much later, but the research that was conducted in the city that was our home, it had to do with the creation of special pluripotent cells. It would degrade toxins and pollutants. This research would give birth to people who could live in all kinds of environmental conditions. This fits with Mister Beretta’s theory!! And so it makes me think...maybe Brigadier Karaf and Charles were alive and...I...”

Karman watched as the Super Beast bit Veldora’s arm and moved wildly.

There were no tears. Karman’s modified body had no such function.

Still, a sense of forlornness he hadn’t felt in decades suddenly filled his chest. He felt it deeply.

“We are asking you as well!”

“I can’t help but wonder if one of my friends are in there...”

“Aye. Hell, this one could have been my younger sister!”

“Yes, please let them go. I’m begging you!”

Karman’s men all started to plead at once.

Veldora looked at them calmly and muttered that they were being foolish.

When a prisoner of such emotions as hatred and anger, you become unable to consider others and repeatedly act hideously.

And that’s what they were now. Were they still important because they were from home?

For those that were important, some would do anything without question.

Those with weak hearts and who were too foolish to see the

whole picture were easily used and tricked.

This was the nature of humanity, and it was the same in this world as any other.

—However, that was precious in its own way. That was what Veldora thought.

“Kahahaha. Very well. You weak, little fools. I shall listen to your wishes.”

And then a wind started to blow around Veldora.

It blew gently between the people and then surrounded the Super Beasts.

And—

“I will let you go this time. But don’t think I will have mercy if

you bother us again, alright?”

He showed his will as an absolute being. And with that, Veldora cast the Super Beasts outside of his barrier.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 12

Great Modifications in an Old Battlefield

The Super Beasts left quietly.

Their instincts must have told them that they could not win against Veldora.

Veldora and the others did not even bother to watch them leave. They quickly cleaned up after the barbecue and renewed their journey.

During the silent march, Zaza made a decision and approached Veldora.

“Ah, um...Veldora, sir, uh, lord? I would like to ask you something...”

Zaza seemed very anxious about talking to him now.

“What is it Zaza? What happened to your usual brazen attitude?”

“Uh, no, it’s... Ahahahaha...”

He tried to hide his awkwardness with a laugh.

It could not be helped.

When he thought back on the way he had treated Veldora, he had to realize that he had been incredibly rude.

Veldora just grinned mischievously and teased Zaza.

This was very unbecoming, but that could not be helped, since it was Veldora.

After all, Veldora was an evil dragon by nature.

And so he continued to toy with Zaza for a while until he got bored.

“Hmm. No, it is better when you talk normally. Being so formal is no fun at all.”

“What!? I wasn’t talking like that for your amusement—ah!”

“Kahahaha! Yes, yes, that’s much better!”

“I am very sorry for everything I did! I didn’t realize how great you really were, Lord Veldora...”

“Oh, Zaza. I find it creepy when you call me that. You can just say ‘mister.’ However! Do not forget to be respectful, alright?”

“Creepy...what do you think...”

“Oh, don’t worry about it. It’s nothing Zaza.”

“Alright, alright! I’m starting to think maybe it was a misunderstanding that I thought you looked so amazing a while ago...”

“Kaaaahahahaha! What a funny little joke, Zaza!”

And like that, they returned to their usual banter.

Veldora enjoyed it this way, and so while he continued to act grand, he allowed Zaza to speak casually.

Veldora preferred to be friends with people instead of having them fear him.

“So, Vel-, Mister Veldora. Who are you?”

Zaza asked his question.

Everyone else was also interested in this question, and the

surrounding adults perked up their ears.

“Hmm. It is no secret, really. But would you believe me?”

“Yes, yes. Of course, I would believe! After all, we’ve already seen such a ridiculous sight as you punching a Super Beast!”

The adults nodded silently to this.

“Master. Why don’t you tell them the truth? I bet they won’t believe you anyway.”

“I agree. They will not believe you.”

Ramiris and Beretta whispered. Veldora felt the same.

But he did not care if they believed him or not.

“Then I will tell you. I am a visitor from another world. You can call me the result of supernatural power...or more simply, the dragon who controls the storm. Yes.”

Veldora got bored of explaining and ended it abruptly.

He didn't know what religions existed here, but he didn't think they would understand if he said he was a god or a holy spirit.

“Hahaha. Like from a myth?”

“How nostalgic. I almost forgot that people used to pray to a god.”

“Religion faded away once people started living in the cities. Why pray to a god that doesn't help you when you can trust the city to protect your lifestyle.”

Rindo and Sharma said.

As Veldora predicted, they no longer believed in such things anymore.

“So. Seriously, what are you...?”

Zaza had decided that Veldora was just joking, and so he asked him again.

However, Veldora just laughed.

“Kahahaha! Don’t worry. All you need to know is that I am amazing. And then you cannot go wrong!”

Zaza agreed. There was no point in hearing any more.

Because it was true, Veldora was amazing.

By what principle, technology or features, it was all unknown. But it was probably some top-secret, advanced technology, he

thought.

Of course, they were all underestimating Veldora.

They still saw him as human.

To them, Veldora was a high-powered cyborg who might just be able to take on, if not beat, the Machinery Four.

It was a big mistake, but they were unable to realize it yet.



The party continued to walk for some time.

The protection suits were heavy, just like an astronaut's suit. And even though they aided the wearer in terms of mobility, they could not go very fast.

At most, they could travel about 5 kilometers in an hour.

While they did not get too tired, it was mentally exhausting to have to repeat the same movements repeatedly.

The children found it especially tough.

And so it was with an apologetic voice that Karman began to talk.

“Really, though. While we don’t have to worry about Super Beasts because Veldora and Beretta are here, it will still be dangerous if those of the Empire found us. Now, if only we had our Powered Suits, we could fight...”

“Indeed. Our Plasma Gattling is out of ammunition. And we are cyborgs who mainly fight with weapons. Our basic features are not that advanced.”

“But we have been trained well. We could at least buy some time...”

“General Michelle sent us on this escort mission, and yet we’ve had to rely on Veldora to fight the Super Beasts...”

However, Veldora did not care about it at all.

“Don’t worry about that. So, you call that armor a Powered Suit? Yes, it was quite strong. However, Karman, it’s not very fun just being strong, you know? It’s boring. It was amusing enough the first time. But you wouldn’t stand a chance against Beretta if you fought him again.”

“...That is completely true. They wouldn’t stand a chance. Not even if there are ten of them.”

“Wait-wait-wait. Yes, we did lose to you, but surely it was not by such a margin...!?”

Karman had to argue back when he heard Beretta’s words.

However, Veldora agreed with Beretta.

“No, Karman. Beretta is right. The only reason that Beretta took any damage, in the beginning, was because he did not know the nature of the attack. It is no threat once he knows. Which means that it was not much, to begin with.”

“But, it has tremendous power! It is equipped with the Neutrolauncher, the latest weapon from the Empire!”

“Ah, that thing.”

Veldora nodded.

Yes, that was quite powerful.

Veldora could admit as much.

“But, Karman. That weapon not only has a long gun barrel, but it makes a faint sound when being launched. It would not be difficult to find the target point you know?”

“What?!”

“The target point. Beretta would figure it out and distort space in that area in order to alter its course.”

Karman was about to say something but swallowed it.

The sound?

Calculate from the length of the barrel and predict where it would land?

He knew the timing, and so was able to deal with the attack?

There was a lot that he wanted to say but he knew the answer already.

Beretta was nodding his head as if in agreement, and Ramiris was laughing as if this was all common knowledge.

(Who are these people! I don't understand. What kind of features must they have to think this is normal...)

Karman was tired of being surprised all the time.

And then Veldora suddenly opened his mouth as if just having an idea.

“Karman. Why don't you just have the children design you something?”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“What? It's very simple. You can take that Powered Suit or whatever it's called, and have the children create weapons to attach to it. We retrieved the machines that Beretta broke, so perhaps we can fix them if we have the right parts?”

What nonsense—Karman thought. But the children were very happy at this.

“I want to do it!”

“I’m tired of walking.”

“I want to rest for a while!”

It hadn’t even been half a day since the barbecue, but that was their reaction.

“Wa-wait, Mister Veldora! I didn’t say anything because the children were so enthusiastic, but I don’t think you should expect much from...”

Even Zaza disagreed, but Veldora wasn’t bothered.

“You say that I shouldn’t expect much, Zaza. But I am quite serious! Besides, this thing about the Powered Suits is just a side-project. I was really thinking about acquiring a vehicle of some sort.”

“What do you mean...?”

“If there was a broken vehicle, Beretta would be able to repair it. Then we could travel faster, no? It will be six days soon. If we do not arrive at this destination soon, we will miss the appointed time!”

“Time? What are you talking about?”

Ramiris and Beretta knew.

It was almost 1 week.

In other words, it meant the day that Rimuru returned was approaching, and they needed to hurry up and return to their own world in order to destroy all of the evidence.

They would pretend that nothing had happened and wait before coming back to this world again.

Now that they had read the information of this world, it would be possible to connect the Different Gate to this dimension once again.

But since he had made a promise to Michelle, Veldora intended on finishing the current mission.

He wanted to return to his world after they had escorted the people to the new base.

So with this considered, he decided that it was necessary to increase their speed.

The worst-case scenario would involve him showing his true form and taking everyone there.

But he very much wanted to avoid that.

And so he thought of preparing a vehicle.

“So, what do you think Zaza? Is there such a place where we might find a vehicle and parts to repair it with?”

Zaza thought about it.

He felt that there was no point in asking Veldora as he had no intention of answering.

It would be wonderful if such a vehicle could be acquired, but Zaza didn't think that it was likely.

But on the other hand, he had witnessed Beretta's ability to repair things, and so there was a part of him that hoped.

“If I'm not wrong, there is an old Empire testing site up ahead. It's currently a junkyard for old weapons...”

“Alright. Let's go then! We can play with all kinds of—we can prepare!”

Veldora said in conclusion.

Sharma laughed. Rindo shrugged.

The adults sighed in exasperation. But there was a look of trust towards Veldora and the others as well.

As for the children, they cheered at the prospect of the time of rest—and delicious food—that would be coming.

No one objected, and so it was decided that they would all head to this abandoned testing ground.



An hour had now passed since Zaza had led them to the old testing ground.

Everyone was now absorbed in the search for materials.

They had also all taken off their protective gear and were dressed lightly.

Obviously, this was because Veldora had purified the area.

The children and Veldora were now staring at the ground and seemed to be having a passionate debate.

They inspected the parts the adults had gathered and argued over how to assemble them.

Beretta calmly went about repairing and modifying. Ramiris watched him and complained about the choices she didn't like.

This continued until the sun began to set.

Then the children cleaned out old trenches and slept in them.

As Veldora had also isolated the place within a barrier, they

were all able to sleep without their suits on.

No matter how advanced the suits were, you could not get much rest if you had to sleep while sitting up.

And so it wasn't just the children, but even the adults slept a deep sleep as if to make up for the past several days of exhaustion.

Next to them, there were those who did not sleep.

Veldora, Ramiris, and Beretta.

Zaza was patrolling the area as usual, so it was just these three that remained now.

They were whispering to each other, careful that their voices would not be heard by anyone else.

“Hey, hey. What about this idea? You can put beam cannons on both shoulders and also the head. And then the chest can open up and there will be another one! Isn’t that amazing? Isn’t it cool?”

“Are you stupid? You can’t equip beam cannons all over someone’s body. The engine won’t be able to power them! Besides, with only a heat release plate and conductive heat lines, there is no way you can keep the thing cool enough! And adding so much garbage does not make something look awesome!”

“But Lord Veldora, there was a child that asked if you could install two engines. And it is not impossible, so perhaps we can at least have the cannons on both shoulders.”

“Hmm. I see...”

Etcetera.

They were testing the ideas gathered from the children during the day and seeing which were viable.

All of Ramiris's ideas considered nothing but her personal tastes.

The current plan was to secure a means of transportation and new weapons for Zaza and the others while everyone still slept.

They had already finished the vehicles.

Five large transport buses that could carry two hundred passengers each. The vehicles had been completed quietly and were now parked in a line.

They had gathered parts from destroyed tanks and reused them.

The basic structure had already gone through 'Appraisal' and it was determined that they would run just fine without the need for a test drive.

Even in this world, their skills were very good.

They removed the 200mm rail guns, which were the main weapons, and improved the stability and speed of the vehicles.

Thanks to that, in spite of the legs being like a caterpillar, its maximum speed now exceeded 100km/h.

They had also considered comfort, and space expansion had been used to make the seats more spacious. There was even an area where you could lie down.

As for the distance that they could travel... After all, they were equipped with thermonuclear fusion engines, as long as the body of the vehicle did not break, it could run nearly forever.

They would no longer have to walk around on foot. Travel would be much easier.

As it was a caterpillar, bad road conditions did not matter, and they were sure that they could reach their destination on the next day.

And then there was the new equipment for Zaza and the others.

This was the current topic of discussion, and they were not united in their opinion.

Ramiris wanted more power.

Veldora talked about the importance of aesthetics over utility.

Beretta tried to make them come together, but his efforts were like a candle in the wind next to these stubborn two.

“Really, why can’t we make it so they shoot out destructive rays from all over their bodies?”

“What would be the point in that? It will hit our own men!”

They argued.

Beretta was tired.

It was getting annoying. And so he decided to leave them and started repairing the equipment on his own.

First, he pulled out the Powered Suits that were the least damaged and lined them up.

And then he disassembled them.

As he did this...

“Hmm. It will be easier to imagine after seeing the real thing.”

“That’s right, master. Now that I think about it, Zazy can use this, right? Then we can make a few of them. Even if we install all the beam weapons on it, you can just think of them as commander cannons. I think that’s a great idea!”

“Perhaps. As Beretta said, we could add two engines and raise its power output.”

They said. The two had stopped fighting and were now watching what Beretta was doing.

“First, we should decide what the main weapon will be.”

“Oh?”

“Beretta. Do you have an opinion on that?”

Beretta nodded.

Beretta’s opinion often leaned towards Ramiris’s opinion.

He was like his master.

Long Live The Giant Ship Cannon Cause!

Men had a tendency to romanticize big guns.

And there was a good reason for it too. As long as you did not misuse them, they were very effective weapons.

And so Beretta had no issue with adding high-powered weapons.

“First, the Neutron Launcher. This has quite a punch. It’s a must.”

“It sure is!”

“Hmm. I understand.”

“However!”

Beretta shouted heatedly.

“If you put your arms together to make a cannon, the enemy will immediately know that you’re about to do something.”

“Whaaat. Why? But it looks so cool!”

“Hmm. Hmm. I thought it looked cool too, but that is a good point...”

“That’s right. In this instance, coolness has nothing to do with it, Lord Ramiris.”

“Ugh... Fine. Next.”

Beretta nodded.

And then they continued.

“As for this weapon, it was probably made in this style due to the confidence that the enemy will not be able to do anything once it is fired. It does not require much time to prepare, and there are no fatal flaws. However, I have a better idea.”

So saying, Beretta began to draw on the ground while explaining.

It was not a wearable Powered Suit, but a Battle Body that could be considered a second body.

He also had ideas for improved Cyber Bodies and new Powered Suits.

The Powered Suit would be equipped with converted high power firearms that would usually only work in a Battle Body.

And while none were able to shoot beams from their entire body, most of Ramiris’s demands had been fulfilled.

“Hmm!?”

“Very impressive, Beretta. This is a design that contains all my hopes and dreams!”

The two of them forgot that they had been arguing, and they stared hard at the designs on the ground.

“I see. This new Battle Body houses a nuclear fusion reactor in its heart from the beginning. Indeed, if I were to use ‘Space Manipulation,’ the space expansion technology could be much improved. It could help with power shortages as well. And...”

“Yes! Yes! The beam weapons are on the outside! Now we can have lots of them and they can be exchanged depending on the need. This is amazing, Beretta!”

“I am not worthy of such high praise.”

After that, they talked about whether they could not make even more interesting weapons with the remaining parts.

The debate grew increasingly more enthusiastic, and their

mischievous side took hold, resulting in the most shocking modifications being made.

Of course, the consequence was obvious...

“So, Zaza. Which one do you want?”

“What? What is...”

When Zaza and the others returned from their patrol in the morning, they saw a line of super weapons with fearsome power.



Ramiris looked proud.

Beretta was full of a sense of accomplishment.

Zaza had a distant look in his eyes.

Karman and his men stood there in shock.

The children looked at the buses and the line of weapons with shining eyes.

The adults talked about how the buses had been there when they woke up. It was so removed from reality that they could not believe it.

Veldora watched these reactions and laughed loudly.

“Kaahahaha! Now, all of you. You must ride these vehicles so we can get out of here. Zaza. Stop standing there like a fool. You and Karman must decide who will use what weapon!”

“Wa-wait a minute! Before we do anything, where did this all come from!?”

Veldora tried to run through it as if it was nothing, but Zaza demanded an explanation.

However, it was Karman who tried to calm him.

“Now, now, Zaza. I think it’s time we accept things. Those people are not normal. It’s the way things are. Let’s just accept it and use these weapons.”

He showed surprising adaptability. Karman had decided to accept these weapons as reality.

Sharma and Rindo followed.

“Lord Veldora. How are these used?”

“Miss Sharma. These things happen to be my specialty. Leave it to me!”

“Ah, Rindo. I’ll leave it to you, then. Lord Veldora. Thank you very much. Now we shall be able to travel safely.”

They settled in very quickly.

They had decided that it was a waste of time acting stunned, and it was better if they lived with a positive mindset.

Hey, hey. I’m the only one being left behind... Zaza wanted to cry.

However, no one cared about him. So he had no choice but to get on the bus.

“So, Zaza. Are you prepared to have your brain transferred to the new machine? As we predicted, it’s you and Karman who are best suited for these Battle Bodies.”

Veldora said.

Beretta and Ramiris were currently operating on Karman.

One of the buses had a workshop on the second floor that also acted as a weapon storage. It was possible to perform simple operations there.

Zaza didn't say anything anymore.

As Karman had said, there was no point in agonizing over what Veldora and the others said.

“Alright, I'll do it. I, I don't want to lose any more of my comrades.”

He said, after finally making up his mind.

Karma's operation finished in less than an hour, and Zaza was operated on next.

As they only needed to transfer the brain inside the capsule and adjust it, it was child's play for Ramiris and Bereta to perform.

And so Zaza's operation was finished, and Karman's men also underwent modifications.

And like that, Zaza, Karman, and his men gained a new power to fight.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 13 Moving House, And A Guest

The party moved along very comfortably.

Traveling by bus was so comfortable that many of them wondered why they had been made to suffer so much up until now.

First, there was air conditioning.

And they no longer had to wear the hot protection suits and could sit on cushioned chairs.

Everyone was smiling.

The harsh march of yesterday seemed so unnecessary now. Zaza almost wanted to complain.

No, this was no time to complain about anything. But with

such luxury before them now, it was hard not to think about it.

Zaza was not used to such things happening, and so he was slow to adapt, unlike the children.

But then again, he had believed Rindo to be much like himself, and yet Rindo had become fully occupied in driving the bus and appeared to be enjoying it very much.

“Ahahaha! This is amazing!!”

It was almost as if he were a different person.

(Rindo. I never would have expected this from you...)

Zaza muttered.

Still, he could not complain.

After all, he had been driving for quite a while now, and so this much could be overlooked.

The other bus drivers were probably doing the same thing.

He believed this because they were all following the lead bus very closely.

And the children were really enjoying this too.

Barren, cold wasteland spread out before them on the other side of the windows. It wasn't the kind of scene that made you happy.

However, Rindo was driving in a way that would entertain them. He drove at breakneck speed, showing off his driving skills as the vehicle just barely avoided being hit by boulders.

Instead of honking, he would use the Pulse Gun to smash boulders that were in the way.

The Pulse Gun was the only weapon that remained after the others were removed. However, it was ridiculously powerful.

Even on such rough terrain, he was able to main an average speed of 80km/h, and it handled better than any small vehicle.

It could even float in the air for a short duration, which made it seem more advanced than the tanks used by the Empire.

Apparently, it could even go underwater.

Anti-radiation, anti-toxic gas, anti-bacteriological weapons were just some of the things it offered protection against. And it was sealed so tightly that not even a drop of water could get in.

And it went without saying, that the air was kept clean as well.

As long as you stayed in the vehicle, you were guaranteed a much more comfortable living space than any bomb shelter.

Was this really just a bus? It was all very hard to believe.

Rindo wasn't the only one who was getting carried away.

Karman was as well. And his men were incredibly excited.

“Captain Karman. This is amazing! I just came back after scouting the area. This Powered Suit is so much more powerful than before. I just need to think about it while flying, and I can accelerate to Mach 2 in an instant!”

“And no blackout is caused by it. I can see perfectly. Even if I'm in an electromagnetic storm, all the sensors are displayed in my brain...it understands everything and I can control it.”

“Also, there is this thing called ‘Telepathy Line.’ I don't understand how it works, but it allows us to communicate with our thoughts even if we're in an electromagnetic storm!!”

“These modifications are amazing. I think as I am now, I could take on the old team by myself!”

“You idiot. That’s going too far!”

“Really. Ahahaha!”

Like that, they talked about how the features had been upgraded and laughed.

But they had a right to be so excited.

Of course, they did. Zaza understood it very well.

After all...

He had undergone the same surgery as well.

This new body–this Battle Body boasted such features that changed everything Zaza understood about such things.

Veldora had told him that it was the same in structure as Michelle, in other words, the Machinery Four.

He could hardly believe it at first. But when the surgery was over, he realized that it was not a lie.

This was because his body was reacting in a completely different way to before.

The reaction that had troubled Zaza and had to be suppressed with drugs—that rejection he felt in his brain, had somehow disappeared.

It was almost as if he had returned to his human body. It was that natural.

For instance, he felt pain when he bumped against a chair. He felt coldness when touching the walls. And he felt the heat when he tried to touch fire.

There was a pain when he slapped his own cheek.

In other words, he had regained the sense of touch all over his body.

His brain was happy at the return of his five senses, including pain.

This had resulted in a decrease in stress.

While he was a cyborg, he was now much more like an ordinary human—that was Zaza.

However, he had not returned to flesh and blood either.

He knew this, by the monitor that would appear in his brain when he wanted.

He could see ‘Normal/Battle,’ displayed on that monitor.

Now push it! The switch in his brain seemed to shout at him.

He was currently in normal mode.

But Zaza was too afraid to push the switch.

He only had to move his will towards pressing it...but he knew that he would be assaulted by more realities that would be hard to accept.

Karman's men had likely already done it.

That's why they were so excited now.

"Ah, Zaza. Let me ask you something. In your brain..."

"Don't ask me, Karman. If you're talking about the switch, I don't feel like answering that."

Zaza was going to ignore it for now.

He had thought he was prepared for anything, but he was even more anxious now than before the surgery.

It was the anxiety of suddenly being given too much power.

Karman might have felt the same because he nodded knowingly at Zaza's answer.

In other words, he also had a similar display in his brain.

"I see. Well, I understand that. But this really is amazing."

Zaza looked at him.

"So, did you do it then?"

"Yeah. It wouldn't do to test it during an actual fight. I felt as if the flow of time had slowed down the moment I turned it on. It's as if all sensations leave your body and you don't have a care

in the world. After all, you can see your entire body in your brain monitor. It's almost as if you can see yourself from the outside and control your body."

Karman was a military man, so he was more concerned with his current state than Zaza, who mainly worked in intelligence. And so he had already checked his new features.

Pain, heat, and coldness were now just numbers displayed as information. He could look at how the numbers were affected to see what damage he was taking.

He tried cutting himself with a high-frequency blade as a test. The appropriate numbers dropped. However, they returned to normal after a short while and the cut on his arm disappeared.

"So it has a self-repairing feature..."

"Aye, it seems that it does. And when in battle mode, the Powered Suit—no, the Powered Armor, can be controlled remotely. You can call it and make it do some scouting or simple combat automatically."

“...Really!? I guess it just does everything now.”

Electromagnetic storms could block nearly all forms of transmissions with the exception of the military’s secret satellite transmissions. So it was shocking that these suits could communicate wirelessly.

And yet the modification surgery they had underwent now allowed them to not only communicate wirelessly, but control things remotely through ‘Telepathy Line.’

It was all very hard for Zaza to comprehend.

Maybe he should try pushing it—the devil whispered into his ear.

However, Zaza had a will of iron.

He knew that they were all looking at him now and smirking.

(No. I do want to test it out in case of an emergency, but not now. I don't want to become their plaything...)

Zaza thought.

“What is it, Zaza? Don't be so modest. You should test the power out if you really want to.”

“Yes, Zaza. I'm looking forward to seeing it. You should go out and fight with Karman!”

But why?

They were treating him like a toy. He wanted to say.

“Ramiris is right. We should see which of you is the strongest once and for all. Don't worry. As long as you take less than 80% damage, you will be able to auto-repair.”

“Exactly. We used ‘Demon Steel,’ so a little damage won’t mean much to you anyway.”

Veldora was insisting that Zaza and Karman have a test fight.

Even Beretta was nodding. He agreed that such a thing was not likely to lead to any lethal wounds.

Did they want them to fight so bad then?

Perhaps they had betted money on which of them would win...?

Such things went through Zaza’s mind.

He decided that he had to find out.

“Hey, Mister Veldora. You wouldn’t be betting any money on this, would you? Like, which of us is stronger. The one who is a

fighter or the one with more firepower. Surely you and Ramiris would not do something so pointless?”

He knew it was a little on the disrespectful side, but he still asked this through squinted eyes.

The result...

“O-of course, not? Of course, we are not doing something like...that?”

“Wh-what are you saying!? Zaza! Who do you think we are? Why would we modify you just to test something silly like that?”

“Oh, Zaza. I am glad you did not lump me in with these two. So you understand then? I have no interest in such base things!”

As Zaza predicted, Veldora and Ramiris had become very suspicious in their behavior.

While they strongly denied having any such intentions, their behavior was a clear answer in itself.

But what was most surprising, was the Beretta seemed to be a part of it.

“Mister Beretta, were you betting on this too? Which of us were you betting on winning?”

While Zaza only thought about it, Karman asked him straight up.

Beretta heard this and froze.

(Is this Karman a fearless hero!?)

Even Zaza was surprised and did not know how to react.

“Ho-hohoho. How absurd, Mister Karman. Mister Veldora

and the others would never involve themselves in gambling.”

It was Sharma who saved the day.

“You are too wise, Sharma. Zaza and Karman here are very narrow-minded. You have to look at the bigger picture!”

“Ye-yes. Master is right!”

“I won’t say anything this time, but be careful in the future!”

After Sharma came to their rescue, Veldora and the others quickly caught on and made a successful escape.

It went without saying, that this was possible because Zaza did not say anything.



And so the fight between Zaza and Karman was dismissed.

As they had covered up the fact they had been placing bets, Veldora and the others were now too afraid to push for it.

Regardless, the party continued on their way to their destination without much event.

No, there were some problems...

The automated battle machines that patrolled the area.

Monsters that mutated due to the radiation. These were not Super Beasts.

And there were also armored cyborg bandits that were not part of the resistance, The Light of Dawn.

Monsters without human hearts that lived in the ravaged

land.

Such threats would not let these unusual busses go without interruption.

And so they were targeted. However, Karman's men were able to deal with them swiftly.

"These features are insane..."

"I'm surprised, really. You just turned at a right angle, didn't you?"

"Yeah. I was moving at the speed of sound, and yet I could easily change course... My body is one thing, but how can my brain withstand that burden?"

"I don't know. I don't understand it at all..."

There was no need for Zaza or Karman to go out.

Super abilities and super firepower.

Their notions of what was possible had been destroyed the other day, and now Karman's men were obliterating the enemy with overwhelming power.

As long as they were protecting the buses, everyone was safe.

"You know. I was thinking it would take two weeks if we were lucky. And over three weeks at worst. And I assumed it would be impossible for us all to reach it alive. But at this rate, we'll arrive at our destination in just an hour."

Zaza muttered with a faraway look.

It was a wonderful thing, but it was almost too easy, which made it difficult to see it as reality.

They were all relaxing in an air-conditioned bus with cold drinks in their hands...

Sometimes, Zaza wondered if he was dreaming.

“Well, now. You’re thinking too much, Zaza.”

Karman said consolingly. He then took a sip of his chilled drink as if its existence was not the strangest thing.

It was pure, delicious water. And there was no fear of being poisoned.

This cold and luxurious water was enough to raise Karman’s spirits.

He forgot his worries and anxiety. He trusted Veldora and the others now.

Zaza was feeling the same.

“Yes, there is no point in worrying about things.”

Zaza nodded back.

If they were powerful enough to do such modifications as these in one night, then there would be little they could not do.

He would only look like a fool if he kept worrying. He finally felt free.

(Yes, that's it. It's stupid to hold on to what you think is normal!)

He had finally realized it.

And like that, Zaza and the rest of the party arrived at the destination that Michelle had sent them to.

They punched in the code and the door to the underground hideout opened.

The door was hidden behind a boulder, and beyond it were stairs that led to an underground area.

It was big enough for one thousand people to live in comfortably.

However, as it had not been cleaned or had life supporting machines installed, it would not be very relaxing to be in.

In any case, they had to first contact the resistance's headquarters and discuss what they would do next.

There were many things they had to do.

Or so Zaza, Sharma and the others thought...

“Hey, Karman. I’ve been waiting for you.”

“Reiz! If you’re here, that means the person who prepared this place...”

“Yeah, it’s me. On General Michelle’s orders.”

Someone was already there.

In fact, it was a whole group of armored soldiers.

“Karman. Who are these people?”

Rindo asked him cautiously as he stepped out and in front of Sharma.

However, before Karman could reply, the man called Reiz lifted his arms with a laugh.

Then he said,

“Hey, we’re not your enemies. General Michelle gave us a secret order to come here to the south as combat engineers.”

However, Rindo did not let his guard down after hearing this.

“Can you prove it?”

He said to Reiz.

Even Karman had only just recently heard about Michelle’s true purpose, and he wasn’t sure who he was supposed to trust.

And so he gave Zaza a questioning look...

“Sorry. I am not in a position to know all of the others. In fact, none of us who were sent on secret missions were allowed to contact each other. Michelle didn’t want to risk putting the

rest in danger if one of us got caught.”

I see. Rindo and the others nodded.

However, this meant that it would be difficult to prove that Reiz was on their side.

“However, wouldn’t the fact that we were waiting here prove that General Michelle had told us of the situation?”

“That’s true. Rindo, you are worrying too much. General Michelle has been helping the resistance in secret and very few people are aware of it. Because it is unquestionably an act of treachery against the empire. And yet they know and are here. I think that is enough to believe that they are moving at her command.”

“B-but, Mister Zaza!? If that was true, wouldn’t she have told us directly...”

“No, that would be difficult. Didn’t he just say it? If someone

had a loose tongue, the others would be put in danger. While I doubt it, there could be spies from the empire among us. She would be wary of such a possibility. Everyone from the empire has ‘Dog Tags’ implants. Officially, we were purged by General Michelle. That’s when she destroyed our dog tags.”

“That’s right, Rindo. I don’t have a dog tag either. That’s why I can’t enter the city and had to make my scheduled reports outside. It was really inconvenient. It’s not possible to prepare a shelter like this without cooperators inside of the city. You must understand how important it is to keep their identity a secret.”

“If you say it like that...”

Indeed, it would not have been possible for a collaborator on the outside, without access to supplies, to be able to prepare this place.

Rindo could understand that.

“Sorry. I shouldn’t have suspected you so much.”

He apologized.

Reize laughed and forgave him.

“Well, it’s only normal to be cautious. After all, on the surface, our job is to investigate the area and wipe out any resistance members we encounter. But, well, we’re kind of infamous as being the useless guys who often have our supplies stolen while on the move.”

Reiz said. Everyone could not help but laugh.



As Reiz and his men had set up the place, Sharma and the others were able to act quickly.

They decided to leave the children with Veldora as they contacted the other leaders of the resistance.

And so they went to the room with the communications equipment, along with Zaza and Rindo.

“We have now arrived in the hideout provided by General Michelle, as I said we would in my last report.”

Sharma said to the other directors.

‘I see. So there was someone trustworthy within the empire...’

‘Michelle is the highest in command of the Machinery Four. I’m sorry to say it, Sharma. But I believed you were all being tricked.’

‘We were told to gather our fighting force. I shall give you my support. We will send as many men as we can.’

‘Zalando. Aren’t you being a little hasty?’

‘Perhaps. But, Blancha. There is no future for us unless we act. Many are dying due to our life support machines failing. We cannot find new homes now. It is too late. Even if it turns out to be a trap, we have no other hope.’

‘That...’

‘It’s true. We must give this some thought... I had wanted to watch you a little longer before deciding. But I shall come to a decision tonight.’

Their reactions varied.

As Sharma had arrived earlier than scheduled, many of them had not come to a decision yet.

And the main reason for this was that most of them did not entirely trust Michelle. They believed that Sharma was being deceived.

However, now that Sharma had arrived safely, they were

starting to think that they could trust Michelle.

Still, it seemed that it would be difficult for them all to be in agreement.

And so it was decided that the talks would end for now, and they would continue the meeting on the following morning.

Now they just had to wait for their answers.

That's what Sharma thought.

Michelle had requested that they gather a fighting force that they could trust.

However, information was still to be kept from them for the most part.

Each director knew that Michelle was a collaborator. Michelle

had allowed her to share this information.

Even if there was a spy in their midst, Michelle thought it would be a good opportunity to find the traitors. This willingness to sacrifice herself was well-received by the others, and Sharma fully trusted her now.

And so she had told the other directors of Michelle's request, that they gather their men.

There was a possibility of fighting within the empire, and the resistance would act in accordance.

She told them that Michelle would be in their debt after this, and would promise to aid them...

It was no surprise that the other directors had their doubts.

They too had comrades to protect. They did not want to lose men if there was no need.

It would be difficult to persuade them, but not impossible—that's what Sharma thought.

As some of the directors had said, the shelters were at their limits.

The surface was full of threats, but their claustrophobic homes would no longer be able to support them.

So they had no choice but to strike out.

In that case, there was no better time than now.

They had a collaborator within the empire. Michelle. And so helping Michelle to destroy the current regime became a path to survival for the resistance.

With this renewed conviction, Sharma directed her thoughts towards tomorrow's meeting.

Unfortunately, things would not be favorable.

An unexpected problem awaited them.

Sharma and the others finished their communication with the directors and returned to the main hall. There, a stranger awaited them.

She was covered in wounds, proof that a battle had been fought.

Currently, Karman and Reiz were treating her.

“Who is that?”

“She is General Michelle’s adjutant. Her name is Jegyll. I don’t know what happened, but she arrived here like this. Barely breathing...”

Karman answered Sharma's nervous question.

It seemed that the stranger had escaped from the empire.

But there were no pursuers.

Jegyll must have killed them so they would not locate this place.

That's why she was wounded so badly.

"I have used healing drugs and she seems to be improving. Her loss of consciousness should be temporary..."

"...Where am I?"

Just as Reiz was explaining this, Jegyll's eyes cracked open and she muttered.

“Oh, she has come to. Adjutant Jegyll, it is me. Reiz. Do you understand?”

“Reiz... So this must be Shelter 5. The one that General Michelle prepared?”

“Exactly.”

“Did anyone follow me?”

“No. Karman’s men are patrolling the area. No enemies have been sighted.”

“I see. So I killed all of them then...”

Jegyll said. Then she sighed with relief.

Karman nodded and said,

“Adjutant Jegyll. It’s Karman. General Michelle told me everything. I am now just like you.”

“I see. That is comforting. As for the rest of you, I apologize for such a rude greeting. I am Jegyll. I am Michelle’s adjutant and I know of her intentions. I am not your enemy. Please rest easy.”

Jegyll said this, and Sharma and the others introduced themselves.

While this happened, a man who could not read the room—or had no intention of trying—asked Jegyll a very blunt question.

“So, Jegyll or whatever your name is. Why are you here?”

Hey!? Zaza became frantic.

Not just Zaza, but Karman and Sharma as well.

Reiz was speechless at the lack of manners.

This person was Michelle's adjutant. A noble of the highest rank who belonged in the ruling class of the empire.

And yet he had no respect for her.

Even Reiz felt he had to say something...

"No-now, now, Mister Reiz. Calm down. And Mister Veldora, let's try to be a little more polite. Actually, we will be dealing with all the negotiations. You can go over there and play with the children..."

Rindo said as he quickly stepped in between them.

"Ka-Hahahaha! The children are already asleep, thanks to my flawless ability to babysit. Besides, negotiations are very important. You must leave it to me. Don't worry, I won't let things go wrong."

That's what we're worried about!! Everyone who knew Veldora thought this.

However, none of them said it out loud.

“Hohohoho. We cannot allow Lord Veldora to do something as low as that.”

“Ye-yes, Master. We have a nice room prepared. Why don't you go and have a rest!”

“Hmmm. I hope you are not just trying to get rid of me...”

Veldora muttered as he started to walk away, but then—

“Th-that's right! This is no time for talk. General Michelle has been taken!! You must help me...”

Jegyll's face went pale as she dropped this unbelievable bomb

on them.

And so in a flash, the situation suddenly changed for the worse.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 14 A Frightful Trap

I want you to help Michelle. Said Jegyll.

She claimed to have been able to escape at just the right time.

It was clear to her that she was not strong enough to take on General Kristoph. And trying something so futile would not help Michelle's cause in the least—she had decided this and come to this place that Michelle had told her about.

According to her, General Kristoph, the founder of Machinery Arts, had visited South City and talked to Michelle.

But they were unable to come to an agreement, and it had turned to war.

“General Kristoph's strength is overwhelming. And his soldiers are all first-rate fighters. And... General Michelle was worried about injuring any civilians. She did not fight with her full power. And so defeat could hardly be avoided...”

Still, civilians had died. And even now the chaos continued.

And Jegyll had taken advantage of the chaos and escaped from the city...

“Still, surely you know that even we cannot go against the Machinery Four?”

Karman said. Jegyll nodded as if it were the most obvious thing.

The Machinery Four could not be taken by surprise.

They were monsters that surpassed imagination. The strongest weapons of war in this world.

“I know. I do not expect that much of you. However, I want you to gather the power of the resistance and draw away the eyes of the soldiers. And then I can take our best men and save General Michelle...”

South City was in complete chaos. She claimed that the soldiers were unsure where to stand in this battle between the Machinery Four.

And so this was where the resistance soldiers were to come in.

Jegyll had heard that Michelle had requested that they combine forces. And she wanted to use them in her plan to rescue Michelle. She had risked death in order to escape the city and bring them this proposal.

“I see. The numbers of the resistance are unknown and therefore would seem like a great threat to the Empire, which is now in chaos. If things go well, you might even be able to lure General Kristoph out? But what about the others of the Machinery Four?”

“General Michelle was only taken about an hour ago. I do not even know what they were talking about before that, but I think the other cities are not yet aware of what has happened. After all, he would have to make General Michelle’s crimes clear in order to make the others act.”

Jegyll answered Reiz's question.

It was unlikely that the other Machinery Four would get involved.

Even if General Kristoph had the highest military authority, he would need definite proof in order to condemn Michelle, who was the daughter of the Emperor.

Jegyll insisted that he had to contain the incident within South City until he could provide such evidence.

"I see. I understand now. As for us, we would like to continue working together with General Michelle. And so we will do what we can. However..."

"We have not yet heard back from the other resistance leaders. And so we can make no promises as of now."

Sharma and Rindo said to Jegyll apologetically.

They did want to help rescue Michelle, but they could not contribute enough men. This diversion that Jegyll spoke of would require great numbers.

“Jegyll. We can move whenever we’re needed. We’re only alive today because of General Michelle, anyway. So you can use us however you want!”

Karman said with a laugh. His men also chuckled fearlessly and nodded.

Zaza was conflicted about this.

“As for me, I also wish I could go and help her. However, if I leave, no one will be here to protect the others...”

Zaza said.

He did want to go. But he didn’t want to leave the noncombatants unprotected.

While this was a secret hideout, he was still worried.

“But Mister Zaza. What if now is the right time to attack? We may not be as strong as the Machinery Four, but we have Jegyll with us. If we succeed in rescuing General Michelle, we may even be able to defeat General Kristoph! Besides, don’t you think the other resistance members will agree to join if things go well?”

Reiz said as if to encourage him.

Zaza had heard of Reiz. He wasn’t the most serious person, but he was known for being very sharp.

There were records of Reiz’s team fighting the resistance soldiers, and not a single death on either side had resulted from them.

And so Zaza was moved by his opinion.

“Yes. It really is a matter of getting the others to agree to it. If

they all cooperated, we could gather a fighting force as we have never seen before. If the rescue succeeds...”

“...We may be able to attack them from both sides along with the resistance forces that create the diversion...”

Sharma said hesitantly. Zaza had thought about it as well, and he sighed and nodded.

It really depended on the rest of the resistance...

But it seemed like there was a real opportunity in front of them to destroy a corner of the Empire.

It was too good to ignore. It wasn't just Zaza. Sharma and the others thought so too.

—Just then, Veldora's patience had reached its limits.

He opened his mouth and spoke.

“Wait-wait. Aren’t you all forgetting someone? Someone very great and reliable at such times. Someone who is like a secret weapon...!!”

And just like that, the oppressive atmosphere was blown away.

“Surely you don’t actually mean to help us!?”

“But...wasn’t your agreement with Michelle just to escort us here...?”

Zaza and Sharma asked in surprise. Veldora burst into laughter.

Ramiris and Beretta saw this and began to whisper to each other.

“Lord Ramiris. The time limit is tonight. I believe the presentation is today... I doubt there is a difference in the flow of time here. At the earliest, Rimuru might find out about our actions today. So if you wish to hide your tracks, you must return right now...”

“Damn it, master. Wasn’t he going to leave everything to Rimuru?”

“I thought so too. But it’s also quite possible that there won’t be enough time even if you returned now...”

“Yes, I agree with that. Besides, it would leave a bad aftertaste if we left this world like this. And what if we did come back later and everything had ended? Could you imagine such a terrible scenario? In that case, we might as well stay and see how things play out.”

Ramiris and Beretta had the same opinion and were in support of Veldora.

It was also clear that Beretta just didn’t want to deal with the hassle of covering their tracks. He was sure that they would force that role on him anyway.

And it was possible that he would not be quick enough and they would blame him. Beretta's demon instincts were telling him that any such fabrications they might attempt would have dangerous results.

And so Beretta had no objections.

They would all get in trouble! That's what he thought, and he could not hide it.

"Ka-hahahaha! Creating diversions is my specialty. Would you mind if I just destroyed the enemy altogether?"

Veldora asked with an air of triumph.

Next to him,

"He just wants to go wild, doesn't he?"

Ramiris muttered.

“But Lord Ramiris. As much as I hate to admit it, I think having Lord Veldora do that would be the most effective.”

Beretta answered.

Neither of them objected.

Veldora would help—that was what they settled on.

However, there was still a problem.

“Having Lord Veldora’s help would be most welcome, but it will still be difficult to send all our men for this diversion. We must protect our base here and we do not have many men...”

Sending out all their soldiers and leaving those that should be protected? It was out of the question.

And so Zaza suggested that they instead sent the minimum amount of men that they could.

Things would be easier if the other branches sent reinforcements, but he wanted to create a diversion without relying on them.

Zaza was prepared to die trying.

If they drew attention like that so close to the Empire, they would likely be surrounded and annihilated.

Perhaps Veldora, who was unusually strong, would survive. But there was no such hope for Zaza and the others.

But if it would lead to Michelle's rescue...

That's what he thought as he made the decision.

However...

“Oh, Zaza. Do not worry. Beretta and Ramiris will remain here, so those who can fight should go out and cause a scene. We will prepare the weapons and equipment for this by tomorrow.”

Veldora said without any hesitation.

However, there was one person who was not satisfied with this.

It was Ramiris.

“Wa-wait! Master!? I want to go with you!!”

She jumped onto Veldora’s shoulder as she declared this.

There was no way she could stand to be left behind.

“Tsk. But if you come, I will have to watch over you.”

“And what’s wrong with that!”

They were about to start arguing, but here, Beretta offered to help.

“Lord Veldora, why don’t I go too then?”

But Veldora’s reaction was clear.

“Wait, Beretta. You must stay here and protect these people. That way, Zaza will be able to go into battle without regret.”

And so Beretta had no choice but to agree.

After hearing Veldora’s words, Beretta decided to stay.

As for Ramiris...

“I’m going no matter what, alright?”

She had decided she would not back down. And so it was Veldora who gave up.

“You’re incorrigible. Well, I suppose I’ll have to protect you. But then I won’t be able to go all out...”

“So what! There will be no need to!!”

Ramiris was right.

It was clear that Veldora just wanted to go all out. If anything, it was good that Ramiris would be there to keep him in check. That’s what Beretta thought.

And as for her protection, there was no way that Veldora

would have a problem with that.

And so Beretta decided to leave Ramiris to his care.

Ultimately, it was decided that Veldora and Ramiris would participate in the diversion plan while Beretta would stay with the noncombatants.

“Good! Then I will lead the diversion troops! Mister Veldora, you can support us!”

“Leave it to me.”

Zaza said and Veldora nodded.

And like that, the plan was devised on the basis that Veldora would be aiding them.



And now, the present.

It was the next morning when the plan would be put into effect.

Karman and his four subordinates were riding Reiz's supply transport ship and heading for the Empire.

They had held a strategy meeting and carefully planned everyone's official role.

"Yes, yes. Karman and his men would know the most about the inner city. They should infiltrate it and rescue Michelle. I will follow Zaza's command and wreak havoc!!"

Grandma will go to the river to wash the clothes, while grandpa will cut trees in the mountains.

That's what Veldora might as well have said, given the weight behind it.

Of course, in Veldora's mind, he was likely cutting down the Empire's soldiers, not trees.

Such were the images in Karman's head. Just then, Jegyll spoke up.

"By the way, Karma. There is something I've been curious about..."

"Huh? What is it?"

Jegyll looked around as if to appraise them, then she carefully opened her mouth.

"Have you also fought that man, Veldora? According to Michelle, he was as strong if not stronger than her..."

Jegyll was wondering how he could still be alive after such a fight.

Now that he thought of it, he had not made a report of that.

“No, no. The person we fought against was Beretta. All five of us attacked him and we were crushed into the ground.”

“It was hard to believe. But the Neutrolauncher didn’t work on him.”

“Neither did the plasma weapons. Beretta was a monster.”

“But still...”

“Aye. Mister Veldora is on a different level. After all, he could defeat Super Beasts by punching them.”

Not only Karman, but his men all agreed.

There was something more than mere respect in their voice. It was clear that they were all drawn to Veldora and Beretta.

However, as the person listening to them, Jegyll was not satisfied.

“It’s impossible. The Neutrolauncher didn’t work on him? How can you stop neutrons that permeate matter and blast through the atomic nucleus at the speed of light!? And you say he defeated Super Beasts with his fists? Do you take me for a fool?”

Karman could only chuckle at this.

“You don’t know how much we want to agree with you. But it was us who actually fought and were forced to see these unbelievable things you know?”

Jegyll looked at him and muttered. ‘So it’s true then.’

“Still, what technology was used to modify those three?”

“It’s a mystery. However, considering they were able to modify us overnight, I would imagine it had to be the work of

some incredible scientist from the city.”

Jegyll listened to Karman’s men talk. And after thinking about it for a moment, she asked her next question.

“Michelle told me about the fighting style of one called Veldora. But this Beretta sounds quite reliable as well. Was it also this Beretta, who fixed you all?”

“Yes, it was him.”

“Hmm. Interesting...”

Jegyll listened to that much and then bit her lip with a smile.

There was something evil about the way the corner of her mouth rose.

“I thought it would be troublesome having one person stay

here, but it's turned out to be for the best. This information will prove useful. We'll catch him later when we have time."

She had transformed so naturally that for a moment, Karman could not understand what she was saying.

"What? Jegyll. What are you...?"

Karman asked hesitantly.

It was a fatal mistake. That being said, it was already too late the moment that they had put their trust in her.

"You're awfully slow, Karman. I am so thankful for your stupidity. I doubt the cautious Zaza would have fallen into this trap so easily. At least..."

At this point, Karman finally understood.

“Damn it!! All of you. Scatter! And run to the hangar!!”

Karman shouted.

However, it was too late.

“...he would not have made such an amateur mistake. You couldn't know who the traitor was, and yet you trusted me because I was close to Michelle. That's the height of stupidity. You should have left at least one person in the hangar.”

Karman and his men were not wearing their Powered Suits.

They were currently in the hangar.

And just then, there was a thunderous explosion.

The sound of hope dying.

“Jegyll. You. How... What about Veldora and the others...!?”

“Yes. They should have reached the place I had designated by now. These weak resistance soldiers could be crushed whenever we wanted. But an enemy that Michelle was wary of has to be dealt with. And so I have ensured their deaths.”

“Ensured?”

“Yes. The Six Tyrant. Have you heard of it?”

“...You wouldn’t...the most powerful weapon that could destroy cities...?”

“Exactly. It’s an old weapon, but its power is proven. It would be a waste not to use it.”

Jegyll said with a smile. Karman felt a horrifying chill run up his spine.

(She's crazy. A person with an incredibly dangerous way of thinking...)

He thought. And then he wondered.

Would Michelle really have been unable to see the madness within her?

And so Karman could not stop himself shouting.

“...You! Were you betraying General Michelle from the beginning!?”

He asked as he stared at her. Fear and curiosity in his eyes.

However, Jegyll shook her head in denial.

“No, that is wrong. I was reborn. By the hands of the great, true Emperor Fudora. He turned me into the most powerful

warrior–the Bionoid.”

She said grandly. And then with a speed too fast for him to follow, she slammed him to the ground.

“Gggaaagh...”

His cheek had been punched and his stomach kicked. Karman rolled on the ground.

However, pain that exceeded a fixed level was shut off, and so Karman did not feel as much pain as he expected.

The real problem was what Jegyll had just said.

(That means General Michelle was not tricked or betrayed. But the situation is no better for it, and there doesn't seem to be anything I can do.)

While he thought this, Karman also felt that he was stronger than he had expected.

But without puzzling over this, he quickly found the answer.

(It's without a doubt due to the modification surgery.)

Now that he was sure, a sense of gratitude towards Veldora welled up inside of him.

(I'd be dead now if I hadn't been modified. Still, this body really is amazing. I can see the amount of damage as numbers... So that's 10% to the head, 3% to the stomach. I should probably pretend to be dead here...)

And so Karman pretended to be in immense pain as he writhed on the ground.

“Oh? You're still alive then? The Empire's maintenance work is more impressive than I thought.”

Karman ignored her taunts and connected to his mean through 'Telepathy Line.'

'All of you. I'm fine. But things are going badly. But I'm going to get out of this alive.'

That was enough to calm them after the shock they felt over him being attacked.

'Ah, you are safe!'

'But, what should we do? Apparently, the Powered Suits were destroyed?'

'The remote controls are not being recognized...'

They quickly and accurately assessed the situation.

And through the use of Telepathy Line, they quickly decided

on the direction to take without Jegyll realizing it.

‘Are you listening? We are cyborgs, but people think we’re weak without the Powered Suits. Well, they wouldn’t be entirely wrong, but Mister Veldora’s modification skills are incredible. I haven’t even received much damage from Jegyll’s attack just now. And the repairing ability is also great. It seems that my stomach injury will be completely healed in just three minutes.’

‘I see! In that case, maybe the Powered Suits...’

‘Yes. They might still be usable. So don’t lose hope, alright? If we can only escape from this supply transport ship...’

He had said as much. And then that hope was cruelly crushed.

“Miss Jegyll. We have finished. The Powered Suits have been completely destroyed, as you ordered.”

Reiz said as he entered the bridge with a foolish smile.

“Good. And the results of the analysis?”

“I did try and get some data, but much of it was impossible to analyze with the equipment on board this ship. While it was a waste, I prioritized its destruction. After all, they would have combat abilities to match the Empire’s Cyborg Soldiers if they put those on. So it was obvious they had to be destroyed. But, then again, they would still have no chance against us Bionoids. Perhaps I was being paranoid?”

No matter how advanced the weapon was, it could be easily destroyed before it was used.

Reiz said with a laugh.

This meant that Karman’s last hope was gone.

“...Damn you all!”

Karman shouted.

“Oh? He’s still alive. Miss Jegyll, did you go easy on him?”

“I thought he was just some mad dog, but he turned out to be tougher than I thought.”

“I see. But then...”

Reiz smiled mischievously. His right hand then transformed into a blade.

He meant to deal the final blow with that.

But just then...

There was a loud bang followed by a small explosion.

Part of the ship’s control computers had been shot with a blaster.

‘Warning. The ship’s control systems have encountered a fatal error. This ship will crash in 50 seconds. I repeat. This ship’s control systems have encountered a fatal error. This ship will crash in 50 seconds...’

The automatic alarm played. The scene immediately became frantic.

Karman smirked.

“Hehe. Well, there you go. We may not be able to win like this, but now that the ship is out of your control, we can take you down with us. This ship is going to kiss the ground faster than the speed of sound. So, are you tough enough to survive that?”

He pulled out a cigar as he said this with a look of confidence.

He put the cigar in his mouth and inhaled before slowly exhaling the smoke.

His men were also smiling and laughing. Not one of them had a fear of death.

They were ready to do what they had to has military men.

“How troublesome. This cannot be fixed. Who would have thought they had blasters hidden on them. I underestimated you as some meathead, Mister Karman.”

“How vexing. This is why I hate dogs. I have no idea why Michelle ever thought you ruffians would be useful to her? And why have I...”

Reiz said with a shrug, and Jegyll shook her head and continued.

However, Reiz then said something that crushed all of Karman’s confidence.

“Too bad, Mister Karman. But we are able to escape this ship, even though it is moving at such a speed.”

“What!?”

“Isn’t it obvious? Unlike you ancient cyborgs, Bionoids are special.”

“Exactly. I wanted to kill you with my hands, but it appears there is no time. I don’t want to die here with you, so we’ll be leaving now.”

“Consider this ship a present, Mister Karman. Enjoy your luxury coffin.”

Jegyll and Reiz said before evacuating.

“Damn you! Come back here...”

Karman’s shout echoed sadly.

However...

This was all according to Karman's plan.

"Phew. That was amazing, captain."

"Good work on that acting!"

"We somehow made it through."

"Now we just have to survive this crash..."

His men said.

Karman looked at them and shouted.

"You damn idiots! There's no time to waste. Gather around!"

He ordered, and they came together in a circle.

Karman looked at them and nodded.

“Sorry about that. But that’s what you get when you’re with me.”

They stayed silent.

However, they all had mischievous grins on their faces. No one looked like they regretted being there.

Karman chuckled before continuing.

“According to Mister Veldora, my battle body has the same structure as General Michelle. In other words, I can use the Ether Ring Barrier that only the Machinery Four can use. It might sound unbelievable, but I can see it in my brain menu.”

“Are you serious...?”

“I thought it was a joke too. But you’ll have to trust me on this. Well, trust Veldora anyway...as hard as that may be.”

If he was lying, then they would all die.

If he wasn’t, they might just survive this.

In that case, Karman would laugh and believe—that was the path they would take.

‘...2 seconds until the crash.’

“Alright, here it goes! Ether Ring Barrier!!”

Karman howled. The thermonuclear fusion reactor converted all of his energy into special wavelengths—and a ring of black particles surrounded Karman and his men.

Veldora, Ramiris, and Beretta had modified the faulty feature

until it was as close to the original as possible.

Ether Ring Barrier—theoretically, it was a powerful shield that protected you from almost any attack.

—And now, the 70-meter medium-sized transport ship was moving at a dozen times faster than the speed of sound—and it was about to crash into the ground—

And Karman and his men entrusted their lives to this shield.



At the same time.

There was an earth-shattering sound.

It was an explosion so large that it was as if the sun had fallen to the earth.

—Six Tyrant—

A weapon of the devil that the Empire had created.

That being said, the principle was quite simple.

An Ether Ring Barrier would be created for a brief moment. At the same time, at the peak of the hexagram in the center of the Ether Ring Barrier, six gigaton-grade atomic bombs would go off.

The shock waves and heat that would result from this would not be able to be contained within the Ether Ring Barrier. This will cause unimaginable destructive power to be created inside of it.

That was the Six Tyrant.

With such power before them, even the Machinery Four would not go unscathed.

While surprise attacks wouldn't work on them and they could protect themselves with Ether Ring Barrier, they would likely still be burned to death before the rage of the explosion died down.

It was such a horrifying superweapon that now turned its fangs on Veldora and the others...

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 15 Dragon Armor

“Ve-Veldoraaaaaa!!”

Karman awoke to the sound of his own screaming.

That arrogant man who always acted so familiar.

He had been dreaming of Veldora, being swallowed up by hellfire.

“Heh. That’s not like me. Maybe I’ve been depending on him more than I thought...”

Karman muttered as he remembered the situation they had been in.

This was not the time to be worrying about others. They themselves were in a precarious situation.

And so Karman dismissed all thoughts of Veldora from his mind.

(There is no point in worrying about that man now. It seems that the Six Tyrant has already been activated...)

That devil's roar had boomed far off in the distance.

It was the sound of immense energy running wild after it had been sealed in an Ether Ring Barrier.

The barrier was stretching and affecting the space outside of it.

With such a terrifying weapon in front of him, even Veldora would not be able to do anything. That's what Karman thought, but he did not voice it.

But maybe Veldora would...surely he could... There was just a little hope left in his heart.

And he felt that voicing his doubts would erase the last of that hope.

And so Karman turned his attention towards the taking in of his surroundings.

It seemed that he had only lost consciousness for a short time.

According to the clock in his brain, three minutes had not passed since they crashed into the ground.

While he checked the time, he also learned of his condition.

“Are you serious...”

He couldn't help but mutter.

‘All clear.’ Those were the words that were displayed in his head.

The numbers were supposed to appear in red to show damage, but now they were all blue...there was no problem...

Karman was shocked at this unbelievable durability.

He now knew that he was alright, but what about the others?

He thought as he looked around...

Then he discovered them. They were still unconscious.

“Hey, you guys. Are you okay?”

He called. And they groaned.

While they had moderate injuries, it seemed that they were all safe.

“Ouchhhh! It doesn’t actually hurt at all. It’s times like these that I’m happy to be a complete cyborg.”

“But then again, you require maintenance over the smallest things. Mister Zaza tried to hide it, but it seemed like all sorts of functions had been shut down. He would not have lasted much longer had Veldora not modified him.”

“That’s true. However, it was all for nothing...”

“You idiot! Don’t say such a thing!! Mister Veldora is with them. They are surely all right!”

Karman shouted and they all quieted down.

Then they looked at each other and nodded.

“Yes. You’re right!”

“It’s too early to give up. We have to do what we can!”

“Aye. Now, let’s go and find the Powered Suits.”

Karman ordered, and they all moved at once.

No one asked, ‘what if they are broken?’

Finding a method of travel was absolutely necessary for them to leave this wasteland that was full of danger.

If they could not do that, then they would have to wait to be rescued.

For that reason, they would at least have to find a means of communication.

The Powered Suits were likely broken.

However, if they gathered the remains of the ship and its equipment, they might find a way out of their predicament. That's what Karman thought.

They all knew him well, and so they guessed at what his intention was.

However...

They stopped again, shortly after moving.

"...I'm so glad I came to have a look, just in case. To think that not a single one of you has died. You are pretty tough for vermin."

"Yes, what a surprise. According to my data, there was a 99.9% chance of all of you dying. It's impossible that you all survived. So, Mister Karman. What sort of trick did you use?"

A threat had appeared before them in no time—Jegyll and Reiz. And their men were now in front of them.

“Tsk. Back to square one.”

Karman spat.

It had clearly been too early for relief.

“You’re right about that, Reiz. Karman. I am quite interested in your body now. Perhaps the science behind it is more advanced than I thought. You must come to the city with us.”

“Hah! So you can slaughter and dissect us?”

“Or we could kill you here and bring your bodies back, if you prefer? If you’ll come willingly, we will spare you your lives.”

Jegyll said with an expression that looked honest enough.

However, Karman laughed at her.

“Do you take us for fools? There is no reason for you to keep us alive. You’re just trying to trick us, and spare yourself a fight. Aren’t you? I can tell by your eyes. You don’t see us as humans. If you’re going to kill us anyway, then I’ll fight until the end!”

“Aye!”

“We’ll show you what we’re made of!!”

Karman and his men shouted in answer.

Jegyll heard this, and the smile disappeared from her face.

“This is all very hard to understand. You people are most strange.”

“Yes, Jegyll. Let’s just get this over with and kill them.”

Reiz was no longer smiling either. He looked at Karman and

his men with a cold, appraising look.

Alien.

Yes, Jegyll and Reiz were not human.

They may have had the appearance, but they were Bionoids.



The fight started abruptly.

However, it wasn't Karman and his men that were attacked.

It was Jegyll and her men.

Gigantic lifeforms had suddenly appeared and attacked them.

“Super Beasts! Here’s our chance! Let’s hide!”

No, it was surely just a coincidence.

The Super Beasts must have heard the explosion of the ship and come down to search for prey.

However, this ended up saving Karman’s life.

They used that moment when Jegyll’s attention had been diverted, and they hid in the remains of the ship.

‘All of you. Did you turn your power off?’

‘Of course. These hidden cyborg features sure are useful.’

‘Good! Now let’s go and find the Powered Suits.’

They said through Thought Transmission.

In regards to the search, Karman and his men had an idea of how to go about it.

As the machines could be controlled remotely, each of them were connected to their machines through a special 'thought wave.'

There was no guarantee that it would still work, but they had hope.

And so they hid and worked quietly.

On the other hand, Jegyll and her men...

They were struggling against the pack of Super Beasts.

Had the ship still been intact, they would not have been

attacked by the beasts.

And even if they were, the thing had a high power beam cannon installed. And so they wouldn't have had much trouble in dealing with the enemy.

However, Jegyll and her men had no such weapons.

Of course, Bionoids had tremendous strength as anti-cyborg weapons, but they had no methods of attack that covered a wide area. That was their weakness.

The plasma cannon was used against single human enemies. It could not deal a lethal blow to a Super Beast.

The Super Beasts' ability to regenerate was too strong.

While the Bionoids would now lose, it would take a very long time to kill all of the Super Beasts.

Jegyll understood this.

“We’re being hindered by mere purification devices!!”

Jegyll shouted as she kicked the head of one Super Beast. Then she fired off a round of plasma bullets that were a meter in diameter.

Jegyll and Reiz had enough firepower to kill them.

And so eventually, they used the other men as bait, and then Jegyll and Reiz would attack.

Even while they fought, Jegyll’s eyes were searching for Karman and the others.

While they had disappeared behind the remains of the ship, she had not given up the chase.

These wastelands were filled with rocks and cliffs. With enough time, they might actually be able to escape.

She couldn't imagine they would live for very long without being able to receive maintenance or replenish their energy. There was no way they could communicate with others either. Still, she could not underestimate how tenacious Karman and his men were.

They were seasoned warriors and she could not allow them to run free. That was Jegyll's decision.

She was annoyed.

As she was based on a human, she still had emotions.

However, not to the point where it would affect the mission.

That was a feature of Bionoids.

And so Jegyll dealt with the Super Beasts calmly and systematically. She would follow Karman when they were done.

Karman had realized this.

He had left the search to his men while he watched the battlefield.

As he and his men used 'Vision Link,' he had a wide range of sight.

It was an unbelievable feature, but Karman was able to use it without hesitation.

That was the difference between him and Zaza.

Karman did not worry or think too hard about everything.

And in Karman's vision, was a very familiar monster.

“That one...”

He muttered under his breath so no one else could hear.

A great serpent with a red head.

The one that Veldora had defeated. It had become humanoid after that.

‘Continue the search. I have some minor business to attend to.’

‘Captain?’

‘Surely you don’t mean to...?’

‘It’s too dangerous!’

‘Shouldn’t you hide here quietly!?’

As his men could see what he was looking at, they had an idea of what he was going to do.

They frantically tried to stop him, but Karman shook his head.

‘You may be right. But I can’t abandon that one. After all, what if...’

What if that Super Beast had been his lover?

He couldn’t say it, but Karman’s resolve was strong.

‘...I’m leaving the rest to you!’

Karman told them before rushing out.

He went around so that the enemy could not locate him. Then he disappeared into the shadow of some rocks.

His men quickly pulled themselves together and returned to their work.

They would do what they could at the moment. That was the only way to get out of this danger.

Then, just as Jegyll had created a great sphere of plasma and was about to unleash it at the head of the great serpent...

“I won’t let you!”

...Karman jumped out and blocked it with his Ether Ring Barrier.



Karman's arrival was very sudden, but Jegyll was not phased.

Reiz was the same. His reaction suggested he had anticipated this.

"Tsk. I thought you might be a little surprised..."

Karman joked. Jegyll snorted.

"Hehe. As if I wouldn't notice you when you are so close by. We were also looking at you all along."

"But you know what did surprise me? That you would try and protect a Super Beast. A tool. A mere purification device. I thought you were going to launch a surprise attack. But well, you did ruin my attack just now."

Jegyll had known that Karman was approaching.

And so Reiz had intended on shooting Karman while he was targeting Jegyll.

It would be difficult to follow and shoot someone who was moving faster than the speed of sound. And so he had to predict where Karman would move and shoot in advance. And he had predicted wrongly.

Karman hadn't gone for Jegyll. Instead, he had protected the Super Beast. Even Reiz could not have foreseen that.

“Heh. Sorry about that. But I have my reasons too. I swore to protect my lover. And I don't want to break my promise ever again.”

At this, the great serpent with the red head seemed to react.

It wasn't much. In fact, no one even noticed it. But it was almost as if it understood Karman's words.

But Jegyll, on the other hand, did not understand Karman at

all.

“Are you stupid? What does that have to do with this Super Beast over here?”

She asked as she prepared yet another attack.

It was really just her way of toying with Karman. She was not actually interested in a reply.

All it did was buy her some time.

However, Karman answered politely.

“Yes, maybe I am an idiot. But it’s possible that someone from my old home exists within that Super Beast. You called them ‘purification devices’? So you know the secret of the Super Beasts?”

Karman asked. 'Ah, yes,' Jegyll said knowingly.

"Now that I think of it, the use of Six was top-secret."

"Aye, it's true. I didn't know about it either. And I was the captain of a Special Task Force team. So, now I am curious as to why someone like Karman would now."

"Well, it doesn't matter. We're going to kill you right here, so the city residents won't hear anything of it."

There were still questions left unanswered, but it didn't matter to Jegyll.

And so she moved to attack.

She was ready.

Her body had been remade and now specialized in combat.

Karman also didn't let his guard down. His eyes were locked onto Jegyll and Reiz.

Reiz's men were still fighting the Super Beasts, but he also kept his attention on them.

Karman didn't have much chance of winning, but he intended on buying his men as much time as possible, so they could find the Powered Suits.

Still, there was some hope for him.

Veldora's own words... 'Oh, Karman. The Battle Bodies you and Zaza were given were based on our analysis of Michelle. If you can handle it, you will have the strength of a Demon Lord.' If he was to believe those words, he should be able to take on the Machinery Four.

He didn't know what Veldora meant by 'Demon Lord,' but Karman didn't worry about such details.

And so he decided to fight without giving up.

“Reiz. I will handle Karman. You hurry up and get rid of these pesky Super Beasts!”

“Yes, yes. Understood!”

Jegyll ordered him as his superior. And so Reiz obeyed her and moved towards the Super Beasts with his men.

“I won’t let you!”

Karman said as he tried to attack them as a diversion.

However, Jegyll stopped him.

And so he was forced to face her. And the fight began.

As vicious as the fight was, it was mostly Jegyll attacking.

While Karman followed the warning signs that appeared in his brain, it was all rather superficial. He was good at handling heavy weapons, but not at close-quarters combat.

And so he tried to establish the tide of the battle as quickly as possible.

“Hehehe. You’re better than I thought. I was confused as to why you didn’t die from my kick. But now I see it. You’ve undergone some modifications.”

“Yes. And so I’m starting to get used to your movements.”

It was a bluff.

Indeed, Karman was able to react to a certain degree.

However, it was very difficult, even as he relied on his body's features.

It wasn't real Machinery Arts. He was just using the official military combat skills he had gained previously. And that wasn't so useful against a cyborg.

Even now.

Karman aimed his high-power blaster at Jegyll and fired. But she dodged it every time.

Karman clicked his tongue. Jegyll laughed.

"It's no use. You are like a child compared to me. I was humoring you just long enough to take stock of your abilities, but I have sufficient data now. As you were able face me with such weak combat skills, the features of your body must be at least as good as the Machinery Four. But that's all it is. It's still surprising, but you yourself are no threat to me. After all..."

And with those words, Jegyll vanished.

Then she seemed to materialize behind Karman. And she kicked him in the back.

“GUHAAA!”

Karman slammed to the ground.

His brain allowed him to trace Jegyll’s movements. And so he understood what had happened.

It was a simple thing. Ultra-high-speed movement.

Karman was able to see it all displayed in his brain as if he had a bird’s eye view. He saw Jegyll appear behind him.

It was twice the speed of sound.

It was an incredible speed, considering that she still hadn't gone all out.

That was when Karman fully realized that this battle exceeded anything he had ever experienced before.

The speed of his heavy weapons were the same as the speed of sound.

Karman could fight while flying, and hitting his targets determined on his ability to predict where they would go.

Dodging optical weapons was not possible, so he managed by predicting the trajectory and firing time by reading his opponent's movements.

But now, with an enemy moving around at a speed that was clearly faster than him, it was clear that such strategies would no longer be effective.

“Bullet-firing weapons are pointless against cyborg soldiers.

You do understand what this means, don't you?"

Karman didn't need Jegyll to remind him.

It was obvious.

You had to use optical weapons to defeat cyborg soldiers. Because cyborg soldiers could move faster than bullets.

Especially seasoned fighters could even deal with beam weapons if they moved before firing.

This was what Jegyll was talking about.

And blaster weapons were slower than beam weapons. Slow enough for cyborg soldiers to dodge them.

Even an ultra-high-temperature plasma took time for the energy to be gathered. And as it was a short-range weapon, it

was necessary to get close to your target.

The finished plasma sphere had enough power to burn anything it touched. However, it was practically useless in combat when you are moving at a high speed.

And that was why Machinery Arts had been invented. It was the crowning achievement of high-speed combat.

Even if both people otherwise had the same abilities, the difference between knowing and not knowing it was great.

Karman's team was able to use optical weapons for wide-range annihilation.

However, once they were close enough to cyborg soldiers that they became visible to the eye, then there was nothing they could do but be trampled.

Just as Karman currently had no way to defeat Jegyll.

However, Karman did not give up.

He frantically looked through his weapons and searched for something that would be effective on Jegyll.

“Damn it all! But, what about this!”

Karman shouted as he unleashed a card he had up his sleeve.

Both of his arms were crossed and thrust forward as it fired—it was a neutral particle cannon.

It was usually a weapon used while wearing Powered Armor, but Karman was still able to use it in his current state.

As there was not enough power, it would not pack as large a punch as normal, but its speed was still 80% of the speed of light. That was better than the blaster, which wasn't even double the speed of sound. And it was more than enough to be effective on cyborg soldiers.

The speed was accelerated through both arms, the different particles mixed and transformed into an attack...that was not deadly.

“Too slow!”

There was a roar, and then Karman was blown away as something slammed into him.

The particles dispersed and Karman’s special attack was no more.

Jegyll glared at the fallen man.

“Let me give you a little lecture before I kill you. Whether it is a beam weapon or something else, these deadly blows should be dealt once you are sure that your opponent can no longer move. For instance, after they have just used a special attack. I mean, do you even have enough energy left to raise a barrier?”

Jegyll lifted her hand towards Karman and laughed.

It was over. Karman knew that he was about to die.

He realized it after she said it, but Jegyll really hadn't used plasma during the fight.

As always, Karman had used it to distract her.

(I see. When fighting on this level, wasting bullets is a bad idea...)

It was too late now. Karman would not be able to move for the next two seconds. And that was more than enough time for Jegyll to finish him off.

“Damn you!”

“Goodbye, Karman.”

There was a flash.

Karman was enveloped in light...

“...What!?”

Jegyll jumped away frantically.

The ground was burning. Powerful acid was raining down.

No, it wasn't acid. It was the Super Beast's blood, which contained powerful toxins.

“Y-you...”

The monster that Karman had saved was now protecting him.

And...

The serpent's eyes lit up with the will of a noble human, and

then its mouth opened in order to say something to Karman.

“...G-ggkaaarmaan...”

Karman heard his name come from the mouth of the girl who was now a monster. It had such a nostalgic ring to it.

“Is-is it you, Charlotte? Is it you? Are you really...”

It was a miracle.

After one hundred years, Karman had reunited with his lover.

However...

“GGgarrman...I...I...”

Everything below the torso was torn, and purple blood

dripped to the ground.

The rest of the body had exploded and flew everywhere.

The poison blood had been sprayed towards Jegyll, as if the monster was fulfilling its final role.

This blood had the ability to melt anything. And so Jegyll could not approach them.

However, none of that mattered to Karman.

He had forgotten about Jegyll, no, he had forgotten about the battlefield. All he did now was embrace the twisted and transformed being in front of him.

The poison burned his arms, but he didn't mind.

“...So...you...kept...your...promise... I’m...so...glad... Love.

You. And...so...live...Karman...”

In the end, the great serpent forced its mouth to move—and the girl who was now a Super Beast—called Karman’s name.

“Hey, Charlotte! We finally met. Don’t give up!!”

“Yes...we did. I’m glad...I didn’t give up...”

Their reunion was short-lived.

My wish came true—she muttered, and then her hand went limp and fell.

Her eyes closed silently, covering the snake-like pupils.

Then the long red hair fell over her forehead like blood.

“Uuu-uuu-uaaahhhh!!!”

Karman’s wail echoed.

And...

<<...confirmed. Synchronization will begin, as the master ordered>>

—The machine in Karman’s brain said.

It sounded very cold. Karman was immediately brought back to his senses.

At the same time, the earth split, and the Powered Armor that should have been broken now appeared.

<<As you ordered, all restrictions have been deactivated. ‘Self Repair’ has now been overwritten by ‘Ultra Modification

Repair' — Restoration will now begin. Do you choose to incorporate the material around you? YES/NO>>

Material—It was talking about the person Karman was holding.

Karman closed his eyes and hesitated for a second. And then he bit his lip and decided.

“...Yes. We'll always be together, Charlotte. Let's get revenge together.”

He muttered in a voice too quiet for anyone else to hear.

However...

Karman's will resulted in the birth of a superweapon that exceeded all the laws of physics in this world.

<<Permission received. The ‘brain’ has been saved in the hollow vessel—the ‘soul’ will now be installed...success—I will now support you as ‘Charlotte ‘. I look forward to working with you, Karman!>>

Karman’s eyes widened.

But it was only for a moment. He quickly returned to his old self and smiled mischievously.

It wasn’t like him to cry.

And more importantly...

“Aye, Charlotte. We’ll always be together now...”

The modification restoration was complete.

—The two were now united.

The cloud of blood in the air had now disappeared.

What was there now, was not a military machine, but a purple machine in the shape of a dragon.

Jegyll took one look at it and stopped.

“...What? What does this...”

There were wings on its back and a tail grew from its flanks.

Dragonic Armor—it was a destroyer that took features from the Super Beast serpent.

As for its abilities...

“Let’s do this, Jegyll. I’ll kill you. And then I’ll crush the whole Empire. And then, we shall build a new country!”

“You make me laugh! You can dream all you want once you are dead!”

—And then, the two clashed once again.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 16 Unreasonable Child

There were many times that Zaza believed he could no longer be surprised.

It was a world where resources were scarce, and yet Ramiris could create water.

Beretta had repaired machines that anyone else would have found difficult, and he had done it as if it were the simplest thing.

And Veldora brought out food from who knew where.

None of this was normal, and yet it had only been the beginning.

Karman and his team had been feared by all, and yet Beretta had subdued them easily.

And Ramiris had utilized strange and unexplainable phenomenon as if it were the most natural thing.

And...

When Veldora had punched and driven back Super Beasts that were seen as the embodiment of despair...

Zaza had sworn that he would not be shocked again.

Even when the tanks had been altered and they created the buses, Zaza had held back his words and stayed silent.

Well, maybe he had said a few things, but he had held back as much as he could.

Veldora and the others were clearly strange. They could not be measured by this world's standards. He understood that.

So there was no point in being shocked by every single thing...

That being said...

“How is this possible!? Why... How? Really, how is any of this happening...!?”

Zaza could only shout as he saw what was happening in front of him.

After all, they were currently being surrounded by the fires of hell. Their lives should have been burned away... That is what should have been happening.

But it wasn't hot at all. He was not even uncomfortable... It did not seem real. Zaza wondered if he was dreaming.

(Yes, I must have died. A dream. This is a dream! No wonder it is not hot. I died, and am continuing to see the world due to all of my regrets...)

He tried very hard to persuade himself that this was true.

However, Veldora laughed in his face.

“Kaaa-ahahahaha! Oh, Zaza. You really are quite stupid. You should face reality and accept it!”

“E-exactly! I don’t know why they thought something like this would work with Master right here!”

Veldora and Ramiris said as if hearing his thoughts. Zaza was annoyed.

Something like this? It was clearly a state of emergency.

It should have been the end for them... It should have been too late.

“But how can I accept this!? Ho...how is this even

happening?”

Zaza shouted the question.

Ramiris nodded.

“Master. I would like to know as well. I was surprised. Just a little, but I was still surprised! What exactly is happening right now? I want you to explain it!”

Ramiris was relieved that she was protected, but she had been surprised just like Zaza. She was flying around Veldora now and asking him to explain it.

Veldora nodded as if it could not be helped.

“I suppose I must then. But it’s just as it looks. As planned, I have created a diversion. We have triggered their trap on purpose and created this wonderful display of flames. They will all be looking at us now. So the plan is going well!”

Veldora said in a confident voice.

Zaza and Ramiris looked at each other in shock.

The others of the resistance watched them and gulped.

They were also confused by what was happening and did not know how to react.

Zaza had responsibilities.

It wasn't just the diversion team that Zaza led that was here.

Many veteran warriors had been sent from the other bases to join them.

Sharma had spent the previous night persuading them into action. There would be no future for them if they did not move now. And so they had sent soldiers as if this were the final

battle.

And they were here now, under Zaza's command.

So in a way, their lives were in his hands.

Zaza saw that they were looking at him and so he opened his mouth with determination.

“Uhh, in other words...we've been caught in the enemy's trap. And it was just as we want, yes? So, while it may not feel like it...the temperature around us is exceeding 30 million degrees...uh, how are we still alive?”

Zaza asked Veldora hesitantly.

He sounded polite, but there was something reserved about it, as if he wasn't wholly accepting what he was saying yet.

Zaza's brain was measuring insane temperatures around them.

Considering the immense amount of energy, it was as if a gigaton-level atomic bomb had gone off.

He should have been shocked at his enhanced calculating ability, but Zaza was solely focused on the results.

It was hard to believe, yet...

There were six points where the Ether Ring Barrier occurred.

It used the heat as its energy source. As long as the heat rays continued to burn wildly, it would not disappear. It would continue to stay up in the shape of a sphere.

And it was in this secluded inner space that the immense energy was being sealed in.

It was energy that defied imagination and turned all manner of matter into dust.

The explosive atomic energy that occurred at the six points was sealed away from the rest of the atmosphere...And so it pushed its way to the center.

There was no place to escape.

Those who were trapped within would be exposed to the burning heat. And when the pressure and impact that destroyed everything was added—well, that's what should have been happening.

—Six Tyrant—

This trap that Veldora spoke of, it must be the strongest of the Empire's weapons. Zaza had guessed as much.

And so...

—Why are we all alive?

That was the emotion that he could not hide.

They were inside of the superweapon and yet they could see and talk to one another.

Why? It was so absurd and removed from reality.

He didn't even know where to begin if he were to ask questions.

Still, Veldora's reaction had been to tell him that he was being stupid.

That was rather rude.

It did not seem like a matter of stupidity.

“You idiot. Use your head for once. As I already said, I knew there would be a trap. So why wouldn’t I take the necessary measures to deal with it?”

“No, no! First of all, at what point did you know there would be a trap?”

Veldora answered casually, but Veldora was quick to reply.

Indeed, Zaza was also wary of a trap. But they hadn’t been sure that there would be one.

And so he had asked...

“What? Clearly, that Jegyll woman was lying. I was so sure that you had all noticed. But, could it be that you didn’t?”

Again, Veldora answered as if this were a very simple thing.

Zaza turned to Ramiris for help.

“Lord Ramiris, did you know about it?”

“Huh? Me? Oh, of-of course! Yes. That woman was suspicious from the start!”

Ramiris’s eyes shifted uncomfortably as she said this.

Zaza’s instincts told him that she was lying, but he was a nice grownup, and so he said nothing.

In any case, Ramiris was clearly of no help here.

While Veldora looked incredibly bored with the subject, he would have to get him to explain.

“Lord Veldora, sir. If you would, could you explain to me how you found out about the trap and why you came to suspect

Jegyll...”

Zaza asked him directly.

As Veldora’s actions were dictated by his moods, he might just refuse, but there was nothing else Zaza could do. They were currently trapped, and unless the heat around them died down, the Ether Ring Barrier would just stay up forever.

Surprisingly, Veldora answered Zaza’s question good-humoredly.

“Hmm, all right then. After all, it will take a little more time for my ‘Paradox’ to control this energy storm. So I will explain it to you as a way of killing time.”

Veldora said haughtily as he began.

Some of the words made no sense to Zaza, but it had always been that way. And so Zaza listened without interrupting him.



While Veldora was a moody person, he was currently in a very good one.

And so he answered Zaza rather cheerfully.

The thing that had roused his suspicion was Jegyll's timing.

She had arrived right after them. It was almost like she was begging them to suspect her.

And according to her explanation, Michelle had been captured.

Veldora could not help but wonder at this as well.

However...

“She said that General Michelle wasn’t able to use her whole power, for fear of doing damage to the city. Well, then. Why didn’t she escape? If Jegyll could escape, then surely Michelle would not have had a problem. “

“Well... I thought it was because of General Kristoph, the strongest of warriors. It was because General Michelle held him back that Jegyll was allowed to escape...”

Zaza protested, but Veldora shook his head.

“Look here. Michelle’s power is great. I think she may be stronger than Beretta. I was not able to replicate it in the battle bodies I gave you and Karman. That means there is some secret to her power reactor that even Ramiris was unable to analyze. But nevermind that. The point is, there is no way I would not have noticed that someone with so much power had entered a state of battle. I am sure of it. Within the last few days, I have not detected any such immense energy. In other words, no battle occurred.”

He said very smugly.

It was the truth.

Veldora was attempting to decipher the laws of this world, and so he would have immediately detected energy of that level. And so he felt that this was proof that Michelle had not engaged in any battle.

As someone who had noticed this, Veldora was hoping to earn the respect of Zaza and the others.

He felt very good about how things were playing out.

This was his biggest opportunity yet.

“Yes, I see it now. While they are still our best work to date, the power output was not what I expected. I think, maybe the diverted engine -the thermonuclear reactor- is at its limit.”

“Ramiris, we’re not talking about that now. The current issue is why Jegyll wanted us to think Michelle had been captured.”

“Why? What do you mean...?”

Veldora was also interested in the engine, but they could talk about that later.

Veldora continued to talk in order that Zaza and the others could understand his greatness.

“I don’t know how much of what Jegyll said is true, but what would be their reason for keeping Michelle alive?”

“Th-that is because General Michelle is the governor-general and rules over the city. Like a king. Who knows how her death would affect South City. Besides, she is a princess. While General Kristoph is a hero and most trusted by the Emperor, he would not kill General Michelle on his own.”

Even if he had clear evidence that she was connected to the resistance, it was not enough to have her executed—Zaza insisted.

I see. Veldora thought. But he pretended like he had known this all along.

“Of course! And considering all of those facts, is it not even more doubtful that Michelle and Kristoph fought?”

“But if there really was someone who thought Michelle was a bother, wouldn’t they try to kill her? It seems easier than capturing her.”

Ramiris was usually quite thoughtless, but this was a surprisingly sharp observation.

Veldora became inwardly frantic.

(What are you saying now, Ramiris! I had just concluded things in a very impressive way. Why are you asking more questions!?)

As Veldora wondered what to do, Zaza came to his rescue.

“No, Lord Ramiris. It’s just as Mister Veldora says.”

Zaza talked slowly, as if he were thinking hard.

(Oh? Zaza, you can do it!)

Veldora cheered him on.

Zaza continued obliviously.

“It’s true that it would seem easier to kill General Michelle if they thought she would get in the way. However, considering the reasons we have just discussed, there is not a good enough reason to harm her. But if you think about it...”

Zaza then said that this was the best evidence that Jegyll had been lying.

It would be one thing to present the evidence, arrest and have

a military trial at Central. But an immediate execution by Kristoph? That was hard to believe.

“I had been quick to believe her myself, but now that I think about it, someone cautious like General Michelle would not have foolishly gone against the Empire in such a bold way. So she must have been caught in some trap...”

The leaders of the support troops nodded at Zaza’s words.

Michelle’s name was famous within the resistance, and knowing her position and achievements led them to believe Zaza’s theory.

“I know! Michelle didn’t think her most trusted adjutant would betray her! After all, I could never believe that Beretta would betray me!”

And like that, Ramiris’s guess turned out to be the truth.

Veldora nodded.

“So you understand then. I knew it all along. That is why I’ve worked so hard to protect you all!”

Kaaa-hahahaha! He laughed.

Then he saw the looks of respect he was attracting and felt a strong sense of satisfaction.

It went without saying, but it was all just a coincidence.

He hadn’t even been suspicious when talking with Jegyll.

He had only been able to deal with the Six Tyrant because he had created a barrier as a precaution once they had all gathered together.

It wasn’t because he predicted a trap.

They would all survive no matter what happened—that was

the condition of 'Paradox' that Veldora had to maintain, and it was as easy as breathing for him.

This was because of Veldora's Ultimate Skill, 'Nyarlathotep,' which boasted efficient and ridiculously powerful abilities.

Now that he had understood this world's rules, Veldora had become a complete and unreasonably powerful being.

And so he had succeeded in winning the respect of all that were present.

"...I had assumed that you were all suspicious as well. But more importantly, Zaza, you must try and use that body more properly."

He said, ending the conversation while he still looked good.



Zaza now felt a deeper respect for Veldora.

He was completely fooled, but he did not even suspect it.

And it was the same for the rest of the resistance.

However, they were not entirely stupid, and they realized that a very important point had been glossed over.

“I understand now that you saw through the trap and saved us, Mister Veldora. By the way, how does this trap work? I just don’t understand it...but aren’t we being assaulted by a nuclear explosion...?”

Yes, that was the biggest mystery.

It was one thing to notice the trap.

That was amazing. But then shouldn’t he have been able to

avoid it? Zaza wondered.

What kind of confidence, no, skill did it take to neutralize a nuclear explosion?

(No, no. It's impossible. They were completely swallowed up by it, and yet not only were there no shockwaves, but there was no heat. This wasn't just a matter of superior technology...)

Neither the information displayed in his brain nor his experience could explain this phenomenon.

As far as Zaza knew, even if their technology had suddenly advanced several generations, this phenomenon would still be impossible.

The others of the resistance all looked at each other in puzzlement.

“Hmm. You're still going on about that? I suppose you're at too low a level to understand these things. To put it simply, I've

led the heat, impact, and toxins away from you all by giving them directivity.”

Veldora said this with a lighthearted air, but Zaza and the others could not hide their surprise.

“Ridiculous! I have never heard of such technology!!”

“Are you saying that you have control over the laws of physics!?”

“But that would make you like some kind of mythological god!”

The members of the resistance raised their voices in astonishment.

It was too much to believe, and it did not seem like the noise would die down any time soon.

“Hmm. So you don’t believe me? Oh, well. Humans are like that. They can only believe what they can understand. It is the same in all worlds, I suppose.”

Veldora said this with a cheerful laugh. He gave up any further explanation.

It wasn’t that he was trying to gloss over it. It just could not be helped. He was only saying the truth, but it was too much for them to understand.

However, Zaza remembered his words, ‘Then I will tell you. I am a visitor from another world. You can call me the result of supernatural power...or more simply, the dragon who controls the storm. Yes.’

(What if...no, it couldn’t be...)

The question arose in Zaza’s mind, but he didn’t have much time to consider it.

Veldora laughed confidently and then said something most ridiculous.

“Yes, I see it now. It seems we have visitors, so we should continue to create a diversion. And Karman seems to be working very hard.”

While this made no sense to the others, Zaza understood it.

Zaza’s sensors were also telling him that Karman was in a state of combat.

And this also proved that had he been using these features in the beginning, he would have been able to see that Jegyll was lying.

(I see. This is amazing...)

He was impressed, but the problem remained.

They were currently in a furnace from hell. Veldora's power was keeping them safe, but they were still trapped by the Ether Ring Barrier.

If they couldn't get out of here, there was no way they could continue to create a diversion.

"Mister Veldora, you do know that unless some of this heat energy inside here depletes, the Ether Ring Barrier will not be disarmed?"

The Ether Ring Barrier had been running on the power from the outside for just an instant. After that, the heat from within had been converted into energy and was stubbornly keeping it activated.

And currently, the immense difference in pressure on the inside and outside was also suppressed, and this state was perfectly maintained.

As long as they were in this uncomparably powerful barrier, the resistance's army would be useless.

However, Veldora looked undaunted.

“Hmph. How foolish. Do not underestimate me, Zaza. This barrier. I need only break it!”

Veldora said this most shocking thing.

“No-no-no. Surely that is...”

Impossible—he was about to say, but the words froze on his lips.

This was because right in front of him, Veldora had broken the Ether Ring Barrier.

“Dragooooooooon PUNCH!!”

And he did it in one hit.

Ridiculous. Zaza thought.

It was as if Veldora was mocking Zaza's will to no longer be surprised by anything. Reality just kept being redefined in front of him.

I'm too tired, Zaza groaned.

Indeed, it was as Veldora had said. Humans just believed what they wanted to believe.

The truth hurt.

And so he decided to believe Veldora without doubt from now on.

"Wonderful. Well then, I shall now test this power that you have given to me!"

Zaza said with a grin.

There was no hesitation in his voice now. All of his doubts had been blown away.

Zaza had found hope in this desolate world.

And he wasn't the only one.

“Kaaa-hahahahaha! Oh, Zaza. Your face looks so much better now. Good, let's go! We must show them our true power!!”

Veldora shouted as he jumped out excitedly.

His joyous voice reverberated within the hearts of the resistance, which had been dark and closed.

“Zaza. I feel hope for the first time.”

“Me too. Let’s do this. I don’t even care if Michelle is on our side or not. We’ll wreak havoc on the Empire!”

“Yes. If she’s an enemy, we’ll just have to defeat her like the others!”

Indeed.

The members of the resistance had all but given up as they suffered long and hard. But now, at this moment, they fully believed in Veldora.

“Aye, the enemy wasn’t the Empire. It was our hearts that had lost hope! We can do this. We’ll draw as much attention as possible without getting in his way!”

Zaza shouted as he thrust his fist into the air.

Everyone else laughed and nodded at those words.

The enemy was the massive Empire.

However, an Unreasonable Child who knew nothing of what was normal was now with them.

They could not lose—Zaza and the others were sure of it. And so they marched out to battle.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 17 The Door to Destruction

A dozen or more battleships were lined up in the sky, creating an imposing scene.

In the bridge of the flagship Lordaran.

General Kristoph's sharp eyes were observing the Six Tyrant.

It had a diameter of 100 km. And it was covered in a rainbow-colored layer known as the Ether Ring Barrier.

Inside, a violent madness that surpassed anything that could be imagined in this world was erupting.

A gigaton level nuclear bomb—It was a weapon that created a sun on a smaller scale on the surface.

The things detonated at six different points at the same time.

Heat rays and shock waves all bounce off of the barrier and push inward, and then are repelled...resulting in immeasurable destructive power.

“Surely there will be no survivors...”

Kristoph muttered to himself.

The new Emperor, Fudora, had given him a mission. The annihilation of the Resistance.

Jegyll had led them on the right path, successfully gathering the majority of their current fighting force together.

She had made them believe that security was weak. And so the pathetic prey had come here to the land of death.

The first stage of the plan was complete. Now he would move to the second stage.

Now that the resistance had lost the majority of their fighting force, he would attack their hideouts and capture them so they could be used as material for experiments.

“Indeed. It is most fortunate for me as a man of science to be able to witness this superweapon in action.”

The leader of the scientists said. He was giddy like a child.

As far as they were aware, this was the greatest amount of energy ever seen in this world. And it was being controlled by a layer of skin that was the colors of a rainbow.

It was the fruit of the wisdom of their race.

The scientists were all curious about the strength of the Ether Ring Barrier.

During the last great war, it had been an undefeatable shield that protected the city.

And it had worked as expected yet again.

However, there were a few points that should be mentioned.

Unlike the city, where power had to be provided in order to maintain the barrier, this one converted the heat into energy directly.

This astronomical energy that had been created through the gigantic atomic bomb was converted into energy that kept the Ether Ring Barrier running. The theory had been put into practice.

It was a model of the Star System that only the Machinery Four had, which could completely control a thermonuclear reaction.

The Machinery Four's high-power thermonuclear reactors were equipped with finished Stars Systems. They were very rare, as there were only three completed ones in existence.

Now that Almsbine was dead, it was an impenetrable system.

There was not one person who understood how it worked.

This was why the scientists were so excited to see the heritage of the genius scientist with their own eyes.

Kristoph nodded without any particular emotion. Then he started to open his mouth to give the next order.

However, his eyes then caught the distortion of space.

Thin cracks then started to appear on the surface of the Ether Ring Barrier. It was the energy that seeped out of these cracks that were causing the distortion.

Kristoph was quick to realize this...

“All ships activate anti-shock barriers!! And land the ships at

once!!”

He shouted.

They were at least 20 km away from the Six Tyrant. However, if the Ether Ring Barrier really did break, the destructive power that had been pressurized inside would lay waste to the area faster than the speed of sound.

Kristoph followed his instincts and ordered a retreat in order to escape the danger.

His soldiers were sharp from training, and they obeyed his order without question.

It was the scientists who showed surprise.

“General Kristoph. What is happening?”

The lead scientist asked, clearly dissatisfied with the decision.

However, before Kristoph could answer him—an alarm sounded, and something hit the ship’s barrier from the outside. Had all ships not landed, there would have likely been casualties.

After that, there was an earth-shattering roar.

It turned into vibrations and it was so loud that you could hear it inside of the ships in spite of them being soundproof.

“Hey, what’s happening!?”

“Surely it can’t be that the Ether Ring Barrier was unable to contain the energy of the Six Tyrant?”

“So a gigaton level hit was the limit...”

“No, perhaps it was due to maintenance being impossible? Perhaps there was a malfunction.”

The scientists weren't stupid.

They quickly understood the situation and began to give their own explanations.

However, there were some who questioned it.

“I still don't understand. Most of the energy should not be depleted yet. Considering the difference of pressure inside and outside of it, the aftermath should be much worse than a mere shockwave.”

“Hmm. And look at the monitor. There are no balls of fire. There was an explosion, but it was very small, no?”

“So perhaps the chain reaction failed and the nuclear reactor was incomplete?”

“No, it’s not that. Look at the density of reactants in the air. It is not at all normal.”

“Indeed. The explosion happened as it should. However, something caused most of the energy to dissipate. That is probably what happened.”

The scientists stared at the observation systems on the bridge and shared their opinions.

Kristoph looked at them and opened his mouth with a grim expression.

“The top tower of South City has been destroyed.”

“What!?”

“What happened?”

“It seems that a part of the Ether Barrier Ring broke off first, and energy spilled out of it all at

once. And it just happened to pierce the tower.”

Kristoph explained mournfully.

“It can’t be...!?”

“Could it be a coincidence...”

“No! Don’t you know that His Majesty is currently there in order to analyze Michelle’s body structure!?”

Kristoph nodded at the shouting scientist.

“Yes. Thankfully, Alvin is also there, in case Michelle gets violent. But I am still worried about His Majesty. I’m going to return. You all continue down south and see if any of the

resistance have survived.”

“Yes! Understood!”

“General, I doubt there are any survivors.”

Kristoph agreed.

With the violent power that defeated the Ether Ring Barrier in front of them, what could the resistance have done to save themselves?

Still, it was dangerous to presume.

And so Kristoph decided to hammer in the final nail.

“Hmm. But don’t let your guard down. Once you are sure of their annihilation, you will continue on to the second part of the plan, as scheduled. Do you understand?”

“Understood!”

“Understood!”

“Understood!”

Kristoph nodded with satisfaction. Then he exited the ship and flew into the air.

He was headed for South City.

It was 100 km away, but Kristoph could reach it in the blink of an eye.



“Now, the time has come for me to finally accomplish my greatest wish.”

“Yes, Lord Fudora.”

The joy welled up within him.

Fudora suppressed it as his hand rose towards Michelle’s chest.

He would take the fruit of wisdom.

Fudora had stolen the seat of the Emperor Almsbine and become the most powerful in the land.

And now, in order to learn the secret of the Mobius System that he had dreamed of for so long, he had captured Michelle.

The Mobius System—it was an astonishing system created by the genius scientist, Almsbine.

By some practice that wasn’t nuclear, he had created an

unending cycle of eternal energy.

Humanity's dream. The answer to all problems regarding energy.

“Al, your father, was much too kind. He feared sacrifice and hindered the advancement of science. And yet with that brain, he would have succeeded when he was still young. But he feared the results and abandoned the completion of the Mobius System. It was unfortunate. As his junior, I was very disappointed.”

Fudora talked as if to himself.

Michelle had not noticed the change that had come over her adjutant, and she had come in for maintenance after the battle.

When she did this, her brain's features were switched to protection mode, and she was put into a sleep that she was unable to wake from by herself.

After that, he just needed to search for the Mobius system hidden within her body—it was exactly as Fudora had planned.

Almsbine had performed modification surgery on four people himself. The four cyborgs with the highest combat ability—Machinery Four.

Three of them had the Star System, which was the final form of nuclear fusion.

As the name implied, they had small stars fixed into their bodies.

They were now incredible beings that were able to supply an entire city with energy, just by themselves.

However, the Mobius System was on a different level.

It allowed a single person to provide energy for a whole planet.

Fudora had supported Almsbine with all his body and soul in hopes of this dream being fulfilled.

However, right before its completion, Almsbine had abandoned his research forever.

Fudora could not accept it.

Had this system been completed, it would have meant the realization of a world where all of humanity could live happily. Knowing this, he was unable to give up.

‘Sir, why are you doing this!?’

‘It’s too dangerous. This is too much power for human hands. One mistake, and it could destroy the entire universe...’

While he was unsatisfied with this, Almsbine would not change his mind. Fudora had no choice but to pretend to agree with him.

However, that did not last.

He had developed Biocomputers for Bionoids which boasted computing abilities that surpassed quantum computers.

With this ability and Fudora's mind, they could surpass the genius. He should be able to analyze the Mobius System and lead it to completion.

"Sir...that dream we once talked about. I will finish it myself."

Fudora muttered. And then he got to work...

He had decided to use the Six Tyrant as a way of turning the eyes of those old scientists away from him.

There was no point in having a weapon that you could not use.

And so it was also to gather data.

Besides, once the Mobius System was complete, the Star System would become a thing of the past.

That was what Fudora thought, and so he gladly gave his permission.

Now he would be able to concentrate on his work without anyone disturbing him.

His hand sunk into Michelle's chest and connected to her nervous system. He was interfering with the arithmetic element connect to her brain, and then he touched the secret door.

What lay beyond it, was the light of hope.

That was what Fudora believed as he opened it...

Perhaps if the timing had been slightly different, things would not have turned out the way that they did.

Had he been better prepared, he might have been able to do something.

However, the worst thing happened at the worst time.

It happened just as the door opened. As if the devil were smiling at him.

“...Hmm!?”

It happened in an instant.

Fudora detected energy of incredible density. The kind that instinctively filled him with horror.

At the same time, Alvin, who stood by in case of an

emergency, began to move.

He created an Ether Ring Barrier as if to protect the capsule that Fudora and Michelle were inside.

Immediately after, the tower that was seen as the safest place in all of South City, evaporated.

Fudora had barely escaped death.

Still, his face turned pale.

“NO! The Mobius System is running...”

Even when it was off, the excess energy exceeded that of the Star System.

And now, the Mobius System had activated outside of the city, where there were no facilities.

Fudora frantically tried to stop it. However, it was impossible.

The energy being created was too strong, and his hands were full just trying to stop it from going out of control.

“No, could it really be so...!?”

He abandoned all sense of calm and used every cell in his Bionoid body in order to try and control it. And yet still, he found it difficult to stop the flow of energy...

“Help me, Alvin!”

“Certainly.”

Alvin's Ether Ring Barrier helped neutralize the overflowing energy.

However, it was only delaying the inevitable.

(—I see. So this is... This is the Mobius System!? So he...Al really was a genius!!)

Surprise. And an emotion like joy.

Fudora's instincts as a scientist caused him to feel things that seemed inappropriate given his situation.

But also, there was fear.

—It could destroy the universe if they made a mistake—

The words of the genius.

And those words were true.

(Yes, this really is too much power for human hands. This is what he...)

In spite of himself, he found a renewed sense of respect towards Almsbine.

However, that genius was no longer here.

Fudora realised his own arrogance now.

He felt regret too.

Because he had opened the door to destruction...



Kristoph arrived at the scene. He was shocked.

The top of the structure—that had been supported by the space elevator, had been blown off.

Without support, the elevator was dragged down by gravity, wreaking havoc on the city below.

As the city's defense systems had protected the main part, it seemed that no residents had died from it. But the facilities at the top were destroyed.

The scene reminded him of the end of the war.

“Your Majesty...”

Kristoph searched for signs of him. And then he detected Fudora's signal a short distance above him. It seemed like he was all right. Kristoph was relieved.

However, that did not last long.

Kristoph tried to head towards Fudora, but he then stopped in his tracks.

His sensors were telling him that some unfamiliar and gigantic energy was approaching him.

It was coming directly towards him as if it had a will of its own.

Kristoph's senses were telling him it was an enemy.

And—

“KAAAAA—HAHAHAHA! I have arrived!!”

“And so have I!!”

Kristoph encountered them.

Something unreasonable beyond imagination.

“You rats. How did you crawl into here?”

He asked. His voice was filled with rage.

However, Veldora seemed not to notice.

“Oh, you seem to have a decent amount of power too. Nothing like me, of course. I don’t mind letting you go if you won’t bother me. So you should leave while you can.”

He said grandly.

Kristoph could not hide his discomfort.

Even though he was a Bionoid, the old Kristoph’s memories and emotions were still there.

“I see. So you are just a fool who doesn’t know his place. But it’s no surprise that a mere member of the resistance doesn’t

recognize my face. I will give a name you can take with you to hell. I am Kristoph. Surely even a rat like you has heard that name before?”

No one had ever heard that name without feeling a sense of dread. Or so Kristoph thought, as he said it.

What was important now was that Fudora was safe. It would be a waste of time to get into a fight here.

He could deal with the rats at a later time.

Kristoph didn't mind allowing these pests to escape. Of course, all of this was very funny to Veldora.

“Oh, Ramiris. Did you hear that? Uh, Kristoph, was it? Have you heard that name before?”

“Hmmm. It sounds familiar? Actually, how would I even know who is famous in this world.”

“That’s right. Well, it really doesn’t mean anything. Kristoph, or whatever your name is. I am Veldora! The great dragon and dear friend of the Great Demon King Rimuru. Would you like to find out just how foolish you have been? I don’t mind showing a weakling like you just how great I am, you know? Kaaa-hahahahaha!!”

Veldora saw that Kristoph had no intention of retreating, and so he decided to amuse himself by toying with him a little.

And Kristoph as well, was prepared to teach the fool in front of him a good lesson.

“I have no choice then. You will die!”

Boom! The air seemed to explode.

Kristoph had compressed the air and shot it out, faster than the speed of sound.

Airblast–One of the secret Machinery Arts moves.

The fired air-bullet went straight for Veldora's face.

Normally, this would have resulted in his head being blown off.

It should have.

However, Veldora was not normal.

It did no damage.

This level of attack was not even enough to make him itch.

“Hey, hey. Don't you realize how pointless such attacks are? Now give it your all. Maybe it will be a half-decent fight.”

Veldora said as he folded his arms. It was like he was instructing a student.

As for Ramiris...

“Why don’t you just give up? You’re really beneath our notice.”

Ramiris always acted like this against people she knew she could beat.

She had no interest in Kristoph’s pride as a warrior.

Ramiris didn’t mean to do it, but her natural personality was only making Kristoph more angry.

“You arrogant rats. You called yourselves Veldora and Ramiris, I believe... Yes, Jegyll said something about that in her report. Some secret weapon that Michelle fought with. Unfortunately, it seems that Michelle held back and now you have a false sense of confidence. You think you are a god in this small world, but I am here to give you a taste of reality.”

As a fighter and Hero.

Kristoph saw Veldora as an enemy.

An enemy he did not have to hold back when fighting.

“Kahahaha! You think you can beat me? How amusing!”

“I don’t think this guy is going to quit. Get him, master!”

Veldora laughed in reply. Ramiris was leaving it all to him.

There was no need for Ramiris to act reserved when their victory was assured.

And Veldora didn’t need any encouragement.

“Hehehe. This reminds me of those days when I trained with Zegion. You have some good points as well. Your martial arts make sense, not that they would be effective on me.”

As Kristoph looked on in shock, Veldora continued to be as calm as was possible.

“You’ll regret your boasts in hell!!”

With those words said, Kristoph himself turned into a speeding bullet of light.

Veldora still stood there, confident.

He would crush the insolence out of him.

The afterglow remained like an illusion, confusing the senses of the enemy.

Through leaving energy behind, you could disable their heat sensors.

As you were moving faster than the speed of sound,

measuring the sound waves was pointless.

And like that, a most deadly attack was created at an incredible speed.

“Maximum Impact!!”

The body of a Bionoid could change shape at will and also regenerate when damaged. One of only three Star Systems that existed in this world was installed in him. This man, who was the greatest of fighters.

General Kristoph, the strongest of the Machinery Four.

His fists had never seen defeat in the battlefield before, and they now thrust into Veldora...

...And.

All of the kinetic energy bounced off into his fist.

The result.

Kristoph's right arm blew off at the shoulder.

"...What!?"

He couldn't help but move away from Veldora in shock.

All the while, he could hear Ramiris and Veldora talking.

"I knew it! Master, it's just as I thought. This guy isn't too different from Zaza and Karman in terms of energy. So that Michelle woman must have been special!"

"That's true. I wasn't able to see it with Appraisal. But this guy's energy flow is easily read. It seems like it really will be best if we cooperate with her after all."

“Yes, yes. And then we can install that engine in Beretta!”

“What? What exactly are you trying to do with him?”

“Why not! Then Beretta can have a major power up!”

In spite of Kristoph being there as an enemy, the two seemed to have forgotten about him completely.

(This is ridiculous. Can they really not see me!?)

His brain felt like it was burning. A rage was welling up deep within him.

He had never felt so much emotion since he had been reborn as a Bionoid.

He was a being who stayed calm no matter what the situation. A pawn to be moved at Fudora’s command...That was how

Kristoph had seen himself.

However, it seemed that he was mistaken.

(So the warrior within me has not died...)

He had never felt happy about being worshipped as a Hero.

He just wanted to live up to the expectations of his friend, Almsbine. That was his only wish.

He remembered that now.

Kristoph looked at his dismembered arm and then looked back at Veldora.

Now, his heart had calmed completely.

“What did you do? My fist should have had you. It had an Ether Ring Barrier around it!”

He said slowly. At the same time, he tried to regenerate his right arm.

He was a new Bionoid, and the features of his body obeyed his will spectacularly.

In the blink of an eye, his arm was restored.

“—Still, I appear to have underestimated you. Forgive my insolence. I was convinced that there was no substance that could withstand my strength. But I suppose it is not so much a feature of your body, but a type of art?”

Kristoph swallowed back the anger and admitted that Veldora was powerful.

The fist that destroyed everything had been blocked—the answer to this, could only be that Veldora was a master who had

acquired skills that were not a part of Machinery Arts. That was what Kristoph determined.

And so he tried to talk to Veldora in order to receive a hint as to what it could be.

The strongest attacks were based on ultimate defense.

And Kristoph had attacked safely. He hadn't been reckless. And yet, the result had been the loss of his right arm.

It was no wonder that he was shocked.

However, he had still not given up winning.

He pretended to talk, all the while, he ran the Star System at full power.

“Oh, you can tell? ‘Flexibility trumps strength’! To put it

simply, it is the secret of martial arts.”

Veldora answered proudly.

Of course, it was all lies.

The reason that Kristoph’s attack hadn’t worked, was because Veldora was a spiritual life form.

It was simply a matter of energy density that caused Kristoph’s attack to be pushed back.

Veldora hadn’t even defended himself.

It had nothing to do with ‘flexibility trumps strength.’

If anything, it should be, ‘strength trumps flexibility.’

Kristoph was the strongest man in this world.

The reason for his defeat, was that he was fighting against someone from another world who seemed to move by completely different rules.

It was a fight that Kristoph had no way of winning in the first place.

However, Kristoph was not able to accept the reality.

His ideas of the world got in the way, and he could not see any other possibility.

How could it be true that Veldora hadn't used any form of defense...

Kristoph had been the strongest being in this world.

And so when something of another level appeared, he was unable to process it.

No.

Perhaps his instincts did realize it. However, he was in denial.

After all, Kristoph was supposed to be the greatest work of the genius Almsbine.

And so he continued to judge things by what he knew.

And he challenged Veldora once again.

“Nonsense! Don’t you dare think that you’ve beaten me with that level of skill!”

Kristoph shouted. He was risking everything based on his reputation.

However, it would not pay off.

“Dragon PUUUUUUUUNCH!!”

Veldora allowed much of the force to weaken as his fist slammed into Kristoph.

And yet, in front of such a fist, Kristoph’s Ether Ring Barrier was meaningless.

It broke in an instant. And the impact caused Kristoph’s body to go numb.

His rising energy had no place to go and began to disperse into the air.

“No...it can’t be...”

Kristoph could not admit defeat. He meant to fight as a

warrior until the end.

However, his timing was bad.

Veldora had already lost all interest in him.

After all, Fudora had just opened the door.

—The door to destruction.

Veldora's instincts told him of this.

He had had a bad feeling the moment that Michelle's energy began to rise rapidly.

That's why he knew that this was no time to be playing. It was an emergency and Veldora sensed danger.

“Sorry. It seems something has happened with Michelle. So I don’t have time to play with you anymore. Maybe next time. I suggest you train a little more!”

Veldora said with a boisterous laugh. And with that, he and Ramiris left.

Kristoph remained...

“He-hehehe... Surely not. They couldn’t really have lost interest... But he was strong... Is he human? No, more important, I...”

Confused, troubled, he thought.

He was so disturbed that he could not stand up.

Veldora’s attack had freed him from what control Fudora had over his body that had been printed into his instincts.

But it would take a little while longer for Kristoph to realize this...



Veldora reached Michelle in a single jump.

It was an emergency, and so he did not hold back.

He used ‘Teleportation’ without hesitation.

But he almost regretted what he saw once he arrived.

“...Master. This looks really bad!”

“I know, Ramiris. There is nothing I can do now. Let’s leave and pretend like we didn’t see anything.”

“But, wouldn’t that mean abandoning, Zaza, Sharma, Rindo, the children, Karman and everyone we met in this world? We can save ourselves, but I don’t want to abandon them as well!”

“Hmm. Yes... However, there really is nothing...”

“Even you can’t do anything, Master?”

“I can’t. After all...”

After all, the scene in front of them was very appropriate for signaling the end of the world.

Alvin was making a desperate attempt to neutralize the energy that flowed out of Michelle. Fudora’s eyes bulged, blood-shot as he attempted to control it.

Neither of them even noticed that Veldora and Ramiris were there.

Veldora understood what was happening at a glance.

His reading had revealed that Michelle had more energy than Beretta, and now it was all being released.

But what was more dangerous...

(To think it would be this bad. I hadn't been able to read the power reactor, but it seems different in principle from the others. This isn't a sun. Once a sun's life is exhausted, it becomes a supernova—no, collapsar? The energy that is being discharged is immense, but what is most dangerous, is the speed at which it absorbs the matter surrounding it...)

—This is bad, Veldora thought.

It wouldn't be impossible to nullify the leaking energy, but it would be hard to stop the power that was absorbing things.

If he waited until the collapsar was satisfied, it might eventually stabilize. However, that was only if there was a

single collapsar.

But Veldora's eyes caught two of them, and they were growing larger at an alarming rate.

One of them was sucking the substances in, while the other unleashed pure energy.

In other words, it would never be satisfied. It reminded him of Beelzebuth and its insatiable 'stomach'...

"...Because it's like Rimuru's power?"

"Exactly."

Ramiris found the answer, and Veldora nodded.

"What will you do? If this continues, everyone will..."

Veldora could not immediately answer her question.

Had he seriously wanted to neutralize it, he would be able to buy them quite a lot of time.

However, any other methods—for instance, isolating it with a barrier... It would still be difficult to control this much energy.

Eventually, it would break through, and the world would be destroyed.

After all, this was on a different level.

While it was fine now, if left alone, this was bad enough to swallow up the entire universe.

“Oh, well... I don’t feel like it, but I’ll do what I can to stop it.”

“Are you sure, Master?”

“I have no choice but to try.”

There was no option that included leaving things as they were.

Yes, he had talked about running away, but he would have done so by now, had he really meant it.

Veldora was fond of the people here who lived so desperately.

The arrogant Zaza and the brazen-faced Karman.

Serious Rindo and surprisingly tough Sharma.

The children, who never despaired regardless of the situation.

Veldora would never abandon such lovable people.

Perhaps their meeting had only been a coincidence, but there must be some meaning to it.

Even a chance meeting is due to fate—There was no difference between coincidence and the inevitable to Veldora.

He would succeed if he was going to do it at all.

Veldora's pride would not permit failure.

And so Veldora decided to use whatever he could.

“It will stabilize if you can succeed in neutralizing it while I hold it back. Are you listening to me, humans? I don't really want to, but I will help you this one time. It must be tuned speedily and completely so the size of the Mobius is identical!!”

He requested help from the people who he assumed had modified Michelle; Fudora and Alvin.

Asking help from humans was incredibly humiliating for dragons.

Veldora's sisters would have been furious.

However, in that respect, Veldora had a rather flexible mindset.

He quickly unleashed his aura towards Michelle and shouted as Fudora and Alvin stood there in shock.

“Bu-but. Even Al said it was impossible...”

“Silence! I am trying to help you. Stop whining and get to work!! Look here, you're all humans, all right? While there may be differences, you cannot say that it is an unscalable wall.”

Veldora was talking recklessly as always.

However, there was someone there who was moved because of his reckless idealism.

“Let’s do it, Lord Fudora. If we give up now, all of our actions would become meaningless. Let’s save Michelle. My sister.”

“Alvin...you...”

“This is no time to hesitate. If you cannot stop this, your ambitions will be crushed as well.”

“...You... Has your consciousness returned!?”

“It never had to. I was acting all along. I thought that this might happen one day, and so I used a ‘brain’ decoy. After all, you had no intention of killing us, did you, Lord Fudora? That Bionoid didn’t destroy my decoy brain.”

“Tsk. So you tricked me. You are his son, after all. Smarter than I thought...”

“You’re exaggerating now.”

“But why did you pretend to obey me?”

“It was because I agreed with you, Lord Fudora. Of course, had I known the Mobius System would be this dangerous, I would have opposed you.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about. This is purely my ambition to...”

“I think that Jegyll and Kristoph would have regained their own will by now as well? Wasn’t that your plan from the very beginning? You would play the villain so we could defeat you?”

“This is foolishness...”

“But I think you were a little too thorough, seeing as you got rid of people who knew too much and could get in the way. Well, it doesn’t matter now. Let’s hurry up and save Michelle!”

The conversation was over. Alvin tried to intervene with Michelle's Mobius System.

As for Fudora, while he was reluctant, he knew his priorities.

If they failed to control the Mobius System here, everything would be lost.

This was no time to lose themselves in an argument.

"Yes, it must be done quickly. Or else, I might also run out of energy."

Veldora said in an unusually serious voice.

It was easy enough to nullify the energy that was flowing out, but the other side that kept on absorbing it, now that was the real problem.

If it continued to receive energy, the absolute value would increase, as would the amount of energy discharged.

And then of course, so would the power to absorb.

And even worse, there was no regularity to the type of energy that was being unleashed.

“Wait, Master. Isn’t it fundamentally impossible to calculate this!?”

Ramiris cried.

It was no wonder, considering the energy coming from Michelle was constantly changing its condition.

Yes, just as if different kinds of energy were being pulled out from a different dimension...

“Yes. If not, I would have already connected the corridors so it would circulate!”

Veldora said. He felt like crying as well.

Even when he used his Seeker of Truth though his Ultimate Skill, ‘Nyarlathotep,’ he was unable to read the laws of energy that was constantly changing. The result, the only thing he could do was to read the energy that had leaked out and nullify it. It was a passive measure.

Furthermore, he had to use his aura to stop the other side from absorbing. This process was not only very difficult for Veldora, but it was harsh and seemed to be without end.

And time kept moving along.

There was no end in sight.

Just like the number of Pi, prime numbers continued to spread out before him.

Something that seemed to be there but wasn't.

Something that was there but seemed not to be.

It was ruled by laws that could not be seen and that surpassed human knowledge.

Even if you had the calculating ability that exceeded a quantum computer, you would not be able to find an answer.

If told to solve the problem right here and now, the only thing he could say was that it was impossible.

Still, no one would give up.

Alvin sent orders to the different departments, as the city was in an uproar. And all the while, he organized the information.

Fudora read the information, his brain working hard in order

to find laws that may or may not be there.

As for Veldora and Ramiris, they desperately attempted to keep Michelle in her current state.

However, the scale began to tip. And the black sphere started to grow larger.

All of them could see that their limit was reached.

And then the rhythm was broken again, and the energy balance collapsed.

Veldora frantically adjusted it and prevented an explosion, but it was now big enough for anyone to see.

It was too big to be called a micro black hole now, and if it were to be unleashed again, Veldora would find it very difficult to stop it.

“This is bad... At this point, I don’t even know if I can...”

Veldora couldn’t help but mutter.

However, no one was complaining.

This was because Fudora and Alvin had already realized how abnormal he was.

He had already used brute-force to control the Mobius System several times, as it discharged.

Had Veldora not been there, the world would have been long destroyed.

But even if they all did their best, there simply was not enough time.

It was just as the room filled with despair.

Baaam!!

The sound echoed off of Veldora's head.

And then...

“Hey, hey. What's going on here?! I've only been gone for one week, and you guys are already trying to destroy a world!!”

Well, the voice sounded very irritated indeed.

The thing that floated there was a mysterious slime with a paper fan.

It was...

Great Demon King Rimuru had come to take Veldora and the others back.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 18 Rescue

Michelle was in despair.

She had been betrayed by Jegyll, the one friend who she trusted and could be real with.

Her body could not move.

Her brain had been disconnected from it, and now her own body felt like it was far away.

Ah, I'm so tired—Michelle thought.

When the ideals that her father had dreamed of were shattered, Michelle decided to live while hiding her true feelings.

As a leader, she decided to prioritize the values of the majority

over her own.

Save those who needed to be saved, even though it came with sacrifices.

You couldn't save everyone, but save those that you could.

And in the worst-case scenario, you might have to sacrifice a hundred to save one. She had that resolve when it came to politics.

Kill your emotion and only act based on the logic of numbers you could trust.

It was people who could do this that were fit to lead.

So, no matter how much she agonized over something, she didn't complain in front of anyone.

She had always acted as if what she was doing was right. And she would lead them with pride.

—However, it had been different with Jegyll.

And now she was betrayed. It dealt more damage to Michelle than she could have ever imagined.

And that was why the lock to the door had broken.

(I don't care about what happens now...)

She muttered without a voice.

Despair and then resignation. It seemed natural enough.

But...

–Don't give up, Michelle. If you give up, the Mobius System will become uncontrollable—

Her father's voice awakened her consciousness.

(Yes... It's too early to give up...)

Even though she could not move her body, her mind was healthy.

The Mobius System was already running, but she could still...

Besides, there was something strange about Jegyll's betrayal.

(Yes, now that I think about it...)

When she thought back on it, Jegyll had seemed odd.

Her voice and movements were the same as usual. Michelle had occasionally said things that referenced their past as they talked. And Jegyll had reacted properly every time.

And so Michelle assumed that the strangeness she had felt must be nothing. However, now she considered the possibility that something she wasn't aware of was at play here.

The 'brain' was an important organ and was protected in several ways. That meant that hypnosis and brainwashing should not work, but she couldn't be completely confident about it either.

After all, something similar was happening to herself currently.

Perhaps Jegyll had also had her 'brain' isolated from her body and had the information stolen—in spite of knowing very little, Michelle was able to make a guess that was very close to the truth.

(If that's true, then I cannot give up here!!)

Her fighting spirit burned anew, and she considered what it was that she could do now.

Her body wouldn't move.

The only thing that she could do now was to pray for Jegyll and the resistance.

However...

Michelle's consciousness was combined with overwhelming energy that overflowed from her. Her thoughts now moved silently, but faster than the speed of light, towards the hearts of those she believed in...



Michelle's prayer reached Jegyll as well.

However, it was too late to change anything.

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Karman had transformed most strangely. And Jegyll could no longer handle him.

At first, Jegyll had had the advantage with Machinery Arts, but now, none of the attacks could deal a finishing blow.

Karman had incredibly healing ability—it was superior to even the Super Beasts, and he healed immediately after Jegyll dealt any damage.

No. If anything, it seemed like his defense ability was

improving every time he healed. Just as a broken bone is stronger after being healed, the Dragonic Armor seemed to react as if it were a living creature.

Furthermore, Karman showed that he could adapt to Jegyll's movements.

While Jegyll should have been the more skilled of the two, her attacks were no longer hitting their target.

Yes, it was as if he had eyes on the back of his head. He was able to deal with attacks from all directions.

And it wasn't just that.

She was able to place her palm on his armor, but it was poisoned.

The powerful acid would burn her hand.

The shock from the hits and the plasma that hit her upon contact. It was so bad that all of the previous damage did not seem like much to Jegyll.

The various firearms and methods of counterattack.

It was at the same level as the Machinery Four or even higher in terms of energy output.

And this perfect defense that Jegyll could not penetrate.

Karman had completely stopped Jegyll's most powerful method of attack, End Vibration.

It took apart molecules and atoms by causing a certain area to vibrate. It was an incredibly destructive skill that was supposed to be impossible to defend against.

As far as Jegyll was aware, the only way to do this was to create a special barrier that rejected and sealed away any external forces...

Yes, Karman was using the Ether Ring Barrier.

(What's happening? You shouldn't be able to control the Ether Ring Barrier without the Star System... You have to create 'ethers' with the use of a linked particle accelerator...unless, he recreated it!? Do those strange suits they wear come with the Star System installed!?)

Jegyll could not help but come to that conclusion.

She didn't want to believe it, but when it was happening right before her eyes like this, she did not have much of a choice.

(How could the resistance of all people have access to such technology...?)

She had so many questions, but now was not the time.

As her strongest attacks had been ineffective, Jegyll had no way of defeating Karman.

And before she knew it, Karman's men had joined the fight as well.

They were wearing the Powered Suits that should have been destroyed as they toyed with Reiz and his men.

The Super Beasts were there as well, and the battle turned into chaos.

She could not expect reinforcements or the possibility of being revived after death.

And then it happened. In that split second after Jegyll's attack, Karman fired his Giga Buster, immediately evaporating the lower half of Jegyll's body.

As she lay there in shock, Karman thrust out his fist like the jaw of a dragon. He was going to deal the final blow—he was right in front of her now.

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The fist was in front of her eyes. Jegyll saw her own defeat—no, her own death.

(Why...why am I here? Fighting like this?)

It wasn't fear that she felt, but bewilderment.

The 'brain' that was in the Bionoid had become active, and she was awakening to the free will that had been their originally.

Karman's merciless attacks had caused much of the special cells of her Bionoid body to be lost. Many of her functions were shut off as the preservation of life became the main priority. The result was that the restrictions on Jegyll were weakening.

And so she now had doubts about her current situation.

As far as she knew, she had been in a meeting just a moment ago.

And yet, here she was, fighting with Karman—this was most confusing.

It was like she was in a dream. Jegyll desperately resisted the cloud that was muddling her mind.

And then—

—Jegyll? Is that you? Don't give up. Regain your heart!!—

—As Jegyll's consciousness resurfaced from the depths, Michelle's prayer reached her.

Upon hearing those words, Jegyll's consciousness returned

completely.

(Yes. Yes. I was with Prime Minister Fudora and...)

The memories came back as if she were waking from a dream.

And then she remembered the things she had done when she wasn't herself. She was able to read and understand the memories that were saved.

(Ahh... No, no one will believe me no matter what I say. I'm sorry, Michelle... I was not able to be of use to you...)

As the fist of death approached, the memories flashed in her mind.

She felt waves of regret and despair.

Prime Minister Fudora had used her. Then she had betrayed

Michelle, which resulted in the current predicament.

But at the same time, there was a small hope.

She saw it while looking at Karman. He had defeated her. While she wasn't at the same level as the Machinery Four, she was one of the strongest soldiers.

With such power, perhaps they could go and rescue Michelle.

With both regret and hope in her heart, Jegyll accepted her death...

"Damn it! I am not going to give up on the goal we strived towards for so many years! Not here!!"

...No, she could not accept it.

Now that she had awakened, she wouldn't give up. And she

didn't need Michelle's encouragement to reach that decision.

Jegyll used her Bionoid abilities to parry Karman's Buster Knuckle. By sacrificing even more of her cells, she was able to protect the vital organs.

And so she did not die, but now her combat abilities were practically nonexistent.

The battle was over.

Now, she just needed to negotiate.

"That was supposed to be the finishing blow. Miss Jegyll, you are a tough one."

"Hmph. I could not allow myself to be killed. I remembered something. My old dreams and ideals."

“You really don’t want to die, then? And what is this about ideals all of a sudden? You tricked us and tried to kill us...”

“I wish I could explain everything to you. But there is no time. Would you please let me go until we rescue General Michelle?”

“Rescue? You betrayed us and now you’re trying to make excuses?”

Even Michelle understood how convenient it all sounded.

Still, she had to persuade Karman now, or she would not be able to help Michelle.

She had to get Karman to understand her position.

“You may not believe it, but I was being controlled. I want to rescue Michelle now, so will you not let me go?”

“Let you go? You would like that, wouldn’t you? As if we would believe such a story!”

Jegyll could not blame him.

Besides, Karman had a fierce personality and was known to be merciless towards his enemies.

And so she understood that there was no way that he would let her go now.

However, she had to try.

But then, something most unexpected happened.

As she opened her mouth in order to continue the desperate attempt, Karman suddenly looked up at the sky and froze.

“That...”

She heard him mutter, and then she looked up and saw that a black shadow seemed to be spreading in the sky.

No, according to the analysis of her telescope feature, it was a universal strategic reconnaissance aircraft.

“That must be first lieutenant Hiragi...”

“Yeah. I know because I partnered with Hiragi many times. But why here...?”

Jegyll and Karman both seemed to forget the fight as they looked up at the reconnaissance aircraft.

Jegyll was thinking of taking advantage of the moment.

Karman wondered if it was going to interfere.

However, both of their expectations were blown away in the

next instant.

‘Can you hear me? Jegyll! And Karman!’

Hiragi’s voice boomed so loud that the air seemed to shake.

Jegyll and Karman looked at each other.

Then Karman’s men and Reiz and his men stopped fighting.

‘I need you to stop and listen to me! That is what General Michelle wants!’

And like this, an unexpected visitor put an end to Jegyll and Karman’s battle.



Karman was with first lieutenant Hiragi once again.

“Ah, Mister Hiragi. So you were safe?”

“Yes. After telling General Michelle about your defeat, I received a different order from Jegyll by a secret line. It said to wait for the right time and then rescue you guys. But things changed once General Michelle started moving. I was told to follow you and gather information while offering support from the shadows.”

Hiragi said as he glanced towards Jegyll. He added that there had been no need to offer support after all.

Just now, a female officer who worked under Hiragi was putting the torso of Jegyll into a medical capsule. It would not be able to regenerate the lost cells, but by sending nutrients to her body, her ability to self-heal would return. Jegyll had told him as much.

“Jegyll ordered you?”

“Yes, she did.”

“...Now I remember. I did give you that order.”

Karman was confused. Hiragi nodded. Jegyll confirmed it.

“So, she really was being controlled then...?”

“That appears to be the case. It’s definitely difficult to believe, but we should get on the ship now. We can talk as we head over to where General Michelle is.”

And so Hiragi invited Karman and his men to come with them.

While Karman wasn’t completely satisfied with everything, he had known Hiragi for a long time.

He couldn’t believe that Hiragi would betray him, and so he

decided to believe him.

However, Jegyll was an entirely different matter.

Or so Karman thought...

‘Jegyll, you’re safe. I’m so glad that I made it in time.’

The mechanical voice rang once Jegyll’s capsule was brought onboard.

“!?”

Karman looked surprised.

And then Jegyll’s eyes blinked and she muttered.

“...It can’t be. Is that you, Michelle?”

‘Yes. It’s thought waves. I took over this ship’s operating system.’

“What!?”

“Are you kidding...”

The mechanical voice said something most shocking.

Could it be that some artificial intelligence was trying to trick them?

No, Karman knew that this wasn’t the case. After all, while the voice was different, the manner in which it talked was clearly the same as Michelle.

And more than that, there was something about it that had a strong sense of authority.

<<Karman, I detected the thought waves. They are identical to the ones of General Michelle that exist in your memory data.>>

Huh. Karman nodded.

“I see. That’s a... Well, you always exceed my imagination, General Michelle...”

“Well, that’s what she does. Her voice is what woke me up. So I can’t complain...”

Karman had a lot more that he wanted to say, but at this point, he had no choice but to believe.

Judging by Jegyll’s shock and how she reacted as if she were seeing a ghost, he decided that she wasn’t lying.

And it wasn’t just Jegyll.

Reiz and his men had also regained their own will after being exposed to Michelle's thought waves.

“What have we been...”

Reiz and the others looked like they were waking from a dream.

After seeing this, Karman could not continue doubting it.

He put a cigar in his mouth and scratched his head.

“Tsk. All right then. So, General Michelle. What's the situation?”

Karman finally bent.

He swallowed his anger towards Jegyll and decided to listen to what Michelle had to say.

And then he learned that Michelle was currently cut off from her body.

Her body was running wild and unleashing massive amounts of energy...

“...With the encryption key that I have, I could connect Michelle’s ‘brain’ to her body again. I have to hurry!!”

Jegyll said.

But it was very dangerous for Jegyll to get close to Michelle in this situation.

However...Jegyll still intended on going.

Karman also did not hesitate.

“Let’s go, Mister Hiragi.”

“We already are. And at full speed.”

Not only Karman, but Hiragi, no, everyone aboard the ship was united on this.

They would witness the fate of the world...

While Karman was reluctantly convinced...

Kristoph was also listening to Michelle’s ‘voice.’

Now just Kristoph, all the officers and men on the battlefield and all of the resistance were also listening.

This was because Michelle was using the immense amount of energy that was overflowing from her, to unleash the thought waves in every direction.

As the thought waves were so strong, those who still had

intact 'brains' were able to return to their original selves.

Of course, those who were just following orders would now obey Michelle.

As for the resistance...

Sharma had told them that Michelle was an ally, and so they quickly realized that something strange was happening.

Thankfully, Zaza was quick to believe.

"Stop fighting! This is without a doubt, the 'voice' of Michelle!!"

Because of Veldora, Zaza could no longer be shaken so easily.

And so he was able to accept all of this as if it were a mundane part of his every day.

In a way, you could say he had been poisoned by Veldora. But for now, it was working in a good way.

As the resistance's largest fighting force that Zaza was with had now stopped fighting, the Empire was also able to settle down.

And so the battle came to a close without too much chaos.

Once the fighting was finished, they were able to detect the release of unbelievably high-power energy coming from the city.

And with that realization, came the certainty that continuing to battle now would be foolish—both the resistance and Empire were in agreement on this.

“I’m worried about Michelle. We have to go and find out what is happening...”

It was as if Zaza's words represented the will of everyone

present.

And then...

They all decided to head to that location.

It was there that they would bear witness to something they could never have imagined.



Damn it. What was happening?

I take my eyes off them for one week and now a whole world is about to be destroyed.

No one would understand what I'm saying, but even I don't understand how things had come to this.

I had just escaped to take a light breather, as a present to myself. But it looks like I made a mistake in allowing Veldora and Ramiris to do as they pleased.

To think that they would lead a world to destruction...

My little trip seemed cute in comparison.

Yeah, these two were crazy.

They had no sense of what was normal.

Looking at this world that was about to be destroyed, there was something about it that was more shocking than when my body had been torn in two.

It's no wonder Beretta had asked me for help.

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I had absorbed the two pieces of the body and then went to the labyrinth to hear about the research results while I was away. That was when I realized that something was amiss.

Shinji had greeted me most suspiciously.

When I interrogated him, he said that Veldora and the others had gone off to another world without permission.

They had used the Different Gate, which was still being worked on, and had been waiting for me to leave.

Oh, dear. I thought.

They clearly wanted to be the first to find something new, so

they could brag about it later.

I could see through them every time.

As there was no point in waiting for them to return, I analyzed the remaining magic circle and tried to pinpoint their location.

<<It is already complete>>

Master Ciel was always ahead of me.

I was not surprised. Just then, a 'Thought Transmission' arrived from Beretta.

'Lord Rimuru. There is a problem. The two others are also with me...'

Beretta said.

The timing was a little suspicious, but I didn't ask.

He had come to me for help and sounded very frantic.

It seemed that Beretta had become involved in their mess as well.

Stopping those two was a task too great for Beretta.

Had he waited for the right moment and then called me secretly?

In any case...

“Shinji. It seems that they're causing a lot of trouble over there. I'm going to go check on them. I'll leave the rest to you!”

I told him.

As for Shinji, he was standing in front of the new researcher I had brought—Irina. He was sweating and making excuses about something... Well, it had nothing to do with me.

His cheeks were flushed as well, but there was no point in thinking about that.

“What!? Lord Rimuru!? Yo-you’re really going to leave me in this situation alone...!?”

Farewell, Shinji!

Sorry, but I can’t save you!!

You two enjoy your time together.

Oh, he looks like he’s going to cry—well, he is crying.

In any case, I left Shinji there and used ‘Interdimensional

Teleportation' to go to where Beretta was.

I was greeted by Beretta and tried to ask him about what had happened.

However, it did not seem like we would have much time.

“The truth is...”

Just as Beretta began, I felt that the world was starting to creak.

“Hey, hey! You’ve gone too far! Does Veldora not understand...”

“Uh, no, this isn’t Lord Verldora’s doing...”

“I’m sorry you had to put up with this, Beretta. All right. I’ll go and give him a good scolding!”

“What!?”

Ramiris as well—I said. And then I jumped towards Veldora and the others.

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And so I beat Veldora with my paper fan...

Now, what to do?

“Guh!? Rimuru!? Why are you here!?”

“It’s not my fault! I just got mixed up in this mess because of

Master!!”

Veldora was surprised while Ramiris wasted no time in betraying him.

Of course, Ramiris always made excuses, and there was no mistaking that she was an accomplice.

Beretta seemed like he had meant to cover for her a little, but there were limits to what you could do.

In any case, it was then that Beretta also teleported to our location.

“Pl-please wait, Lord Rimuru! You have it wrong. We were experimenting with the magic circle and got caught in an accident!!”

Beretta said frantically as he came after me.

Hmm. An accident, huh?

Is there more to this story?

Or is he just making up excuses?

After hearing Beretta's words, Veldora started to shout as if suddenly acquiring a will of his own.

"That's exactly true, Rimuru. It is most hurtful that you always blame me for everything. And how can you hit me on the head like that so suddenly!"

He made a show of being angry and indignant, but his eyes looked oddly anxious.

That suggested he was at least somewhat ashamed.

And Ramiris betrayed Veldora immediately because she knew

she had done something bad... It seemed like a good time to mislead them.

“I see. Sorry about that. I actually wanted to praise you for making such a wonderful magic circle... But since you say it was an accident, I guess it was just a coincidence that it turned out so well?”

So, what would be their reaction?

“That’s because of my research! It wasn’t an accident! It was all according to plan!”

“Ramiris!? We both did the research! I won’t forgive you for trying to steal all of the credit!!”

Idiots.

They took the bait too easily.

“...Lord Ramiris, Lord Veldora... That’s what you call a confession...”

Beretta muttered sadly.

“What!?”

They realized at the same time.

They let the cat out of the bag.

But Beretta was guilty too. He had tried to lighten the crime by saying it was an accident, but perhaps he should have discussed it with the others in advance.

Well, he may have had his reasons.

And...

“Well, it seems there are more pressing matters. And this really doesn’t seem like Veldora’s doing.”

I said as I looked towards the two Collapsers that were enlarging after sucking in energy and matter from around them.

The two Collapsers were affecting each other and growing, and there was a single woman between them—the singularity of supergravity, a black hole that swallowed up everything.

“Why is this happening?”

“That’s what I want to know! Apparently, it’s called the Mobius System or something. That woman over there, Michelle; her power reactor caused it to go crazy. We were just trying to stop it!”

“Exactly. We’ve been desperately trying to stop the destruction of the world. I am very offended that you could blame it on me, Rimuru!”

Thank you for the explanation that explained nothing.

Ramiris looked frantic, but I could hear the details about it later.

But it was true. Veldora wasn't at fault, and if anything, seemed to have worked hard.

I regretted what I did just a little. But then again, it was because Veldora had worked so much mischief in the past that caused the misunderstanding.

So he brought it upon himself.

I would very much like for Veldora to look at what he had done in the past and feel remorse.

However, the Mobius System?

A blackhole as a power reactor? Was this some kind of joke?

I didn't understand it.

Were they that advanced in terms of science in this world...?

And how did they...

<<In other words, it's a type of phase shift power reactor...>>

Please make it simple, easy to understand and brief.

<<...To put it simply, when something falls into the Collapser, the matter is converted into energy. It makes use of this phenomenon. By using two toruses, they affect each other and theoretically, would create infinite energy. That's what they must have thought. But it's far from perfect and incredibly dangerous.>>

Master Ciel's explanation was hard to follow.

In other words, it was not simple at all. Still, I barely managed to understand.

Basically, it was an incomplete product.

The imperfect engine was out of control, leading to the current situation—that was all that I needed to understand.

If this continued to spread, it might swallow up the entire universe.

If that happened, would it also affect the other dimensions?

<<No. It will not affect the other dimensions. Only this universe will lose its progress and be returned to 0.>>

Oh. If it didn't affect the other worlds, then I could just leave

it and return home...

But Veldora was trying to save this world.

In that case, I would like to answer to his show of spirit.

But, was it even possible?

<<It's simple. In a way, this is similar to Beelzebuth. The problem isn't the release of positive energy, it's the disappearance negative energy. However, the way of dealing with it is the same. As energy has a direction, you just need to control that...>>

I see.

Growthspeed = the movement of time. So when the world loses its power to expand, then it loses the concept of time as well.

If the expansion of the universe was positive energy, then the phenomenon in front of us now could be considered negative energy. Negative energy was special and was not something you could easily guard against.

Veldora was unaffected by almost every kind of interference wave.

That was how good his ‘Probability Manipulation’ was.

Had this been an attack from an enemy, it would have likely have no effect.

So even if the world was destroyed, Veldora would be returned to his dimension without feeling any effects from it.

Even in a world without energy—in other words, where time had stopped—Veldora would be able to move without any problem.

However, with this phenomenon that robbed everything of

energy that was in front of him, even Veldora could do nothing but try to use his immense energy in order to neutralize the effect.

In a way, it was a matter of compatibility.

But it had nothing to do with me.

As an example, if Beelzebuth, which had been my skill, had become uncontrollable, it would have been much like this.

And so even I knew how to deal with it.

Regardless of being expansion or annihilation, there was a direction to power. Energy had a flow and you just needed to stop it.

In other words, you needed to stop time.

If you stopped time, the expanding negative energy would stop.

So Veldora would not be able to deal with the phenomenon.

After all, Veldora could not control time.

There was something called 'Space Time Control' in his ultimate skill, Nyarlathotep, but Veldora had never stopped time by his own will. Perhaps he just needed some practice, but it was too much trouble for him, and he never tried to make use of that skill.

He was powerful from the beginning, and he was never interested in anything that he didn't like. It was a bad habit that Veldora had.

As he could still move while time had been stopped, he did not think that it was necessary to learn to stop it himself.

While that did make sense, it was highly inconvenient in

situations such as this one.

But then again, situations like this weren't common. But I did hope that he would start practicing after this... It was annoying that he only relied on me for help when he was in trouble.

...Well, he was always like that, so I had become accustomed to it.



I understood what was happening now. So it was time to put a quick end to it.

Just as I thought this, people started to gather around.

First, there was a group of fully armored soldiers who came out of a building.

It seemed like they meant to help those who were trying to neutralize the gravity waves, but it was completely pointless.

I could see the despair on the face of their commander, so they must have sensed the futility of what they were doing as well.

Furthermore, an aircraft—well, it was a warship—appeared in the sky.

It seemed like the result of incredible technology, to be sure, but no warship was going to save them now.

I wasn't sure if they had beam weapons, but shooting the black hole with it would not do anything.

As I thought this, someone came jumping out.

“Michelle! Stay awake! I will reboot you this instant!”

A voice said as they came running.

It was a woman who had lost the lower half of her body, and she was being carried by a rough looking older man.

She was calling to the woman named Michelle in an attempt to have her stop the destruction.

She didn't seem like she was in the best condition herself, but I suppose she was still more worried about this Michelle.

However, it would be better if they did not get close.

The man was wearing some terribly cool looking armor, and had enough energy for two people. So while he may be able to bear it, the gravitational field here had already been formed.

If they got close, it was possible that they would go passed the event horizon and be stretched into a line towards a singularity?

Perhaps he sensed this, because the man stopped in his tracks. Then he and the woman began to argue.

From what I could hear, words like 'closer' and 'no' were being thrown around.

But the man maintained his calm and tried to persuade her.

Well, I should move while I could.

There would be more casualties if I waited.

And so I quickly stopped time.

And then I quickly walked over to the singularity.

There was a rainbow-colored bridge that hovered in the darkness. And on the other side of the boundary surface, there were two rings in the air.

The Mobius System?

<<It's a black hole engine. The final destination of a technique they call science. The ultimate energy generating device.>>

I see...

Well, I understood that it was amazing.

An ultimate power that exceeded nuclear energy. However, there was no point if you couldn't control it.

<<In the first place, this technology is clearly out of place for this age. Compared to your old world, master, this place is about two centuries more advanced... But that is not enough to use this technology. They haven't even invented metal that can tolerate the heat, much less repress it. So it's no wonder that it went out of control.>>

Indeed.

Apparently, those cyborg-like people had miniaturized nuclear power reactors and particle acceleration devices through space compression installed within them.

That was clearly the result of a different civilization, but it did suggest that they had developed quite a bit as well.

However, an engine that could control a micro black hole... It was hard to imagine where that technology had come from.

It was too foreign and did not match their level.

So that meant the person who made this had probably been from another world. If I was able to meet them, I would consider making them honorary members of my research team.

I thought as I looked at the Mobius System, while the world stood still.

Well, it would be dangerous to leave it here. So I might as well take it.

<<In that case, I will manage it responsibly!>>

Manage...?

Master Ciel was obsessed with skills. Had she just found a new hobby...?

She sounded pretty happy. So the possibility was strong.

Oh, well.

Currently, the energy thing isn't a problem, and since Master Ciel is so happy, it would feel barbaric to ruin the fun for her.

And so I put the Mobius System into my 'Stomach.'

"So, Rimuru. What are you going to do with it?"

Veldora seemed a lot more confident now that time had been stopped.

He didn't miss the fact that I had quietly taken the Mobius System.

I had let my guard down and forgotten that Veldora was able to move.

“I'm thinking about studying it, since it looks amusing.”

“What! That's not fair! And both Ramiris and I were not able to analyze it, you know? And so we worked so hard towards acquiring it!!”

“Who cares! I thought you were working hard to save the world? It's because of that that I was going to ignore the other things you did!”

“Oh, uh.. No, that is right... Kahahaha... Phew. It's just that Ramiris wanted to install it in Beretta...”

Veldora must have understood his position, because he suddenly became quiet.

It would be several hundred years before he could beat me in an argument.

However, install it in Beretta?

That was a surprisingly amusing idea, wasn't it?

<<...It is possible, but please wait for me to finish studying it. I would like to offer something that has been perfected.>>

Oh, that's amazing, Master Ciel!

A true perfectionist as always.

And now she had given her permission.

So it was all but settled. It would go in Beretta.

“Yes, we will adopt that idea!”

“What!?”

“Beretta seems to have suffered a lot, so we will give it to him as a reward!”

“Kaaa-hahaha! That’s it, Rimuru my old friend. You understand me. Ramiris will be so pleased!”

Veldora was in a good mood now.

I was also interested, and it was important to make good use of your resources.

Beretta had the earth element, and with a perfect Mobius System created by Master Ciel, he should be able to control it

safely.

So the matter of dealing with the dangerous object was resolved.

Now I just needed to get a replacement heart—power reactor—for this Michelle person.

That was easy enough.

Master Ciel had already analyzed the nearby cyborgs and was working out a solution.

<<Nuclear Fusion Core Reactor—what they call it the Star System. But it seems like a waste to give it to a single person. Oh, well.>>

Master Ciel did not want to compromise when it came to her creations, but it also seemed like too much power for one person. It was quite the dilemma.

After all, it was an engine with higher output than even the Mobius System, which they had failed to control. So I could understand how she felt.

She tried too hard sometimes, Master Ciel.

It seemed like she hadn't spent much time or effort, but the result was far superior to what the other cyborgs had.

But then again, we were taking their Mobius System, so perhaps it was a fair trade.

While that was being done, I interrogated Veldora.

He had thrown caution aside and did as he pleased in this world. And he seemed to have enjoyed it a lot.

That's why I couldn't let him go places alone.

Veldora and Ramiris needed a guardian.

Veldora finished his story and then smiled happily as if I had no reason to be upset.

Oh? But your punishment hasn't even begun yet?

There was some saying about it 'not hurting after it passes your throat', and now that we had dealt with the Mobius System, he thought that the world was saved...

And so I decided to give Veldora a taste of reality by making him settle matters in this world until the end.

Side Story – Visit to the Unknown – 19 Day of Regeneration

I deactivated the time suspension.

“...We should charge in and neutralize the effects of the gravity waves!”

“And then Miss Jegyll can...”

“I can go with you! I came this far, after all. And I intend to go until the end!”

All at once, things became very noisy again.

I would have to make them all calm down once, so they could listen to what I had to say.

While the immediate danger was gone, the root of the problem had not been solved yet. To be precise, while the world

had not been destroyed, the planet was still dying.

I opened my mouth to say something, but it turned out that there was no need.

Michelle had opened her eyes.

“Silence!”

A shout.

That was all. Those who had been talking about a plan, in which their lives would be at risk, now closed their mouths and looked at Michelle with expressions of shock.

“Michelle!”

“General Michelle. Did you succeed in controlling it? But, how did you reconnect your ‘brain’?”

“No, that’s impossible! Even after regaining control of your body, it would still be impossible to stop the energy in your state!!”

“General Michelle, according to my partner, you are currently in a stable position. But are you really okay?”

Questions that were full of disbelief were being thrown around.

It was no surprise.

The problem had been solved so quickly that it was hard to believe it.

“I know that you all have a lot you want to say, but wait. I must thank my saviour first!”

With these words, the others seemed to regain their calm a little.

And then their gazes turned to Veldora and then me.

Boing.

A light blue sphere—well, more of an ellipse—creature.

And even I knew that my appearance was suspicious.

However, Michelle looked straight at me.

And then she said:

“So, it’s you that saved me and this world? You have my thanks.”

Amazingly, this Michelle person seemed to understand what had happened while time had stood still.

Perhaps she had grown mentally when her 'brain' was cut off from her body?

Either that, or it was an effect of the special substances birthed from the Mobius System. Apparently, Veldora had not been able to use 'Appraisal' due to outside disturbances. The Mobius System was so mysterious that it was no wonder Master Ciel had an interest in it.

In any case, this would make things easier.

Michelle seemed like a leader here. She had that sense of authority that allowed her to dominate the others. And it would make it easier for me to talk if someone in her position was able to understand things.

I intended to negotiate about the future in detail.

With this thought in mind, I transformed into a human as a show of politeness.

I felt more relaxed as a slime, but it was hard to look people in the eyes.

“Hello. I am Rimuru. It seems like my comrades have caused you a lot of trouble.”

“I’m Michelle. They haven’t caused any trouble at all. It was I who asked for their aid.”

Michelle answered back. She sounded a little nervous.

Next to me, Veldora was mumbling. ‘Don’t use such lukewarm words. Introduce me as a sworn brother!’ I would definitely be ignoring him.

Regardless, he was clearly going to leave everything to me. So I left him and looked around the room.

Before I knew it, a hushed silence had fallen over the place.

And their eyes were piercing into me.

Why?

Don't they realize how uncomfortable it made me?

I wondered, but I couldn't just say goodbye and leave now.

There were still problems left to solve.

“Now, I'm sure you all have different opinions, but surely you agree that this chaos must be stopped? I want to discuss the future. Is that all right?”

Veldora and the others had sided with the Resistance.

That meant they had gone against the Empire, and yet, they were also somehow allies with Michelle.

In other words, things were not so simple. There was a lot happening behind the scenes.

And as things had escalated so far, it seemed like the proper thing to do was to make everything clear.

“Of course. And I would like the leaders of the resistance to hear as well. There is no point in hiding anything now. It will expose the Empire’s shame...but this is not the time to worry over such things...”

Michelle said. Then she smiled with an insightful look.

She accepted my suggestion and began to talk about the hidden truth.

“...Tribes warring, language barriers, economic disparities, religious differences. In view of all of these things, my father, Almsbine, decided who would become residents of the city. It was all a gamble for the survival of our species. I still feel that it is meaningless to argue about good and evil in this case. After all, our civilization would not exist today if he had not enacted

this.”

Michelle finished there.

That was the full story of the project.

Of course, you could try to persuade those who had been cut off and abandoned, but you were not likely to make them understand.

But an administrator had to make decisions. She said.

They would have talked if things could be resolved that way. However, when one side profited while the other suffered, there was nothing you could do to reach a consensus.

And if that happened, they would run out of resources while discussions ran on. Mankind would be destroyed.

But, even then...

“That’s not enough, Michelle. Even after that, there was no future for us...”

A man muttered quietly. He was sitting on the ground and looked exhausted.

And yet the voice rang around the room, and everyone heard him clearly.

“Fudora...what are you...?”

He’s called Fudora, huh?

He was the man who had been fighting the raging gravity waves next to Michelle until the end.

Appearance-wise, Fudora was a young man. And yet he

seemed aged, somehow.

The voice was just as tired. But he spoke so that everyone could hear him, not just Michelle.

It was full of despair, and yet it was an accurate analysis of the current situation.

“We don’t have a future. Even if we used our remaining resources wisely, there is still a limit to how many humans we can support. There was nothing to spare for the people outside of the city who called themselves the Resistance. Even within the cities, West does not have much time. North is already starting to crumble. That is why...we needed the Mobius System...”

He said this very weakly.

It was very close to what Master Ciel predicted for this world’s future.

“...Wait. What do you mean? Didn’t we go through with the contamination removal plan as a way of fighting against those predictions?”

“No, Michelle. That was just our official stance. The Super Beasts were born as a way of leaving the roots of mankind’s possibilities. We created lifeforms that could live under harsh circumstances and hoped that they would become intelligent. We humans cannot live in undeveloped land. We can’t do anything once severed from our civilization. It’s not enough to decontaminate the world.”

Fudora said.

And then he laughed as if he had gone mad.

Then voices rose and the arguments began...



That’s it, really.

According to Master Ciel, 'As they have not inherited the technology, they are not able to lower their civilization level.'

They needed those cities to maintain their current lifestyle. And that required immense energy.

Apparently, all of their food was automatically grown as well. They did not even know how to do it all by hand anymore. Their civilization had become too convenient. They could not return.

And now, their world was contaminated.

They would need to cultivate the earth after they purified it.

However, there was no water.

The ground was dry and unfit for growing crops.

There were no rivers, it was just barren wasteland as far as the eye could see.

Not only that, but it seemed that even the seas had dried up.

You could not see the sun. It really did look like it was the end of the world.

Really, it was astounding that humanity had survived at all.

So there really wasn't any hope of getting out of this situation by human hands. So the only way was to make use of the cities...but they had limits.

Nuclear fusion reactors didn't create energy out of nothing. You needed fuel.

So, considering all of that...

This world had no future.

...And so that was why this man called Fudora and seen hope in the Mobius System.

And he had tried to kill everyone who might get in his way, just in case his plan failed.

In other words, humanity needed to be culled.

Perhaps this Fudora had the resolve to commit heinous crimes.

It seemed like they were discussing having him executed. And giving my opinion on the matter wouldn't help them solve anything.

However, I had every intention of stopping something as troubling as an execution.

Fudora seemed quite smart. Perhaps I could find a use for him if this world was going to execute him.

I would use this problem as a way of negotiating in my favor.

Fudora's testimony had revealed the truth to everyone, so that would make things easier.

No one would accuse me of doing things on my own later.

I had a plan.

To be precise, I would make this world indebted to me by solving their problem, and then I would take Fudora as payment.

At the same time, I would close my eyes towards all the things that Veldora and the others had done.

Besides, it didn't seem like any continued talks would lead to anything good. It was best to go ahead and solve the problem.

"I know you all have your reasons. You must have a lot to say. However, I would like it if you left things to me now. And with that, we can wipe the slate clean. As for the future, we can talk about it once you've seen the results!"

I interrupted their conversation with this declaration.

In any case, they couldn't ignore me now. And it was to my advantage that they seemed a little exasperated.

Usually, interactions with other worlds had to be conducted more carefully.

That's why I had told them not to go...

However, since Veldora and the others had already gotten so involved, I couldn't abandon them.

To put it bluntly, I would have trouble sleeping at night.

Still, it would be necessary to give Veldora and Ramiris a long, hard talk about the importance of prudence.

But that could come later.

How much could I interfere in the affairs of this world—should I interfere at all? It was a difficult question.

Basically, I needed a pretext for saving this world.

The room fell quiet as soon as I spoke.

Then they all looked at me awkwardly.

I could even see fear in some of their eyes.

I don't understand.

I went out of my way to become a human because I thought it would be rude.

That being said, I could very well make use of their confusion.

“Rimuru...Lord... What did you...?”

I ignored this question from Michelle as I turned to Veldora.

Veldora had been discussing something with Ramiris and Beretta while I had been distracted by Michelle.

It seemed like he was bragging to them about what happened while time had stopped.

While I was here, he acted as if the problems of Michelle and the others were none of his business.

He was telling them that it was because of him that the Mobius System would be installed in Beretta. Ramiris and Beretta listened to him with the deepest respect.

It was a little annoying, but I would let it pass.

I would have him work in exchange later on.

“Veldora. This world seems to be in danger, huh?”

“Hmm? Yes, it appears to be so. So, what are you going to do, Rimuru? Maybe we could just take the children with us?”

“No.”

“Hmph. How cold of you! We should save those that we can save. Then they can learn of my greatness!”

Veldora said. I smiled at him.

Veldora saw my smile and finally sensed the danger.

“Wh-what are you going to do? Put away that scary fan!”

I beat the air with the fan so that it cracked loudly.

Veldora was stunned as his eyes looked to me with worry.

“By the way, about your punishment for acting without my permission...”

I paused ominously and cracked the paper fan in the air again.

I continued only after confirming that Veldora’s eyes were shifting uncomfortably.

“I think I will exclude you and Ramiris from my next plan.”

“What!?”

“...Huh? Me too!?”

“Yes, why shouldn’t I? Both of you broke your promise and went off by yourselves.”

I said. Now it was not just Veldora. Ramiris was getting very nervous too.

Ramiris seemed to assume that she had nothing to do with it. Did she really think that I would overlook her?

If that was true, she was too naive.

“But I have nothing to do with this! I was just dragged in!”

“Wait, Rimuru! There is a reason here that is deeper than the sea!”

“Waaah! It’s not like that, Rimuru!! I was abducted by Master, that’s what happened!!”

“Hey, shut up!! Stop spouting lies! You were quite happy to plot along with me!”

And then the ugly fight between them began.

“...However, I have considered the possibility of not asking about it. Thankfully, I am the only one who knows about your little escapade. So, if you would listen to what I have to say...”

I said this as if it were really too good for them. They immediately took the bait. It was quite amusing.

“KA-HAHAHA! Well, why didn’t you say so sooner. Ask us anything you want, Rimuru!”

“I’ll do anything, okay? Leave it all to me!”

They were so easy.

“...I’m not sure...”

“I swear to keep my promises from now on! We won’t run away!!”

“Me too! Besides, it’s more interesting with you there, Rimuru!”

Veldora and Ramiris made their desperate appeals.

Beretta was looking at them with exasperation. It was as if he knew that this would happen.

Well, no real harm had come from it, and they both seemed to be sorry.

“So, no more forestalling?”

“Yes!”

“I promise!”

They might do it again once they forget their fear, but they should be obedient for a while.

This was enough for now.

And so I nodded and forgave both of them.



“So, what is it you want us to do?”

“I’ll do anything!”

Both of them rushed me on as if they were still worried that I

would change my mind.

They really didn't need to. I wasn't mad anymore.

And so I left it in the past and answered their question.

"I can't really leave this world as it is, so I want to save it as soon as possible. That will be easy for you two won't it?"

I said casually.

"Hey, hey. Are you sure, Rimuru? Wasn't it you that forbid anyone from interfering too much with this world?"

"E-exactly? Saving this world? We won't be able to do that while looking like we're not involved?"

It was incredibly rare for these two to say something that made sense.

Perhaps it was due to my daily efforts to educate them. There was a sense of normalcy that had taken root and was growing.

However, it was a bit late for that.

“How can we leave this world and go home, when we know that it’s headed for destruction?”

Not being able to sleep at night would be the least of my problems.

It would be one thing if I didn’t know about it. But now that we did, I didn’t think it was wrong to lend them a hand.

“Kaa-hahaha! Yes, that’s true. Then I will hesitate no further in helping them. That’s what you want, right?”

“Yeah. Do it.”

I gave my permission.

It would be a farewell once we returned to our own world.

And so there was no need to worry about being used over and over.

“All right! All right! Can I wake up the sleeping spirits and share the power?”

“I don’t mind, but that power...”

“Oh, don’t play dumb! Of course, I’m going to get it from you, Rimuru!”

Ah, I knew it.

Of course...

“Well, fine. But only this once, okay?”

“Okay! You can trust me on this!”

But, I don’t trust you at all?

I thought. But Ramiris seemed very enthusiastic. There was no need to dampen her spirit.

Besides, she was right about one thing. Making the spirits active again would mean extending this planets lifespan.

In order to maintain an environment that was rich with nature, the role of spirits was very important.

And so the two began to act.

“Let’s begin then!”

Veldora shouted loudly as he returned to his original form.

A great, black dragon.

The aura he had been holding back was now unleashed, and immense energy now surrounded the planet.

Impressive. Seeing it like this, he definitely exuded a sense of dignity.

Unfortunately, Veldora's everyday attitude ruined it...

“Kaaa-hahaha! I shall give you my blessing! Fertile Paradox!!”

Immense energy was unleashed into the atmosphere—it purified the toxins and caused a miracle—

Barren wasteland. Contaminated dirt. As I watched, it all started to fill with greenery.

The thick clouds that obstructed the sun began to be blown away by the storm.

The dark clouds that appeared were full of water that fell as torrential rain.

The terrain changed and gained color.

And when the rain stopped, the warm sunlight fell down on them.

–Veldora had revived the greenery, created water, and filled the land.

Well, well. It really was incredible when you saw it with your own eyes.

Now that I think about it, I had received a complaint from Ruminas after the great war.

The deserts had turned into jungles and the cities were swallowed up by the trees.

She strongly reproached Veldora for being excessive.

However, Veldora had run away. So I had to apologize profusely in his place.

Now that I saw the scene in front of me, I could understand her complaint a little more.

In conclusion, it was all Veldora's fault.

I shouldn't have been blamed for it. I had to pay some ridiculous reparations too. Honestly, I was starting to get angry just thinking about it. It was all Veldora's fault.

Recently, I had felt that Veldora was lacking in restraint, but I suppose he had really been doing his best. It could not be helped.

It was a good thing to be reminded of what would happen when he did forget.

The miracle did not end there.

“Now, it’s my turn! Elemental: The World!!”

Ramiris shouted triumphantly as she used her power.

She stole more than a little of my ‘Nihility Collapse’ energy and used it to transform into an adult.

A beautiful, young woman—of course, the reality was that she was the same disappointing Ramiris who had the heart of a child.

Ramiris sung.

And her beautiful voice woke up the sleeping spirits.

And then–

The earth was blessed and regained the appearance of its golden age.

Flowers bloomed on the ground. The air became thick and sweet. It became a paradise for the spirits that could not be seen with human eyes.

This way, they wouldn't be forced to develop dangerous things. The gifts of nature would bring new life.

It was quite impressive.

Ramiris really was the queen of the spirits.

Had she stayed like this all of the time, there would be no reason to despise her. It was too bad!

I only lent her my power. I would take it back as soon as she was finished.

Of course, she would definitely complain about it, but it was not good for her to have this power when she hadn't grown mentally.

It was for her own good.

And like that, the planet was reborn.

They would be able to live without fighting each other for food and water.



Now...

It was unlikely that Veldora and Ramiris, who were

preoccupied with their work, would need any protection, but I still left it to Beretta.

And then I turned back to Michelle, who I had been neglecting.

Michelle and the others had become speechless. Their eyes were glued to the scene before them.

“Ah, sorry to keep you waiting.”

I said. Michelle turned to me with a look of surprise.

Yes, yes. I understand.

She was exasperated how ridiculous Veldora and the others were.

I could see a giant building behind them that had smoke rising

from one of the upper floors. Apparently, it was also Veldora's doing.

Michelle looked like she had a lot she wanted to say.

However, I was in no mood to hear it.

I had sworn never again to make the same mistake that I did with Ruminas.

Take your complaints to the man himself!

And so I decided to tell them what I wanted to say and that alone.

“I think this planet will be restored soon if you leave things to those two. I hope you can then forgive them for everything they did.”

After I said this, all of the people including Michelle began to shake their heads vertically at an incredible speed.

This gesture seemed to have the same meaning here, so I guess they agreed.

So there would be no problems left between our worlds.

The only thing left was...

“Also, I have a suggestion if you don’t mind? It seems like you want to execute this Fudora guy. In that case, give him to me. I’ll punish him for you...”

That punishment would be being put in Ramiris’s research team.

I could expect advancements in our technology, which was more than I could ask for.

The airships in this world seemed like they could fly in space as well. The possibilities were endless.

Perhaps this was counting my eggs before they hatched, but...

“Pl-please wait! Would you please reconsider sentencing Lord Fudora to divine punishment!?”

A beautiful youth—called Alvin, said as he kneeled before me.

Divine punishment? That was an exaggeration.

I thought. But judging by their reactions, it seemed like the others feared me as well.

This was probably because Veldora had shown his abilities as a dragon.

They clearly saw me as being in the same class. Oh, well.

“No, no, no. It’s nothing like that...”

“Lord Fudora is...

I tried to explain, but Alvin began his passionate speech.

What it contained just confirmed what I had already guessed.

Almsbine, the previous emperor, had been suffering from a fatal disease, and so Fudora acted in his stead.

Fudora respected Almsbine and didn’t want his reputation to be tarnished. And so he decided to take all of the blame.

Well, it was a complicated problem.

The world was dying.

Should everyone die?

Or should a small minority survive?

When asked these questions, which answer was the right one?

An administrator's job was to protect their people.

If it was said that if you abandoned the citizens you were supposed to keep safe, then problems would arise for your government.

It would become a source of trouble in the future. An unbridgeable gap would exist between ruler and citizens.

As men of science, Almsbine and Fudora did not hesitate to choose the path of a small number of survivors.

It was the logical way to think, once you took emotion out of

it.

However, it was a decision too heavy for a person to bear.

—However, they needed a sacrificial lamb.

That's why Fudora was going to settle everything and entrust Michelle with his hopes for the future.

“Is that true, brother?”

“Aye, it is true, Michelle.”

Alvin nodded to her as he finished his defense of Fudora.

Fudora was sagging as if drained of all of his strength.

And so I patted him on the shoulder and nodded to him

reassuringly.

Then I turned to Michelle and the others and said plainly:

“Please don’t worry. There won’t be anything so extravagant as divine punishment. But I am taking this man with me so you can ascend to the seat of Emperor and unite the world.”

If that’s what I have to say to get a new researcher! That was my true feelings on the matter.

However, their reaction was different from what I was expecting.

“Ohh... He will entrust the sovereign right to General Michelle...”

“Am I really worthy?”

“Huh? Uh, I think so?”

Weren't things going in that direction?

Michelle was the daughter of Almsbine, the previous Emperor. So she should be the next emperor. That was supposed to be the right answer.

I had only said it because of those reasons. Their reaction was so overdone.

It made me frantic. Maybe I had been wrong.

Or perhaps they wanted Michelle's older brother, Alvin, to become the new emperor?

If that was the case, then it was really up to them to talk about it and work it out.

In the first place, giving my opinion on the matter would be interfering with their government.

They were saying something about me entrusting the sovereign right, but I didn't have the authority to do such a thing.

“Very well, then. I swear to protect and guide this world you have beautifully restored with all of my body and soul!”

Michelle said as she kneeled.

It really was so overblown.

Besides, it was Veldora who did the restoring. And Ramiris gave it the power to maintain its state.

Well, I did lend her the power. But it was those two that had put it into action.

I was pretty sure that Veldora and Ramiris would hate me for stealing the credit.

“Hmm... Good luck? Right, so you don’t mind if I take this guy with me?”

In any case, I had succeeded in leaving things pretty vague.

On top of that, I had acquired some valuable personnel. And while there seemed to be more than a few misconceptions, I was alright with it.

All’s well that ends well!

As it was too much trouble, I decided that there was no need to clear up any misunderstandings.

After that, we were guided into the city, where we talked about the finer points.

I even promised to make schools once things had settled down and send students to help train them.

Michelle agree with this idea wholeheartedly and gave her consent.

As they wanted a way to contact us, I gave them a communication crystal.

Now it would be possible to contact each other if something happened.

Once the schools were finished and they were ready to receive us, they would send word.

And just like that, my first negotiation with another world came to a peaceful conclusion.



–As an aside, Almsbine was still alive.

After returning to Tempest, Fudora took out the ‘brain’ that had been frozen, and said he wanted to research a treatment method.

In order to save Almsbine, who was afflicted by a fatal disease, Fudora had gone to the extent of saving him in a state of suspended animation.

My restorative medicine healed him completely.

We’ll just say that Master Ciel was also really good in regards to medicine as well.

Normally, she wouldn’t have helped them, but if it gave her an opportunity to learn more about the Mobius System, that was a different story–she didn’t exactly say it in so many words, but it was pretty obvious that that was what she was thinking.

It would be better if I didn’t interfere with this matter.

Veldora was very satisfied after being able to run wild.

Ramiris was the same. On top of that, we had a brilliant new assistant.

Beretta seemed to have suffered much as well, but he had acquired a new power that more than made up for it. Besides, the Mobius System would be installed in him once it was complete.

In the end, the visit to the other world was a fond memory for all three of them.

As for me, I was able to get some operating data from the Different Gate.

And with a friend from a new civilization, the possibilities seemed to have increased.

If you looked at the results alone, it was a great success.

However, you could never be too careful.

And so this definitely did not mean that Veldora and the others were now allowed to do as they pleased.

Troubling others and being troubled by them.

Like that, our lives continued...



A day that future generations would call the 'Day of Regeneration'...

Zaza saw it.

That overwhelming presence.

A being that was like a god from legend and myth.

The dragon.

(Really...could he really—have been the storm dragon...?)

His body shook with shock, fear and wonder.

The dragon only needed to roar once, and the thick clouds were blown away and the sunlight rained down on them.

The dragon only flapped its wings, and a tornado erupted and called forth thunderclouds.

The embodiment of the supernatural. A being worthy of that monicker.

Zaza was filled with joy as he looked up at the blue sky.

“Great dragon... I was so insolent...

Zaza remembered his attitude up until now as he muttered the words in shame.

And then...

—Kaaaaa-hahaha! You’re as stiff as ever!—

The voice of Veldora, that carefree man that he couldn’t bring yourself to hate, now echoed in Zaza’s ears.

“I see. Yes. It’s not like me... Until the very end, you are always ahead of me. Damn it.”

Zaza muttered happily.

Zaza could see the children running towards him.

Karman was there, on the other side.

And there was Sharma, Rindo and the other resistance members as well.

On such a beautiful new days as this, it would be an act against God to continue fighting.

That is what Zaza thought.

—And so it was on this day, that the Empire and the Resistance made an eternal peace treaty.

It was a historic moment, but it was easily overshadowed amidst the miracle that was the rebirth of the planet.



Michelle had no words as her eyes were glued to the person.

The jiggly, mysterious lifeform had turned into the embodiment of beauty.

And then, the great words were formed.

The world was saved, and as the person who was left to unite it—Michelle made a promise.

–I will lead humanity so that it never pollutes this world again–

And this duty would be passed onto future generations of emperors.

And eventually—

.....

....

...

The legend states:

The embodiment of beauty took the dragon and maiden with him and ascended.

The empire boasted prosperity after that, as if to prove the validity of the divine right of the Emperor.

And so future emperors declared that they had been chosen by God to lead the world.

However—

—If God were to determine that the emperor's actions were not justified, the prosperity of this world would once again vanish, as if it were nothing but a dream—

—Such words were inscribed.

And so the imperial family respected God and dedicated their bodies and souls in order to fulfill their role, which was the governing of the world.

This sovereignty given by God—after the Day of Regeneration, it became an unending tradition, and was the duty of the imperial family.

.....

.....

...

—And that was how the legend was born.

Of course, none of that had anything to do with Rimuru

anymore.

Side Story – ‘Hot Spring – Toranoana/Volume 2 Extra

By the way, if you travel east from the swamplands that the lizardmen live in, you will come out into a mountain district.

There is a great underground cave there that is a natural labyrinth created by active volcanoes. It was packed with endless, twisting passages. So much so that even the Lizardmen could not fully navigate it.

You could go deep down one path and find yourself in the world of an ice cave. Another route might take you to a world of burning heat, called a magma pit.

It was said that there was a demon world there that was hidden because it was too dangerous.

However, the labyrinth was not important now...

It was the active volcano.

If there is a volcano, then there should be a hot spring—it was that thought that started everything.



“And that is the reason! I’m thinking about going to the hot spring. What do you all think?”

My voice rang through the meeting room.

However, they did not seem to have understood me very well.

“You say that, but isn’t a hot spring just hot water? Why don’t you just go play in the river?”

“Yes, yes. They had water from hot springs in the bath houses of the dwarf kingdom. I didn’t think they were so special.”

As dwarves, Kaijin and Garm were not interested. Dord and

Myrd were nodding, so they probably agreed with them.

Hot springs were not particularly unusual, so I could understand their opinion. However, what I was thinking of was very different from what the dwarves were thinking of.

“A hot spring, huh? What exactly is that?”

“Isn’t it a place where water gathers after being heated from a volcanic mountain?”

Souei answered Benimaru’s question. Surprisingly, Souei knew quite a lot. In any case, as they all weren’t too enthusiastic, I would have to make them listen as I lectured them on the wonders of bathing.

Being thorough about hygiene through bathing would help prevent diseases. But more than anything, as a former Japanese person, I wanted to introduce bath culture to them. Of course, my main motive was my own enjoyment.

“Exactly! Well, there are volcanic mountains without hot springs, but we’ll ignore that for now. Just as Souei said, our current goal is to find water heated by a volcanic mountain. When water is heated underground, various substances are dissolved into it. These substances are supposed to be good for you. So, as you can see, it’s perfect for healing your tired body!”

After I said this, Benimaru seemed interested.

“That sounds good. It might be interesting to give it a try.”

“Quite impressive, Lord Rimuru. You sure know a lot.”

It seemed like they had warmed up to my idea.

Next, I just had to persuade the old dwarves...

“Besides, imagine this. When you play in the river, do you go in while wearing your clothes? If you are just wiping yourself with a bucket, then you wouldn’t take all of your clothes off. But in the bath, it’s normal to take it all off!”

“Well, that may be true, but...”

“But we’re quite satisfied with playing in the water. Aren’t we?”

“...”

Hmph. These old guys were slow to take the bait.

“I don’t care about that. Where’s your imagination? For instance...”

“Huh!?”

When I tried to explain it in detail, Kaijin seemed to have noticed something.

“...Do you mean! You aren’t suggesting...”

After Kaijin, Garm seemed to realize it as well.

“Hehehe. So you do see. Exactly. Quite the paradise will be waiting. Don’t you agree?”

All of them gulped at this.

Their uncooperative attitude had dissipated. There was now a burning passion in their eyes.

“You see, there is a wonderful thing called ‘mixed baths’...”

“I’ll help you.”

“Say no more. We are friends!!”

“Yes. What he said.”

“...!!”

They all promised their unconditional support.

Benimaru looked a little disgusted, while Souei looked as if it did not concern him.

Like this, the plan to create a hot spring in Tempest began.



What was wrong with a normal bath?

No, it wasn't that it was wrong. To put it simply, it would cost too much to make a normal bath house.

You needed a lot of firewood to boil the water. As a lot of buildings were currently being constructed, there was quite a lot of discarded material. However, that would not last for long.

You could gather tree branches in the forest, but you also needed to burn fires for food. And so I thought that there would not be any left to use for the bath.

And so the land was inspected, and a water source with the perfect temperature was discovered.

Then it was my turn. I created a pipe out of Demon Steel and then used 'Shadow Movement' to connect the source to Tempest.

This was done within the shadow space, but that wasn't a problem, since I didn't need to breathe. If anything, the real problem was covering the parts of the pipe that were outside of the shadow space.

I ended up just shoving it all onto 'Great Sage,' and it turned out to be a pretty easy problem.

The dwarves carved marble stone and created a wonderful, great bath house. The words 'mixed bath' seemed to have worked. And I could tell that they put their backs into it. Even

with just a glance, you could see that it was built to look luxurious and gorgeous.

This place would eventually become a tourist attraction that would be renowned around the world, but that was a story for a different time.

Oh, what happened to the ‘mixed bath’ you say?

As if things really worked like that in the world.

“Oh, it’s turned out so wonderful. Dwarf craftsmen really are brilliant. But while it’s nice you made one for us women, you must make one for the men as well.”

Shuna declared with a smile. They were apparently defeated without a word of protest.

Benimaru consoled them and said they should be happy to be able to enter the baths at all. Now they would build the men’s bath without sulking. It was all according to plan.

By the way, as I was a slime, I could enter the women's bath as much as I wanted. But that had nothing to do with them.

Side Story – ‘Paradise View – Gamers etcetera/Volume 3 Extra

An earthly paradise spread out beyond the steam.

It was the ideal place that anyone would pine for.

Cabal and Gido’s reproachful stares were annoying.

And it wasn’t just them, Kaijin, Garm and the three dwarf brothers were also jealous.

Damn it. They didn’t know when to give up. No matter how many times I said no, they still tried to follow me.

Ultimately, it was Shuna’s ice cold stare and a good beating by Shion that forced them to quit.

“Shit! It’s not fair that only you get to go.”

“Exactly... If we could only just get a peek...”

Cabal and Giddo were crying as the other dwarves comforted them.

As they did this every day, I could at least admire their spirit.

However, this was one time that I had to hold my tongue.

–After all, the place I was headed was...

I was being carried by Shion to one of two rooms.

The hot spring.

Yes, in order to heal the stress of the day, I had come to the baths with Shuna and Shion.

I could understand a little, why the others wouldn't give up.

After all, I was being surrounded by Shuna, Shion and Elen.

They were all beautiful.

A blessing to the eyes, as they say.

Not only that, but there was one other person here today.
Demon Lord Milim.

“Wahahahahaha! To think there was such a pleasurable place!
This is a great country!”

Milim said as she ran around naked.

As it was dangerous, I told her not to run.

When she was quiet, she was incredibly beautiful, but her words and actions were so immature. But, perhaps that was part of Milim's appeal...

In any case, she was definitely still easy on the eyes...and so I was thankful for my good fortune everyday.



Baths really were wonderful.

And when it was a hot spring, you could expect all kinds of effects. So it was only normal to use it every day.

I used to be a man, but now I was a slime.

And while I could turn into a human, I had no gender.

So that meant I could use the women's bath without issue.

While Milim was being rowdy today, she was usually quite calm..

I calmed my heart and tried to blend into my surroundings with a peaceful spirit...and then yielded to the will of Shion and Shuna.

And then, I was covered in bubbles and then massaged before being carefully rinsed with water.

This scene had become a normal part of my life ever since the hot spring was created.

Looking at art was hardly a hobby for me, but I was greatly moved by the scene before me.

Shion had beautifully toned muscles. And yet, she had large, soft fruits on her as well.

Shuna had a slender frame that she was pale and smooth like porcelain. And while those mystical fruits were small, they were

an ideal shape and very beautiful. There were two light red spots on her pale skin. They had such an impact that they seemed to fill my brain's memory capacity.

Both were wonderful.

Very wonderful.

As for Elen, she seemed to be a little troubled after comparing herself to them. But she was still growing, so there was no need to take such a tragic view of things.

While it may have been the end of the world for her, I found it rather amusing.

—And then there was Milim. Who didn't have a problem in the world.

Wahahaha! She laughed and swam energetically.

What a child.

Mentally, she was definitely at the same level.

Also, if I could make just one complaint, I wished she would stop using me as a kickboard.

Look, I know that I float, okay? I do. But that's different.

Becoming the toy of a beautiful girl might sound like an enviable role, but something about being used like this didn't feel right to me.

I was looking at something beautiful, and then get used like this out of nowhere.

It took me a while to even understand what was happening. I thought I was drowning in the hot spring.

...Well, it's not like I actually needed to breath, so I couldn't really drown.

It was Shion who saved me from Milim.

Of course, she only took me away from Milim so she could wash me as always...

After I was covered in bubbles from a special soap that Shuna made with a concoction of herbal essences, Milim stole me again.

“Hey. What are you...”

I became frantic.

“Wahahaha!”

Milim didn't answer. Instead, she stretched me out and

started to wipe her body over me.

“Stop using me as a bath towel!!”

I screeched.

I frantically escaped from Milim’s arms and washed the soap bubbles off. Then I entered the water and quickly moved away from her.

“Tsk. So stingy, Rimuru.”

Milim said with an annoyed pout.

Wait, wait. This is not what you call stingy.

I couldn’t let my guard down for a second.

However...

I was only cautious of Milim at that time.

I had no idea that Shion and Shuna were eyeing me and Milim like hawks who were targeting their prey.

And then...

Before I knew it, I was being used as a bath towel by Shion and Shuna as well!

A little...no, a big part...of me thought it felt rather nice. But I swore to take that secret with me to the grave.

End.

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